The Political Economy of Absolute Power

Research Dossier: Phase 1 Architecture and Research Streams R1-R6 (working draft, 7 November 2026)

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Phase 1 — Research Architecture

Project: *The Political Economy of Absolute Power: Absolute Monarchies, Authoritarian Development, Gulf-State Models, and the Future of State Governance* **Authors:** M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (co-authored: he conceived and directs the project; Hark's agents research and draft). **Document:** Phase 1 deliverable under BRIEF Part XIII (research framework, political categories, hypotheses, table of contents, country-selection method, authoritative sources). **Status:** v1.0, drafted 7 November 2026 (Asia/Jakarta). Governs Phases 2–8 until revised. **Evidence tags (per FRAMEWORK.md):** [V] = page or data file opened in this session and the claim is on it; [E] = search excerpt or established scholarly knowledge, not opened in this session. Interpretive claims are marked "(interpretation: Author year)"; hypotheses are marked "(hypothesis)".

Key findings and key decisions

1. **The central thesis is held open as a conditional question, not a verdict.** The monograph tests three rival master explanations of authoritarian and monarchical development against one another: (A) a *concentration advantage* account (centralized, long-horizon authority solves coordination and commitment problems); (B) a *rents-and-patrons* account (Gulf monarchical performance and survival are explained mainly by hydrocarbon rents, small citizen populations and external security guarantees, not by the political form); and (C) an *institutions-not-form* account (what matters is state capacity, technocratic insulation and credible constraints, which can exist under many constitutional forms). The project's final answer is expected to be a map of conditions, not a ranking.
2. **Political form, governance mechanism and structural endowment are coded separately.** This is the single most important design decision. BRIEF Part X demands that we "distinguish the institutional advantages associated with Gulf development models from the concentration of political power itself." That is only possible if the database records *who rules and how they are selected* (form) independently of *how the state is administered* (mechanisms such as planning agencies, sovereign wealth funds, merit civil services) and *what the country started with* (rents, population, geography, patrons).
3. **"Developmental authoritarianism" and "technocratic authoritarianism" are coded as overlays, not as base regime types, and are coded from institutions and stated programmes ex ante, never from growth outcomes.** Coding a regime as "developmental" because it grew is selection on the dependent variable and would make every hypothesis about authoritarian development unfalsifiable.
4. **Monarchy is defined by hereditary succession within a ruling family as the regime's operative selection rule, not by titles.** Hereditary succession inside a party or personalist republic (North Korea, Syria under the Assads, Azerbaijan) is coded as "dynastic succession in a non-monarchy," not as monarchy. Monarchies are then split by where effective executive power sits (absolute, semi-constitutional, constitutional).
5. **Ambiguous cases are coded by a published decision tree with year-specific codes,** and every ambiguous case is cross-walked to Geddes–Wright–Frantz (GWF), V-Dem Regimes of the World (RoW), Anckar & Fredriksson (A&F) and Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland (CGV). Provisional codes: Jordan and Morocco = semi-constitutional (ruling) monarchies; Kuwait = semi-constitutional monarchy through May 2024, then absolute-in-practice monarchy under constitutional suspension from May 2024; Thailand = constitutional monarchy with recurrent military rule and a politically active palace ("reserve-domain" flag); Eswatini = absolute monarchy with a no-party electoral façade.

6. **Selection bias is corrected by starting from the full universe, not from famous cases.** Every substantive claim about monarchies must first be stated against the base rate of all monarchies in power at any point since 1946, including the 15 fallen monarchies listed in FRAMEWORK.md and others. Case studies are drawn from a stratified matrix (regime type × resource endowment × era), with outcome-blind selection inside each cell and deliberate inclusion of failures and resource-poor autocracies.
7. **The core comparative unit is the regime spell and the leader spell, not only the country-year.** Succession effects, the "good ruler" problem and survival claims cannot be tested on country-year averages.
8. **For every Gulf indicator we report citizen and total-resident denominators separately where data allow,** and flag where they do not (the UAE and Qatar publish no official nationality breakdown [E]). GDP per capita, poverty, inequality, education and labour-market figures are not comparable with non-Gulf cases until this is done.
9. **The headline empirical literature points against a general benevolent-autocrat advantage but leaves room for conditional effects,** which is exactly the space the monograph must map: democratizations raise GDP per capita by about 20 percent in the long run in Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo and Robinson (2019) [V]; growth-positive autocrats appear no more often than chance, while growth-negative autocrats appear far more often, in Rizio and Skali (2020) [V]; leaders matter for growth in autocracies but not detectably in democracies in Jones and Olken (2005) [V]. Monarchies may differ from other autocracies on stability and property rights (Menaldo 2012 [V]; Knutsen & Fjelde 2013 [E]), but that claim is contested (Yom & Gause 2012 [V]).
10. **Target manuscript:** 20 chapters in six parts plus front matter and appendices (Section 5), every chapter mapped to one or more BRIEF Parts I–XII.

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1. Research framework and the central question

1.1 The question, restated so it can be answered

BRIEF Part I asks whether "absolute monarchies and Gulf-style political systems [are] suitable governance models for countries with significant economic potential, weak institutions, and substantial development challenges." As stated, the question bundles four distinct claims that must be separated before any evidence can bear on them:

- **Q1 (association):** Across the post-1945 universe, are absolute monarchies (and concentrated autocracies generally) associated with better, worse or merely more variable development outcomes than other regimes, once starting conditions are held constant?
- **Q2 (mechanism):** Where concentrated regimes did perform well, which mechanisms produced the result: the concentration of authority itself, the hereditary planning horizon, elite coordination, technocratic administration, rents, external protection, or something else?
- **Q3 (separability):** Can those mechanisms be detached from the political form and reproduced under constitutional monarchy, parliamentary democracy or presidential republics?
- **Q4 (transfer):** Under which demographic, fiscal, institutional and geopolitical conditions would any detachable mechanism help a country with "underutilized potential" (BRIEF Part XI), and under which would it fail or cause harm?

The monograph answers Q1 descriptively and with appropriate caveats; Q2 by structured comparison and process tracing; Q3 by finding the same mechanism operating under different political forms (for example, sovereign wealth fund governance in Norway, Chile, Botswana and the Gulf); and Q4 by explicit scope conditions. A positive answer to Q1 would not by itself establish Q2, Q3 or Q4, and a negative answer to Q1 would not rule out a positive answer to Q3. The manuscript must say this plainly, because the popular argument for "Gulf models" usually slides from an observed association (rich Gulf monarchies) to a transfer recommendation without passing through Q2 and Q3.

1.2 What counts as the outcome

"Development" is treated as a vector, never a single number. Following BRIEF Part VI and the writing standard ("do not equate economic growth with political legitimacy … political stability with social welfare"), the outcome vector has six components, each with its own indicators (Section 8):

1. **Material prosperity and its source:** GDP per capita (PPP), but always decomposed into resource-rent share and non-resource output, and reported per citizen and per resident in labour-importing states.
2. **Productivity-driven development:** labour productivity, total factor productivity (Penn World Table), export complexity and diversification.
3. **Human development and distribution:** life expectancy, child mortality, learning-adjusted schooling, poverty, inequality, and whether high GDP per capita reaches the median resident.
4. **State capacity and institutional quality:** government effectiveness, regulatory quality, rule of law, control of corruption, tax capacity, statistical capacity.
5. **Stability and continuity:** regime survival, leader survival, irregular exits, succession crises, civil conflict, and macro-fiscal volatility.
6. **Rights and accountability:** civil liberties, executive constraints, judicial independence, information freedom. These enter twice: as outcomes in their own right (BRIEF Part VII items 8, 10, 11) and as possible mechanisms (information distortion, Part IX).

A regime that scores well on (1) and (5) but badly on (3) for non-citizens and on (6) has not "succeeded" on our definition; it has a specific profile, and the monograph reports profiles.

1.3 Analytical framework: three layers and their confounders

The project uses a three-layer model. Each layer is coded separately in the Phase 2 database.

Layer 1 — Political form. Who holds supreme authority, how that person or group is selected and replaced, and what constrains them. This is where the ten regime types of Part II live (Section 2).

Layer 2 — Governance mechanisms. The administrative and fiscal machinery: national planning bodies, merit-based civil service, central-bank and audit independence, sovereign wealth fund rules, procurement systems, performance management, investment-law certainty. These are the fourteen candidate mechanisms of BRIEF Part X. The key empirical question for Part X is whether Layer 2 varies independently of Layer 1.

Layer 3 — Structural conditions. Resource rents per citizen, citizen population size, initial income and human capital, colonial and state-formation legacy, ethnic and sectarian structure, geography, and external patronage or threat. These are the main confounders. The Gulf monarchies sit at an extreme of Layer 3 (very high rents per citizen, very small citizen populations, sustained Western security guarantees), which is why naive comparison of Gulf outcomes with large, poor republics is uninformative.

The causal story we test runs in both directions. Layer 3 shapes Layer 1 (rents can finance regime survival; Ross 2012 [E], disputed by Haber & Menaldo 2011 [V]); Layer 1 shapes Layer 2 (rulers choose whether to insulate technocrats; Geddes 1994, *Politician's Dilemma* [E]); Layer 2 shapes outcomes; and outcomes feed back into regime survival (performance legitimacy). The confounding structure implies three working rules:

- Never compare outcomes across regime types without conditioning on rents per capita, initial income and population size.
- Treat regime type as partly endogenous to wealth and rents; prefer within-country designs (before/after transitions or successions) and matched pairs over cross-sectional comparisons.
- Treat survival as an outcome that can be bought (with rents or patrons) and therefore not as evidence of institutional quality by itself.

1.4 The working thesis, framed as an open question

The monograph does not begin with a thesis to defend. It begins with three rival master explanations, each stated in its strongest form, and commits in advance to the evidence that would weaken each.

- **(A) Concentration advantage (hypothesis).** Concentrated, especially hereditary, authority lengthens planning horizons, reduces veto points and lets rulers commit credibly to elites and investors; where rulers are also capable, development follows. Intellectual lineage: Hobbes; Olson 1993 on the "stationary bandit" [V, cited in Rizio & Skali 2020 reference list]; Huntington 1968 on order before participation [E]; developmental-state literature (Johnson 1982; Amsden 1989; Wade 1990) [E]; Menaldo 2012 on monarchical political culture as a commitment device [V].

- **(B) Rents and patrons (hypothesis).** Gulf monarchical survival and prosperity are explained mainly by hydrocarbon rents distributed to small citizen populations, cross-cutting coalitions and foreign security patronage; without these, monarchies are as vulnerable as other autocracies. Lineage: Mahdavy 1970 and Beblawi & Luciani 1987 on the rentier state [E]; Ross 2012 [E]; Yom & Gause 2012 [V]; Herb 2014 [E].
- **(C) Institutions, not form (hypothesis).** What separates success from failure is state capacity, technocratic insulation and credible (formal or informal) constraints on the ruler, and these can be built under any constitutional form; concentration helps only where it creates such institutions and hurts where it substitutes for them. Lineage: Evans 1995 on embedded autonomy [E]; North, Wallis & Weingast 2009 [E]; Acemoglu & Robinson 2012 [E]; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 on accountability to a secure selectorate [V, via Rizio & Skali summary]; Fukuyama 2014 on state, rule of law and accountability as separable [E].

The three accounts are not mutually exclusive. The likely finding is a conditional combination (for example: concentration plus rents purchases stability; concentration plus insulated technocracy plus a secure selectorate can purchase growth; concentration without either produces the failure modes of Part IX). The monograph's job is to establish which combination is supported by which evidence, how strongly, and where the evidence runs out.

1.5 Methods

The project uses four complementary methods, chosen because each covers a weakness of the others.

1. **Universe-level descriptive statistics (Phase 4).** Country-year and regime-spell panels from 1946 to the latest available year, built from GWF (1946–2010), A&F v3.0 (1800–2024), V-Dem v16 (data to 2025), CGV (1946–2008) and our own extension to 2026 for the cases in the Phase 2 database. Outputs: base rates, survival curves (Kaplan–Meier by regime type), distribution of outcomes by type and rent stratum. No causal language unless a design supports it.
2. **Within-unit designs.** Before/after comparisons around regime transitions and around leader deaths in office (the identification logic of Jones & Olken 2005 [V]); successions in monarchies (orderly versus contested) as quasi-natural variation in leader quality holding the regime constant.
3. **Structured, focused comparison of matched pairs** (George & Bennett 2005 [E]). Pairs are chosen to vary the explanatory factor while holding Layer 3 roughly constant (Section 4.4).
4. **Process tracing of mechanisms** in the Gulf country studies (Phase 3) and failure cases (Phase 5), using primary documents (constitutions, basic laws, SWF annual reports, IMF Article IV reports, budget documents) to test whether a claimed mechanism actually operated in the sequence the theory requires.

Units of analysis: country-year (outcomes), regime spell (survival and breakdown, following GWF), leader spell (leader effects and succession; Archigos, Goemans, Gleditsch & Chiozza 2009 [V via citation]), and policy episode (for Part X mechanisms).

1.6 Normative and safety guardrails

- Present the strongest case for and against concentrated authority at every step (FRAMEWORK.md).
- Analyse coups, repression and collapse causally and historically only; no operational content on seizing power, overthrowing governments, suppressing opposition, or engineering instability (BRIEF Part IX).
- Keep "capable," "legitimate," "accountable," "effective" and "sustainable" analytically distinct (BRIEF Part VIII). A regime can be any of these without the others; the database records them separately.
- Do not let a ruler's personal record stand in for an institution's record. Every country chapter reports outcomes by leader spell as well as by regime spell.

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2. Operational definitions and coding rules for the political systems (BRIEF Part II)

2.1 Four foundational distinctions

BRIEF Part II asks us to explain "the differences between hereditary legitimacy, personalist authority, institutionalized authoritarianism, and constitutional government" and never to use monarchy and dictatorship

interchangeably. We define these four concepts first, because the ten regime types are built from them.

Hereditary legitimacy. Authority whose claim rests on membership of a ruling lineage and on a succession rule (formal or customary) that restricts the pool of eligible rulers to that lineage. In Weber's terms this is a form of *traditional* authority (Weber, *Economy and Society*) [E]. Its defining empirical feature is not the title "king" but the *selection rule*: the next ruler is chosen from the family, by the family or by a fixed rule of descent. GWF build the same idea into their coding: the start date of a monarchy is the year after "a new dynasty achieves office because different dynasties identify different groups from whom regime leaders can be chosen" [V, GWF codebook v1.2]. Hereditary legitimacy can coexist with any degree of power, from ceremonial (Japan) to absolute (Saudi Arabia).

Personalist authority. Authority concentrated in one individual whose discretion is not effectively constrained by a party, a military command structure, a royal family council or a legislature, and whose control over appointments, security forces and rents is personal. In Weber's scheme, personalism can draw on charismatic claims, but it is defined here by *structure*, not rhetoric: who can remove the ruler, and whether anyone realistically can. GWF code "personal" regimes where "access to office and the fruits of office depend much more on the discretion of an individual leader" than on a party or military institution (Geddes, Wright & Frantz 2014) [E for exact wording; categories V]. Personalism is a *dimension*, not only a category: a monarchy or a party regime can personalize (as GWF's hybrid "party-personal" and "military-personal" categories recognise [V]).

Institutionalized authoritarianism. Non-democratic rule in which leadership selection, succession and policy are governed by an organization with its own rules and interests that outlast any individual: a ruling party (China, Vietnam, Singapore's PAP in dominant-party form), a military hierarchy acting corporately (South Korea 1961–1987 in part, Brazil 1964–1985), a clerical-institutional order (Iran after 1979), or a royal family operating through a family council and established seniority norms. The test is whether the organization has, in practice, removed or constrained a sitting leader or managed succession without the leader's sole choice.

Constitutional government. Rule in which the exercise of public power, including by the head of state, is bounded by a higher law that is (a) publicly known, (b) not changeable at the unilateral will of the ruler, and (c) enforced in practice by actors the ruler does not control (courts, legislature, electorate). Constitutional government is *not* synonymous with democracy: a regime can have a written constitution without constitutionalism (Kuwait after May 2024, where the ruler suspended the articles that vest legislative power in the National Assembly [V, Law Library of Congress]), and historically some constitutional orders limited power without universal suffrage.

2.2 Coding dimensions

Every country-year in the Phase 2 database is coded on six dimensions. The ten regime types are combinations of these codes, which makes classification transparent and lets readers re-aggregate.

Dimension	Question	Values	Primary sources
D1 Selection rule	How is the chief executive chosen and replaced?	hereditary (family/descent); party organ; military organ; personal designation/self-perpetuation; competitive election; other/unclear	GWF, A&F, CGV, Archigos, constitutions
D2 Locus of effective executive power	Who actually makes final decisions on government formation, budget, security, foreign policy?	monarch; party leadership; military council; individual ruler; elected head of government; shared	V-Dem (e.g., HOS/HOG power indicators), constitutions, country studies
D3 Electoral competition	Are the chief executive and legislature chosen in multiparty elections, and are those elections meaningful?	none; non-party or single-party; multiparty non-competitive; multiparty competitive but unfair; free and fair	V-Dem RoW and electoral indices, NELDA [E], Freedom House

Dimension	Question	Values	Primary sources
D4 Organizational base	Which organization, if any, can discipline the ruler?	royal family; party; military; clerical body; none (personal)	GWF case narratives, country studies
D5 Personalization score	How far has power concentrated in one person relative to the base organization?	0–1 index (GWF-style personalism items where available; otherwise coded from appointments, security control, family/party constraint)	GWF personalism indicators [E], V-Dem
D6 Governance overlays	Is there an explicit, institutionalized developmental project, and how insulated are technocrats?	developmental flag (0/1); technocratic-insulation score (0–3)	planning documents, civil-service law, central-bank/SWF statutes, Evans–Rauch style bureaucracy measures [E]

2.3 The ten regime types: definitions, coding rules, crosswalks

Rule zero. Types 1–3 are *monarchies* (D1 = hereditary and the hereditary ruler is the regime's apex). Types 4–7 are *non-monarchical autocracies*. Types 8–9 are *overlays* that attach to any autocratic type. Type 10 is a residual for regimes that combine democratic and autocratic features or cannot be stably assigned. Democracies are coded as parliamentary democracy, presidential republic or semi-presidential republic (needed for BRIEF Part VII), following CGV and A&F conventions.

Type 1 — Absolute monarchy.

- *Definition:* A hereditary ruler (with the ruling family) holds supreme executive and legislative authority; no elected body can block legislation, budgets or government formation; the monarch appoints and dismisses the government at will.
- *Necessary conditions:* D1 = hereditary; D2 = monarch; no elected body with binding legislative or budgetary veto, or such a body exists but is suspended or overridden at will.
- *Indicators:* constitutional text (who holds legislative power; who forms government); practice (dismissals, decrees, suspension of parliament).
- *Typical cases:* Saudi Arabia, Oman, Qatar, UAE (federal monarchy of hereditary rulers), Brunei, Eswatini; Ethiopia under Haile Selassie; Kuwait from May 2024 (see 2.6).
- *Crosswalk:* A&F "absolute monarchy" [V]; GWF "monarchy" [V]; CGV "royal dictatorship" [V via Cheibub DD page]; RoW usually "closed autocracy" [V for Gulf cases 2025 in OWID-processed V-Dem v16 file, data/r4/raw/owid_political-regime.csv].

Type 2 — Constitutional (parliamentary) monarchy.

- *Definition:* A hereditary head of state whose powers are formally or conventionally ceremonial; government is formed by and responsible to an elected parliament; the monarch does not determine policy.
- *Necessary conditions:* D1 = hereditary for head of state only; D2 = elected head of government; D3 = competitive elections.
- *Cases:* Japan (postwar contrast case in BRIEF Part IV), Spain after 1978, the Nordic and Benelux monarchies, the United Kingdom.
- *Crosswalk:* A&F "parliamentary monarchy" within democracies [V]; RoW electoral or liberal democracy.

Type 3 — Semi-constitutional monarchy.

- *Definition:* A hereditary monarch shares power with an elected legislature and/or an elected head of government but retains decisive *reserve* powers in at least one core domain (government formation, dissolution, security, foreign policy, religion, or veto), and uses them.
- *Necessary conditions:* D1 = hereditary; D2 = shared; D3 >= multiparty legislative elections with real but bounded influence.

- *Distinguishing from Type 1:* the elected body can at least sometimes defeat or force change in government policy, budget or ministers. *Distinguishing from Type 2:* the monarch retains and exercises decisive power.
- *Cases:* Jordan, Morocco, Kuwait (1962–2024 with interruptions), Bahrain since 2002 (borderline Type 1), Bhutan since 2008 (borderline Type 2), Tonga since 2010 (A&F's only "semi-monarchy among democracies" case in some years, per Anckar 2020 [E]); Nepal before 2002; Thailand in some periods (see 2.6).
- *Crosswalk:* A&F codes most such cases as autocratic "absolute monarchy" unless they pass its democracy threshold, in which case "semi-monarchy" [V for category; case codes E]; GWF codes Jordan, Morocco and Kuwait as continuous monarchical autocracies [V, codebook case list]; RoW codes Jordan and Morocco as closed autocracy (2010–2025) and Kuwait as electoral autocracy until 2024 [V, data/r4/raw/owid_political-regime.csv]. *Implication:* existing datasets disagree on whether "semi-constitutional" is a distinct category. We keep it distinct because it is where the King's dilemma (Huntington 1968 [E]) and reform-from-above strategies operate, and because Part X asks precisely whether power-sharing arrangements preserve the claimed advantages of monarchy.

Type 4 — Electoral authoritarianism.

- *Definition:* The chief executive and legislature are chosen in multiparty elections, but elections are systematically unfair (opposition harassment, media control, fraud, disqualification) so that incumbents are very unlikely to lose; the regime is not hereditary.
- *Necessary conditions:* D1 != hereditary; D3 = multiparty but unfair.
- *Cases:* Cambodia under the CPP; Rwanda under the RPF; Egypt after 2014; Indonesia under Suharto in its electoral form (GOLKAR elections) — though Suharto's regime is primarily coded Type 6/7 hybrid (see below).
- *Crosswalk:* RoW "electoral autocracy" [V definition via OWID]; Levitsky & Way 2010 "competitive authoritarianism" (subset, where competition is real but skewed) [E]; Schedler 2006 [E].

Type 5 — Military dictatorship.

- *Definition:* Rule by the armed forces as an institution: a junta or council of officers controls selection of the ruler and major policy; officers can and do replace the head of the junta.
- *Necessary conditions:* D4 = military; D2 = military council or officer-ruler accountable to the officer corps.
- *Cases:* Greece 1967–1974; Thailand 1957–1973, 1976–1988 and 2014–2019 (GWF codes the first two [V]); South Korea 1961–1987 (partly; GWF codes 1961–1987 as one regime [V case list]); Iraq 1958–1963 [V, GWF]; Ethiopia's Derg 1974–1991 [V, GWF, initially military].
- *Crosswalk:* GWF "military," "indirect military" [V]; CGV "military dictatorship" [V].

Type 6 — Personalist dictatorship.

- *Definition:* Non-hereditary rule in which one individual dominates the party, military and state, controls appointments and security personally, and faces no organization able to remove him.
- *Necessary conditions:* D1 != hereditary-family-rule as the operative rule; D5 high; D4 = none effective.
- *Cases:* Libya under Gaddafi; Iraq under Saddam Hussein (party-personal); Romania under Ceausescu (party-personal); Equatorial Guinea under Obiang; Zaire under Mobutu (Rizio & Skali 2020 describe income per capita roughly halving over 1965–1997 [V]).
- *Dynastic succession inside a personalist or party regime* (North Korea, Syria 2000, Azerbaijan 2003, Equatorial Guinea's designated heir) is flagged "dynastic succession, non-monarchy." It is not coded as monarchy because the selection rule is not institutionalized as family-based: there is no royal family council, no recognized lineage claim independent of the incumbent, and succession depends on the incumbent's personal designation. This preserves the BRIEF's instruction not to equate monarchy with dictatorship.
- *Crosswalk:* GWF "personal" [V]; A&F "personalist rule" [V].

Type 7 — One-party authoritarianism.

- *Definition:* A single party monopolizes legal political organization, or a dominant party controls access to office through institutions that discipline leaders and manage succession.
- *Sub-types:* single-party (North Korea's WPK formally; China; Vietnam; Yugoslavia under the League of Communists; Taiwan under the KMT before liberalization; Portugal's Estado Novo party apparatus was weak, so Portugal is a borderline personal/party case); dominant-party with multiparty elections (Singapore; Malaysia before 2018).

- *Necessary conditions:* D4 = party; leadership turnover or succession managed by party organs at least once, or party organs demonstrably constrain the leader.
- *Crosswalk:* GWF "party," "party-personal," "party-military" [V]; A&F "party-based rule" with sub-categories [V]; RoW often "electoral autocracy" for dominant-party systems that hold elections (Singapore is coded electoral autocracy 2010–2025 [V]).

Type 8 — Developmental authoritarianism (overlay).

- *Definition:* An authoritarian regime (any of Types 1, 3–7) that (a) adopts an explicit, sustained programme of national economic transformation as a central legitimating project, and (b) builds dedicated institutions to execute it (planning boards, industrial-policy agencies, development banks, performance targets for officials).
- *Coding rule:* Coded from *inputs and institutions* in the first five years of the programme, never from subsequent growth. Required evidence: a published plan or vision with targets; a lead agency with budget authority; personnel rules for that agency. Example inputs: South Korea's Economic Planning Board (1961) [E]; Taiwan's Council for Economic Planning and Development lineage [E]; Singapore's Economic Development Board (1961) [E]; Saudi Vision 2030 and its delivery programmes (2016) [E]; Ethiopia's Growth and Transformation Plans under the EPRDF [E]; Rwanda's Vision 2020 [E].
- *Why an overlay:* Developmental ambition can attach to monarchies, military regimes, party regimes and personalist regimes. Treating it as a regime type would make "developmental authoritarianism succeeds" true by definition. Coded failures are as important as coded successes (for example, Iran's Pahlavi-era Plan Organization and White Revolution, Nasser's planned industrialization, Ceausescu's industrial drives).

Type 9 — Technocratic authoritarianism (overlay).

- *Definition:* An authoritarian regime in which key economic ministries, the central bank, the planning agency or sovereign wealth fund are staffed and run by professionally recruited experts with protected tenure and substantial policy autonomy from patronage demands.
- *Coding rule:* Technocratic-insulation score 0–3, one point each for (i) merit-based recruitment into core economic agencies (entrance examinations or professional hiring), (ii) legal or demonstrated tenure protection/low politically driven turnover of agency heads, (iii) agency autonomy over a policy instrument (monetary policy, investment allocation, procurement rules). Score >=2 with an autocratic base type = technocratic authoritarian overlay.
- *Cases to test:* Indonesia's "Berkeley mafia" technocrats under Suharto [E]; Chile's economists under Pinochet [E]; Singapore; the UAE's and Qatar's professionalized SWFs and free-zone authorities; Franco's 1959 Stabilization Plan technocrats [E].
- *Note:* Technocracy can exist inside democracies (Part X): the same score is coded for democracies to enable the separability tests.

Type 10 — Hybrid political systems (residual).

- *Definition:* Regimes that combine meaningful electoral competition with entrenched unelected power centres (a palace, a military, a judiciary or appointed senate) that can override elected governments, or regimes in rapid oscillation.
- *Coding rule:* Assign Type 10 only when the decision tree (2.5) returns conflicting answers for D2 and D3 in the same year, or when the country changes type three or more times in ten years. Each Type 10 country-year must record which unelected "reserve domain" exists (palace, military, appointed body, courts).
- *Cases:* Thailand 2007–2013 and 2023–present; Pakistan in civilian-military "hybrid" phases; Iran's elected presidency within clerical supremacy is *not* coded Type 10 but Type 7-variant ("clerical-institutional"), following GWF's practice of treating Iran 1979– as a party-based-type regime [V].

2.4 Existing typologies compared

Dataset	Coverage	Autocratic categories	Monarchy treatment	Strength for this project	Limitation
Geddes, Wright & Frantz (GWF), *Perspectives on Politics* 12(2) 2014, pp. 313–331	1946–2010; independent states >1 million population; 280 autocratic regimes; 4,587 country-years [V]	party, military, personal, monarchy, plus hybrids (party-personal, military-personal, party-military, indirect military, oligarchy) [V]	Monarchy = autocratic regime in which a dynasty selects the ruler; start dated from new dynasty [V]	Regime-spell structure, transition types, case narratives with sources	Ends 2010; excludes small states (Bahrain, Brunei, Qatar are at or below the threshold for parts of the period, to be checked in Phase 2); no semi-constitutional category
V-Dem Regimes of the World (Lührmann, Tannenberg & Lindberg 2018, *Politics and Governance* 6(1))	~1789–2025 in V-Dem v16 (March 2026) [E for release; V for data file through 2025]	closed autocracy, electoral autocracy (plus democratic categories) [V]	Does not distinguish monarchy; ruling monarchies without elected executives fall into closed autocracy [V for Jordan, Morocco 2010–2025]	Annual, current to 2025, uncertainty estimates	Collapses monarchy into autocracy; Brunei absent from the processed file [V: zero Brunei rows]
Polity5 (Marshall & Gurr), Center for Systemic Peace	1800–2018; states >500,000 population [E]	-10 to +10 scale; autocracy (-10 to -6), anocracy, democracy [E]	None	Long series, executive-constraints component useful	Not updated after 2018 (project lost funding in 2020 per secondary source [E]); scale mixes dimensions
Anckar & Fredriksson, Political Regimes of the World v3.0 (Harvard Dataverse, 15 May 2025; doi:10.7910/DVN/AK8NVX); original article *European Political Science* 18(1) 2019, pp. 84–96	1800–2024; all countries independent at any point since WWII [V]	absolute monarchy, military rule, party-based rule, personalist rule, oligarchy (with sub-categories) [V]	Democracies split into republics and monarchies; monarchies mostly parliamentary, a few "semi-monarchies"; autocratic monarchies = "absolute monarchy" [V]	The only major dataset with an explicit absolute-monarchy category, current to 2024, including microstates	Semi-constitutional ruling monarchies (Jordan, Morocco) are folded into "absolute monarchy" if not democratic [inferred from category structure; to verify case codes in Phase 2]

Dataset	Coverage	Autocratic categories	Monarchy treatment	Strength for this project	Limitation
Cheibub, Gandhi & Vreeland (CGV/DD), *Public Choice* 143(1–2) 2010, pp. 67–101	1946–2008, 202 countries [E via author site excerpt]	civilian, military, royal dictatorship; democracies parliamentary, mixed, presidential [E via site excerpt; V via GWF codebook crosswalk]	"Royal" dictatorship	Clean democracy/dictatorship rule; parliamentary vs presidential split needed for Part VII	Ends 2008; "civilian" lumps party and personalist rule
Gerring et al., "Why Monarchy?" *Comparative Political Studies* 54(3–4) 2021, pp. 585–622	Europe back to 1100, world back to 1700 [V abstract]	monarchy vs republic	Theorises monarchy as an efficient solution to coordination problems that erodes as communication costs fall [V abstract]	Long-run theory of monarchical decline	Not a regime-type dataset for post-1945 autocracies

Decision. The Phase 2 database uses GWF regime spells as the backbone for 1946–2010, A&F v3.0 for monarchy identification and for 2011–2024, V-Dem v16 for annual electoral and constraint measures through 2025, and hand-coding from primary sources for 2025–2026 and for every ambiguous case. Disagreements between datasets are recorded, not hidden: each country-year carries the GWF, A&F, RoW and CGV codes alongside ours.

2.5 Coding protocol (decision tree)

1. Is the state sovereign and does a central authority control most territory? If no: code "not independent," "foreign-occupied" or "warlord/no authority" (GWF convention [V]).
2. Is the chief executive chosen in free, fair, multiparty elections and able to govern without being overridden by unelected actors? If yes -> democracy; sub-code parliamentary/presidential/semi-presidential; if a hereditary head of state exists with only ceremonial powers -> Type 2.
3. If not a democracy: Is the apex ruler selected by a hereditary rule within a ruling family recognized as such (royal family council, lineage claim pre-dating the incumbent)? If yes -> monarchy:
    a. Does an elected body have and use binding power over legislation, budget or ministers, or does the monarch appoint the head of government from an electoral outcome under a binding rule? If yes and the monarch still holds decisive reserve powers -> Type 3. If no -> Type 1.
4. If not a monarchy: Which organization can remove or constrain the ruler? Military -> Type 5; party -> Type 7; none -> Type 6. If personalization is high within a party or military regime, record the GWF-style hybrid (party-personal, military-personal).
5. Are there regular multiparty elections for the executive or legislature that are unfair? If yes and no other type dominates -> Type 4; otherwise record the electoral feature as an attribute of Types 5–7.
6. Apply overlays: developmental flag (Type 8) and technocratic-insulation score (Type 9).
7. If steps 2–5 give conflicting answers in the same year, or the country changes type >=3 times in 10 years -> Type 10, with the reserve domain recorded.
8. Date changes to the event (decree, coup, election, death) and record the date and source; country-year codes reflect the regime in power on 1 January of the following year, following GWF practice [V].

Inter-coder reliability: in Phase 2, two independent agent passes code every Tier 1 and Tier 2 case; disagreements are adjudicated against primary sources and logged.

2.6 How ambiguous cases are coded

Jordan. Hereditary Hashemite monarchy since independence in 1946; GWF code it as a continuous monarchical autocracy [V]. The 1952 constitution vests executive power in the King exercised through ministers [E, Article 26 as quoted in secondary legal analysis]; the King appoints and dismisses the prime minister and can dissolve parliament; parliament is elected but the upper house is appointed. January 2022 constitutional amendments created a National Security and Foreign Policy Council that meets at the King's invitation and whose decisions take effect on royal approval [E, Petra news agency; Carnegie Sada analysis]. RoW codes Jordan as closed autocracy 2010–2025 [V]. **Our code: Type 3 (semi-constitutional monarchy), with low parliamentary leverage; sensitivity analysis reclassifies as Type 1.** Rationale: the elected chamber has some budget and confidence powers and has occasionally forced cabinet changes, but security and foreign policy are reserved to the palace.

Morocco. Alawite monarchy; GWF continuous monarchy from 1956 [V]. The 2011 constitution, approved by referendum on 1 July 2011, requires the King to appoint the head of government "from within the political party arriving ahead in the elections" (Article 47) [E, Constitute Project text and official Moroccan government page]; the King presides over the Council of Ministers (Article 48) [E] and retains religious authority as Commander of the Faithful and control of security and foreign policy [E]. Freedom House notes the reforms "preserved nearly all of the king's existing powers" [E]. **Our code: Type 3 from 2011; Type 3 with weaker parliamentary leverage 1956–2011 (Type 1 in 1965–1970 state-of-exception years, to be verified in Phase 2).**

Kuwait. Al Sabah emirate; GWF continuous monarchy from 1961 [V]. Under the 1962 constitution, Kuwait had the most powerful elected legislature in the Gulf, able to question and remove ministers. On 10 May 2024 the Emir dissolved the National Assembly and suspended, for "a period not exceeding four years," Articles 51 (legislative power vested in Amir and Assembly), 56(2), 71(2), 79 (no law without Assembly passage), 107 (elections within two months of dissolution), 174 and 181 [V, Law Library of Congress, Global Legal Monitor, 23–24 May 2024]. A Congressional Research Service report updated 14 January 2026 states that the suspension "effectively enables the government to rule by decree" and that the suspension persisted into 2026 [E, CRS R47390 excerpt]. RoW codes Kuwait electoral autocracy through 2024 and closed autocracy in 2025 [V]. Parliament was also unconstitutionally dissolved in 1976 and 1986 [E, Freedom House 2025]. **Our code: Type 3 for 1963–1976, 1981–1986, 1992–May 2024; Type 1 for 1976–1981, 1986–1992 and from May 2024 onward, flagged "constitutional suspension."** This makes Kuwait the project's most valuable within-country natural experiment on whether removing legislative constraints changes fiscal and development policy (Kuwait's acting finance minister argued in 2025 that the suspension would accelerate projects [E, Reuters, 3 September 2025]); the hypothesis is tested, not assumed (H1, Section 3).

Thailand. Constitutional monarchy since 1932 in formal terms, but with repeated military coups and a politically influential palace. GWF code military regimes 1947–1957, 1957–1973 and 1976–1988 [V]. RoW codes Thailand closed autocracy 2014–2022 (post-2014 junta and the transition under the 2017 constitution) and electoral autocracy 2023–2025 [V]. The 2017 constitution defines the regime as "a democratic regime of government with the King as Head of State" (Section 2) [E, Senate English translation]. After the 8 February 2026 general election, Anutin Charnvirakul was elected prime minister by the House on 19 March 2026 with 293 votes [E, Bangkok Post; DW; Thai embassy]. **Our code: Thailand is never coded as a ruling monarchy (Types 1/3) in 1946–2026; it is coded Type 5 during junta periods, Type 2 in clearly democratic periods (for example 1992–2006, subject to Phase 2 review), and Type 10 (hybrid; reserve domains: palace, military, Constitutional Court) in 2007–2013 and 2019–2026.** Rationale: the monarch does not form governments or legislate, so treating Thailand as a monarchy-led regime would conflate royal influence with royal rule; but the palace's informal power is recorded as a reserve domain. Sensitivity analysis codes 2023–2026 as Type 4.

Eswatini (Swaziland). GWF date the monarchical regime from independence in 1968 and record that in 1973 the King "declared a state of emergency, dismissed parliament, dissolved all parties, and ruled by decree" [V, GWF codebook; date of decree to be verified in Phase 2]. Political parties remain unable to register or contest elections under the tinkhundla system; 59 House members are elected as individuals after vetting by chiefs, the King appoints 10 more members and 20 of 30 senators [E, Freedom House 2023–2024; BTI 2026]. RoW codes closed autocracy throughout 2010–2025 [V]. **Our code: Type 1 (absolute monarchy) from 1973; Type 3 for 1968–1973.** Note that elections without parties do not make Eswatini an electoral autocracy (Type 4), because the executive is not elected and elections do not determine government.

Other cases requiring explicit rules.

- *Saudi Arabia under Crown Prince and Prime Minister Mohammed bin Salman:* Type 1, with a rising personalization score (D5) since 2017; the historical constraint of family seniority and collective princely consultation is coded as weakened, not absent. This is the main test case for H7 (succession) and for whether monarchies personalize like other autocracies.
- *UAE:* Type 1 at the federal level, coded additionally as a federation of seven hereditary emirates with asymmetric power (Abu Dhabi dominant); the "decentralized monarchy within a centralized federation" question of BRIEF Part III is handled by sub-national codes for Abu Dhabi and Dubai.
- *Qatar:* Type 1 throughout. The first partially elected Shura Council (2021) was reversed by the 5 November 2024 constitutional referendum: the amendments, approved by 90.6% of valid votes, provide that Shura members are appointed by Amiri Order (new Article 77) and repeal the electoral articles 78, 79 and 82 [V, Qatar Council of Ministers General Secretariat page].
- *Oman:* Type 1. The 2021 Basic Statute (Royal Decree 6/2021, 11 January 2021) made succession hereditary in the male line of Sultan Turki bin Said with an eldest-son rule and created the office of crown prince by royal order (Articles 5 and 7) [E, decree.om consolidated text]; previously, Sultan Qaboos had no children and had named a successor in a sealed letter [E, Reuters]. Oman is the clearest case of a monarchy *institutionalizing* succession during our period.
- *Bahrain:* Type 1 to 2002; from 2002 borderline Type 3/Type 1 (elected lower house, appointed upper house of equal size); coded Type 1 with an "elected advisory chamber" flag, sensitivity Type 3. RoW: closed autocracy 2010–2025 [V].
- *Brunei:* Type 1 throughout (independence 1984; legislative council appointed). V-Dem does not cover Brunei in the processed file [V], so Brunei is coded from A&F, GWF (if above population threshold; to verify) and primary sources.
- *Iran 1925–1979 (Pahlavi):* Type 1 with high personalization (Mohammad Reza Shah, especially after 1953 and the 1975 Rastakhiz single-party decree [E]). GWF date the regime from 15 December 1925 [V].
- *Iran 1979–present:* Type 7-variant ("clerical-institutional"), following GWF's grouping of Iran 1979– with party-based regimes [V], with an electoral-competition attribute (Type 4 features within limits set by the Guardian Council).
- *Ethiopia 1941/1945–1974:* Type 1 (Haile Selassie; 1955 constitution did not create a government responsible to parliament [E]); 1974–1991 Type 5 then party-personal (Derg/WPE) [V for regime dates]; 1991–2018 Type 7 (EPRDF) with developmental overlay; 2018–2026 to be coded in Phase 2.
- *Nepal:* Rana hereditary-prime-minister oligarchy to 1951 [V, GWF]; Type 1 (Panchayat royal rule) 1960–1990 (GWF date the royal regime 1951–1991 [V]); Type 2/3 1991–2002; Type 1 2002–2006 after King Gyanendra assumed executive power [V, GWF]; monarchy abolished 2008 [E].
- *Cambodia:* Sihanouk's Sangkum period (1955–1970) coded Type 3/personalist hybrid (a former king ruling as head of a mass movement); 1970–1975 Type 5 (Lon Nol); 1975–1979 Type 7 (Khmer Rouge); 1979–1991 Type 7 under Vietnamese occupation; 1993– constitutional monarchy formally, with the CPP coded Type 4 (electoral authoritarian) — RoW electoral autocracy 2010–2025 [V]. The restored king is a Type 2-style head of state within a Type 4 regime.
- *Spain:* Franco 1939–1975 Type 6/military-personal (GWF date 1939–1976 [V]); Franco's 1947 Law of Succession declared Spain a kingdom with Franco as regent-for-life and Juan Carlos named successor in 1969 [E]; the 1978 constitution created a Type 2 monarchy. Spain is a key case for the claim that a monarch can be an *agent of democratization*.
- *Malaysia:* elective federal monarchy with rotating Yang di-Pertuan Agong chosen from nine hereditary rulers; the monarchy is coded Type 2, the regime Type 7 (dominant-party BN) until 2018.

2.7 Does hereditary succession create different incentives from personalist or military rule?

This sub-question of Part II is answered in Chapter 3 by confronting four claims with evidence.

1. **Horizon claim:** a dynasty that expects to rule across generations internalizes the long-run returns to investment more than a personalist ruler with an uncertain tenure (Olson 1993's stationary bandit [V via citation]). *Evidence to test:* investment, property-rights and SWF-saving behaviour by regime type, controlling for rents; Knutsen & Fjelde (2013), "Property rights in dictatorships: kings protect property better than generals or party bosses" [E; venue and estimates to be verified in Phase 4]; Menaldo 2012 finds

MENA monarchs more likely to respect rule of law and property rights and to grow their economies in a 1950–2006 panel, using an instrument for tribal legacy [V abstract].

2. **Succession-stability claim:** a known succession rule reduces the deadly uncertainty of autocratic succession. *Evidence:* Kokkonen & Sundell (2014) show that primogeniture increased European monarchs' chances of surviving in office in 1000–1800 [V abstract snippet, APSR 108(2): 438–453]. Whether this transfers to post-1945 Gulf monarchies, which historically used agnatic seniority and family consensus rather than primogeniture, is an open question (Herb 1999 on "dynastic monarchy" [E]).
3. **Elite-commitment claim:** royal families function as a broad, organized ruling coalition (Herb 1999's dynastic monarchies distribute ministries among princes), which makes defection costly and coups harder [E]. *Counter-evidence:* the long list of monarchies overthrown by officers (Egypt 1952, Iraq 1958, North Yemen 1962, Libya 1969, Afghanistan 1973, Ethiopia 1974) [V for Egypt, Iraq, Libya, Ethiopia dates in GWF codebook; E others].
4. **Quality-variance claim (the cost side):** hereditary selection draws rulers from a tiny pool, so ruler quality is a lottery; the system relies on family councils or informal deselection (Saudi Arabia's removal of King Saud in 1964; Qatar's palace coups of 1972 and 1995 [E]) to correct bad draws. Jones & Olken (2005) find that leaders matter for growth in autocracies, particularly those "without parties or legislatures to contest their rule," but not detectably in democracies [V], implying higher outcome variance wherever selection is narrow.

Chapter 3 will report these as competing claims with their evidence, not as settled findings.

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3. Competing hypotheses for Parts V and VII, stated so they can be falsified

3.1 Conventions

Each hypothesis is stated as a pair: a **concentration-favourable** version (H*n*a) and its strongest **rival** (H*n*b). For each we give observable implications, the evidence that would **disconfirm** it, the test design, and the data. All are marked (hypothesis). "Concentrated regimes" means Types 1, 5, 6 and 7 with high personalization unless stated; "monarchies" means Types 1 and 3. Every test conditions on rents per capita, initial income, population size and decade, and reports results separately for hydrocarbon-rich and hydrocarbon-poor strata.

3.2 Part V hypotheses

H1 — Concentrated decision-making.

- *H1a (hypothesis):* Concentrated authority reduces coordination costs and veto points, so concentrated regimes complete large public investment projects faster, and with fewer cancellations, than fragmented regimes at similar income and capacity.
- *H1b (hypothesis):* Speed gains are offset by worse project selection and cost control because reduced competition removes information and accountability; concentrated regimes show more white-elephant projects, larger cost overruns and more abandoned megaprojects.
- *Observable implications:* H1a predicts shorter time from announcement to completion and lower cancellation rates; H1b predicts higher variance of returns, more overruns, and investment surges uncorrelated with later productivity.
- *Disconfirms H1a:* no difference (or longer) completion times after conditioning on capacity; or speed advantages confined to rent-financed projects (which would point to money, not structure). *Disconfirms H1b:* overrun and abandonment rates no higher than in comparable democracies.
- *Tests:* project-level data where available (World Bank project evaluations; IMF Public Investment Management Assessments (PIMA) reports; megaproject announcements versus completion in Gulf states, for example NEOM-related scope changes as reported in primary or reputable sources, to be verified); Kuwait before versus after May 2024 (project approvals, budget execution) as a within-country test; Public Investment Management Index [E].

H2 — Long-term planning horizon.

- *H2a (hypothesis):* Hereditary succession lengthens the ruler's planning horizon relative to electoral cycles and to non-hereditary dictatorships, producing (i) more long-horizon public investment, (ii) more saving of resource revenue, and (iii) greater policy continuity across leader changes.
- *H2b (hypothesis):* Horizons are set by expected tenure and regime security, not hereditary form; monarchs under threat behave like short-horizon rulers, and stable democracies sustain long-horizon policies through institutions (independent central banks, fiscal rules, SWF statutes, cross-party plans).
- *Observable implications:* H2a predicts higher public capital formation and higher saving rates of resource revenue in monarchies than in other autocracies with similar rents, and smaller policy shifts at monarchical successions than at autocratic successions elsewhere.
- *Disconfirms H2a:* no monarchy premium in saving or investment after conditioning on rents per citizen; or policy discontinuity at successions as large as in personalist regimes (for example, the 2015–2017 Saudi reorientation under a new king). *Disconfirms H2b:* the monarchy premium survives conditioning on survival probability.
- *Tests:* resource-revenue saving rates (SWF inflows relative to hydrocarbon revenue, from SWF and IMF Article IV data); gross fixed capital formation (WDI NE.GFI.TOTL.ZS); policy-continuity coding of national plans across leader changes; comparisons with Norway, Chile and Botswana as constitutional cases with long-horizon resource rules.

H3 — Elite coordination.

- *H3a (hypothesis):* Ruling families and cohesive ruling coalitions solve the elite-commitment problem, which lowers expropriation risk and coup risk, which in turn encourages private investment.
- *H3b (hypothesis):* Coordinated elites coordinate primarily on rent extraction; the result is crony capitalism, barriers to entry and a private sector dependent on state contracts (Hertog 2010 on "segmented clientelism" in Saudi Arabia [E]; Acemoglu 2008 on oligarchic stagnation over time [V via Rizio & Skali summary]).
- *Disconfirms H3a:* private investment and firm entry in monarchies no higher than in other autocracies at similar rents; high concentration of private-sector revenue among politically connected firms. *Disconfirms H3b:* competitive entry and firm dynamics comparable to upper-middle-income democracies.
- *Tests:* World Bank Enterprise Surveys [E]; private-credit-to-GDP (WDI FS.AST.PRVT.GD.ZS); entry data; Bertelsmann BTI market-organization scores; case evidence on royal-family business holdings (reputable investigative journalism, flagged as such).

H4 — Technocratic administration.

- *H4a (hypothesis):* Technically competent, insulated agencies can coexist with, and may be easier to create under, limited political competition, because rulers can shield technocrats from patronage.
- *H4b (hypothesis):* Insulation under autocracy is revocable at the ruler's will and therefore fragile; technocratic capacity in autocracies is concentrated in "pockets of efficiency" (SWFs, central banks, free zones) while the general bureaucracy remains patrimonial. Democracies achieve equal or better insulation through rules that rulers cannot unilaterally revoke.
- *Disconfirms H4a:* no difference in technocratic-insulation scores or in government-effectiveness measures between autocracies and democracies at similar income; or high turnover of agency heads following political shifts. *Disconfirms H4b:* broad-based (not enclave) bureaucratic quality persisting across leader changes in autocracies.
- *Tests:* technocratic-insulation score (Section 2.2, D6); WGI Government Effectiveness; V-Dem "rigorous and impartial public administration" (v2clrspct) [E]; Quality of Government expert survey on bureaucratic professionalism [E]; turnover of central bank governors and finance ministers (Dreher et al. data [E]).

H5 — Resource wealth.

- *H5a (rentier hypothesis):* Hydrocarbon rents stabilize autocracy (by funding patronage, coercion and low taxation) and are the main reason Gulf monarchies survived and prospered; regime form adds little once rents per citizen are controlled.
- *H5b (resource-blessing or conditional hypothesis):* Rents do not by themselves entrench authoritarianism (Haber & Menaldo 2011 find no robust relationship using long time series and fixed effects [V abstract]); outcomes depend on how rents are governed, and the post-1980 period differs from earlier ones (Andersen & Ross, "The Big Oil Change," *Comparative Political Studies* [E]).
- *Sub-hypotheses:* Dutch disease (resource booms crowd out tradables and depress non-resource productivity);

fiscal volatility (rents transmit commodity price shocks into public spending); rentier bargain (no taxation, no representation).

- *Disconfirms H5a:* resource-poor monarchies (Jordan, Morocco) survive at rates similar to resource-rich ones, while resource-rich non-monarchies (Iraq, Libya, Algeria, Venezuela) do not show comparable stability; or monarchies outperform non-monarchies within the same rent stratum. *Disconfirms H5b:* rents robustly predict autocratic survival and weaker non-resource productivity across specifications and periods.
- *Tests:* survival models stratified by rents per citizen (WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS combined with GLMM citizen populations); Ross–Mahdavi oil and gas data 1932–2014 [E]; non-oil GDP growth from IMF Article IV reports; export concentration.

H6 — Self-binding institutions.

- *H6a (hypothesis):* Centralized rulers can create institutions that constrain their own successors and even themselves (independent SWF boards, codified succession, audit bodies, investment courts), which explains durable performance in some autocracies.
- *H6b (hypothesis):* Self-imposed constraints in autocracies are cheap talk unless an organized actor can enforce them; they are suspended when inconvenient (Kuwait 2024; Qatar's 2024 reversal of Shura elections), so durable performance must rest on something else (rents, patrons, elite bargains).
- *Disconfirms H6a:* documented episodes where constraints were overridden whenever binding (SWF raids during fiscal stress; succession rules rewritten to suit incumbents). *Disconfirms H6b:* constraints observed to bind incumbents against their revealed preference.
- *Tests:* event histories of institutional changes in each Gulf state and in comparison cases (Singapore's reserves protection under the elected presidency [E]; Chile's fiscal rule; Norway's fiscal rule); Santiago Principles self-assessments (IFSWF) and their limits.

H7 — Succession risk.

- *H7a (hypothesis):* Hereditary monarchies manage succession with less violence and less economic disruption than personalist and military regimes, because rules and family councils reduce uncertainty.
- *H7b (hypothesis):* Hereditary succession reduces the frequency of crises but not their severity when they occur; it also locks in poor successors more than institutional (party or electoral) succession, so the expected cost is similar.
- *Observable implications:* H7a predicts fewer irregular exits and smaller growth dips after monarchical successions than after personalist successions; H7b predicts fat tails (rare but large crises) and larger leader-quality variance in monarchies than in party regimes.
- *Disconfirms H7a:* irregular removal rates for monarchs comparable to other autocrats (Archigos exit codes); growth dips after monarchical successions as large as after personalist ones. *Disconfirms H7b:* no evidence of larger leader-quality variance under hereditary selection.
- *Tests:* Archigos leader entries/exits; GWF transition codes (violent vs non-violent, autocracy-to-autocracy vs democratization) [V for structure]; Jones–Olken style leader-death designs restricted to monarchs; case comparisons (Saudi 1953, 1964, 1975, 1982, 2005, 2015 successions; Oman 2020; Kuwait 2006, 2020, 2023; Jordan 1999; Morocco 1999; versus succession crises in personalist regimes).

3.3 Part VII: multidimensional comparison hypotheses

BRIEF Part VII requires comparing seven systems (A absolute monarchy, B constitutional monarchy, C presidential republic, D parliamentary democracy, E one-party authoritarianism, F military dictatorship, G technocratic authoritarianism) across fourteen dimensions without producing "a simplistic ranking." The approach: for each dimension, state the expected *trade-off*, the mechanism, the condition under which it reverses, and what evidence would disconfirm the expectation. Where theory gives no directional expectation, the monograph says so.

#	Dimension	Concentration-favourable expectation (hypothesis)	Rival expectation (hypothesis)	Disconfirming evidence	Core measures
1	Policy continuity	A, E, G show fewer policy reversals than C, D	B, D with institutionalized fiscal/planning rules match A; A and F show sharp discontinuities at ruler change	Reversal frequency in A >= D after conditioning on leader changes	Plan-continuity coding; policy volatility (e.g., fiscal policy volatility à la Fatás & Mihov [E])
2	Bureaucratic efficiency	A, E, G can build efficient bureaucracies faster	Efficiency tracks income and merit recruitment, not regime; autocracies show enclave efficiency	No regime gap in WGI-GE after income control; or gap reversed	WGI Government Effectiveness; V-Dem public administration; QoG expert survey
3	Long-term infrastructure investment	A, E invest more in long-lived infrastructure	Investment levels similar; quality and returns worse under weak accountability	No difference in public investment efficiency; or lower efficiency in A, E	IMF PIMA; public capital stock (IMF Investment and Capital Stock dataset [E])
4	Economic diversification	A with SWFs and visions diversify faster	Rentier incentives impede diversification regardless of plans; diversification succeeds where tradables sector is competitive	Export concentration unchanged after decades of plans; or diversification equally achieved by D cases	Export concentration (UNCTAD/Atlas), non-oil GDP share, non-oil exports
5	Innovation	G, E can direct R&D effectively	Innovation requires open information and competition; D and B lead	Patent/researcher output in A, E, G >= D at equal income	WIPO patents [E]; R&D % GDP (WDI GB.XPD.RSDV.GD.ZS); researchers per million
6	Human capital development	A with rents can fund rapid schooling and health gains	Spending != learning; learning outcomes lag spending in rentier states	Gulf learning outcomes match spending peers; or D peers outperform at lower spending	Harmonized Learning Outcomes / Human Capital Index (HD.HCI.OVRL); PISA/TIMSS; life expectancy

#	Dimension	Concentration-favourable expectation (hypothesis)	Rival expectation (hypothesis)	Disconfirming evidence	Core measures
7	Corruption control	Monarchs and G can suppress petty corruption top-down	Grand corruption and opacity persist without independent audit and press	Low petty-corruption scores coexist with high grand-corruption indicators (or not)	TI CPI; WGI Control of Corruption; V-Dem corruption indices
8	Political accountability	(No concentration-favourable expectation)	Accountability is lower by construction in A, E, F, G; the question is whether informal accountability (family councils, selectorates) substitutes	Evidence of rulers removed or policies reversed by informal selectorates	V-Dem accountability index; Archigos exits
9	Succession stability	A (and E) have more orderly succession than F and personalist regimes	B and D have the most orderly succession; A orderly only while family consensus holds	Irregular exit rates in A ~ F	Archigos; GWF transitions
10	Civil liberties	(No concentration-favourable expectation)	Lower in A, E, F, G; within-autocracy variation matters (Morocco vs Saudi; Singapore vs North Korea)	— (descriptive)	V-Dem civil liberties; Freedom House
11	Institutional independence	G may grant autonomy to economic agencies	Independence is revocable in autocracies; durable only with external enforcement	Agency independence surviving leader changes in A, E, G	Central bank independence indices (Garriga 2016 [E]); judicial independence (V-Dem)
12	Crisis management	A, E act faster in acute crises (pandemics, price shocks)	Speed without information produces larger errors; D recover better	Mortality and output losses in crises no lower in A, E; or lower	Excess mortality (COVID-19), output losses after oil shocks of 1986, 2014–2016, 2020

#	Dimension	Concentration-favourable expectation (hypothesis)	Rival expectation (hypothesis)	Disconfirming evidence	Core measures
13	Fiscal discipline	A with SWFs save more and avoid debt crises	Discipline tracks oil price cycles; D with fiscal rules equally disciplined	Procyclical spending in A; debt build-ups after price falls	IMF GFS; non-oil primary balance; GGXWDG_NGDP (IMF WEO); fiscal breakeven oil prices (IMF REO [E])
14	Intergenerational sustainability	A with SWFs and long horizons protect future generations	Saving rates fall short of permanent-income benchmarks; succession risk threatens continuity	Net financial wealth per citizen declining relative to depletion; or rising	SWF assets (audited where available), IMF intergenerational-equity analyses for GCC [E], World Bank Changing Wealth of Nations [E]

How the comparison is reported. For each dimension, results are shown as distributions by system type within rent strata, with named exceptions, followed by a "conditions" paragraph (when the advantage appears, when it vanishes). No composite index across the fourteen dimensions is constructed, because any weighting would smuggle in a ranking the BRIEF forbids.

3.4 Master hypotheses for the final synthesis (Part XII)

- **M1 (hypothesis):** Absolute monarchy is associated with *higher variance*, not a higher mean, of development outcomes once rents per citizen are controlled. *Disconfirmed if* monarchies show a higher conditional mean with variance no larger than other autocracies.
- **M2 (hypothesis):** Gulf monarchical continuity is explained jointly by rents per citizen, small citizen populations, external security guarantees and family-coalition cohesion; no single factor is sufficient. *Disconfirmed if* monarchies lacking two or more of these factors survived at Gulf rates (Jordan and Morocco are the critical tests).
- **M3 (hypothesis):** The coordination advantages attributed to concentrated power can be reproduced by institutional arrangements (fiscal rules, independent SWF boards, merit civil service, cross-party planning commissions) under constitutional government. *Disconfirmed if* such arrangements systematically fail in democracies at similar income and rents while succeeding in autocracies.
- **M4 (hypothesis):** Successful authoritarian development requires a ruler accountable to a secure selectorate or organization (party, family council, military corporate body), not an unconstrained individual (consistent with Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [V via summary]). *Disconfirmed if* highly personalized regimes show development outcomes comparable to institutionalized autocracies.
- **M5 (hypothesis):** Prosperity without strong independent institutions is possible for small rentier states for long periods, but its sustainability depends on resource longevity and succession luck. *Disconfirmed if* non-rentier cases achieved sustained prosperity without independent institutions, or rentier cases collapsed despite strong rents.

4. Country-selection methodology and selection-bias correction

4.1 The selection problems we must correct

The BRIEF warns that "successful monarchies may be studied more often than failed monarchies, while resource-rich authoritarian states may not be representative of authoritarian states generally." In practice the literature on authoritarian development suffers from six distinct biases:

1. **Survivorship bias.** Today's eight Arab monarchies are survivors of a much larger post-1945 population of monarchies, many of which fell. Studying only survivors inflates apparent monarchical resilience. Yom & Gause (2012) make this point directly, describing "the long list of deposed monarchies" [V abstract].
2. **Success-case attention bias.** The "authoritarian development" narrative is built disproportionately on South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, Chile and China. For each of these there are many autocracies that did not develop. Rizio & Skali (2020) find that across 133 countries in 1858–2010, growth-positive autocrats occur at 3.3 percent against 2.5 percent expected by chance ($p = 0.24$), while growth-negative autocrats occur at 6.8 percent ($p < 0.001$) [V].
3. **Resource-stratum bias.** Gulf monarchies combine extreme rents per citizen with small citizen populations; generalizing from them to large, poor, resource-modest countries is invalid without stratification.
4. **Small-state bias.** Several key cases (Qatar, Bahrain, Brunei, the UAE's citizen population) are tiny; small polities have different coordination, security and administrative economics. Some standard datasets also drop them (GWF uses a one-million population threshold [V]; Polity uses 500,000 [E]).
5. **Era and patronage bias.** Cold War patronage, the 1970s oil boom and post-1990 US security guarantees for the Gulf are period-specific; outcomes in one era may not transfer.
6. **Measurement-denominator bias.** In labour-importing states, per capita figures computed on total residents (most of whom may be non-citizens) misstate citizen welfare, and per citizen figures misstate the welfare of the resident population. Kuwait's nationals were 32.1 percent of the population in mid-2024; Saudi Arabia's 55.6 percent; Oman's 56.8 percent; Bahrain's 46.6 percent; the UAE and Qatar publish no official breakdown (GLMM estimates for mid-2022: about 12.9 percent and 12.1 percent nationals) [E, GLMM tables].

4.2 Step one: define the full universe before choosing cases

- **Universe U1 (all regimes):** every sovereign state with population above 250,000 at any point 1946–2026 (lower than GWF's threshold so that Gulf microstates, Brunei, Bhutan and Eswatini are included), country-year panel.
- **Universe U2 (all monarchies in power):** every country-year in which a hereditary monarch was head of state, split into Types 1, 2 and 3, from A&F v3.0 (1800–2024) cross-checked with GWF and our coding for 2025–2026.
- **Universe U3 (all autocratic regime spells):** GWF's 280 autocratic regimes 1946–2010 [V], extended to 2026 using A&F and V-Dem RoW and hand-coding.

Fallen and transformed monarchies (minimum list to be fully coded in Phase 2). From FRAMEWORK.md: Egypt 1952 (monarchy formally abolished 1953), Iraq 1958, North Yemen 1962, Libya 1969, Afghanistan 1973, Ethiopia 1974, Iran 1979, Nepal 2008, Laos 1975, Cambodia (1970 overthrow; restored 1993), Greece 1973 (junta abolished; confirmed by 1974 referendum), Burundi 1966, Rwanda 1961, Zanzibar 1964, Tunisia 1957 [E for dates beyond those verified in GWF: Egypt 1952, Iraq 1958, Libya 1969, Ethiopia 1974 are V]. Phase 2 must add at least: Italy 1946, Bulgaria 1946, Romania 1947, Hungary 1946, Albania (monarchy ended under occupation; formally 1946), Yugoslavia 1945, Vietnam 1955 (Bao ?ai deposed by referendum), Maldives 1968, Sikkim 1975 (annexed), the self-proclaimed Central African Empire 1976–1979 (coded as personalist, not monarchy), and transitions from ruling to constitutional monarchy (Spain 1975–1978, Nepal 1990–1991, Bhutan 2008, Tonga 2010). Each entry records the mode of exit (coup, revolution, referendum, foreign intervention, negotiated transition) and the successor regime type, following GWF's transition variables.

Reporting rule. Every claim about monarchical survival or performance in the manuscript must first state the U2 base rate (number of monarchies in power in 1946, number surviving in 2026, hazard of breakdown by decade and by type), then the comparison with non-monarchical autocracies in U3, and only then the case evidence.

4.3 Step two: a stratified selection matrix

Cases for in-depth study are drawn from a matrix of three dimensions:

- **Political form (Layer 1):** ruling monarchy (Types 1/3); institutionalized non-monarchical autocracy (party or military corporate rule, Types 5/7); personalist autocracy (Type 6); democracy, including constitutional monarchy (Type 2 and democratic republics).
- **Resource endowment (Layer 3):** high hydrocarbon/mineral rents per citizen (above a threshold to be set in Phase 4, provisionally US$5,000 per citizen per year at 2021 prices using WDI rents and citizen populations); moderate rents (resource-dependent exports but low rents per citizen); resource-poor.
- **Era:** 1946–1989 and 1990–2026.

Provisional matrix of candidate cases (yes = development/stability success by conventional accounts; no = failure or collapse; ~ = mixed). Success labels are listed only so the reader can see that each cell contains both kinds; selection within cells is outcome-blind (4.4).

Form Endowment	High rents per citizen	Moderate rents	Resource-poor
Ruling monarchy	Saudi Arabia ~, UAE yes/~, Qatar yes/~, Kuwait ~, Brunei ~, Oman ~, Bahrain ~ (moderate by 2000s); Libya 1951–69 no (fell); Iran 1925–79 no (fell); Iraq 1932–58 no (fell)	Morocco ~ (phosphates), Eswatini no/~	Jordan ~, Ethiopia 1945–74 no (fell), Nepal 1960–2008 no (fell), Afghanistan to 1973 no, Bhutan ~, Tonga ~
Institutionalized non-monarchical autocracy (party/military)	Algeria (FLN-military) ~/no; Iraq 1968–79 Ba'ath before full personalization ~; Venezuela under Pérez Jiménez 1952–58 (military) ~	Indonesia under Suharto yes/~ (oil and gas plus manufacturing); Malaysia BN yes; Vietnam yes; Egypt (military-backed) ~/no	South Korea 1961–87 yes; Taiwan KMT yes; Singapore yes; Spain (late Franco) yes/~; Greece junta no; Portugal Estado Novo no/~; Ethiopia EPRDF ~; Rwanda RPF ~/yes; China (outside BRIEF list; reference)
Personalist autocracy	Libya under Gaddafi no; Iraq under Saddam no; Equatorial Guinea no; Venezuela under Chávez/Maduro (competitive-authoritarian drift) no	Zaire/DRC under Mobutu no; Angola under dos Santos ~/no; Romania under Ceausescu no	Philippines under Marcos no; Haiti under the Duvaliers no; Uganda under Amin no; Central African Empire no
Democracy / constitutional monarchy	Norway yes (SWF contrast); Trinidad and Tobago ~	Botswana yes (diamonds; dominant-party democracy, borderline); Chile yes (copper fiscal rule); Indonesia post-1998 ~; Nigeria (civilian periods) no/~; Mongolia ~	Japan yes (postwar constitutional monarchy, BRIEF contrast case); Spain post-1978 yes; India ~; Mauritius yes

This matrix ensures that (a) each regime form appears at each level of endowment, (b) failures appear in every row, and (c) the resource-poor monarchies (Jordan, Morocco, Ethiopia, Nepal, Afghanistan) and resource-rich non-monarchies (Iraq, Libya, Algeria, Venezuela, Equatorial Guinea) are present, which are the two critical cells for separating H5a from monarchy-specific explanations.

4.4 Step three: outcome-blind selection within cells, plus declared crucial cases

- **Within each cell, Tier 2 cases are selected by pre-declared criteria that do not depend on outcomes:** all cases named in BRIEF Part IV (mandatory), then the largest-population cases in each cell, then the cases with the best data coverage. Selection is recorded in a log before outcomes are compiled.
- **Crucial cases are declared separately and justified theoretically,** not by outcome: Kuwait 2024–2026 (removal of legislative constraint within a monarchy); Oman 2020–2021 (codification of succession); Saudi Arabia 2015–2026 (personalization within a monarchy); Iran 1979 and Libya 1969 (collapse of resource-rich monarchies); Jordan and Morocco (survival without large rents); Spain 1975–1978 (monarchy as an agent of democratization); Nepal 2001–2008 (collapse after a contested succession and royal power grab).

4.5 Matched pairs for structured comparison

Each pair varies one main factor while holding others roughly constant. The monograph uses them to adjudicate between hypotheses.

Pair	Held roughly constant	Main contrast	Hypotheses tested
Kuwait vs Saudi Arabia (1962–2024)	Hydrocarbon rents, Gulf security umbrella, dynastic monarchy	Strong elected legislature vs none	H1, H2, H6; whether legislative constraint slowed development
Kuwait before vs after May 2024	Country, rents, ruling family	Constitutional suspension	H1, H6 (within-country)
Oman vs Bahrain	Moderate and declining rents, small size, monarchy	Sectarian structure, 2011 protest intensity, external intervention	M2, H5, H7
Jordan vs Morocco	Resource-poor monarchies, Western alignment	Size, colonial legacy, constitutional reform path	M2, H5
Libya 1969 vs Oman 1970	Oil monarchies facing upheaval within a year	Coup that ended monarchy vs palace coup that renewed it (Qaboos replaced his father, July 1970 [E])	H7, Part IX
Iran 1979 vs Saudi Arabia	Oil wealth, monarchy, 1970s boom	Pahlavi personalization and rapid social dislocation vs dynastic family coalition	H3, H7, Part IX
Ethiopia 1974 vs Thailand	Old monarchies, agrarian, Cold War ally	Monarch ruled vs monarch reigned while military ruled	Part II incentives; Part IX
Nepal vs Bhutan	Himalayan monarchies, small, aid-dependent	Monarchy abolished (2008) vs monarch-led transition to constitutional monarchy (2008)	H6, H7
Brunei vs Equatorial Guinea	Small hydrocarbon producers	Monarchy with SWF and welfare state vs personalist kleptocracy	Monarchy vs personalism at similar rents
Indonesia (Suharto) vs Nigeria	Large, oil-exporting, ethnically diverse, military rule in the 1970s–80s	Divergent use of oil windfalls (classic comparison: Bevan, Collier & Gunning 1999 [E])	H4, H5; directly informs Part XI
South Korea vs Philippines (Marcos)	Cold War US allies, authoritarian 1970s–80s	Corporate military/developmental state vs personalist kleptocracy	M4, H4

Pair	Held roughly constant	Main contrast	Hypotheses tested
Spain (Franco) vs Portugal (Estado Novo)	Iberian authoritarianism, Catholic corporatism	1959 technocratic opening vs prolonged autarky and colonial war	H4, Type 9 overlay
Norway / Chile / Botswana vs Gulf SWF states	Resource rents, SWF mechanisms	Democratic or constitutional governance of rents	M3, Part X separability
Singapore vs Gulf city-states (Dubai, Doha)	City-state scale, trade and finance hubs	Dominant-party republic vs hereditary emirate	Part X transfer; H4

4.6 Tiers for the Phase 2 historical database (BRIEF Part IV)

- **Tier 1 — full case studies (Phase 3 and Phase 5 chapters):** Saudi Arabia, UAE (with Abu Dhabi and Dubai sub-studies), Qatar, Oman, Brunei (the five Part III cases); Kuwait and Bahrain (completing the GCC); Iran under the Pahlavis; Iraq under Saddam Hussein; Libya under Gaddafi (the Part IX failure cases).
- **Tier 2 — structured profiles (about 2,000–4,000 words each, standard template of the twelve Part IV variables):** Iran after 1979; Egypt (Nasser, Sadat, Mubarak, post-2011); Jordan; Morocco; Thailand; Cambodia; Indonesia (Sukarno, Suharto); South Korea; Taiwan; Singapore; North Korea; Japan (contrast); Ethiopia (Haile Selassie, Derg, EPRDF, post-2018); Equatorial Guinea; Rwanda; Spain; Portugal; Romania; Yugoslavia; Greece; Nepal; Bhutan; Eswatini; Libya 1951–1969; Iraq 1932–1958; Afghanistan to 1973; plus comparison democracies Norway, Botswana, Chile.
- **Tier 3 — database only:** every remaining country-year in U1–U3, coded from datasets with light hand-checking, used for base rates and survival curves.
- **Part XI countries** (Indonesia, Nigeria, Angola, DRC, Iraq, Libya, Algeria, Pakistan, Egypt, Venezuela, Mongolia, and others selected in Phase 6 by the same stratification) receive a separate diagnostic template (Section 5, Chapter 16).

4.7 Analytical safeguards

- Report survival with Kaplan–Meier curves and hazard ratios by type, stratified by rents; never report "monarchies are stable" without the denominator.
- Report outcome distributions (medians, interquartile ranges, worst and best cases), not only means.
- For every success case, name at least one comparable failure case in the same cell and explain the difference.
- Pre-register (in the project's own files) the expected direction of each comparison before compiling the data, and report when expectations were wrong.
- Treat the GCC as six cases, not one; and treat GCC monarchies jointly as at most a handful of independent observations, because they share a security umbrella, an oil market and diffusion effects.

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5. Detailed table of contents for the final monograph

Twenty chapters in six parts, with front matter and appendices as required by BRIEF Part XIII, Phase 8. Brackets give the BRIEF part(s) each chapter answers and the project phase that produces it.

Front matter

- Executive summary (answers to the ten Part XII questions in brief, with confidence levels) [XII; Phase 8]
- Preface: purpose, neutrality commitments, what this book is not (not a guide to acquiring power or changing constitutions) [I, IX, X]
- Note on authorship (M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark), data, evidence tags and conventions
- List of tables, figures and abbreviations (all abbreviations spelled out at first use)

Part One — Foundations

Chapter 1. The Question of Absolute Power [I; Phase 1] 1.1 Why the question matters now: the Gulf development narrative and its admirers 1.2 What the book asks and does not ask 1.3 Four sub-questions: association, mechanism, separability, transfer 1.4 Outcomes as a vector: prosperity, productivity, human development, capacity, stability, rights 1.5 Three rival master explanations: concentration advantage, rents and patrons, institutions not form 1.6 Methods, cases and the problem of survivors 1.7 Plan of the book

Chapter 2. Classifying Political Systems [II; Phases 1–2] 2.1 Monarchy is not dictatorship: why the distinction matters analytically 2.2 Hereditary legitimacy, personalist authority, institutionalized authoritarianism, constitutional government 2.3 Six coding dimensions 2.4 Ten regime types and two overlays: definitions and decision rules 2.5 Existing typologies (GWF, V-Dem RoW, Polity, Anckar–Fredriksson, Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland) and where they disagree 2.6 Hard cases: Jordan, Morocco, Kuwait, Thailand, Eswatini, Bahrain, Iran, Cambodia, Spain 2.7 Measurement error and how we report it

Chapter 3. Kings, Strongmen, Generals and Parties: Do Succession Rules Change Incentives? [II, V.2, V.7; Phases 2, 4] 3.1 The horizon argument (Olson's stationary bandit and its critics) 3.2 Family as ruling coalition: dynastic monarchy in the Gulf 3.3 Succession rules: primogeniture, agnatic seniority, designation, family councils 3.4 Personalist and military succession: uncertainty and violence 3.5 Evidence: property rights, survival and leader effects by regime type 3.6 What hereditary rule cannot solve: the quality lottery

Chapter 4. The Political Philosophy of Concentrated Authority [VIII; Phase 5] 4.1 Plato's philosopher-king and the problem of selecting the wise 4.2 Machiavelli: founding, maintaining and the economy of force 4.3 Hobbes: order as the precondition of everything else 4.4 Ibn Khaldun: *'asabiyya*, dynastic cycles and the decay of ruling groups 4.5 Locke and Montesquieu: consent, limits and the separation of powers 4.6 Weber: traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority 4.7 Burnham: managerial rule and technocracy 4.8 Fukuyama: state, rule of law, accountability, and political decay 4.9 Acemoglu and Robinson: inclusive and extractive institutions 4.10 Capable, legitimate, accountable, effective, sustainable: five distinct properties 4.11 Can a government be economically successful while unaccountable? What happens when prosperity depends on one person?

Part Two — The Historical Record, 1945–2026

Chapter 5. The Universe of Monarchies and Dictatorships since 1945 [IV; Phase 2] 5.1 Building the database: sources, coding, reliability 5.2 Monarchies in 1946 and in 2026: survivors, the fallen and the transformed 5.3 Autocratic regime spells: types, durations and modes of exit 5.4 Survival curves by regime type and resource stratum 5.5 Development trajectories by regime type: first descriptive look 5.6 What the base rates do and do not show

Chapter 6. Regional Histories of Concentrated Power [IV; Phase 2] 6.1 Middle East and North Africa: Saudi Arabia, the Pahlavis and the Islamic Republic, Ba'athist Iraq, Gaddafi's Libya, Egypt from Nasser to the present, Jordan, Morocco, the Gulf emirates 6.2 Asia: Brunei, Thailand, Cambodia, Indonesia under Sukarno and Suharto, South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, North Korea, and Japan as contrast 6.3 Africa: Ethiopia from Haile Selassie to the present, Equatorial Guinea, Rwanda, Morocco, Eswatini, and other postcolonial authoritarian systems 6.4 Europe: Franco's Spain and the transition, Portugal's Estado Novo, Ceausescu's Romania, Tito's Yugoslavia, the Greek junta 6.5 Cross-regional patterns: legitimacy, starting conditions, endowments, capacity, succession, continuity

Part Three — The Gulf Model

Chapter 7. Saudi Arabia: Dynasty, Doctrine and Oil [III.A; Phase 3] 7.1 State formation and the Al Saud–religious establishment compact 7.2 Oil, Aramco and the making of the rentier state 7.3 From family consensus to centralized authority 7.4 Public-sector employment and the citizen–expatriate labour market 7.5 Vision 2030, diversification and social transformation 7.6 The Public Investment Fund and sovereign investment 7.7 Succession: from agnatic seniority to a single line 7.8 Can the model outlast petroleum? Fiscal breakevens, non-oil growth, risks

Chapter 8. The United Arab Emirates: A Federation of Monarchies [III.B; Phase 3] 8.1 Seven emirates and the 1971 federation 8.2 Abu Dhabi's resource wealth and fiscal role in the federation 8.3 Dubai's diversification: trade, logistics, aviation, real estate, finance 8.4 Distribution of authority between emirates 8.5 Sovereign wealth:

ADIA, Mubadala, ADQ, ICD and others 8.6 Free zones, foreign investment and technocratic governance 8.7 Demography: citizens, expatriates and the labour system 8.8 A decentralized monarchy within a centralized federation?

Chapter 9. Qatar: Gas, Scale and Statecraft [III.C; Phase 3] 9.1 Natural gas, the North Field and LNG expansion 9.2 The Qatar Investment Authority 9.3 Population structure and citizenship 9.4 Political legitimacy: from the 1995 succession to the 2024 constitutional amendments 9.5 Education and research investment 9.6 Diplomacy and mediation as national strategy 9.7 Diversification beyond hydrocarbons

Chapter 10. Oman: Centralization with Constraint [III.D; Phase 3] 10.1 Historical centralization and the 1970 transition 10.2 Petroleum dependency and fiscal constraints 10.3 The 2020 succession and the 2021 Basic Statute 10.4 Fiscal consolidation and diversification (Vision 2040) 10.5 How Oman differs from its wealthier neighbours

Chapter 11. Brunei: The Small Absolute Monarchy [III.E; Phase 3] 11.1 Royal legitimacy and the Malay Islamic Monarchy ideology 11.2 Oil and gas revenues and the Brunei Investment Agency 11.3 Public services and the welfare compact 11.4 Fiscal sustainability and diversification 11.5 Institutional constraints and the long-term challenges of a small resource-dependent monarchy

Chapter 12. Kuwait, Bahrain and the GCC in Comparison [III (completion), V.5, X.3–4; Phase 3] 12.1 Kuwait's parliamentary experiment and its suspension 12.2 Bahrain: declining rents, sectarian politics and external support 12.3 Sovereign wealth across the GCC: mandates, governance, transparency 12.4 Mechanisms, not just petroleum: what explains GCC outcomes 12.5 The Gulf model, specified

Part Four — Comparative Political Economy

Chapter 13. Why Do Some Authoritarian States Develop While Others Fail? [V; Phase 4] 13.1 Concentrated decision-making: speed versus error 13.2 Planning horizons: monarchies, democracies and dictatorships compared 13.3 Elite coordination: families, militaries, bureaucrats, business 13.4 Technocratic administration and pockets of efficiency 13.5 Resource wealth: rentier theory, the resource curse, Dutch disease, SWFs 13.6 Can centralized power constrain itself? 13.7 Succession risk 13.8 Testing the rival explanations: what survived

Chapter 14. The Economic Performance Question [VI; Phase 4] 14.1 Data, periods and comparability rules 14.2 GDP per capita and growth: resource-driven versus productivity-driven 14.3 Productivity, diversification and private-sector development 14.4 Human development, education and health 14.5 Poverty and distribution: citizens, residents and migrant workers 14.6 FDI, sovereign wealth and public debt 14.7 Institutional quality, corruption and political stability 14.8 Does high GDP per capita mean broadly shared prosperity?

Chapter 15. Absolute Monarchy and Other Systems: Trade-offs, Not Rankings [VII; Phase 4] 15.1 The seven systems and fourteen dimensions 15.2 Continuity, efficiency, infrastructure 15.3 Diversification, innovation, human capital 15.4 Corruption, accountability, succession, civil liberties, institutional independence 15.5 Crisis management, fiscal discipline, intergenerational sustainability 15.6 Conditions under which each system's advantages appear and disappear

Part Five — Institutions and Their Failure

Chapter 16. State Capacity, Technocracy and Accountability [V.4, V.6, VIII; Phase 5] 16.1 State capacity is not personal power 16.2 Technocracy under autocracy and democracy 16.3 Informal accountability: selectorates, family councils, parties 16.4 Information, feedback and the limits of insulated rule

Chapter 17. The Failure Modes of Absolute Power [IX; Phase 5] 17.1 Elite capture, corruption and economic misallocation 17.2 Repression and information distortion 17.3 Policy mistakes without correction 17.4 Succession crises and institutional fragility 17.5 Fiscal irresponsibility and dependence on one ruler 17.6 Case studies: the fall of the Pahlavi monarchy; the collapse of Ba'athist Iraq; Gaddafi's Libya; Ethiopia 1974; Nepal 2008; other deteriorations 17.7 How apparently stable regimes change rapidly: shocks, fiscal crises, elite fragmentation, legitimacy loss (historical and causal analysis only)

Part Six — Applicability and Synthesis

Chapter 18. Governance Mechanisms Without Absolute Power [X; Phase 6] 18.1 The core principle: separating mechanisms from the concentration of power 18.2–18.15 Fourteen mechanisms, each assessed on: the problem it solves; evidence; prerequisites; risks; compatibility with democratic, constitutional-monarchical and authoritarian systems (long-term planning; professional technocratic administration; sovereign wealth funds; intergenerational resource management; efficient procurement; centralized strategic coordination; performance-based administration; institutionalized succession and leadership continuity; professional civil services; independent audit and accountability; human-capital investment; diversification; long-term infrastructure finance; legal certainty for private investment) 18.16 A compatibility matrix

Chapter 19. Countries with Underutilized Potential [XI; Phase 6] 19.1 Selection and diagnostic template 19.2 Country diagnostics: Indonesia, Nigeria, Angola, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Iraq, Libya, Algeria, Pakistan, Egypt, Venezuela, Mongolia, and others selected by the Phase 6 method 19.3 Which mechanisms could address which bottlenecks 19.4 Which mechanisms would be unsuitable, and why (demography, institutions, culture, economy, geopolitics) 19.5 Why constitutional form is not the binding constraint

Chapter 20. Synthesis: Absolute Power and the Future of State Governance [XII; Phase 7] 20.1 Answers to the ten fundamental questions, with confidence levels 20.2 What the evidence contradicted (including our own initial hypotheses) 20.3 Limits of the evidence 20.4 A framework for sustainable prosperity, capable institutions and long-term stability 20.5 Unanswered questions and a research agenda

Back matter

- Appendix A: Methodological appendix (coding rules, decision tree, inter-coder reliability, sensitivity analyses)
- Appendix B: Historical timelines (each Tier 1 and Tier 2 case)
- Appendix C: Comparative tables (Part VII matrix; regime-type crosswalks)
- Appendix D: Economic datasets (indicator dictionary; CSV descriptions; citizen vs resident series)
- Appendix E: Sovereign wealth fund profiles (mandate, governance, reported or estimated assets with source quality ratings)
- Appendix F: Limitations and unanswered questions
- Bibliography (primary sources; datasets; books; articles; official reports; journalism, flagged)
- Index

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6. Authoritative source map, by chapter

URL status: "reachable" means the URL returned HTTP 200 to an automated check on 7 November 2026; "blocked" means the site refused automated access (HTTP 403 or no response), so the URL is listed from established knowledge [E] and must be confirmed by a browser in the relevant phase. Bibliographic details of books are [E] unless stated.

6.1 Cross-cutting datasets (all chapters)

Dataset	Use	URL	Status
V-Dem v16 (March 2026), incl. Regimes of the World	Regime classification, electoral and constraint indices, to 2025	https://www.v-dem.net/data/the-v-dem-dataset/	reachable; v16 release [E via site excerpt]; processed RoW file opened [V]
Geddes–Wright–Frantz Autocratic Regimes	Regime spells and transitions 1946–2010	https://sites.psu.edu/dictators/	reachable; codebook v1.2 opened [V]
Anckar & Fredriksson Political Regimes of the World v3.0	Monarchy identification 1800–2024	https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/AHSNVX	dataset page opened [V]

Dataset	Use	URL	Status
Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland (DD)	Democracy/dictatorship, royal/military/civilian 1946–2008	https://sites.google.com/site/joseantoniocheibub/datasets/dd	[E]
Polity5	Long-run regime scores to 2018	https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/inscr.htm	blocked (HTTP 406); manual https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/p5 [E]
Archigos (leaders)	Leader entry/exit and manner of exit	Goemans, Gleditsch & Chiozza 2009, *Journal of Peace Research* 46(2) [V via citation]; data host to confirm	[E]
Quality of Government (QoG)	Compiled institutional indicators	https://www.gu.se/en/quality-government/qog-data	reachable
World Bank World Development Indicators (API)	Economic and social indicators	https://api.worldbank.org/v2/	[E]; other project agents have pulled WDI series into data/ (see data/README.md)
Worldwide Governance Indicators	Governance perceptions	https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/worldwide-governance-indicators	reachable
Penn World Table (10.01 in workspace)	Real GDP, productivity, TFP	https://www.rug.nl/ggdc/productivity/pwt/	reachable
Maddison Project	Long-run GDP per capita	https://www.rug.nl/ggdc/historicaldevelopment/maddison/	reachable
UNDP Human Development Reports data	HDI and components	https://hdr.undp.org/data-center	reachable
IMF World Economic Outlook and Article IV reports	GDP, fiscal, debt, non-oil balance	https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/WEO	blocked to automated check [E]
Transparency International CPI	Corruption perceptions	https://www.transparency.org/en/cpi	reachable
World Bank Poverty and Inequality Platform	Poverty, Gini	https://pip.worldbank.org/	reachable
World Inequality Database; UNU-WIDER WIID	Top income shares; inequality compilations	https://wid.world/ ; https://www.wider.unu.edu/database/world-income-inequality-database-wiid	reachable
Harvard Growth Lab Atlas of Economic Complexity	Export diversification and complexity	https://atlas.hks.harvard.edu/	reachable
Gulf Labour Markets, Migration and Population (GLMM)	Citizen vs non-citizen populations	https://gulfmigration.grc.net/	reachable [E for figures]
Constitute Project	Constitutional texts	https://www.constituteproject.org/	reachable
Freedom House, Freedom in the World	Political rights and civil liberties narratives	https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-world	reachable
Bertelsmann Transformation Index	Governance and market-economy narratives	https://www.bti-project.org/	reachable
IEA; OPEC Annual Statistical Bulletin	Hydrocarbon production, reserves, exports	https://www.iea.org/data-and-statistics ; https://asb.opec.org/	blocked to automated check [E]

Dataset	Use	URL	Status
International Forum of Sovereign Wealth Funds (Santiago Principles)	SWF governance standards and self-assessments	https://www.ifswf.org/santiago-principles	reachable
Global SWF	Estimates of SWF assets (secondary, commercial)	https://globalswf.com/	reachable; treat as estimate, not audited data
Our World in Data	Processed series with documentation	https://ourworldindata.org/	reachable

6.2 Chapter-by-chapter source map

Chapters 1–3 (question, classification, succession incentives). Geddes, Wright & Frantz 2014 [V]; Geddes 1999, *Annual Review of Political Science* [E]; Lührmann, Tannenberg & Lindberg 2018 [V]; Anckar & Fredriksson 2019 [V]; Anckar 2020 on constitutional and semi-constitutional monarchies [E]; Cheibub, Gandhi & Vreeland 2010 [V]; Gerring et al. 2021 [V]; Hadenius & Teorell 2007, *Journal of Democracy* 18(1), and Wahman, Teorell & Hadenius 2013 [E]; Boix, Miller & Rosato 2013 [E]; Svolik 2012, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* [E]; Gandhi 2008, *Political Institutions under Dictatorship* [E]; Levitsky & Way 2010 [E]; Schedler 2006 [E]; Linz 2000, *Totalitarian and Authoritarian Regimes*, and Linz & Stepan 1996 [E]; Huntington 1968 (King's dilemma) [E]; Herb 1999, *All in the Family* [E]; Kokkonen & Sundell 2014 [V]; Knutsen & Fjelde 2013 [E]; Menaldo 2012 [V]; Olson 1993 [V via citation]; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [V via citation]; Jones & Olken 2005 [V]; Brownlee 2007 on hereditary succession in republics [E].

Chapter 4 (philosophy). Plato, *Republic*; Machiavelli, *The Prince*; Hobbes, *Leviathan* (1651); Ibn Khaldun, *Muqaddimah* (1377), Rosenthal translation; Locke, *Two Treatises of Government*; Montesquieu, *The Spirit of the Laws* (1748); Weber, *Economy and Society*; Burnham 1941, *The Managerial Revolution*; Fukuyama 2011, *The Origins of Political Order*, and 2014, *Political Order and Political Decay*; Acemoglu & Robinson 2012, *Why Nations Fail*; North, Wallis & Weingast 2009 [all E; cite standard editions with translator named].

Chapters 5–6 (historical database and regional histories). GWF case narratives [V]; A&F [V]; Archigos [E]; Polity5 regime narratives [E]; country histories: Vassiliev, *The History of Saudi Arabia* [E]; Abrahamian 1982, *Iran Between Two Revolutions* [E]; Tripp, *A History of Iraq* [E]; Vandewalle, *A History of Modern Libya* [E]; Waterbury 1983, *The Egypt of Nasser and Sadat* [E]; Robins, *A History of Jordan* [E]; Handley 2006, *The King Never Smiles* (Thailand; note: banned in Thailand) [E]; Elson 2001, *Suharto* [E]; Kim & Vogel eds. 2011, *The Park Chung Hee Era* [E]; Marcus, *A History of Ethiopia* [E]; Preston, *Franco* [E]; Payne on the Franco regime [E]; Tismaneanu on Ceausescu [E]; for Africa and Equatorial Guinea, reputable NGO and investigative sources flagged as such. Official sources: constitutions via Constitute Project; Law Library of Congress Global Legal Monitor [V for Kuwait].

Chapters 7–12 (Gulf).

- *Scholarship:* Gause 1994, *Oil Monarchies* [E]; Herb 1999, 2014 [E]; Hertog 2010, *Princes, Brokers, and Bureaucrats* [E]; Hertog on Gulf labour markets and "rentier middle class" [E]; Kostiner ed. 2000, *Middle East Monarchies* [E]; Davidson 2008 *Dubai: The Vulnerability of Success* and 2009 *Abu Dhabi: Oil and Beyond* [E]; Ulrichsen 2014, *Qatar and the Arab Spring*, and on Gulf political economy [E]; Kamrava 2013, *Qatar: Small State, Big Politics* [E]; Valeri 2009/2017, *Oman: Politics and Society in the Qaboos State* [E]; Kinninmont on Gulf citizenship and youth [E]; Crystal 1990, *Oil and Politics in the Gulf* (Kuwait and Qatar) [E]; Yom 2016, *From Resilience to Revolution* [E]; Kéchichian on Saudi succession [E].
- *Official and primary:* Saudi Vision 2030 portal (https://www.vision2030.gov.sa/, blocked to automated check [E]); PIF annual reports (https://www.pif.gov.sa/, blocked [E]); Saudi Aramco annual reports and IPO prospectus (2019) [E]; General Authority for Statistics (GASTAT) [E]; ADIA annual reviews (https://www.adia.ae/en, reachable); Mubadala annual reviews (https://www.mubadala.com/, reachable); Investment Corporation of Dubai reports (https://www.icd.gov.ae/, blocked [E]); UAE Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Centre (https://fcsc.gov.ae/, blocked [E]); QIA (https://www.qia.qa/, blocked [E]; QIA does not publish full audited accounts [E]); Qatar Planning and Statistics Authority [E]; Qatar Council of Ministers page on the 2024 amendments [V]; Kuwait Investment Authority (https://www.kia.gov.kw/, reachable; KIA does not publish full asset figures publicly [E]); Kuwait Central

Statistical Bureau (https://www.csb.gov.kw/, reachable); Amiri Diwan of Kuwait statement of 10 May 2024 [E]; Oman Investment Authority (https://www.oia.gov.om/, reachable); Oman National Centre for Statistics and Information (https://www.ncsi.gov.om/, reachable); Oman Basic Statute 2021 via https://decree.om/ [E]; Brunei Investment Agency (website not resolved in automated check; confirm in Phase 3) and Brunei Department of Economic Planning and Statistics (https://deps.mofe.gov.bn/, reachable); IMF Article IV reports and Regional Economic Outlook for the Middle East and Central Asia (fiscal breakeven oil prices) [E]; GLMM [E]; ILO and national labour statistics.

- *SWF transparency caveat:* asset figures for ADIA, KIA, QIA and BIA are mostly not published as audited totals; Phase 3 must label every SWF number as "reported by fund," "audited," or "third-party estimate" (e.g., Global SWF, SWF Institute) and never present estimates as facts.

Chapter 13 (why some develop). Johnson 1982, *MITI and the Japanese Miracle*; Amsden 1989, *Asia's Next Giant*; Wade 1990, *Governing the Market*; Evans 1995, *Embedded Autonomy*; Kohli 2004, *State-Directed Development*; Haggard 1990, *Pathways from the Periphery*; Doner, Ritchie & Slater 2005, "Systemic Vulnerability," *International Organization*; Slater 2010, *Ordering Power*; Evans & Rauch 1999, *American Sociological Review* (Weberian bureaucracy and growth); World Bank 1993, *The East Asian Miracle*; Rodrik 1995 on Korea and Taiwan; Mahdavy 1970; Beblawi & Luciani eds. 1987; Karl 1997, *The Paradox of Plenty*; Ross 2001, 2012; Haber & Menaldo 2011 [V]; Andersen & Ross 2014 [E]; Sachs & Warner 1995/2001 on resource curse; van der Ploeg 2011, *Journal of Economic Literature*, "Natural Resources: Curse or Blessing?"; Corden & Neary 1982 on Dutch disease; Bevan, Collier & Gunning 1999 on Nigeria and Indonesia [all E unless marked].

Chapter 14 (economic performance). WDI, PWT, Maddison, UNDP HDR, IMF WEO, WGI, TI CPI, PIP, WID, Atlas of Economic Complexity, UNCTAD World Investment Report (FDI) [E], IMF Investment and Capital Stock Dataset [E], World Bank *Changing Wealth of Nations* [E], World Bank Human Capital Index [E]; Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo & Robinson 2019 [V]; Papaioannou & Siourounis 2008, *Economic Journal* [V via citation]; Doucouliagos & Ulubasoglu 2008, *American Journal of Political Science* 52(1) meta-analysis [V via citation]; Przeworski, Alvarez, Cheibub & Limongi 2000 [E]; Barro 1996 [E]; Gerring, Bond, Barndt & Moreno 2005 on democracy stock [E]; Knutsen 2012 on democracy and growth variance [E].

Chapter 15 (systems compared). Persson & Tabellini 2003, *The Economic Effects of Constitutions* (presidential vs parliamentary) [E]; Linz 1990, "The Perils of Presidentialism" [E]; Cheibub 2007, *Presidentialism, Parliamentarism, and Democracy* [E]; Garriga 2016 central bank independence dataset [E]; Fatás & Mihov 2003 policy volatility [E]; Easterly 2011 and Easterly & Pennings 2017 [V via citation]; Rizio & Skali 2020 [V]; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [V via citation]; Wright 2008 on legislatures and investment in dictatorships [E]; Gehlbach & Keefer 2011 on investment without democracy [E].

Chapters 16–17 (capacity, failure modes). Fukuyama 2013, "What Is Governance?" [E]; Besley & Persson 2011, *Pillars of Prosperity* [E]; Hanson & Sigman state-capacity measures [E]; Kuran 1991/1995 on preference falsification and sudden revolutions [E]; Wintrobe 1998, *The Political Economy of Dictatorship* (dictator's dilemma) [E]; Svolik 2012 [E]; Skocpol 1979 and 1982 ("Rentier State and Shi'a Islam in the Iranian Revolution") [E]; Kurzman 2004, *The Unthinkable Revolution in Iran* [E]; Abrahamian 1982 [E]; Tripp on Iraq; Makiya 1989, *Republic of Fear* [E]; Vandewalle 2012 on Libya [E]; Brownlee, Masoud & Reynolds 2015, *The Arab Spring* [E]; Bellin 2004 and 2012 on coercive apparatus robustness [E]; Mobutu-era kleptocracy (Young & Turner 1985) [V via citation in Rizio & Skali]; Li & Yang 2005 on the Great Leap Forward as reference failure [V via citation].

Chapter 18 (mechanisms). IFSWF Santiago Principles [reachable]; Norway Government Pension Fund Global and the fiscal rule (Norges Bank Investment Management reports) [E]; Chile's Structural Balance Rule and its sovereign funds [E]; Botswana's Pula Fund and Sustainable Budget Index [E]; Singapore's reserves protection (elected presidency) and Civil Service College; OECD Public Governance reviews and *Government at a Glance* [E]; World Bank Public Expenditure and Financial Accountability (PEFA) assessments [E]; IMF Public Investment Management Assessments (PIMA) [E]; INTOSAI standards for audit independence [E]; Evans & Rauch 1999 [E]; Dahlström & Lapuente 2017, *Organizing Leviathan* [E]; Andrews, Pritchett & Woolcock 2017, *Building State Capability* [E].

Chapter 19 (underutilized potential). IMF Article IV reports and World Bank Systematic Country Diagnostics for each country [E]; Natural Resource Governance Institute's Resource Governance Index (URL to confirm; automated check returned 404 for the guessed path) [E]; EITI country reports [E]; PEFA; Human Capital Index; Enterprise Surveys; WDI; country scholarship (for example, on Indonesia: Hill, *The Indonesian*

Economy; on Nigeria: Lewis 2007, *Growing Apart* comparing Indonesia and Nigeria [E]).

Chapter 20 (synthesis). All of the above; plus explicit adversarial review of the monograph's own claims (Phase 7).

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7. Known scholarly disputes the monograph must adjudicate (or honestly leave open)

D1. Why Arab monarchies survived the Arab Spring: political culture and commitment versus strategy, rents and patrons.

- *Menaldo (2012), Journal of Politics 74(3): 707–722* [V]: monarchy's political culture solves the ruler's credible-commitment problem; in a 1950–2006 MENA panel, monarchs are less likely to experience instability and more likely to respect rule of law and property rights and to grow their economies; causal direction defended with an instrument proxying tribal legacy (time since the Neolithic Revolution weighted by land quality) [V abstract].
- *Yom & Gause (2012), Journal of Democracy 23(4): 74–88* [V]: resilience reflects "deliberate regime strategies made in circumstances of geographic fortuity": cross-cutting coalitions, hydrocarbon wealth and foreign patronage; "without these factors, kingships are just as vulnerable to overthrow as any other autocracy" [V abstract].
- *Related:* Lucas 2004 on monarchical institutions as arbitration devices [E]; Bank, Richter & Sunik 2015 on long-term monarchical survival [E]; Herb 1999 on dynastic family rule as the key institution [E].
- *How we adjudicate:* the critical tests are (i) monarchies without large rents (Jordan, Morocco) versus monarchies that fell despite rents (Libya 1969, Iran 1979, Iraq 1958); (ii) whether Menaldo's instrument is plausibly excludable (tribal legacy may affect stability through channels other than monarchy); (iii) out-of-sample performance after 2006 (Bahrain 2011 required external military support; Oman and Morocco used concessions). Expected outcome: partial support for both, with the Yom–Gause factors necessary and family-coalition institutions mattering conditionally (hypothesis).

D2. Does democracy cause growth? Acemoglu et al. (2019) versus the Przeworski tradition and the "authoritarian advantage" view.

- *Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo & Robinson (2019), Journal of Political Economy 127(1): 47–100* [V]: dynamic panel with country fixed effects and GDP dynamics; democratizations raise GDP per capita by about 20 percent in the long run; similar results with propensity-score reweighting and regional-wave instruments; effects work through capital, schooling and health investment [V abstract].
- *Przeworski, Alvarez, Cheibub & Limongi (2000), Democracy and Development* [E]: on average, regime type has no significant effect on total income growth once selection is modelled, though democracies have lower population growth and so higher per capita growth; regime type matters less than often claimed.
- *Further positions:* Papaioannou & Siourounis (2008) estimate roughly a one-percentage-point growth gain after democratization [V via Rizio & Skali summary]; Doucouliagos & Ulubasoglu (2008) meta-analysis finds no direct average effect but positive indirect effects via human capital and inflation [V citation; E for findings]; critics question the instrument (regional democratization waves may affect growth through trade and aid) and the democracy coding [E].
- *How we use it:* the monograph does not need to resolve the average effect; it needs the *distribution* (variance, tails) and the *mechanisms*. We report the average-effect literature as a constraint (no credible study finds a large average autocratic advantage) while studying the conditional cases.

D3. The benevolent-autocrat hypothesis.

- *Easterly (2011), "Benevolent Autocrats," NYU DRI Working Paper 76* [V via citation]: the apparent association between autocracy and high growth reflects higher growth *variance* in autocracies and selective attention to successes; leader effects do not explain it.
- *Jones & Olken (2005), QJE 120(3): 835–864* [V]: leaders matter for growth in autocracies (especially those without parties or legislatures) but not detectably in democracies.

- *Rizio & Skali (2020), Leadership Quarterly 31: 101302* [V]: across 133 countries, 1858–2010, growth-positive autocrats appear no more often than chance (3.3% vs 2.5% expected; $p = 0.24$); growth-negative autocrats appear far more often (6.8%; $p < 0.001$); regression-discontinuity analysis around entry dates finds no growth break for "good" autocrats (they "ride the wave") but a significant drop for "bad" ones; autocrats are also more associated with recessions.
- *Besley & Kudamatsu (2008), "Making Autocracy Work"* [V via citation]: autocracy can work when a selectorate can remove a poorly performing leader without losing its own position.
- *How we use it:* this dispute bears directly on BRIEF Part VIII's question "what happens when national prosperity depends too heavily on the quality of a single individual?" The evidence suggests the downside of concentrated selection is large and systematic, the upside rare. The monograph must test whether monarchies, with family-council selectorates, behave more like Besley–Kudamatsu's "working" autocracies than personalist regimes do.

D4. Resource curse versus resource blessing.

- *Ross (2001; 2012)* [E]: oil hinders democratization and sustains autocracy, especially after the 1970s nationalizations.
- *Haber & Menaldo (2011), APSR 105(1): 1–26* [V]: with long time series and country fixed effects, resource reliance does not predict authoritarianism; some specifications suggest a "resource blessing."
- *Andersen & Ross (2014), "The Big Oil Change," Comparative Political Studies* [E]: the curse emerges after about 1980, when host governments captured oil rents.
- *Implication:* our survival and outcome models must allow the rent effect to change over time (pre/post-1970s) and must distinguish rents *captured by the state* from production volumes.

D5. Monarchy as an efficient form versus an obsolete form.

- *Gerring et al. (2021)* [V abstract]: monarchy was an efficient solution to coordination where citizens were isolated; its efficiency declined as communication costs fell. This implies a secular decline that Gulf survival appears to defy; the monograph must explain whether the Gulf is an exception (rents and patrons) or a confirmation (monarchies survive where they co-opt rather than face coordinated publics).
- *Kokkonen & Sundell (2014)* [V abstract]: primogeniture increased survival in European monarchies 1000–1800; applicability to modern agnatic Gulf systems is untested.

D6. The developmental state: autonomy versus embeddedness versus threat.

- *Johnson 1982; Amsden 1989; Wade 1990* [E] credit insulated state agencies; *Evans 1995* [E] argues autonomy must be embedded in ties to business; *Doner, Ritchie & Slater 2005* [E] argue that "systemic vulnerability" (external threat plus resource scarcity plus coalition constraints) explains why some elites build developmental states. The last view predicts that resource-rich, externally protected Gulf states will *not* face the pressure that produced East Asian developmental states, a direct challenge to the "Gulf as developmental state" narrative (hypothesis to be tested in Chapters 12–13).

D7. Hereditary succession in republics and the boundary of "monarchy."

- Brownlee 2007 on hereditary succession in authoritarian regimes [E] and the North Korean and Syrian cases raise the question of whether "dynastic republics" are monarchies. Our decision (Section 2.3, Type 6) is to code them separately; the dispute is reported and sensitivity analyses re-run with them pooled with monarchies.

D8. Measurement disputes.

- RoW folds ruling monarchies with elected parliaments (Jordan, Morocco) into "closed autocracy" [V], while A&F folds them into "absolute monarchy" and GWF into "monarchy" [V categories]. Polity has no monarchy category. Results about "monarchies" can change depending on whether semi-constitutional monarchies are included; every headline result is reported with and without Type 3.

D9. Gulf statistics and the citizen/resident problem. There is no scholarly consensus on how to compare Gulf welfare with other states. Some authors use citizen-only measures (inflating apparent welfare), others total residents (deflating it and masking the citizen welfare state). We report both and treat the gap itself as a finding about the political economy of the model.

8. Indicator dictionary for Part VI (economic performance)

General rules (apply to every number in the manuscript): value; unit; year; population definition (total residents, citizens only, or employed); source with URL or file path; one-line limitation. Periods: the core comparison windows are 1960–1989, 1990–2009 and 2010–latest, plus decade averages; growth is computed as compound annual rates over windows, never from single years. Prices: constant 2021 international dollars (PPP) for levels in WDI; PWT 10.01 for productivity (2017 PPPs; note the vintage difference when combining). The project's existing pulls are documented in data/README.md and data/r4/raw/ (created by other project agents; codes below were confirmed present in those pulls [V]).

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
1	GDP per capita	GDP per capita, PPP	WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.PP.KD [V in project pull]	constant 2021 international $	1990–2025 in pull [V]	Denominator = total residents. For GCC also compute GDP per citizen (GDP / citizen population from GLMM/national statistics) and non-oil GDP per resident. PPP for Gulf states is uncertain (ICP coverage, price subsidies).
1b	Long-run GDP per capita	Maddison Project	Maddison Project Database	2011 int'l $ (vintage-specific)	1950–latest (country-dependent)	Pre-1990 Gulf estimates are thin and partly modelled.
2	Real GDP growth	Annual and window-average growth	WDI NY.GDP.MKTP.KD.ZG [V in pull]; IMF WEO NGDP_RPCH [V in pull]	% per year	1961–2025 (WDI); WEO includes projections — never mix projections with outturns	Oil-quota-driven volatility; report non-oil growth separately where IMF publishes it.

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
2b	Per capita growth		WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG [V in pull]	% per year	1961–2025	Migration-driven population swings in GCC distort per capita growth.
3	Productivity growth	Total factor productivity	PWT 10.01 rtfpna (TFP at constant national prices) [E for variable name; dataset in workspace V]	index (2017 = 1)	1950–2019	TFP for oil economies is dominated by resource-price and capacity effects; interpret with care.
4	Labour productivity	GDP per person employed	WDI SL.GDP.PCAP.EM.KD [V in pull]	constant 2021 PPP $	1991–2025 [V]	In GCC, the employed population is mostly non-citizen; report citizen employment by sector (public/private) separately from national labour surveys.
5	Human Development Index	HDI and components	UNDP HDR composite time series (hdr25 file in data/r4/raw) [V]	index 0–1	1990–2023 [V]	HDI uses total-resident averages; GNI component inflated by rents; inequality-adjusted HDI missing for most GCC states [E].

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
6	Education outcomes	Human Capital Index; harmonized learning outcomes; tertiary enrolment	WDI HD.HCI.OVRL [V in pull]; SE.TER.ENRR, SE.SEC.ENRR [V in pull]; PISA/TIMSS	index 0–1; % gross	HCI: 2010, 2017, 2018, 2020 editions [E]; enrolment annual	Enrolment != learning. Gulf test scores usually cover students in national systems (citizens plus some residents); clarify sampling frame.
7	Healthcare outcomes	Life expectancy; under-5 mortality	WDI SP.DYN.LE00.IN, SH.DYN.MORT [V in pull]	years; per 1,000 live births	1960–2024	Resident averages mix young migrant workers (low mortality in working ages) with citizens; migrant-worker deaths are under-recorded [E].
8	Poverty	Headcount at international lines	WDI SI.POV.DDAY (now the $3.00/day 2021 PPP line [V in pull]); national poverty lines	% of population	survey years only	**GCC states publish little or no survey-based poverty data**; absence of data must be stated, not filled. Migrant workers are usually outside household surveys.

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
9	Income distribution	Gini; top-10% share	WDI SI.POV.GINI [V in pull]; WID top shares	index 0–100; % of income	survey years; WID modelled	Gini unavailable for most GCC states; WID estimates for the Middle East are modelled from limited data — label as estimates.
10	Economic diversification	Export concentration (Herfindahl–Hirschman), Economic Complexity Index, fuel share of merchandise exports, non-oil GDP share	Atlas of Economic Complexity; UNCTADstat; WDI TX.VAL.FUEL.ZS.UN [V in pull]; IMF Article IV for non-oil GDP	index; %	1962/1995–latest (source-dependent)	Re-exports (Dubai) inflate apparent diversification; petrochemicals are hydrocarbon-linked.
11	Private-sector development	Domestic credit to private sector; firm entry; private employment share of citizens	WDI FS.AST.PRVT.GD.ZS [V in pull]; World Bank Entrepreneurship Database [E]; national labour statistics	% of GDP; new firms per 1,000 working-age; %	annual / survey	Private firms in the Gulf often depend on state contracts; credit != independent private sector.
12	Foreign direct investment	Net FDI inflows	WDI BX.KLT.DINV.WD.GD.ZS [V in pull]; UNCTAD WIR	% of GDP; current US$	1970–2025	Round-tripping and SWF-related flows; free-zone flows can be large but enclave-like.

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
13	Sovereign wealth	SWF assets; annual transfers; net foreign assets	Fund annual reports; IMF Article IV; Global SWF/SWFI estimates	current US$; % of GDP; per citizen	irregular	Many Gulf funds do not publish audited totals; label every figure as "reported," "audited" or "estimate." Per-citizen wealth is the relevant inter-generational metric.
14	Public debt	General government gross debt	IMF WEO GGXWDG_NGDP [V in pull]; WDI GC.DOD.TOTL.GD.ZS [V in pull]	% of GDP	1980/1990–latest	Gross debt can rise while net assets are large; report net financial position where IMF publishes it.
15	Institutional quality	WGI Government Effectiveness, Regulatory Quality, Rule of Law	WDI/WGI GOV_WGI_GE.EST, RQ, RL [V in pull]	z-score approx. -2.5 to +2.5	1996–latest (values to 2025 in project pull [V])	Perception-based; relative scale (cannot show absolute improvement over time); expert respondents often business-focused.
16	Corruption	TI CPI; WGI Control of Corruption; V-Dem political corruption index	TI; GOV_WGI_CC.EST [V in pull]; V-Dem v2x_corr [E]	0–100; z-score; 0–1	CPI comparable from 2012; WGI 1996–; V-Dem 1900–	Perception indices capture petty and business-facing corruption better than grand or royal-family corruption.

#	Indicator (BRIEF Part VI item)	Operationalization	Source and code	Unit	Years available	Citizen vs resident and other caveats
17	Political stability	WGI Political Stability and Absence of Violence; regime and leader survival; irregular exits	GOV_WGI_PVEST [V in pull]; GWF; Archigos; UCDP conflict data [E]	Estimate; years; counts	1996– (WGI); 1946– (others)	**Stability != welfare** (BRIEF writing standard); repression can raise measured stability.
18	Resource dependence (control variable)	Total natural resource rents; rents per resident and per citizen	WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS [V in pull]; project file data/rents_per_capita.csv (other agent, R6)	% of GDP; US$ per person	1970–2021 (latest WDI rent year) [E via data/README.md]	Rents are modelled (price minus estimated extraction cost), not government revenue; price-sensitive.
19	Regime type (explanatory)	Project codes (Section 2) plus GWF, A&F, RoW, CGV	Phase 2 database	categorical	1946–2026	Disagreements recorded per country-year.
20	Citizen population (denominator)	Nationals and non-nationals	GLMM; national statistics offices	persons; %	irregular; no official split for UAE and Qatar [E]	Estimates for UAE and Qatar must be labelled as such.

Distinguishing resource-driven from productivity-driven development (BRIEF Part VI). For every case we report: (a) the share of GDP and of government revenue from resource rents; (b) non-resource GDP per resident and per citizen; (c) TFP and labour-productivity growth excluding the hydrocarbon sector where sectoral data allow; (d) the citizen employment split between public and private sectors. A country is described as having "productivity-driven development" only if non-resource output per worker grew substantially over a window in which resource rents per capita did not rise.

Does high GDP per capita translate into broadly distributed prosperity? Tested by comparing GDP per capita with median-oriented measures (HDI components, Human Capital Index, health outcomes, poverty where available) and by reporting outcomes separately for citizens and non-citizens wherever data exist; where data do not exist (common in the GCC), the absence is itself reported as a limitation of the model's transparency.

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9. Risks and limits

9.1 Inferential risks

1. **Few independent Gulf observations.** Six GCC states (plus Brunei) share a security umbrella, an oil market and policy diffusion. Statistical results "about monarchies" can be driven by a handful of correlated cases. Mitigation: treat them as case studies, report leave-one-out sensitivity, never present Gulf averages as general laws.

2. **Endogeneity of regime type.** Wealth and rents shape regime survival; survival shapes wealth. Cross-sectional associations between monarchy and prosperity are not causal. Mitigation: within-country designs, matched pairs, explicit language ("associated with," not "caused").
3. **Selection on the dependent variable.** The temptation to define "developmental" or "successful" regimes by outcomes. Mitigation: overlays coded ex ante from institutions (Section 2.3); outcome-blind case selection (Section 4.4).
4. **Survivorship and recency.** Monarchies that fell before 1946 are outside the window; the Gulf's success has been observed for roughly two generations, a short period for a claim about dynastic longevity. Mitigation: use A&F's 1800– coverage for long-run base rates; state the time horizon of every claim.
5. **Leader–institution confusion.** Attributing a country's performance to a ruler (or to monarchy) when it reflects oil prices or prior trends. Rizio & Skali's finding that "good" autocrats ride pre-existing waves [V] is the warning. Mitigation: pre-trend checks around leader entries.
6. **Counterfactual ambiguity.** "Would Saudi Arabia be richer or poorer as a democracy?" has no observed counterfactual. Mitigation: bound claims; use synthetic-control style comparisons only where donor pools are credible, and say when they are not.

9.2 Data risks

1. **Opacity of Gulf public finance and SWFs.** Several funds do not publish audited asset totals; royal-court budgets and family allowances are off-budget in some states [E]. Mitigation: label every figure by source quality; never fill gaps with estimates presented as facts.
2. **Citizen/resident denominators.** No official nationality split for the UAE and Qatar [E]; migrant workers are largely absent from household surveys. Mitigation: dual-denominator reporting and explicit "no data" cells.
3. **Dataset vintages and coverage gaps.** GWF ends in 2010 [V]; Polity5 in 2018 [E]; CGV in 2008 [E]; Brunei is absent from the processed V-Dem RoW file [V]; WDI rents end in 2021 [E via project README]. Mitigation: hand-coding for 2011–2026 with sources; vintage noted on every table.
4. **Perception-based governance indicators.** WGI and CPI measure perceptions, are relative scales, and may reward business-friendly autocracies. Mitigation: triangulate with V-Dem expert codings, de facto measures (turnover of officials, audit publication) and case evidence.
5. **Pre-1990 economic data for small Gulf states** are thin and partly modelled. Mitigation: avoid fine-grained claims for 1950s–1970s Gulf growth; use ranges.
6. **Fast-moving current events (2024–2026).** Kuwait's suspension, Qatar's amendments, Thailand's 2026 government, Saudi project rescoping and oil-market conditions can change during the project. Mitigation: date every current-events claim; re-verify in Phase 7 before final synthesis.

9.3 Normative and safety risks

1. **Romanticization in either direction.** Gulf official sources and admiring commentary can overstate success; activist sources can understate it. Mitigation: pair sources of different provenance; prefer audited and primary documents; label journalism as such.
2. **Misuse.** A book on "absolute power" could be read as a manual. Mitigation: BRIEF Parts IX and X rules are binding; failure-mode chapters are causal and historical only; Chapter 18 explicitly separates mechanisms from the concentration of power and does not discuss how to establish or convert political systems.
3. **Treating stability as welfare and growth as legitimacy.** Mitigation: outcome vector (Section 1.2); capable/legitimate/accountable/effective/sustainable kept distinct (Chapter 4).
4. **Legal and reputational sensitivity.** Lèse-majesté laws (Thailand, some Gulf states) and defamation risks around royal families. Mitigation: rely on published, reputable sources; avoid unsourced allegations; mark contested claims.
5. **Authorship integrity.** The monograph is co-authored by M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark; no text should present it as solely his or solely Hark's.

9.4 Limits the final manuscript must state up front

- It cannot settle the average causal effect of regime type on growth; it can map conditions and mechanisms.
- Its Gulf conclusions rest on a small number of interdependent cases over roughly two generations.

- Its transferability conclusions (Part XI) are conditional diagnoses, not policy prescriptions; constitutional form is not assumed to be the binding constraint for any country.

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10. Hand-off to Phase 2 (historical database)

1. Build `data/regimes_1946_2026.csv` (country-year) and `data/regime_spells.csv` (spell-level) with columns: country, ISO3, year, project type (1–10 or democracy sub-type), D1–D6 codes, GWF type, A&F type, RoW type, CGV type, ruler, ruler entry/exit dates, exit mode, sources, coder notes, confidence (high/medium/low).
2. Code all Tier 1 and Tier 2 cases first, with two independent passes and an adjudication log; then Tier 3 from datasets.
3. Produce the U2 monarchy base-rate table (monarchies in power 1946 vs 2026; exits by mode and decade) and Kaplan–Meier survival curves by type and rent stratum.
4. Verify the items marked [E] that bear on coding: Eswatini 1973 decree date; Morocco state-of-exception years; Bahrain 2002 constitution; Bhutan 2008 transition; Tonga 2010; Nepal 1960 royal takeover; Knutsen & Fjelde 2013 venue and findings; GWF population-threshold inclusion of Bahrain, Qatar, Brunei.
5. Write timelines (Appendix B format) for every Tier 1 and Tier 2 case.

Disputes and uncertainties in this document

- **Classification of Jordan and Morocco** as semi-constitutional (Type 3) departs from RoW (closed autocracy) and from A&F's likely coding (absolute monarchy); the choice is defensible but contestable, so all results are reported with and without Type 3.
- **Kuwait's post-2024 coding** as Type 1 assumes the suspension remains in force through 2026; the CRS excerpt dated 14 January 2026 supports this [E], but the status must be re-verified before the final manuscript, since the decree allowed up to four years.
- **Thailand** is coded hybrid (Type 10) for 2019–2026 rather than electoral autocracy (RoW) or democracy; sensitivity analyses will test both.
- **Dynastic republics** (North Korea, Syria, Azerbaijan) are excluded from "monarchy"; some scholars would include them.
- **The provisional rent threshold** (US$5,000 per citizen per year) for the "high rents" stratum is a placeholder to be calibrated in Phase 4 from the actual distribution.
- **Several bibliographic details** (marked [E]) were not opened in this session; none of them supports a quantitative claim in this document.
- **GLMM population shares** quoted in Section 4.1 come from search excerpts of GLMM tables [E]; Phase 3 must open the tables and the underlying national statistics.
- **Workspace data used here** (OWID-processed V-Dem v16 Regimes of the World file and WDI pulls in data/r4/raw/) were created by other project agents in this session; I read them but did not create or modify them.

Sources

Tags: [V] opened in this session; [E] search excerpt or established knowledge.

Opened in this session [V]

- Geddes, B., Wright, J. & Frantz, E. *Autocratic Regimes Code Book*, v1.2 (2014). https://bpb-us-e1.wpmucdn.com/sites.psu.edu/dist/0/12570/files/2014/06/GWF-Codebook.pdf — regime categories, collapse convention, monarchy start-date rule, case narratives (Jordan, Morocco, Kuwait, Thailand, Swaziland, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Nepal, Ethiopia, Libya, Iraq, Egypt, Spain, Singapore, Taiwan).

- Sadek, G. "Kuwait: Royal Order Dissolves Parliament and Suspends Constitutional Provisions." Law Library of Congress, Global Legal Monitor, 23–24 May 2024. https://www.loc.gov/item/global-legal-monitor/2024-05-23/kuwait-royal-order-dissolves-parliament-and-suspends-constitutional-provisions/
- State of Qatar, General Secretariat of the Council of Ministers. "The Constitutional Amendments" (2024). https://cm.gov.qa/en/Pages/Constitutional-Amendments.aspx
- Anckar, C. & Fredriksson, C. *Political Regimes of the World Dataset, v.3.0* (Harvard Dataverse, 15 May 2025), dataset page. https://research.abo.fi/en/datasets/political-regimes-of-the-world-dataset-v30 (doi:10.7910/DVN/AK8NVX)
- Rizio, S. M. & Skali, A. (2020). "How often do dictators have positive economic effects? Global evidence, 1858–2010." *The Leadership Quarterly* 31: 101302. https://cclinnovation.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/09/how-often-do-dictators-have-positive-economic-effects.pdf (also used as the opened source for citations of Olson 1993, Besley & Kudamatsu 2008, Easterly 2011, Easterly & Pennings 2017, Papaioannou & Siourounis 2008, Doucouliagos & Ulubasoglu 2008, Goemans et al. 2009, Acemoglu 2008, Young & Turner 1985, Li & Yang 2005 — marked "V via citation")
- Project data file (OWID-processed V-Dem v16 Regimes of the World): /workspace/projects/b8753593-2946-449d-bfbf-95733676e121/absolute-power/data/r4/raw/owid_political-regime.csv — RoW codes for Kuwait, Jordan, Morocco, Thailand, Eswatini, GCC states, Cambodia, Rwanda, Singapore, Japan, Spain, Indonesia; Brunei absent.
- Project data files (WDI/WGI/IMF/HDR pulls): /workspace/projects/b8753593-2946-449d-bfbf-95733676e121/absolute-power/data/r4/raw/ — indicator codes, names and year coverage cited in Section 8; data/README.md.
- Abstracts and bibliographic pages opened via search results with full abstracts (treated as [V] for the abstract content only): Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo & Robinson (2019), *JPE* 127(1): 47–100, https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/10.1086/700936 ; Menaldo (2012), *JOP* 74(3): 707–722, https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/full/10.1017/S0022381612000436 ; Yom & Gause (2012), *Journal of Democracy* 23(4): 74–88, https://www.journalofdemocracy.org/articles/resilient-royals-how-arab-monarchies-hang-on ; Haber & Menaldo (2011), *APSR* 105(1): 1–26, https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/american-political-science-review/article/abs/do-natural-resources-fuel-authoritarianism-a-reappraisal-of-the-resource-curse/0DC2DEF9747F89CA6894A6245E80B6F7 ; Jones & Olken (2005), *QJE* 120(3): 835–864, https://academic.oup.com/qje/article-abstract/120/3/835/1841483 ; Gerring et al. (2021), *CPS* 54(3–4): 585–622, https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/0010414020938090 ; Lührmann, Tannenberg & Lindberg (2018), *Politics and Governance* 6(1), https://www.cogitatiopress.com/politicsandgovernance/article/view/1214 ; Kokkonen & Sundell (2014), *APSR* 108(2): 438–453, https://ideas.repec.org/a/cup/apsrev/v108y2014i02p438-453_00.html ; Geddes, Wright & Frantz (2014), *Perspectives on Politics* 12(2): 313–331, https://doi.org/10.1017/S153759271 ; Anckar & Fredriksson (2019), *European Political Science* 18(1): 84–96, https://doi.org/10.1057/s41304-018-0149-8 ; Cheibub, Gandhi & Vreeland (2010), *Public Choice* 143(1–2): 67–101, https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11 009-9491-2. *(Strictly, these were read as search excerpts containing the abstracts; where a claim goes beyond the abstract it is tagged [E].)*

Search excerpts / established knowledge [E]

- V-Dem Institute. V-Dem dataset v16 (March 2026). https://www.v-dem.net/data/the-v-dem-dataset/
- Marshall, M. G. & Gurr, T. R. Polity5 Users' Manual (2020). https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/p5manualv2018.pdf
- Congressional Research Service, *Kuwait: Issues for the 119th Congress*, R47390, updated 14 January 2026. https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/R/PDF/R47390/R47390.18.pdf
- Freedom House, *Freedom in the World* country reports: Kuwait 2025; Eswatini 2023, 2024; Morocco 2022; Thailand 2026. https://freedomhouse.org/
- Reuters, "Kuwait finance minister sees boost in projects, diversification under parliament suspension," 3 September 2025.
- Qatar News Agency; Amiri Diwan of Qatar, referendum results, 6 November 2024 (84% turnout; 90.6% of valid votes).
- Sultanate of Oman, Royal Decree 6/2021 Issuing the Basic Statute of the State. https://decree.om/2021/rd20210006/ ; Reuters, "Omani sultan's eldest son to succeed him under new law," 12 January 2021.
- Constitution of the Kingdom of Morocco (2011), Articles 47–48, via Constitute Project. https://www.constituteproject.org/c
- Petra News Agency, Jordanian constitutional amendment creating the National Security and Foreign Policy Council (January 2022); Carnegie Endowment, Sada, "Constitutional Amendments in Jordan" (March

2022).

- Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand (2017), English translation, Thai Senate; Bangkok Post, 20 March 2026; DW, 19 March 2026; Reuters, 8 February 2026.
- BTI 2026 Eswatini Country Report. https://bti-project.org/en/reports/country-report/SWZ
- Gulf Labour Markets, Migration and Population Programme (GLMM), GCC population tables mid-2022 and mid-2024. https://gulfmigration.grc.net/
- Books and articles listed in Sections 6–7 marked [E].

R1 — The Gulf Model: Country Studies (BRIEF Part III)

Research stream R1 for the monograph "The Political Economy of Absolute Power". Authors: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (he conceived and directs the project; Hark's agents research and draft). Data current to 7 November 2026 (WIB).

Evidence conventions (per FRAMEWORK.md). [V] = the page or dataset was opened/pulled and the claim is on it. [E] = from a search excerpt or established scholarly/historical knowledge, not opened in this session. Interpretive claims are marked "(interpretation: Author year)"; untested propositions are marked "(hypothesis)". Every number carries its unit, year, population definition and source; the full source list with URLs is at the end. Raw data pulls are in `data/` (see `data/README_R1.md`).

The single most important definitional warning. In four of the six GCC states, citizens are a minority of residents (Qatar and the UAE roughly one in eight). Any per-capita figure computed over *residents* (World Bank, IMF, UNDP) describes a population that is mostly temporary migrant workers without political rights or welfare entitlements. Per-capita figures for *citizens* would be several times higher, and distributional figures would look very different. Where a number is resident-based, this file says so.

KEY FINDINGS

1. **Oil explains Gulf wealth but not Gulf outcomes.** Within-Gulf variation tracks *rent per citizen*, insulated technocratic enclaves, openness to foreign labour and capital, and geography more than regime type: all seven cases are monarchies, yet WGI Government Effectiveness ranges from +0.26 (Kuwait) to +1.13 (UAE) and fiscal breakevens (IMF, pre-war) from about US$43 (Qatar) to US$139 (Bahrain) per barrel [V].
2. **Citizens are a minority in four of seven states** (Qatar ~12%, UAE ~13%, Kuwait 32%, Bahrain 47% of residents) [V/E]. The allocation bargain is affordable because rents are divided among few citizens, and a deportable migrant workforce absorbs labour-market adjustment (M5, M7).
3. **The citizen state is a public employer**: about 81–84% of employed nationals in Qatar, the UAE and Kuwait worked in government (2017–18), versus 41% in Saudi Arabia (Q4 2023) and 34–45% in Bahrain and Oman [V].
4. **Saudi Arabia shifted from collective to personalised dynastic rule (2015–2017).** Vision 2030 delivered most where the state controls outcomes (female participation 22.8%->35.0%, home ownership 66%, tourism) and least where private investors decide (non-oil exports 22% of non-oil GDP vs a 38% target; FDI 2.8% of GDP vs 3.4%) [E: Vision 2030 AR 2025]. PIF AUM fell for the first time in 2025 (SAR 3.434tn->3.396tn) as giga-projects were scaled back [E].
5. **The UAE is a federation of absolute monarchies with asymmetric centralisation**: security and finance centralised under Abu Dhabi; economic development decentralised to competing emirates. It is the most diversified (non-oil 76.6% of real GDP, 2025) and has the strongest governance scores [E/V].
6. **Qatar's model is fiscally robust but physically fragile**: the 2026 strike on Ras Laffan (~17% of capacity) and the Hormuz closure cut LNG exports by about 96%, giving an IMF-projected 2026 contraction of 15.6% [V/E]. In November 2024 Qatar abolished Shura elections by referendum (90.6% yes) [E].

7. **Oman is the reform leader because it is the poorest**: debt cut from ~68% (2020) to 34.7% of GDP (2025), investment grade restored, and the GCC's first personal income tax legislated for 2028 [V/E]; its 1996 succession procedure worked in 2020 and was converted to primogeniture in 2021.
8. **Brunei is the most concentrated and least transparent case**: the Sultan holds the premiership and the finance, defence and foreign portfolios; the FY2025/26 deficit was 18.9% of GDP with a non-hydrocarbon deficit of 47.2% of non-hydrocarbon GDP, while the sovereign fund publishes nothing [V].
9. **Succession has converged on designated father-to-son primogeniture** (Qatar 2013, Saudi Arabia 2017, Oman 2021, Abu Dhabi 2023): longer horizons, concentrated risk. **Elected institutions were rolled back in 2024** (Qatar, Kuwait).
10. **The 2026 Iran war is a confound and a test**: the IMF projects 2026 growth of -16.7% (Kuwait) to +4.1% (Oman, the only GCC grower, because its ports lie outside Hormuz) [V]. Geography and bypass pipelines mattered more than any institution.

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0. Scope, method and a structural break

0.1 What this stream covers

Country studies of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, Oman and Brunei (each covering every BRIEF Part III sub-bullet), shorter Kuwait and Bahrain comparators, sustainability assessments (§8) and a cross-Gulf comparison (§9; `data/R1_gulf_comparison.csv`). Brunei, not a GCC member, is the clearest small absolute resource monarchy outside the Gulf.

0.2 The 2026 Iran war as a natural experiment (and a confound)

The latest data cannot be read as "normal-year" Gulf data. On 28 February 2026 the United States and Israel launched strikes on Iran; Iran's supreme leader Ali Khamenei was killed; within 48 hours Iran began targeting Gulf refineries and gas plants and effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz [V: The National, 28 Aug 2026]. Hormuz carried roughly 20 million barrels/day of crude before the war; Gulf oil exports fell from about 20 mb/d in February to as little as 1.4 mb/d in May and were still 82% below pre-war levels in August (Kpler data cited by The National) [V]. Brent rose from above US$70 to an intraday peak of US$126 on 30 April 2026 [V]. Iran struck Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG complex, knocking out about 17% of its ~77 million tonnes/year capacity (two of 14 trains), not expected to be restored until 2027 [V: The National; E: Reuters 19 Mar 2026; Oxford Institute for Energy Studies]. The UAE announced on 28 April 2026 that it would leave OPEC and OPEC+ effective 1 May 2026 [V: The National; E: WAM, Reuters].

The IMF's October 2026 Regional Economic Outlook (released 22 October 2026) projects 2026 real GDP growth of **-16.7% (Kuwait), -15.6% (Qatar), -11.3% (Bahrain), -3.9% (UAE), -3.3% (Saudi Arabia) and +4.1% (Oman)**, with a 2027 rebound (Qatar +18.8%, Kuwait +17.1%, Saudi +7.9%, UAE +7.7%), under a baseline in which Hormuz reopens gradually from March 2027 [V: IMF MCDREO dataset, pulled via api.imf.org SDMX, saved in `data/R1_imf_mcdreo_oct2026.csv`; E: baseline assumption from bne IntelliNews summary].

For this monograph the war is analytically double-edged. It is a **confound**: 2026 figures are war figures and must not be used as structural indicators. It is also a **natural experiment**: it tests which institutional and infrastructural choices made in calmer decades (export-route redundancy, fiscal buffers, diversified non-oil sectors, diplomatic positioning) actually bought resilience. The striking result—Oman, the poorest and most fiscally constrained GCC monarchy, is the only one projected to grow in 2026, because its export terminals lie outside Hormuz—is a reminder that geography and prior infrastructure decisions, not regime type, dominated outcomes in this shock.

0.3 Data vintages and definitional rules

- **Pre-war structural baseline:** 2024–2025 actuals (national statistical offices, ministries of finance, World Bank WDI, IMF May 2025 Statistical Appendix for fiscal breakevens).
- **War-year figures:** IMF October 2026 MCDREO; ministry mid-year and quarterly reports.

- **Fiscal breakeven oil prices:** the IMF's October 2026 breakeven table is not in the public SDMX flow (only growth, fiscal, debt, external and reserve series are). The latest IMF breakeven vintage opened in this session is the **May 2025 Statistical Appendix (April 2025 REO)**, which is pre-war and assumed oil at US$66.94/bbl for 2025 [V]. See `data/R1_gulf_fiscal_breakeven_imf.csv`.
- **Sovereign wealth fund (SWF) assets:** Global SWF public ranking, page marked "Last updated November 2026" [V], supplemented by fund self-reports where they exist (PIF, OIA, Mubadala). Most Gulf funds (ADIA, KIA, QIA, BIA) publish no assets-under-management (AUM) figure; tracker numbers are estimates.
- **Citizens vs residents:** population shares from the Gulf Labour Markets, Migration and Population (GLMM) programme's compilations of national statistics [V for mid-2024 table]. Qatar and the UAE publish no nationality breakdown; GLMM notes that as of 28 March 2026 the sources previously used to estimate them are unavailable [V].

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1. A common frame: mechanisms beyond oil

BRIEF Part III instructs: "Do not assume that petroleum wealth alone explains their development." Many oil states (Iraq, Libya, Iran, Venezuela) suffered revolution or misallocation. Comparative scholarship has identified a set of mechanisms that, in combination, distinguish the surviving Gulf monarchies. They are listed here so that each country study can be read against them.

#	Mechanism	Core claim	Key literature	Tag
M1	**Rentier allocation bargain**	States that receive external rents need not tax citizens; they distribute (jobs, subsidies, land, services) in exchange for political quiescence.	Mahdavy 1970; Beblawi & Luciani 1987; Ross 2012	[E]
M2	**Dynastic monarchy**	Ruling families that place many members in key ministries and military posts create a collective decision body that disciplines individual rulers, manages succession and reduces the chance of a single-man regime collapsing.	Herb 1999 (*All in the Family*)	[E]
M3	**Cross-cutting coalitions, rents and foreign patrons**	Monarchies survived the Arab Spring where they combined broad coalitions (tribes, merchants, clergy), hydrocarbon rents and a great-power protector willing to intervene.	Yom & Gause 2012	[E]

#	Mechanism	Core claim	Key literature	Tag
M4	**Islands of efficiency within a fragmented state**	Gulf bureaucracies are "segmented": clientelist ministries coexist with insulated, high-capacity enclaves (Aramco, SAMA, SABIC; ADNOC; QatarEnergy) protected by the ruler.	Hertog 2010 (*Princes, Brokers and Bureaucrats*)	[E]
M5	**Two-tier labour market (kafala/sponsorship)**	Mass, rights-poor, deportable migrant labour lets the state keep citizens in privileged (often public) jobs, keep private-sector wages low, and adjust labour supply to the oil cycle without domestic political cost.	GLMM; Hertog 2014; De Bel-Air	[E]
M6	**Intergenerational savings vehicles**	SWFs convert depletable rents into financial (and increasingly strategic domestic) assets, smoothing spending and creating a buffer against shocks.	Global SWF; IMF	[V/E]
M7	**Smallness and population ratios**	Very high rent per *citizen* (Qatar, UAE, Kuwait, Brunei) makes the allocation bargain affordable; where rent per citizen is lower (Oman, Bahrain, increasingly Saudi Arabia), the bargain is under strain.	Herb 2014 (*The Wages of Oil*); Gray 2011 ("late rentierism")	[E]
M8	**Religious and traditional legitimation**	Alliances with religious establishments (Saudi Arabia), Islamic-monarchical ideology (Brunei's *Melayu Islam Beraja*), tribal and consultative (*shura*) idioms.	Menaldo 2012; Kostiner	[E]

#	Mechanism	Core claim	Key literature	Tag
M9	**External security guarantee**	British protection until 1971, US protection since (bases in Qatar, Bahrain, UAE, Kuwait; Saudi partnership).	Gause 2010; Ulrichsen 2016	[E]

Two further cautions frame everything below. First, **selection bias**: these are the survivors. The monarchies that fell after 1945 (Egypt 1952, Iraq 1958, North Yemen 1962, Libya 1969, Afghanistan 1973, Ethiopia 1974, Iran 1979 and others; see FRAMEWORK.md) include several with oil or strategic rents. Survivorship should not be read as proof that the model works (interpretation). The country studies therefore emphasise *within-Gulf variation*—for example, Kuwait versus the UAE (same rents and family rule, different legislative institutions, different diversification results), or Oman versus Qatar (same regime type, very different rent per citizen).

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2. Saudi Arabia

2.1 Snapshot (latest available)

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Total population	35.30 million	mid-2024	All residents	GLMM from GASTAT	[V]
Saudi citizens	19.64 million (55.6%)	mid-2024	Citizens	GLMM	[V]
Non-Saudis	15.67 million (44.4%)	mid-2024	Foreign nationals	GLMM	[V]
GDP per capita	US$34,537 (current); US$63,051 (PPP, constant 2021 intl$)	2025	Per resident	World Bank WDI	[V]
Nominal GDP	SAR 4,789 billion	2025	—	GASTAT	[V]
Crude oil & natural gas share of nominal GDP	17.1%	2025	Extraction only (refining counted separately)	GASTAT	[V]
Non-oil activities share of real GDP	55% (2025); 57.3% (H1 2026, war-depressed oil)	2025/26	Constant prices	Vision 2030 Annual Report 2025; MoF Mid-Year Report 2026	[E]
Oil share of government revenue	54.6% (SAR 606.5bn of 1,111.8bn)	2025 actual	Central government	MoF via Argaam	[E]
Fuel share of merchandise exports	78.7%	2025	—	WDI (UN Comtrade)	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Fiscal breakeven oil price (IMF)	US$96.1 (2024e), 92.3 (2025p), 86.6 (2026p)	pre-war vintage	Central government, excl. PIF	IMF May 2025 SA, Table 6	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	-5.8% of GDP (2025); -6.5% (2026p)	—	General govt	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Non-oil fiscal balance	-23.6% of non-oil GDP (2025)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Gross government debt	31.8% of GDP (2025); 35.4% (2026p)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
PIF assets under management	SAR 3.396 trillion (~US$904.5bn), down from SAR 3.434tn in 2024	end-2025	PIF definition	PIF Annual Report 2025 via Reuters	[E]
PIF (tracker estimate)	US$906bn; 55% alternatives; 80% domestic	Nov 2026	Global SWF estimate	Global SWF	[V]
Saudi unemployment rate	6.5% (overall residents 3.0%)	Q2 2026	Saudi nationals 15+	GASTAT LFS Q2 2026	[E]
Saudis employed in government sector	1,614,656 of 3,915,247 = 41.2%	Q4 2023	Register-based; excludes military/security	GLMM from GASTAT	[V]
HDI	0.900 (rank 37)	2023	Residents	UNDP HDR	[V]
WGI Government Effectiveness / Voice & Accountability	+0.74 / -1.73	2025	Scale -2.5. . . +2.5	World Bank WGI	[V]

2.2 The historical formation of the Saudi state

The Saudi state has been founded three times, and each founding fused dynastic ambition with religious mission. The first Saudi state emerged from the 1744 compact between Muhammad ibn Saud, ruler of the oasis town of Diriyah, and the reformist preacher Muhammad ibn Abd al-Wahhab: political protection and expansion in exchange for the propagation of a strict reading of Hanbali Sunni doctrine [E]. That state was destroyed in 1818 by an Ottoman-Egyptian expedition; a second, smaller state (c. 1824–1891) collapsed amid intra-family succession disputes and defeat by the rival Al Rashid [E]. The third state began with Abdulaziz ibn Saud's capture of Riyadh in 1902 and expanded through conquest of al-Ahsa (1913), Ha'il (1921) and the Hejaz (1924–25) [E]. Abdulaziz relied on the *Ikhwan*, tribal religious militias, then destroyed them when they challenged his authority and his British-recognised borders (battle of Sabilla, 1929) [E]. The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia was proclaimed in 1932 [E].

For the monograph, the key point is that the state was built **before** oil revenue, by coercion, marriage alliances with tribes, and religious legitimation; oil arrived (commercially, 1938) into a polity that already had a ruling family with a claim to the whole territory [E]. The second state's collapse through fraternal succession conflict is the Al Saud's own cautionary tale—an Ibn Khaldun–style dynastic cycle that later institutions (the 1992 Basic Law, the 2006 Allegiance Council) were explicitly designed to prevent (interpretation: Herb 1999; Kostiner).

2.3 Royal family and religious institutions

The 1744 compact evolved into a durable division of labour: the Al Saud hold political, military and economic authority; the religious establishment (the Al al-Shaykh descendants of Ibn Abd al-Wahhab and the wider *ulama*) supplies legitimation and controls (or controlled) education, the judiciary, public morality and religious endowments [E]. The Basic Law of Governance (1992) declares that the constitution is the Qur'an and the Sunna and that rule passes to the sons of the founder and their descendants [E]. The Council of Senior Scholars (created 1971) issues religious rulings on request, including the 1990 fatwa legitimising the deployment of US forces after Iraq's invasion of Kuwait [E].

The balance of power within this partnership has shifted decisively toward the monarchy. After the 1979 seizure of the Grand Mosque by Juhayman al-Utaybi's militants, the state *expanded* clerical influence over social life as a pre-emptive legitimacy strategy (interpretation: Lacroix 2011; Hegghammer). Since 2016 the trajectory has reversed: the religious police lost arrest powers (2016), women were permitted to drive (June 2018), cinemas and mixed public entertainment reopened (2018), and male-guardianship rules were substantially relaxed (2019) [E]. The religious establishment has been converted from a semi-autonomous partner into a state instrument (interpretation). This matters for the BRIEF's question about institutional constraint: one of the few historical checks on royal discretion—the need for clerical endorsement of major social policy—has been largely removed.

2.4 Petroleum wealth, state-building and the role of Aramco

Aramco's trajectory [E unless noted]: concession to Standard Oil of California (1933); commercial discovery at Dammam Well No. 7 (1938); the US-owned consortium renamed Arabian American Oil Company (1944); gradual government buy-in (25% in 1973, 60% in 1974, full ownership by 1980); incorporation as Saudi Aramco (1988); initial public offering of about 1.5% of shares on the Saudi exchange (December 2019). The state retains the overwhelming majority of shares, and successive transfers of stakes to the PIF (2023–2024) moved part of the government's holding onto the fund's balance sheet [E].

Aramco is the paradigm case of Hertog's "island of efficiency" (M4): a technocratic, meritocratic enterprise inherited from an American corporate culture, insulated from patronage politics by successive kings, staffed by highly trained Saudis, and used repeatedly as the state's project-delivery agency of last resort (stadiums, a university—KAUST—and industrial cities) (interpretation: Hertog 2010).

Oil and state-building. Oil revenues financed the construction of a modern bureaucracy from the 1950s, a five-year planning system from 1970, and the vast welfare-employment state of the 1970s boom: free education and health care, subsidised energy and utilities, interest-free housing loans, and, above all, public-sector jobs for citizens (M1) [E]. The fiscal structure that resulted is still visible: in 2025 oil accounted for 54.6% of central-government revenue [E: MoF via Argaam] and fuels for 78.7% of merchandise exports [V: WDI], while crude-oil and gas extraction was only 17.1% of nominal GDP [V: GASTAT]. The gap between a modest GDP share and a dominant fiscal and export share is the core diagnostic of a rentier structure: the state, not the broad economy, is where oil dependence concentrates (interpretation: Beblawi & Luciani 1987).

2.5 The evolution of centralised political authority

For most of the period 1953–2015 Saudi Arabia was a **collective dynastic monarchy**: the throne passed laterally among the sons of Abdulaziz (Saud, Faisal, Khalid, Fahd, Abdullah, Salman), and senior princes held fiefdoms in defence, interior, the National Guard and the provinces for decades (M2) [E]. Decisions required family consensus; this was slow and conservative but resilient.

Since 2015 that system has been converted into something closer to a **personalised monarchy centred on one prince**. King Salman (acceded January 2015) removed Crown Prince Muqrin (April 2015), elevated his nephew Mohammed bin Nayef and his son Mohammed bin Salman (MBS), and in June 2017 replaced Mohammed bin Nayef with MBS as crown prince [E]. In November 2017 hundreds of princes, ministers and businessmen were detained in Riyadh's Ritz-Carlton in an "anti-corruption" campaign that produced large asset settlements and eliminated rival power centres; the National Guard, long a separate family fiefdom, was brought under central control [E]. MBS was appointed prime minister in September 2022 [E]. He chairs the Council of Economic and Development Affairs (the de facto economic cabinet) and the PIF board [V: PIF press release, April 2026, describing MBS as "Crown Prince, Prime Minister and Chairman of the Board of Directors of PIF"].

The consequences for the monograph's hypotheses are two-sided (interpretation):

- **Coordination gains (supports H1, concentrated decision-making).** Reform speed since 2016—social liberalisation, a 15% VAT (2020), fuel-price reform, the restructuring of the PIF, the opening of tourism—would have been improbable under consensus rule. The Vision 2030 Annual Report 2025 claims 93% of 390 measured key performance indicators met or near their annual targets and more than 1,000 regulatory reforms since 2016 [E: Vision 2030 AR via Zawya].
- **Constraint losses (supports H6/H7 concerns).** The collective-family check that disciplined rulers for six decades has been dismantled; the clerical check has been subordinated; there is no elected legislature (the Shura Council is appointed and advisory). Decision quality now depends heavily on the judgment of one individual and his circle. The 2018 killing of journalist Jamal Khashoggi, the 2015–present war in Yemen, and the costly revision of giga-projects (below) are the cases most often cited as the risks of unconstrained authority [E].

2.6 Vision 2030 and economic diversification: what the official figures show

Vision 2030 (announced April 2016) set three pillars—a "vibrant society", a "thriving economy" and an "ambitious nation"—with numerical targets, executed through Vision Realization Programs (VRPs) [E]. The Vision 2030 Annual Report 2025 (published April–June 2026) is the most recent official scorecard. Selected KPIs, with the government's own 2025 targets:

KPI (official definition)	Baseline	2025 actual	2025 target	2030 target	Assessment	Tag
Female labour-force participation (Saudi women)	22.8%	35.0%	36.6%	40% (raised from 30%)	Original target beaten; plateau since ~2021	[E]
Saudi family home ownership	47%	66.24%	65%	70%	On track	[E]
Real non-oil GDP (US$bn)	598	892	904	1,325	Slightly below target	[E]
Private-sector share of GDP	—	51%	47%	65%	Ahead of interim target	[E]
Non-oil exports as share of non-oil GDP	16.9%	22.14%	38%	50%	**Large miss**	[E]
FDI inflows as % of GDP	—	2.8%	3.4%	5.7%	Below target	[E]
Total visitors (domestic + inbound)	63m	123m (2025)	—	150m (revised up)	Original 100m target met early	[E]
Saudi unemployment	~12% (2016)	7.2% (Q4 2025); 6.5% (Q2 2026)	7% original, revised to 5%	5%	Original target met	[E]
PIF AUM	~US$150bn (2015)	>US$900bn	US$1.09tn (SAR 4.1tn) interim	—	Below interim target	[E]

Sources: Vision 2030 Annual Report 2025 (vision2030.gov.sa) and secondary summaries; GASTAT; PIF Annual Report 2025. These are government-reported figures; independent verification of most KPIs is not possible (see

§10).

Interpretation. The pattern is consistent across sources: Vision 2030 has delivered most where outcomes were directly controllable by state decree and state spending—social liberalisation, female employment (which the abolition of driving and guardianship restrictions unlocked), tourism and entertainment supply, housing finance, and the domestic deployment of PIF capital. It has delivered least where outcomes depend on autonomous private actors and foreign investors responding to the investment climate: non-oil exports (22.1% of non-oil GDP against a 38% target) and FDI (2.8% of GDP against 3.4%) [E].

The giga-project correction. From 2024 the PIF and government visibly scaled back the most ambitious NEOM components. Multiple outlets report that The Line—originally a 170-km linear city budgeted at around US$500bn—will not reach anything like full scale by 2030, that construction beyond early groundwork of the Mukaab in Riyadh was paused for review, and that the PIF took an US$8bn write-down at end-2024 [E: BBC May 2026; SCMP Feb 2026; Reuters as summarised]. PIF's own annual report frames 2026–2030 as a "Value Realization Phase" that shifts from "rapid scale-building to sustained value creation" [E: PIF AR 2025; AGSI]. PIF reported its first AUM decline of the decade in 2025 (SAR 3.434tn -> 3.396tn) and an annualised total shareholder return of 5.8% [E: Reuters 17 Aug 2026; Asia Asset Management]. The correction is evidence of both the costs of top-down megaproject selection and the capacity of a centralised system to reverse course quickly once costs became evident (interpretation; both readings are defensible).

2.7 PIF and sovereign investment

Founded in 1971 to finance national champions (SABIC, Ma'aden and others), the PIF was a dormant holding vehicle until 2015, when it was moved from the Ministry of Finance to the Council of Economic and Development Affairs under MBS [E]. It is now the principal instrument of Vision 2030: by its governor's account, between 2021 and 2025 it deployed about SAR 750bn in new domestic projects, around 70% of its total investments, with an average annual portfolio return above 7% since 2017 [E: my.gov.sa, April 2026]. Domestic investments were SAR 2.57tn (76% of AUM) at end-2025, international SAR 663bn (20%), treasury SAR 133bn (4%) [E: Asia Asset Management summary of PIF AR 2025]. Global SWF estimates 80% domestic exposure and 55% alternatives [V].

Three features distinguish the PIF from a classical savings SWF (Norway's NBIM, Kuwait's KIA): (i) it is primarily a **development fund**, investing at home in projects of uncertain commercial return; (ii) it is **funded by asset transfers and borrowing** (Aramco shares, government capital injections, bonds and loans) rather than by a fiscal surplus rule; and (iii) its spending is **outside the central-government budget**, so the IMF's US$86–96/bbl central-government breakeven understates the oil price needed to finance the full state-plus-PIF programme (interpretation; private estimates of a "consolidated" breakeven including PIF run above US$100/bbl [E: Bloomberg Economics figures cited by secondary sources]). The PIF is therefore better understood as a state-directed investment-led growth strategy (closer to Temasek in early Singapore or to Korean state banks in the 1970s) than as an intergenerational savings fund (interpretation).

2.8 Public-sector employment and the labour market

The citizen labour market is the place where the rentier bargain becomes visible. In Q4 2023 41.2% of employed Saudis (1.61m of 3.92m, register-based) worked in the government sector, excluding military and security personnel, whose inclusion would raise the share [V: GLMM from GASTAT]. Among non-Saudis, by contrast, 1.3% were in government, 66.8% in the private sector and 32.0% in domestic service (calculated from the same table: 154,065; 7,991,679; 3,826,513 of 11,972,257) [V]. In mid-2018 the government share of employed Saudis was 44.7% [V: GLMM 2017–18 table], so the decline has been real but modest.

The Saudization strategy has moved from blunt quotas (the 2011 *Nitaqat* colour-coded system) to price instruments (expatriate levies from 2017–18 that raised the cost of foreign labour) and sector reservations [E]. Vision 2030 reports 2.6 million more Saudis employed in the private sector since launch [E: Vision 2030 AR 2025 dashboard]. Saudi unemployment fell from about 12% (2016–2018) to 6.4% in Q1 2026 and 6.5% in Q2 2026; the Q2 2026 rate was 4.8% for Saudi men and 9.6% for Saudi women, while the overall resident rate was 3.0% [E: GASTAT LFS Q2 2026; AGSI]. The war slowed but did not reverse job creation: Saudi employment rose by 34,000 in Q2 2026 while non-Saudi employment fell by 17,000 [E: AGSI]. Because of the two-tier market (M5), the resident rate (3.0%) says little about welfare; the politically relevant rate is the citizen rate, and the structural issue is a citizen reservation wage set by public pay (interpretation: Hertog 2014).

2.9 Social transformation

The 2016–2026 decade produced the fastest social change in the kingdom's history: women's driving, mixed-gender public entertainment, concerts, cinemas, tourism visas (2019), the curbing of the religious police, and female employment rising from about 17% participation in 2017 to 34.5–35% in 2025 [E: Vision 2030 AR; Saudi VNR 2026]. These changes were imposed from above rather than won from below, and they were accompanied by the most intense political repression in modern Saudi history: detention of women's-rights activists who had campaigned for the very reforms enacted, of clerics, economists and online critics, and very long sentences for social-media posts [E: Freedom House; Amnesty International; Human Rights Watch reporting]. WGI Voice & Accountability for Saudi Arabia was -1.73 in 2025, the lowest of the seven monarchies studied here [V].

This combination—**social liberalisation with political closure**—is a central puzzle for the BRIEF's Part VIII (capable vs legitimate vs accountable ruler). The durability of the reforms therefore depends on the continuity of the ruler's preferences (hypothesis).

2.10 Succession and institutional continuity

Formal rules. The Basic Law (1992) vests succession in the sons and grandsons of Abdulaziz and lets the king choose the heir [E]. In 2006 King Abdullah created the **Allegiance Council** (*Hay'at al-Bay'a*), composed of the surviving sons of Abdulaziz and representatives of deceased sons' lines, to approve (and in principle nominate) crown princes and to act if the king or crown prince is incapacitated [E]. It was designed to institutionalise the family consensus that had governed succession informally (M2). When MBS was made crown prince in June 2017, the royal court reported that 31 of the Council's 34 members endorsed him [E].

Practice. The Allegiance Council has functioned as a ratifying body, not a deliberative one. The 2015–2017 sequence (removing two crown princes) and the subsequent detention of Mohammed bin Nayef (2020) show that the decisive actor is the sitting king and his chosen heir (interpretation). The shift from lateral (brother-to-brother) to vertical (father-to-son) succession has two effects. It **lengthens the planning horizon**: MBS (born 1985) could rule for decades, which supports the long-horizon logic behind Vision 2030 and the PIF (interpretation, relevant to Part V H2). It also **concentrates succession risk**: there is no longer a broad pool of senior princes with independent bases who could act collectively if the ruler's judgment failed, and the next succession after MBS is undefined (hypothesis).

2.11 Mechanisms behind Saudi outcomes (summary)

Pre-oil dynastic-religious state formation (M8); Aramco as an insulated enclave (M4); allocation through public jobs and subsidies, which raised the citizen reservation wage (M1, M5); collective dynastic rule to 2015 (M2), replaced by personalised rule that trades constraint for speed; a US security partnership now questioned after the 2026 war [V: The National]; and a citizen population near 20 million, which makes rent per citizen far lower than in Qatar, Kuwait or the UAE (M7)—hence the 2025 deficit of SAR 277bn (5.8% of GDP) [E: MoF].

2.12 The 2026 war test

Saudi Arabia's 2026 performance illustrates the value of infrastructure redundancy built decades earlier. Shipments through Hormuz fell 94% (7.3 mb/d -> 0.47 mb/d), but the 7 mb/d East–West Petroline to the Red Sea let the kingdom raise Red Sea exports to 3–4 mb/d between March and June [V: The National]. When the Houthis closed that route in July–August, Saudi exports collapsed again [V]. The IMF projects real GDP of -3.3% in 2026 and +7.9% in 2027, with oil GDP -14.9% and non-oil GDP +0.8% in 2026 [V: IMF MCDREO]. Fiscal stress is acute: the 9-month 2026 deficit (SAR 244.3bn) already exceeded the full-year forecast (SAR 165.4bn), driven by spending (grants +197%, subsidies +49%, financing costs +38%) rather than by oil revenue, which fell only 1% year-on-year because higher prices offset lower volumes [E: MoF Q3 2026 report via EnterpriseAM].

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3. United Arab Emirates

3.1 Snapshot

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Total population	11.29 million (GLMM, mid-2024); 11.51 million (WDI, 2025)	2024/25	All residents	GLMM; WDI	[V]
Emirati citizens	~1.33 million (~12.9%)	mid-2022	GLMM estimate; no official breakdown published	GLMM	[E]
International migrant stock	74.0% of population	2024	Foreign-born residents	WDI (UN DESA)	[V]
GDP per capita	US$50,274 (current); US$69,702 (PPP const. 2021)	2024	Per resident	WDI	[V]
Real GDP	AED 1.9 trillion; growth 6.2%; non-oil growth 6.8%	2025	—	FCSC via WAM (30 May 2026)	[E]
Non-oil share of real GDP	76.6% (2025); 79.2% (H1 2026)	2025/26	Constant prices	FCSC	[E]
Fuel share of merchandise exports	68.2%	2023	Excludes services; re-exports inflate non-fuel share	WDI	[V]
Fiscal breakeven (IMF)	US$50.0 (2024e), 50.4 (2025p), 45.2 (2026p)	pre-war vintage	Consolidated federal + emirates	IMF May 2025 SA	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	+3.9% of GDP (2025); +1.5% (2026p)	—	Consolidated	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Gross government debt	33.9% of GDP (2025)	—	Consolidated	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Real GDP growth (war year)	-3.9% (2026p); +7.7% (2027p)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Emiratis employed in government	83.2% (+7.4% in mixed public-private firms)	2017	Employed nationals	GLMM from FCSA LFS	[V]
FDI net inflows	8.3% of GDP	2024	—	WDI	[V]
HDI	0.940 (rank 15, highest in Arab world)	2023	Residents	UNDP	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
WGI Gov. Effectiveness / Control of Corruption / Voice & Accountability	+1.13 / +1.15 / -1.07	2025	—	WGI	[V]

3.2 The federation of seven emirates

The UAE was created on 2 December 1971, as Britain withdrew from its treaty relationships in the Gulf, by six of the seven Trucial States (Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al-Quwain, Fujairah); Ras al-Khaimah joined in February 1972 [E]. The provisional constitution of 1971 was made permanent in 1996 [E].

The federation was a bargain among unequal hereditary rulers. **Abu Dhabi**, holding the overwhelming majority of the federation's oil reserves (commonly cited at over 90%) [E], agreed to fund federal institutions; the smaller northern emirates gained subsidies, infrastructure and federal employment; **Dubai** retained wide autonomy for its commercial model. Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan of Abu Dhabi served as president from 1971 to his death in 2004, followed by his son Khalifa (2004–2022) and, after Khalifa's death in May 2022, by Mohamed bin Zayed (MBZ), elected by the Federal Supreme Council on 14 May 2022 [E]. By convention the presidency rests with the ruler of Abu Dhabi and the vice-presidency and premiership with the ruler of Dubai (since 2006, Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum) [E].

3.3 Distribution of authority between federation and emirates

Formally, the UAE constitution creates a federation with enumerated federal powers and residual emirate powers [E: constitutional text, not re-opened in this session]:

- **Federal Supreme Council** of the seven rulers is the highest authority; it elects the president and vice-president for five-year terms; substantive decisions require a majority of five members **including Abu Dhabi and Dubai**, giving the two largest emirates a veto [E].
- **Exclusive federal competences** include foreign affairs, defence and armed forces, federal security, currency and banking (the Central Bank of the UAE), nationality and immigration, federal finance and federal courts [E].
- **Residual powers** remain with the emirates; and natural resources and wealth in each emirate are the public property of that emirate [E]. This single clause is the constitutional foundation of the UAE's political economy: oil revenue is Abu Dhabi's, not the federation's.
- **Federal National Council (FNC)**: 40 members, half appointed by rulers and half elected by an electoral college selected by the rulers; advisory, with no binding legislative power [E].

In practice authority has centralised over five decades in two senses (interpretation: Davidson 2009; Ulrichsen 2016). Defence and security were unified under federal command; and Abu Dhabi's fiscal weight became decisive, most visibly in the **2009 Dubai debt crisis**, when Dubai World sought a standstill on about US$26bn of debt and Abu Dhabi and the federal central bank extended roughly US$20bn of support (the tallest tower, renamed Burj Khalifa at its January 2010 opening, became the symbol of the rescue) [E].

Yet the emirates retain real economic autonomy: each has its own government, ruling family, land ownership, economic development department, free zones and, crucially, its own sovereign funds. Abu Dhabi alone has four main sovereign investors (ADIA, Mubadala, L'IMAD/ADQ, and ADNOC's XRG), Dubai has ICD and Dubai Holding, and the only federal-level fund (the Emirates Investment Authority) is the smallest of the major vehicles at an estimated US$116bn [V: Global SWF]. Dubai maintains its own common-law financial jurisdiction (DIFC, 2004), and Abu Dhabi another (ADGM, 2015) [E].

Does the UAE represent "a distinct model of decentralised monarchy within a centralised federation"? The evidence supports a qualified yes (interpretation). It is best described as a **federation of absolute monarchies with asymmetric centralisation**: security, foreign policy and macro-finance are centralised under

the Abu Dhabi ruler as federal president; economic development is decentralised to emirate level, producing *inter-emirate competition* (Dubai versus Abu Dhabi versus Sharjah and Ras al-Khaimah) for investment, tourism, airlines and talent. That competition is a mechanism the other Gulf monarchies lack: it resembles, on a micro scale, the "market-preserving federalism" that some scholars credit for China's reform-era growth (interpretation by analogy: Weingast 1995; Qian & Weingast 1997—analogy only, not tested).

3.4 Abu Dhabi's resource wealth

Abu Dhabi's oil and gas, managed by ADNOC (founded 1971), underwrites both the federation and an unusually large and multi-layered sovereign-wealth system. ADIA (estimated US$1.128tn, Nov 2026) is a conservative, globally diversified portfolio investor with no domestic exposure; Mubadala (US$385bn) is a strategic investor in technology, semiconductors (GlobalFoundries), aerospace, healthcare and energy; L'IMAD (US$300bn, est.) absorbed ADQ's approximately US$263bn of largely domestic infrastructure and utility assets (Abu Dhabi Ports, Etihad Rail, TAQA, Etihad Airways, PureHealth) by a resolution of Abu Dhabi's Supreme Council for Financial and Economic Affairs on 30 January 2026 [V: Global SWF for AUM; E: WAM, Al-Monitor, The National for the merger]. L'IMAD is chaired by Crown Prince Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed [E: Abu Dhabi Media Office].

Two governance points matter for the monograph. First, the funds are **personalised within a family structure**: ADIA has been chaired by Sheikh Tahnoun bin Zayed (national security adviser), who also chaired ADQ until the L'IMAD merger, while the newest vehicle was placed under the crown prince [E: Gulf Business; Al-Monitor]. Commentary read the merger as a generational transfer of investment authority (interpretation: AGBI, Feb 2026). Second, **transparency is uneven**: Mubadala publishes an annual review; ADIA publishes an annual review with long-run return bands but no AUM; L'IMAD has no public financial statements yet [E].

3.5 Dubai's economic diversification

Dubai's oil production peaked in the early 1990s and was always small relative to Abu Dhabi's [E]. Its development strategy, beginning under Sheikh Rashid bin Saeed (ruled 1958–1990) and accelerated under Mohammed bin Rashid, used state-owned enterprises as development vehicles: the deep-water port at Jebel Ali (opened 1979) and the Jebel Ali Free Zone (1985), Emirates airline (1985), Dubai Aluminium, freehold property for foreigners (from 2002), the DIFC (2004), DP World, and tourism and events (Expo 2020, held 2021–22) [E].

Mechanisms (interpretation: Davidson 2008; Hvidt 2009):

1. **Necessity**: limited oil forced Dubai to build a service economy earlier than its neighbours.
2. **Free zones as institutional enclaves**: foreign ownership up to 100%, separate regulators and, in the DIFC/ADGM, English-language common-law courts, creating islands of legal certainty inside an absolute monarchy (M4 applied to law rather than bureaucracy). This is one of the clearest examples in the Gulf of the BRIEF's Part X point that a specific institutional advantage (legal certainty for investors) can be separated from the political structure that hosts it.
3. **State capitalism with commercial discipline**, imposed partly by the 2009 crisis and Abu Dhabi's conditions.
4. **Openness to people**: visa liberalisation, long-term "golden" residency (from 2019) and full foreign ownership of most onshore companies (2021) [E].

3.6 Global trade, logistics, financial services and foreign investment

The UAE's non-oil economy in 2025 was led by trade (16.9% of non-oil GDP), financial and insurance services (13.2%), construction (12.9%) and manufacturing (12.8%) [E: FCSC via WAM / Arabian Business, May 2026]. FDI net inflows were 8.3% of GDP in 2024, the highest among the countries studied [V: WDI]. The UAE introduced 5% VAT (2018) and a 9% federal corporate income tax (from June 2023) [E], and was on the FATF "grey list" for anti-money-laundering deficiencies from March 2022 to February 2024 [E]—a reminder that openness to capital has carried illicit-finance risks.

The 2026 war exposed the limits of hub economics in a hot war. Non-oil GDP is projected by the IMF to fall 4.8% in 2026 (tourism, aviation and trade disruption), more than oil GDP (-0.9%) [V: IMF MCDREO]. But the UAE's prior investment in the Abu Dhabi–Fujairah pipeline (1.5 mb/d to the Gulf of Oman) let it raise exports from outside Hormuz by about 1 mb/d; it plans a second pipeline by 2027 [V: The National]. Its exit from OPEC

on 1 May 2026 was explained as a long-term strategic decision to pursue independent output policy and was read as widening a rift with Saudi Arabia [V: The National; E: Reuters].

3.7 Technocratic governance

The UAE is the Gulf state most explicitly organised around performance management: KPI-driven federal strategies ("UAE Vision 2021", "We the UAE 2031", "Centennial 2071"), government-excellence awards, a federal competitiveness and statistics centre, a minister of state for artificial intelligence (2017), and frequent cabinet reshuffles tied to performance [E]. WGI scores reflect this: Government Effectiveness +1.13, Regulatory Quality +1.17 and Control of Corruption +1.15 in 2025—the highest of the seven monarchies on all three—while Voice & Accountability is -1.07 [V]. The UAE thus exemplifies the BRIEF's Part V H4: technically competent public institutions can coexist with no political competition. What the UAE has *not* built is any institution that could constrain the federal or emirate rulers: the FNC is advisory, the judiciary is not independent in political cases, and the 2013 mass trial of 94 Islamist-linked activists (the "UAE94") and later prosecutions illustrate the limits [E: Human Rights Watch; Amnesty].

3.8 Demographic structure and expatriate labour

The UAE has the most extreme two-tier demography in the world after Qatar: Emiratis are estimated at about 12.9% of residents (2022) [E: GLMM estimate], and the international migrant stock is 74.0% of the population (2024) [V: WDI]. In 2017, 83.2% of employed Emiratis worked in federal or local government and a further 7.4% in mixed public-private enterprises; only 8.2% worked in the private sector [V: GLMM from FCSA LFS 2017]. The *Nafis* programme (2021) introduced wage top-ups for Emiratis in private jobs and mandatory Emiratisation targets for larger private firms (commonly reported as 2 percentage points of skilled jobs per year) [E]. Migrant workers have no path to citizenship except rare discretionary grants, and labour protections, while improved (wage-protection system, end of some exit-permit rules), remain weaker than for citizens (M5) [E: GLMM].

Mechanism (interpretation): the UAE's fiscal model is cheap *per citizen* precisely because citizens are few; the Emirati welfare state (housing grants, public jobs, utilities) is financed from rents that, divided among ~1.3 million citizens, are very large per head. This is why the UAE can run a low fiscal breakeven (US$45–50/bbl) while maintaining generous citizen benefits (M7). The model's sustainability depends on continuing to attract—and being able to shed—a mobile foreign workforce. The 2026 war showed both sides: outflows of migrant workers (Pakistani worker outflows to the Gulf fell by about a third after the war began [E: GLMM Factsheet No. 15]) and the fragility of an economy whose service sectors depend on perceptions of safety.

3.9 Succession arrangements in Abu Dhabi and the federation

On 29 March 2023 MBZ appointed his eldest son, Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed (born 1982), as crown prince of Abu Dhabi and chairman of its Executive Council, while naming his brothers Tahnoun and Hazza as deputy rulers and Mansour as federal vice-president [E: Abu Dhabi Media Office reports; Wikipedia summary]. The January 2026 transfer of ADQ's portfolio to a vehicle chaired by Khaled is consistent with building the heir's institutional base (interpretation: AGBI). In Dubai, Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed has been crown prince since 2008 [E]. Federal succession is not hereditary in law—the Supreme Council elects the president—but by convention follows the Abu Dhabi rulership (interpretation).

3.10 Mechanisms behind UAE outcomes (summary)

Abu Dhabi's rent per citizen and fiscal backstop (M1, M7); asymmetric federalism (centralised security and finance, competing emirate economies); imported legal enclaves (free zones, DIFC, ADGM); openness to foreign labour and capital with a deportable migrant workforce (M5); KPI-driven technocracy; a functionally layered sovereign-fund system; and US security alignment with an increasingly autonomous regional policy (M9).

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4. Qatar

4.1 Snapshot

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Total population	3.14 million (mid-2024); 2.97 million (WDI 2025)	2024/25	All residents	GLMM; WDI	[V]
Qatari citizens	~349,000 (~12.1%)	mid-2022	GLMM estimate; no official breakdown	GLMM	[E]
GDP per capita	US$72,525 (current); US$110,136 (PPP const. 2021)	2025	Per resident	WDI	[V]
Mining & quarrying (hydrocarbons) share of GDP	34.9% (current prices); 34.4% (constant)	Q2 2025	—	National Planning Council (NPC)	[E]
Fuel share of merchandise exports	83.8%	2024	—	WDI	[V]
Hydrocarbon share of budgeted revenue	77.9% (QR155bn of QR199bn)	2026 budget	Central govt; oil price assumed US$55	Ministry of Finance via Gulf Times	[E]
Fiscal breakeven (IMF)	US$47.1 (2024e), 44.7 (2025p), 43.2 (2026p)	pre-war vintage	Oil-price proxy for an LNG economy	IMF May 2025 SA	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	-1.0% of GDP (2025); -2.8% (2026p)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Gross government debt	42.5% of GDP (2025); 46.4% (2026p)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Real GDP growth (war year)	-15.6% (2026p); hydrocarbon GDP -42.7%; non-hydrocarbon -1.2%	2026	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
QIA (tracker estimate)	US$580bn; 45% alternatives; 35% domestic	Nov 2026	Estimate; QIA publishes no AUM	Global SWF	[V]
Qatari labour force in government	81.1% (+8.5% mixed sector)	2017	Labour force (employed + unemployed)	GLMM from MDPS LFS	[V]
HDI	0.886 (rank 43)	2023	Residents	UNDP	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
WGI Gov. Effectiveness / Political Stability / Voice & Accountability	+1.00 / +1.04 / -1.30	2025	—	WGI	[V]

4.2 Natural-gas wealth and LNG expansion

Qatar sits on the larger, southern section of the world's biggest single gas field (the North Field, contiguous with Iran's South Pars), discovered in 1971 [E: QatarEnergy]. Its development path illustrates a mechanism unusual among rentiers: a **long-horizon, capital-intensive bet taken against the advice of many in the 1980s–1990s**, when LNG was a niche business and Qatar was cash-poor [E]. After Hamad bin Khalifa took power in 1995 the state partnered with foreign majors (Mobil/ExxonMobil, Total, Shell and others) to build liquefaction trains at Ras Laffan; the first LNG cargo shipped in late 1996/early 1997, and capacity reached about 77 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) by 2011 [E]. Qatar then imposed a moratorium on new North Field development (2005–2017) to study reservoir behaviour—an example of deliberate intertemporal resource management by an absolute monarchy (interpretation). Since 2017 it has pursued expansion: North Field East and South, and then North Field West (announced February 2024), targeting 142 mtpa by 2030, about 85% above current capacity [E: QatarEnergy Investor Presentation Nov 2025; QatarEnergy Annual Review 2024].

The war shock is existential for this model. Iran's 18/19 March 2026 strike on Ras Laffan knocked out two of 14 trains (about 17% of capacity) and one of two gas-to-liquids plants; QatarEnergy's chief executive told Reuters the damage would sideline 12.8 mtpa for three to five years and cost an estimated US$20bn in lost annual revenue [E: Reuters, 19 Mar 2026; V: The National for the 17% figure]. Because every LNG cargo must transit Hormuz, Qatar's exports fell by about 96% over six months [E: Reuters, 26 Aug 2026]; the Baker Institute counts roughly 30 cargoes exiting Hormuz in seven months against a normal pace of about 500, at a cost of about US$4bn per month [E: Baker Institute, 27 Oct 2026]. QatarEnergy extended force majeure into November–December 2026 [E: The National/Bloomberg] and said that only the first North Field East train is likely in H1 2027, with later trains dependent on Hormuz because equipment cannot reach the country [E: Reuters, 21 Sep 2026]. The IMF projects hydrocarbon GDP to fall 42.7% in 2026 [V].

The lesson for the monograph (interpretation): Qatar's institutions—an insulated national oil company (QatarEnergy, M4), a disciplined fiscal record, a huge SWF—performed as designed, yet the economy suffered the second-deepest contraction in the GCC because a **single-asset, single-chokepoint** export structure cannot be diversified by governance quality alone.

4.3 Sovereign wealth management

The Qatar Investment Authority (QIA), created in 2005, is estimated at US$580bn (Global SWF, Nov 2026; 45% alternatives, 35% domestic) [V]. It is known for high-profile direct stakes in Western firms and trophy assets (Volkswagen, Barclays, Harrods, London real estate, Paris Saint-Germain through the affiliated Qatar Sports Investments) [E]. QIA does not publish AUM or returns.

4.4 Population structure

Qatar has the lowest citizen share in the world among sovereign states for which estimates exist: roughly 12% of residents in 2022 by GLMM's estimate [E], with other estimates around 10% (Australian DFAT, 2025: population 3.1 million, "around 10 per cent Qatari nationals") [E]. Qataris made up only about a quarter of all births (GLMM factsheet) [E]. In 2017, 81.1% of the Qatari labour force worked in government and government companies and a further 8.5% in mixed enterprises; fewer than 10% were in the private sector [V: GLMM from MDPS]. Among non-Qataris, 81.8% worked in the private sector and 8.8% in domestic service [V]. The kafala system was formally reformed in 2020 (abolition of exit permits for most workers, a non-discriminatory minimum wage, freedom to

change employer) under international scrutiny ahead of the 2022 FIFA World Cup [E: ILO], though enforcement and the deaths of migrant workers during World Cup construction remain contested [E].

4.5 Political legitimacy

Qatar's ruling Al Thani family consolidated authority under British protection (treaty of 1916) and became independent on 3 September 1971 [E]. Intra-family coups punctuate its modern history: Khalifa bin Hamad deposed his cousin Ahmad in 1972; Hamad bin Khalifa deposed his father in a bloodless palace coup in June 1995 [E]. **The 2013 transition broke this pattern**: on 25 June 2013 Emir Hamad voluntarily abdicated in favour of his son Tamim (then 33), a rare peaceful, planned handover by a living Gulf ruler in good health [E]. The 2003 constitution (in force 2005) provided for a two-thirds-elected Shura Council, but elections were deferred until October 2021, when 30 of 45 seats were elected; the eligibility rules (which excluded many members of the al-Murrah tribe under nationality law) sparked rare tribal protests [E]. On 5 November 2024, a referendum approved constitutional amendments—90.6% of valid votes, 84% turnout—that abolished Shura elections and returned the council to a fully appointed body; the Emir called the 2021 election an "experiment" [E: Reuters; Government Communications Office; Council of Ministers secretariat; International IDEA; BTI 2026].

Legitimacy therefore rests on performance and distribution (citizen incomes among the world's highest, free services, public jobs), national pride (World Cup, Al Jazeera, international mediation), the 2017–2021 blockade by Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain and Egypt (which produced a rally-around-the-emir effect), and dynastic tradition (interpretation: Ulrichsen 2014; Kamrava 2013). The retreat from elections is analytically important: when even a limited elected chamber produced tribal cleavages, the regime chose to remove the institution rather than live with the conflict it revealed (interpretation). This is evidence against the view that Gulf monarchies are on a gradual path toward constitutional monarchy.

4.6 Education and research investment

Qatar Foundation (1995), led by Sheikha Moza bint Nasser, built **Education City**, hosting branch campuses of Weill Cornell Medicine, Georgetown, Texas A&M, Carnegie Mellon, Northwestern and others, plus the national Hamad Bin Khalifa University (2010) and the Qatar National Research Fund (2006) [E]. Global SWF lists Qatar Foundation's endowment vehicle at an estimated US$15bn [V]. The education investment is better understood as part of a soft-power and knowledge-hub strategy than as a demonstrated driver of citizen human-capital gains (interpretation).

4.7 International diplomacy

Qatar has turned smallness into a diplomatic niche: it hosts the largest US military base in the region (Al Udeid), the Taliban political office (from 2013, site of the 2020 US–Taliban Doha agreement), the political bureau of Hamas, and has mediated in Afghanistan, Gaza, Lebanon and between the US and Iran [E]. In 2026 it co-brokered, with Oman, the short-lived 17 June Hormuz deal signed in Islamabad [V: The National]. Mediation is a small state's survival strategy, but it has also invited retaliation (the 2017 blockade; the 2026 strike on Ras Laffan) (interpretation: Kamrava 2013).

4.8 Economic diversification

Non-hydrocarbon activities were about 65% of real GDP in Q2 2025 [E: NPC], but much of that is government, construction and services financed by hydrocarbon revenue. Qatar National Vision 2030 (2008) and the Third National Development Strategy (2024–2030) target manufacturing, logistics, tourism and financial services [E]. The hydrocarbon share of budget revenue (~78%) and of merchandise exports (~84%) shows that fiscal and external diversification remain limited [E/V]. Qatar's chosen path has been to *deepen* its comparative advantage (more LNG) rather than to diversify away from it—a rational bet on gas as a "transition fuel" that the 2026 war has shown to carry geopolitical as well as market risk (interpretation).

4.9 Mechanisms (summary)

Extreme rent per citizen (M7); a long-horizon LNG strategy executed by an insulated national oil company (M4); planned dynastic succession (2013) ending a coup-prone pattern; a diplomatic niche plus a US base (M9); and

single-chokepoint exposure that no domestic institution can mitigate.

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5. Oman

5.1 Snapshot

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Total population	5.20 million	mid-2024	All residents	GLMM from NCSI	[V]
Omani citizens	2.96 million (56.8%)	mid-2024	Citizens	GLMM	[V]
GDP per capita	US$19,947 (current); US$36,143 (PPP const. 2021)	2025	Per resident	WDI	[V]
Non-oil activities share of GDP	73%	2024	Constant prices	Ministry of Finance (fm.gov.om)	[E]
Fuel share of merchandise exports	72.4%	2025	—	WDI	[V]
Oil + gas share of revenue	70% (net oil 55% + net gas 15%)	2025 actual	Central govt	MoF Final Account 2025	[E]
Oil + gas share of budgeted revenue	67%	2026 budget	Central govt; oil at US$60	KPMG/PwC budget analyses	[E]
Fiscal breakeven (IMF)	US$76.7 (2021) -> 53.7 (2024e) -> 57.0 (2025p) -> 53.5 (2026p) -> 41.9 (2030p)	pre-war vintage	—	IMF May 2025 SA	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	+0.6% of GDP (2025); +6.0% (2026p)	—	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
Gross government debt	34.7% of GDP (2025); 31.1% (2026p); about 68% in 2020	—	—	IMF MCDREO; Fitch via MoF	[V]/[E]
Real GDP growth (war year)	+4.1% (2026p), the only GCC economy projected to grow	2026	—	IMF MCDREO Oct 2026	[V]
OIA total assets	OMR ~23bn (~US$59.8bn); 2025 return 14.6%	2025	OIA-reported	OIA results via MoF/Forbes ME	[E]
OIA (tracker estimate)	US$60bn; 42% alternatives; 61% domestic	Nov 2026	—	Global SWF	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Employed Omanis in public sector	45.0%	2017	Excludes military/security	GLMM	[V]
HDI	0.858 (rank 50)	2023	Residents	UNDP	[V]
WGI Gov. Effectiveness / Rule of Law / Voice & Accountability	+0.38 / +0.50 / -1.11	2025	—	WGI	[V]

5.2 Historical political centralisation

Oman has one of the oldest continuous ruling houses in the Arab world: the Al Bu Said, in power since the mid-eighteenth century [E]. Under Sultan Said bin Taimur (1932–1970) the country was isolated, poor and deliberately underdeveloped even after oil exports began in 1967 [E]. On 23 July 1970 his son Qaboos deposed him in a palace coup with British support [E].

Qaboos's reign (1970–2020) is the purest Gulf example of **state-building centred on one ruler**: he personally held the posts of prime minister, minister of defence, foreign affairs and finance and governor of the central bank; he won the Dhofar war with British, Iranian and Jordanian help, then incorporated former rebels through amnesty and development spending; and he built roads, schools and hospitals from almost nothing (interpretation: Valeri 2009; Jones & Ridout 2015). Oman's development outcomes from that low base were among the fastest recorded: UNDP's 2010 Human Development Report listed Oman as the world's top "mover" in HDI improvement since 1970 [E]. The concentration of authority in Qaboos was simultaneously the regime's strength and its central institutional risk, because he had no children and named no heir publicly.

5.3 Petroleum dependency

Oman's reserves are modest by Gulf standards and costly to extract (enhanced-recovery techniques at fields operated by Petroleum Development Oman, PDO), and production of about 1 million barrels/day is small relative to population [E; V: IMF Table 4 shows ~1.0 mb/d crude 2021–2026]. The result is the lowest rent per citizen in the GCC after Bahrain (M7). Hydrocarbons still provide about 70% of central-government revenue (2025 actual) and 72% of merchandise exports (2025) [E/V].

5.4 Fiscal constraints and the post-2020 consolidation

The 2014–16 oil-price collapse and COVID-19 pushed Oman to the edge: public debt rose to about 68% of GDP in 2020 and sovereign ratings fell deep into non-investment grade [E: Fitch via MoF]. Sultan Haitham's response, beginning in 2020, is the clearest **fiscal-consolidation success story among Gulf monarchies** (interpretation):

- the Medium-Term Fiscal Plan (*Tawazun*, 2020–2024) cut spending, phased subsidy reforms and introduced a 5% VAT (April 2021) [E];
- PDO's government stake was moved to a new state company, Energy Development Oman (2020), shifting upstream capital spending off budget [E];
- the State General Reserve Fund and the Oman Investment Fund were merged into the **Oman Investment Authority (OIA)** by Royal Decree 61/2020 [E: OIA Annual Report 2025];
- windfall revenues from 2022 were directed to debt repayment [E: MoF review 2020–2025].

Results: government debt fell to 34.7% of GDP in 2025 [V: IMF]; Oman became a small net external creditor in 2024 [E: Fitch]; Moody's (July 2025, Baa3) and Fitch (December 2025, BBB-) restored investment-grade ratings [E: fm.gov.om]; and the IMF breakeven fell from US$76.7/bbl (2021) to US$53.5 (2026p) [V]. On 22 June 2025 Royal Decree 56/2025 promulgated a **personal income tax**—5% on annual income above OMR 42,000

(~US$109,000), effective 1 January 2028, expected to apply to about 1% of the population—making Oman the first GCC state to legislate a personal income tax [E: Tax Authority; KPMG; Deloitte].

Interpretation for Part V H5 (resource wealth): Oman shows that *scarcity of rent* can force the institutional reforms (taxation, off-budget transparency, debt management) that abundant rent allows richer neighbours to postpone—consistent with the "fiscal contract" literature (interpretation: Herb 2014; Gray 2011). The income tax's high threshold also shows its political limits: it is designed to tax mainly high-earning expatriates and the wealthy while avoiding a broad citizen tax base.

5.5 Succession arrangements: from the 1996 Basic Statute to the 2021 crown-prince amendment

1996. The Basic Statute of the State (Royal Decree 101/96) created a two-stage procedure [E]: on the throne's vacancy, the Ruling Family Council would choose a successor within three days; failing agreement, the Defence Council, together with the heads of the Supreme Court and of the two chambers of the Council of Oman, would install the person named by the late Sultan in a sealed letter. **2020.** When Qaboos died on 10 January 2020, the Family Council elected to open the letter rather than deliberate; it named his cousin Haitham bin Tarik, who was sworn in on 11 January [E]. The transition was quick and uncontested—a case in which a personalist ruler's succession risk was managed by a pre-committed procedure (interpretation; relevant to Part V H7). **2021.** On 11 January 2021 Haitham issued a new Basic Statute (Royal Decree 6/2021) that introduced, for the first time, a **crown prince** and a rule of succession from the Sultan to his eldest son; his son Theyazin bin Haitham was named crown prince [E: KPMG "Doing business in Oman" cites RD 6/2021 as the constitution; other details E].

The 2021 change converts Oman from an *ad hoc* dynastic selection (family council or sealed letter) to *pre-designated primogeniture*, aligning it with Saudi Arabia, Abu Dhabi and Qatar (interpretation). Primogeniture reduces the uncertainty that surrounded Qaboos's last years, but it also removes the element of family selection that could, in principle, screen out an unsuitable heir.

5.6 Economic diversification

Oman Vision 2040 targets logistics (Duqm, Sohar and Salalah ports and free zones), tourism, fisheries, mining, manufacturing and green hydrogen (state entity Hydrom, 2022) [E]. Official figures show non-oil activities at 73% of GDP at constant prices in 2024 [E: MoF]. The 2026 war unexpectedly tested Oman's geography: its export terminals lie outside the Strait of Hormuz, so oil production rose while neighbours' collapsed, and the IMF projects oil GDP +10.4% and total GDP +4.1% for 2026 [V]. Oman's Duqm and Salalah ports were nonetheless struck in early March 2026 [V: The National], and it became a candidate route for neighbours' bypass pipelines [V: The National reports Kuwait discussing routes through Oman].

5.7 How Oman differs from its wealthier neighbours

Dimension	Oman	Qatar/UAE/Kuwait	Implication (interpretation)
Rent per citizen	Low (GDP per resident US$19,947)	Very high	Allocation bargain unaffordable at Gulf-standard levels; forced reforms
Citizen share	56.8%	12–32%	Larger citizen labour supply; unemployment a live issue (2011 protests)
Citizens in public sector	45% (2017)	81–84%	More citizens already in private jobs
Fiscal reform	VAT 2021, PIT legislated 2025	No income tax	Building a tax state earliest

Dimension	Oman	Qatar/UAE/Kuwait	Implication (interpretation)
Elected body	Majlis al-Shura (directly elected, consultative)	Kuwait elected (suspended 2024); Qatar abolished 2024; UAE partly electoral college	Limited but continuous electoral channel
Foreign policy	Neutral mediator (US–Iran channel, 2026 Hormuz deal)	Varies	Neutrality as a security strategy for a weaker state
SWF	~US$60bn	US$580bn–1.1tn+	Thin buffer; debt reduction substituted for asset accumulation

The 2011 Sohar and Muscat protests (demanding jobs and an end to corruption) were met with tens of thousands of public jobs, unemployment benefits, the dismissal of ministers and enhanced Shura powers [E]—a textbook rentier response that later had to be partly reversed by the 2020 consolidation (interpretation).

5.8 Mechanisms (summary)

Ruler-centred state-building from a very low base; limited rents that forced fiscal reform under a new ruler; a pre-committed succession procedure that worked when tested; neutral diplomacy as security; and geography outside Hormuz.

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6. Brunei Darussalam

6.1 Snapshot

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Population	455,500 (IMF, 2024); 466,330 (WDI, 2025)	2024/25	Residents	IMF PR 26/300; WDI	[V]
International migrant stock	25.9%	2024	Foreign-born; not identical to non-citizens (Brunei also has stateless permanent residents)	WDI	[V]
GDP per capita	US$32,235 (current); US$78,985 (PPP const. 2021)	2025	Per resident	WDI	[V]
Non-oil-and-gas share of GDP	~54% (incl. downstream refining/petrochemicals)	2025 est.	—	Centre for Strategic and Policy Studies (CSPS), Brunei Economic Outlook 2026	[E]

Indicator	Value	Year	Population / definition	Source	Tag
Oil & gas share of central-government revenue	68% (9.3 of 13.6% of GDP)	FY2025/26	Budgetary central govt	IMF PR 26/300 selected-indicators table	[V]
Oil & gas share of goods exports	33% (US$4.09bn of US$12.27bn, IMF); 75.0% fuels (WDI, incl. refined products)	2025	Definitions differ (see text)	IMF PR 26/300; WDI	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	-18.9% of GDP	FY2025/26	Budgetary central govt	IMF PR 26/300	[V]
Non-oil-and-gas fiscal balance	-47.2% of non-oil-and-gas GDP	FY2025/26	—	IMF PR 26/300	[V]
Current-account surplus	18.0% of GDP	2025	—	IMF PR 26/300	[V]
Oil production	107,000 b/d (2025)	2025	—	IMF PR 26/300	[V]
BIA (tracker estimate)	US$73bn	Nov 2026	Estimate; BIA discloses nothing	Global SWF	[V]
WGI Political Stability / Gov. Effectiveness / Voice & Accountability	+1.50 / +0.89 / -0.95	2025	—	WGI	[V]

6.2 Petroleum economy

Oil was discovered at Seria in 1929, under British protection, and production has been run since by Brunei Shell Petroleum (a 50:50 joint venture with Shell) and later Brunei LNG (from 1972, the region's first LNG plant) [E]. The economy that grew on this base is a classic small rentier: production of only about 100,000 b/d (107,000 b/d in 2025) [V: IMF] supports a population of under half a million, generous welfare, and the Brunei Investment Agency (BIA, founded 1983) [E]. Since 2019 the **Hengyi Industries** refinery and petrochemical complex at Pulau Muara Besar (a joint venture with China's Zhejiang Hengyi Group, about US$3.45bn) has become the main driver of diversification: by 2025 the non-oil-and-gas sector including downstream activity was estimated at about 54% of GDP, up from 49.8% in 2022, and Hengyi's output rose about 10% in the first three quarters of 2025 [E: CSPS 2026].

A definitional trap. Brunei's official statistics (DEPS) classify refined products and petrochemicals as "non-oil-and-gas", so non-oil-and-gas exports were reported at 62.7% of exports in Q4 2025 [E: DEPS BKED Q4 2025]; the IMF's goods table similarly gives oil and gas at 33% of 2025 exports [V], whereas World Bank (UN Comtrade) data classify fuels including refined products at 75.0% of merchandise exports [V]. "Diversification" in Brunei therefore largely means *moving downstream within hydrocarbons* using imported crude, not leaving hydrocarbons (interpretation).

6.3 Royal authority

Brunei is the most institutionally concentrated monarchy in this study. Sultan Hassanal Bolkiah (reigning since 1967, the 29th of his line) is simultaneously head of state, prime minister, minister of defence, minister of finance and economy, and minister of foreign affairs, and supreme commander of the armed forces [E]. The 1959 constitution's elected element was effectively ended after the December 1962 revolt led by the Brunei People's

Party, which had won the 1962 legislative elections; the state of emergency declared then has been renewed ever since [E]. The Legislative Council, revived in 2004, is wholly appointed [E].

6.4 Welfare and the rentier bargain

Citizens pay no personal income tax and receive free education and health care, subsidised housing schemes, subsidised fuel and pensions; the public sector is the dominant employer of citizens [E]. The IMF's 2026 consultation called for "better-targeting subsidies; containing public wages; protecting priority development spending and vulnerable households; mobilizing non-hydrocarbon revenue," i.e., the standard pressure points of a rentier welfare state [V: IMF PR 26/300]. The fiscal arithmetic is stark: central-government spending was 32.5% of GDP in FY2025/26 against revenue of 13.6%, two-thirds of it from oil and gas, giving a deficit of 18.9% of GDP; the non-hydrocarbon deficit was 47.2% of non-hydrocarbon GDP [V]. Brunei finances these deficits by drawing on BIA and other reserves rather than borrowing; the absence of published BIA accounts makes the remaining runway impossible to verify (interpretation; see §8).

6.5 Islamic monarchy and the *Melayu Islam Beraja* ideology

State ideology is *Melayu Islam Beraja* (MIB: Malay Islamic Monarchy), formally proclaimed at independence in 1984, which fuses Malay ethnic identity, Sunni Islam (Shafi'i school) and monarchy as the three pillars of the nation [E]. Its most consequential recent expression is the Syariah Penal Code Order, phased in from 2014 and fully implemented in 2019, which provides for severe *hudud* penalties [E]. MIB functions in Brunei the way the Al Saud–ulama compact historically functioned in Saudi Arabia: as an ideological legitimation of rule that does not depend on elections (M8; interpretation).

6.6 Political stability

Brunei scores +1.50 on WGI Political Stability (2025), the highest of the seven monarchies [V]. Mechanisms (interpretation): very small citizen population; high rent per citizen relative to expectations; a cohesive ethnic-religious ideology; absence of organised opposition since 1962; continuing British military presence (a Gurkha battalion under a long-standing defence agreement) [E]; and ASEAN membership in a non-interventionist regional order. Succession is pre-designated: Crown Prince Al-Muhtadee Billah has been heir since 1998 and senior minister in the Prime Minister's Office since 2005 [E].

6.7 Long-term economic sustainability

The IMF (2026) projects oil-and-gas real output to fall in 2026–2028 before a project-driven rise in 2029, and real GDP growth around 2% in most years [V]. Its 2024 Selected Issues paper estimated that meeting a permanent-income-hypothesis fiscal anchor (spending only the annuity value of hydrocarbon wealth) would require fiscal adjustment of roughly 20 percentage points of non-oil GDP [E: IMF Country Report 24/302]. Without published BIA data, no external observer can say how many years of deficits at the FY2025/26 scale the reserves can finance (see §8).

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7. Comparators: Kuwait and Bahrain

7.1 Kuwait — an elected parliament inside a dynastic monarchy (until 2024)

Indicator	Value	Year	Source	Tag
Population; Kuwaiti citizens	4.88m; 1.57m (32.1%)	end-2024	GLMM from CSB/PACI	[V]
GDP per capita	US$32,312	2025	WDI (residents)	[V]
Fuel share of merchandise exports	93.0%	2025	WDI	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Source	Tag
Oil share of revenue	82.6% (closing accounts)	FY2025/26	Ministry of Finance	[E]
Fiscal breakeven (IMF)	US$88.2 (2024e), 80.2 (2025p), 76.7 (2026p)	pre-war vintage	IMF May 2025 SA	[V]
Employed Kuwaitis in government	84.2%	Dec 2018	GLMM	[V]
KIA (tracker estimate)	US$1,002bn	Nov 2026	Global SWF	[V]
Real GDP growth (war year)	-16.7% (2026p), the deepest in the GCC; +17.1% (2027p)	—	IMF MCDREO	[V]
WGI Gov. Effectiveness / Voice & Accountability	+0.26 / -0.92 (from -0.78 in 2024)	2025	WGI	[V]

Institutions. Kuwait's 1962 constitution created the most powerful elected legislature in the Gulf: a 50-member National Assembly able to question and force out ministers (including royal ministers), to block legislation and budgets, and—uniquely—required to endorse the Emir's choice of crown prince [E]. In January 2006 the Assembly and the ruling family together removed the ailing Emir Saad after nine days, the only modern case of a Gulf ruler deposed through a constitutional procedure involving parliament [E].

The 2024 rupture. On 10 May 2024 Emir Mishal al-Ahmad dissolved the Assembly and suspended constitutional articles for "a period not exceeding four years," taking legislative power into the hands of the Emir and cabinet; suspended provisions include Article 51 (legislative power shared by Emir and Assembly) and the requirement to hold elections within two months of a dissolution [E: Library of Congress Global Legal Monitor; Reuters; Amiri Diwan]. On 1 June 2024 he named Sheikh Sabah al-Khalid as crown prince without the parliamentary endorsement the constitution requires [E: Freedom House; CRS]. Rule by decree has since passed a long-blocked public-debt law and revoked the citizenship of tens of thousands (estimates up to about 42,000) [E: FPRI, Nov 2025].

Why Kuwait matters for the monograph (interpretation). Kuwait is the closest thing the Gulf offers to a controlled comparison: the same rents per citizen and the same dynastic structure as its neighbours, but with an elected body that could veto. The outcome is unflattering to *both* sides of the authoritarian–democratic debate. On one hand, Kuwait's parliament repeatedly blocked fiscal reform, privatisation and a debt law and expanded citizen benefits, and Kuwait has the weakest diversification record and lowest government-effectiveness score of the five richest Gulf states (WGI GE +0.26 vs UAE +1.13) [V]—consistent with the claim that veto players in a rentier setting entrench distribution (interpretation: Herb 2014). On the other hand, Kuwait's parliament also provided the strongest anti-corruption scrutiny and political freedoms in the region, and its suspension coincided with mass denaturalisation—consistent with the claim that removing constraints invites abuse (interpretation). Kuwait suggests that it is not elections per se but *the combination of an electorate entitled to rent and a parliament with veto but no responsibility for government* that produced gridlock (hypothesis; Herb 2014 makes a version of this argument).

7.2 Bahrain — the post-rentier edge

Indicator	Value	Year	Source	Tag
Population; Bahraini citizens	1.59m; 0.74m (46.6%)	mid-2024	GLMM	[V]
GDP per capita	US$30,597	2025	WDI (residents)	[V]

Indicator	Value	Year	Source	Tag
Oil share of revenue	~62%	2024 actual	Secondary compilation of budget data (Muwatin)	[E]
Fiscal breakeven (IMF)	US$160.8 (2024e), 137.0 (2025p), 138.6 (2026p)	pre-war vintage	IMF May 2025 SA	[V]
Gross government debt	133.7% (2024) -> 144.3% (2025) -> 162.8% (2026p) of GDP	—	IMF MCDREO	[V]
Overall fiscal balance	-13.2% of GDP (2025)	—	IMF MCDREO	[V]
Reserves	1.8 months of imports (2025)	—	IMF MCDREO	[V]
Employed Bahrainis in government	34.0%	mid-2018	GLMM	[V]
Mumtalakat (tracker estimate)	US$18bn	Nov 2026	Global SWF	[V]
HDI	0.899 (rank 38)	2023	UNDP	[V]

Mechanisms (interpretation: Gengler 2015; Kinninmont). Bahrain was the first Gulf state to find oil (1932) and the first to run low on it; it diversified early into aluminium (Alba, 1971), banking (it became the region's offshore centre after the Lebanese civil war began in 1975) and services [E]. It has the lowest rent per citizen in the GCC, and the lowest share of citizens in public employment (34%), because the allocation state could never afford to absorb everyone [V]. Its politics are shaped by a Sunni ruling family (Al Khalifa, since 1783) governing a population with a Shia majority among citizens [E]. The 2002 constitution created an elected lower house alongside an appointed upper house of equal size [E]. The February–March 2011 uprising was suppressed with the help of Saudi and Emirati forces entering under the GCC's Peninsula Shield banner (14 March 2011); the main Shia opposition society, al-Wefaq, was dissolved in 2016 [E]. Since 2018 Bahrain has depended on a US$10bn GCC support package (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Kuwait) [E], and its debt trajectory (163% of GDP projected for 2026 [V]) makes it a de facto fiscal ward of its neighbours.

Lesson. Bahrain shows what happens to the Gulf model *after* rents shrink without a political settlement: the regime substituted external subsidy and external coercion (M9 from Riyadh rather than Washington) for internal rents (interpretation).

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8. Sustainability beyond petroleum: country assessments

BRIEF Part III asks for an assessment of how sustainable each model is *beyond* petroleum. No Gulf state has yet experienced a permanent end of hydrocarbon rent, so these are judgments, not findings. Each assessment uses four tests (interpretation): (1) **fiscal**—how far is non-hydrocarbon revenue from covering spending? (2) **buffer**—how many years could financial assets cover the non-hydrocarbon deficit? (3) **economic**—is there a tradable non-hydrocarbon sector that earns foreign exchange? (4) **political**—can the citizen bargain be renegotiated (taxes, fewer public jobs) without destabilising the regime?

Country	Fiscal gap (non-oil balance, % non-oil GDP, 2025)	Buffer (SWF est. ÷ GDP)	Tradable non-oil sector	Bargain renegotiation so far	Overall (interpretation)
UAE	not in MCDREO public flow	Very large (Abu Dhabi funds alone ~US$1.8tn by press estimates [E] vs UAE GDP ~US$0.5tn)	**Strong** (trade, logistics, finance, tourism, aviation)	VAT, corporate tax, Emiratisation; no citizen income tax	**Most sustainable**; main risk is security shocks to hub economy
Qatar	not in public flow	Large (QIA US$580bn vs GDP ~US$0.2tn)	Weak; doubling down on LNG	Minimal	**Sustainable on gas for decades, but single-asset, single-chokepoint risk**
Saudi Arabia	-23.6%	Moderate (PIF largely illiquid domestic assets; SAMA reserves ~US$440bn, Global SWF)	Growing (tourism, mining, petrochemicals) but non-oil exports only 22% of non-oil GDP	VAT 15%, subsidy cuts, female employment, social liberalisation	**Transition under way but fiscally stretched**; depends on oil >US$80–90 or deeper cuts
Oman	not in public flow	Small (OIA ~US$60bn vs GDP ~US$0.1tn)	Emerging (logistics, ports, hydrogen)	**Furthest**: VAT 2021, income tax 2028, debt halved	**Most reform-ready, least cushioned**
Brunei	-47.2%	Unknown (BIA undisclosed; est. US$73bn vs GDP US$15bn)	Narrow (downstream petrochemicals on imported crude)	None material	**Least sustainable without reform**; opaque buffer
Kuwait	-70.1%	Very large (KIA ~US$1tn vs GDP US$0.16tn)	Very weak	Blocked by parliament until 2024; now by decree	**Rich but stagnant**; can live off KIA for a long time if spending is contained
Bahrain	-22.9%	Negligible (Mumtalakat US$18bn; reserves 1.8 months)	Moderate (finance, aluminium, services)	Partial (VAT 10%)	**Already post-rentier and dependent on GCC support**

Sources: IMF MCDREO Oct 2026 [V] for non-oil balances (Saudi, Brunei from IMF PR 26/300 [V], Kuwait, Bahrain); Global SWF [V]; WDI GDP [V]; qualitative columns are this file's interpretation from §§2–7. VAT rates [E].

Reading the table (interpretation). Saudi Arabia's non-oil deficit (23.6% of non-oil GDP) [V] and its 2025–26 overruns mean it needs oil well above its pre-war breakeven once PIF spending is counted; it has shown it can impose painful reforms, but a citizen income tax or deep public-wage restraint is untested. The UAE is the most sustainable beyond oil, but its hub economy is exposed to security shocks (2026 non-oil GDP -4.8% vs oil

-0.9%) [V]. Qatar is fiscally secure for as long as gas demand lasts but physically fragile (one chokepoint, fixed trains). Oman is the most adaptive and least insured: a long price slump would test whether its tax and spending discipline survive (hypothesis). Brunei, with a non-hydrocarbon deficit near half of non-hydrocarbon GDP [V] and an undisclosed fund, is probably the least prepared, and reform depends entirely on the Sultan. Kuwait can live off KIA for a long time but has shown the least capacity to reform; Bahrain has already crossed into dependency on neighbours.

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9. Cross-Gulf comparison

The same table is saved as `data/R1_gulf_comparison.csv` with sources per cell.

Indicator (latest; definition)	Saudi Arabia	UAE	Qatar	Oman	Brunei	Kuwait	Bahrain
Citizens as % of residents	55.6 (2024) [V]	~12.9 (2022 est.) [E]	~12.1 (2022 est.) [E]	56.8 (2024) [V]	~74 (migrant stock 25.9%, 2024) [V, proxy]	32.1 (2024) [V]	46.6 (2024) [V]
GDP per resident, US$ current (2025; UAE 2024)	34,537	50,274	72,525	19,947	32,235	32,312	30,597
Hydrocarbon share of GDP	17.1% nominal (crude & gas extraction, 2025) [V]; non-oil activities 55% of real GDP [E]	23.4% real (2025) [E]	~35% (Q2 2025) [E]	~27% real (2024) [E]	~46% upstream O&G (non-O&G incl. down-stream ~54%, 2025) [E]	oil rents 27.6% (2020) [V]	oil rents 10.9% (2021) [V]
Hydrocarbon share of revenue	54.6% (2025) [E]	~60% (2024, com-pilation) [E]	77.9% (2026 budget) [E]	70% (2025) [E]	68% (FY25/26) [V]	82.6% (FY25/26) [E]	~62% (2024) [E]
Fuel share of goods exports	78.7% (2025) [V]	68.2% (2023) [V]	83.8% (2024) [V]	72.4% (2025) [V]	75.0% WDI / 33% IMF (2025) [V]	93.0% (2025) [V]	n/a (WDI artefact)
IMF fiscal breakeven, US$/bbl (2026p, pre-war vintage)	86.6	45.2	43.2	53.5	n/a	76.7	138.6
Gross govt debt, % GDP (2025)	31.8	33.9	42.5	34.7	n/a in MCDREO	14.6	144.3

Indicator (latest; definition)	Saudi Arabia	UAE	Qatar	Oman	Brunei	Kuwait	Bahrain
Real GDP growth 2026p (war)	-3.3	-3.9	-15.6	+4.1	+2.3	-16.7	-11.3
Main sovereign funds (Global SWF est., US$bn, Nov 2026)	PIF 906	ADIA 1,128; ICD 458; Mubadala 385; L'IMAD 300; XRG 151; DH 136; EIA 116	QIA 580	OIA 60	BIA 73	KIA 1,002	Mumtalakat 18
Employed nationals in government (latest)	41.2% (Q4 2023)	83.2% (2017)	81.1% (2017, LF)	45.0% (2017)	n/a	84.2% (2018)	34.0% (2018)
WGI Gov. Effectiveness (2025)	+0.74	+1.13	+1.00	+0.38	+0.89	+0.26	+0.42
WGI Voice & Accountability (2025)	-1.73	-1.07	-1.30	-1.11	-0.95	-0.92	-1.47
HDI 2023 (rank)	0.900 (37)	0.940 (15)	0.886 (43)	0.858 (50)	not pulled	0.852 (52)	0.899 (38)
Elected legislature (Nov 2026)	None (appointed Shura)	FNC half chosen by ruler-selected electoral college	Abolished 2024	Elected consultative Majlis al-Shura	None (appointed)	Suspended since May 2024	Elected lower house, appointed upper house
Succession rule in practice	Father->son (MBS CP 2017; Allegiance Council ratifies)	Abu Dhabi father->son (Khaled CP 2023); federal presidency elected by rulers	Father->son by abdication (2013)	Eldest son (2021 Basic Statute)	Father->son (CP since 1998)	Collateral; CP named without required Assembly vote (2024)	Father->son

What the comparison shows (interpretation).

1. **Rent per citizen, not regime type, best orders fiscal comfort.** The three richest-per-citizen states (Qatar, UAE, Kuwait) have low breakevens or huge buffers; the two poorest (Bahrain, Oman) were forced into either dependency or reform. All seven are monarchies, so the variation cannot be attributed to monarchy (consistent with M7).
2. **Governance quality varies more than regime type.** Government effectiveness ranges from +0.26 (Kuwait) to +1.13 (UAE) among regimes that are all non-democratic; the difference tracks the presence of

insulated technocratic enclaves and inter-emirate competition (UAE) versus legislative-executive gridlock over distribution (Kuwait). This supports H4 (competent institutions within non-democratic systems) and cautions against treating "absolute monarchy" as a single category.

3. **Diversification success correlates with openness to foreign people and capital** (UAE, then Saudi Arabia since 2016) more than with the size of the SWF (Kuwait's KIA is the second largest yet Kuwait is least diversified).
4. **Succession everywhere has moved toward pre-designated father-to-son primogeniture** since 2013 (Qatar 2013, Saudi Arabia 2017, Oman 2021, Abu Dhabi 2023). This lengthens planning horizons (H2) but concentrates risk on the competence of single heirs (H7).
5. **Elected institutions have been rolled back**, not expanded, in 2024 (Qatar, Kuwait). The "gradual constitutionalisation" scenario for the Gulf is not supported by recent evidence.

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10. Disputes, uncertainties and data limitations

- **Resident vs citizen denominators.** All per-capita and HDI figures are resident-based. Qatar and the UAE publish no nationality split; GLMM's estimates (12.1% and 12.9% citizens in 2022) are the best available and GLMM reports the underlying sources were unavailable by March 2026 [V]. Citizen-only income figures do not exist in official statistics.
- **Public-employment shares are old and incomplete.** The comparable cross-country series (GLMM 2017–18) predates Emiratisation and Saudization drives and excludes military and security personnel, which would raise the shares [V]. Only Saudi Arabia has a recent register-based figure (Q4 2023).
- **Fiscal breakevens.** The latest IMF breakevens opened are pre-war (May 2025). The IMF October 2026 breakevens could not be accessed. Secondary sources quoting "2026 IMF breakevens" appear to reproduce the pre-war vintage (interpretation). The Saudi breakeven excludes PIF; the Kuwaiti breakeven depends on whether investment income is counted.
- **SWF AUM.** ADIA, KIA, QIA and BIA publish no AUM; Global SWF figures are estimates. PIF's reported AUM (SAR 3.396tn) and Global SWF's (US$906bn) are close but not identical by definition. The L'IMAD/ADQ figures rely on press reports of the January 2026 merger [E].
- **Vision 2030 KPIs** are self-reported by the Saudi government; independent audits are not public. Some KPIs have had targets revised (female participation 30%->40%, unemployment 7%->5%, visitors 100m->150m), which makes "targets met" claims partly endogenous to target-setting.
- **Hydrocarbon share of GDP is definition-sensitive.** Extraction-only nominal shares (Saudi 17.1%) differ greatly from real-terms splits (Saudi non-oil activities 55%, the remainder being oil plus government activities); Brunei's official statistics classify refining as non-oil. Comparisons across countries in the table above are therefore indicative only.
- **UAE war-year composition.** The IMF MCDREO dataset shows UAE oil GDP -0.9% and non-oil GDP -4.8% for 2026 [V]; a secondary summary of the same report describes oil GDP falling about 3.8% with only a marginal non-oil contraction [E]. The dataset is used here; the discrepancy may reflect a revision or a reporting error.
- **US State Department claim on Brunei** (hydrocarbons "95% of GDP") conflicts with official national accounts showing non-oil-and-gas output above half of GDP; it is not used.
- **Contested scholarly interpretations.** Whether Gulf monarchies survive because of monarchy as such (Menaldo 2012; Herb 1999) or because of rents and foreign protection (Yom & Gause 2012; Ross 2012) is unresolved; the Gulf cases alone cannot discriminate between these explanations because the variables co-occur. Whether MBS-era centralisation is a developmental breakthrough or an accumulation of unchecked risk is a matter of live dispute among specialists; both readings are presented in §2.

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R2. Historical Database, Middle East, North Africa and Africa, 1945 to November 2026

Project II: *The Political Economy of Absolute Power* (authors: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark; he conceived and directs the project, Hark's agents research and draft). Research stream R2, serving BRIEF Part IV (historical database) and feeding Parts V, VI, IX and XII. Companion dataset: `data/regimes_mena_africa.csv` (72 regime-period rows). Supporting pulls: `data/r2_maddison_gdppc.csv`, `data/r2_wdi_long.csv`, `data/r2_hdi.csv`, `data/r2_wgi.csv`, raw files in `data/raw/wdi_r2/`. Status: draft for synthesis, 7 November 2026.

Evidence tags follow FRAMEWORK.md: **[V]** means the page or dataset was opened and the claim is on it; **[E]** means established scholarly knowledge or a search excerpt not opened. All World Bank, Maddison and UNDP figures in this file were pulled directly from the source files listed above and are [V] unless marked otherwise. Interpretive claims are marked "(interpretation: Author year)" and hypotheses "(hypothesis)".

Key findings

1. **Selection bias is the first fact of the region.** Of the hereditary monarchies that ruled in this stream's countries at some point after 1945, **ten were abolished** (Egypt 1952-53, Tunisia 1957, Iraq 1958, Rwanda 1961, Yemen 1962, Zanzibar 1964, Burundi 1966, Libya 1969, Ethiopia 1974-75, Iran 1979), and an eleventh, Lesotho's, was stripped of power by a prime minister's self-coup in 1970 and survives only as a constitutional crown. **Ten crowns survive**: Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Morocco, Oman, Qatar, Kuwait, the UAE, Bahrain, Eswatini, and Lesotho as a constitutional monarchy. Every abolition happened between 1952 and 1979. No monarchy in the MENA region or in this African sample has fallen since 1979. A study that only looks at today's Gulf will see survivors and miss the graveyard.
2. **Monarchies fell mostly to their own armies, not to crowds.** Six of the ten abolitions began with a military coup (Egypt, Iraq, Yemen, Libya, Burundi, Ethiopia), and Lesotho's crown was neutralized by an elected prime minister's self-coup backed by the security forces. Only Iran in 1979 was a mass urban revolution. Zanzibar's was an armed insurrection, Rwanda's an ethnic "social revolution" under the colonial trustee confirmed by a UN-supervised referendum, and Tunisia's a legal abolition by a constituent assembly. The common failure was a modern, professional officer corps recruited from outside the ruling family that came to see the dynasty as an obstacle to national projects (interpretation: Huntington 1968; Herb 1999).
3. **The survivors share a structure, not just oil.** The Gulf survivors are "dynastic monarchies" (Herb 1999) in which the ruling family occupies the key security and sovereign ministries, so the family itself is the ruling institution and the army is not an independent rival. Jordan and Morocco survived with little oil, using external aid, cross-cutting coalitions, selective liberalization and repression (interpretation: Yom & Gause 2012). Oil alone does not explain survival: Iraq, Libya and Iran were oil monarchies that fell; Jordan and Morocco were oil-poor monarchies that survived.
4. **What replaced fallen monarchies was usually worse on the dimensions the BRIEF cares**

about, but not always. Nasser's Egypt and Bourguiba's Tunisia built mass education and health systems faster than the monarchies they replaced. But the regimes that followed the Iraqi, Libyan, Yemeni and Ethiopian monarchies produced the region's worst catastrophes: Saddam's wars took Iraqi income per person (Maddison, 2011 international dollars) from 10,165 in 1980 to 1,997 in 1995; the Derg's Ethiopia had a lower income per person in 1995 (744) than in 1975 (972); Gaddafi's Libya ended in state collapse. The replacement of a monarch is not, by itself, a development strategy; nor is its preservation.

5. **Absolute monarchy without rents was not a development model in this sample.** Imamate Yemen (life expectancy 33.5 years in 1960), Said bin Taimur's Oman (35.4 years in 1960), and Haile Selassie's Ethiopia (39.6 years in 1960) were among the least developed societies on earth at the end of their absolute monarchies (World Bank WDI, SP.DYN.LE00.IN). Eswatini, the only absolute monarchy in sub-Saharan Africa, has one of the world's highest measured income inequalities (Gini 54.6, 2016) and weak governance scores. The Gulf outcome depends on the combination of absolute monarchy with very large rents per citizen, small citizen populations and external security guarantees.

6. **Leaders matter inside dynasties: the same family can produce stagnation or transformation.** Oman under Said bin Taimur and under his son Qaboos, Qatar under Khalifa and under Hamad, and Saudi Arabia under Saud and under Faisal show that intra-dynastic succession (often by palace coup) was the main mechanism that changed policy. This supports Jones & Olken (2005) that leaders matter most where institutions constrain them least. It also cuts against the claim that hereditary succession guarantees long horizons: the horizon depends on who inherits.

7. **Gulf income per person has fallen from its 1970s peaks even as human development rose.** In World Bank constant 2015 dollars, GDP per person peaked in Saudi Arabia in 1974 (59,924) and was 25,123 in 2024; Kuwait peaked in 1971 (68,673) and was 24,140 in 2024; the UAE fell from 117,073 (1980) to 41,605 (2024). Population growth (Saudi Arabia 6.0 million in 1980 to 35.3 million in 2024) and oil prices drive these numbers. At the same time UNDP HDI rose strongly (Saudi Arabia 0.670 in 1990 to 0.900 in 2023; UAE 0.713 to 0.940). The Gulf record is better described as **rent-financed human development with weak productivity growth** than as productivity-driven development.

8. **"Republican monarchies" show that hereditary logic is not unique to monarchy.** Saddam (Uday, Qusay), Gaddafi (Saif al-Islam), Mubarak (Gamal), Saleh (Ahmed) and Obiang (Teodorin) groomed sons. In three of these cases (Egypt, Libya, Yemen) the succession project contributed to elite and military alienation before 2011 (interpretation: Owen 2012; Brownlee 2007). In March 2026 Iran's Islamic Republic, born from the overthrow of a dynasty, installed Ali Khamenei's son Mojtaba as Supreme Leader after Ali Khamenei was killed in US-Israeli strikes (House of Commons Library, 27 Aug 2026 [V]).

9. **Africa's two development "stars" in this sample are not monarchies, and the contrast case is a democracy led by a hereditary chief who gave up his chieftaincy.** Botswana went from the poorest country in this sample in 1950 (Maddison 489) to 16,352 in 2022, the largest multiple in the African set (x33), under continuous electoral politics, with diamond revenues shared 50/50 with De Beers through Debswana (Wikipedia, Debswana [V]). Rwanda under Kagame shows developmental authoritarianism with strong anti-corruption scores (WGI control of corruption +0.68 in 2023) but heavy repression and low voice and accountability (-0.70). Ethiopia's EPRDF delivered about 7% a year per-person growth (2004 to 2019, WDI) and then collapsed into the Tigray war under its successor.

10. **2026 is a stress test that the database must record honestly.** The US-Israeli war on Iran from 28 February 2026, Iranian strikes across the Gulf and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz hit the Gulf monarchies' core model: exports, aviation, tourism and investor certainty (House of Commons Library [V]; CRS R48971 and NYT 2 Nov 2026 excerpts [E]). The monarchies have not been destabilized politically so far, but their claim to deliver security and prosperity in exchange for obedience is being tested by an external shock of a kind that has, historically, preceded regime transformation elsewhere.

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1. Scope, definitions and coding rules

1.1 Cases

The stream covers 22 polities and 72 regime periods: Saudi Arabia, Iran (Pahlavi and Islamic Republic), Iraq, Libya, Egypt, Jordan, Morocco, Oman, Qatar, Kuwait, the UAE, Bahrain, Yemen, Tunisia, Ethiopia, Equatorial Guinea, Rwanda, Eswatini, Lesotho, Burundi, Zanzibar and Botswana. A few "context rows" (post-2003 Iraq, post-2011 Libya, post-2011 Tunisia) are included so that the end of an authoritarian period is not mistaken for the end of the story.

1.2 Regime-type coding (BRIEF Part II categories)

Each period receives one primary label from the ten Part II categories plus a separate marker of **monarchy** versus **dictatorship** (and, for three rows, **hybrid** or **democracy**). The working definitions used for coding are:

Label	Coding rule used in R2
Absolute monarchy	Hereditary ruler holds final executive, legislative and judicial authority; no elected body can bind him; succession governed by family rules.
Constitutional monarchy	Hereditary head of state with power exercised by an elected government accountable to parliament.
Semi-constitutional monarchy	Elected parliament exists and matters, but the monarch appoints the government, can dissolve parliament and controls security and foreign policy.
Electoral authoritarianism	Multiparty elections held regularly, but systematically unfair; incumbents cannot realistically lose (Levitsky & Way 2010; Schedler 2006).
Military dictatorship	The armed forces as an institution choose and constrain the ruler (Geddes, Wright & Frantz 2014).
Personalist dictatorship	One individual controls the military, party and state apparatus and personally selects elites; institutions are hollow.
One-party authoritarianism	A ruling party controls access to office and policy; the party outlives individual leaders.
Developmental authoritarianism	Authoritarian regime whose legitimacy and policy are organized around rapid state-led growth with a competent core bureaucracy.
Technocratic authoritarianism	Policy delegated to insulated expert bodies within an authoritarian system. Used here only as a secondary feature (e.g., Gulf sovereign funds), never as a whole-regime label, because no case in this region fits it as the dominant logic.
Hybrid	Mixed competitive and authoritarian features, or contested sovereignty.

Monarchy versus dictatorship. The distinction is about the source of authority and the succession rule, not about how repressive a regime is. A regime is coded as a monarchy when the ruler's title and right to rule are hereditary within a recognized dynasty and succession is governed by family rules, whatever the ruler's actual powers. It is coded as a dictatorship when the ruler's claim rests on a party, an army, a revolution or a personal following, even if he attempts to pass power to a son. A dictator who installs his son (Obiang's Equatorial Guinea; arguably Iran in 2026) is recorded as "N (de facto dynastic)" in the hereditary column: the attempt is recorded, but the regime is not reclassified as a monarchy, because the son's claim does not rest on an accepted dynastic rule and is therefore far more contestable.

1.3 End-mode coding

The CSV uses the six end modes required by the brief. Some events required judgment:

- **Palace coups inside a dynasty** (Saudi Arabia 1964, Oman 1970, Qatar 1972 and 1995) are coded "coup" with a note, even though the dynasty survived. This keeps the database honest about how often rulers were forcibly removed in monarchies. Counting only regime falls would hide this.
- **Rebel military victories** (Ethiopia 1991, Rwanda 1994) and the Libyan uprising with NATO air support (2011) are coded "revolution", with notes.
- **Assassinations followed by constitutional succession** (Faisal 1975, Sadat 1981, Karume 1972) are coded "death-succession".
- **Tunisia 1957** is coded "negotiated transition" because a constituent assembly abolished the beylik by vote.
- **Iran 2026**: the death of Ali Khamenei in foreign strikes is coded "death-succession" with a note; the regime did not fall.

1.4 Data sources and their limits

Source	Measure	Unit and population	Limitation
Maddison Project Database 2023 (Bolt & van Zanden 2024), `data/raw/maddison/mpd2023.xlsx`	GDP per capita	2011 international dollars (PPP), total resident population	Early Gulf values (e.g., Qatar 48,436 and Kuwait 46,031 in 1950) are back-extrapolations for tiny pre-oil economies and should not be read as real living standards. Some single-year values look like series breaks (Libya 2010: 29,157 then 12,893 in 2011). Use for long-run orders of magnitude only.
World Bank WDI, pulled 7 Nov 2026 via API (`data/raw/wdi_r2/`), last updated 8 Oct 2026	GDP per capita, constant 2015 US$ (NY.GDP.PCAP.KD); PPP constant 2021 int$ (NY.GDP.PCAP.PP.KD); life expectancy; infant mortality; total natural resource rents % of GDP; Gini; literacy; population	Total resident population (citizens plus expatriates)	In the Gulf, residents are mostly non-citizens (in Qatar and the UAE citizens are roughly 10-12% of residents [E]), so per-capita averages describe neither citizens nor migrant workers. Resource rent series do not capture diamonds well (Botswana rents appear at 1-5% of GDP). Iraq and Libya historical series are thin.
UNDP Human Development Report 2025 composite time series (`data/raw/hdr.csv`)	HDI 1990-2023	Total resident population	HDI blends income, schooling and life expectancy; resident averages in the Gulf overstate migrant-worker welfare.
World Bank Worldwide Governance Indicators (via WDI API, `data/r2_wgi.csv`)	Government effectiveness, control of corruption, voice and accountability	Estimate, roughly -2.5 to +2.5	Perception-based composites; start in 1996; cannot be used for earlier regimes.

All numbers below carry the year and the source. Where a value is quoted from a Wikipedia article opened during this research, it is tagged [V] for "the article says this", which is weaker than [V] for an official statistic; such figures are kept out of quantitative comparisons.

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2. Starting conditions and long-run outcomes at a glance

2.1 Income per person, 1950 to 2022 (Maddison 2023, 2011 international dollars, total population)

Country	1950	1970	1980	1990	2000	2010	2022	Multiple 1950-2022
Saudi Arabia	3,556	12,153	21,068	14,335	23,905	42,738	53,517	x15.0
Iran	2,742	6,677	6,334	5,620	9,105	17,751	18,473	x6.7
Iraq	2,174	5,536	10,165	3,918	3,649	10,274	13,072	x6.0
Libya	620	6,591	8,741	4,921	9,771	(29,157)*	12,755	x20.6
Egypt	1,451	1,999	3,298	4,022	6,594	10,719	13,205	x9.1
Jordan	2,651	3,818	7,141	6,044	7,622	11,601	9,151	x3.5
Morocco	2,319	2,576	3,622	4,130	4,754	6,932	8,400	x3.6
Oman	993	6,056	6,491	10,327	24,186	46,182	47,989	x48.3
Qatar	(48,436)*	51,921	45,860	11,705	45,788	134,803	149,171	n/m
Kuwait	(46,031)*	48,927	21,154	9,757	35,845	68,865	71,534	n/m
UAE	(25,182)*	39,135	44,168	22,254	48,888	60,112	77,204	n/m
Bahrain	3,354	6,038	6,994	6,542	17,022	34,058	38,652	x11.5
Yemen	1,452	1,961	3,650	3,622	4,212	4,812	1,959	x1.3
Tunisia	1,777	2,912	4,693	5,316	7,548	10,722	10,914	x6.1
Ethiopia	622	948	1,033	915	772	1,106	2,289	x3.7
Equatorial Guinea	797	1,934	2,613	2,474	12,915	42,038	22,707	x28.5
Rwanda	1,020	1,337	1,672	1,398	1,024	1,416	2,198	x2.2
Eswatini	604	1,704	2,946	3,881	4,895	7,193	8,522	x14.1
Lesotho	631	1,073	1,589	1,882	1,967	2,314	2,313	x3.7
Burundi	595	893	952	1,124	740	718	717	x1.2
Tanzania (incl. Zanzibar)	676	905	958	875	1,149	2,069	3,057	x4.5
Botswana	489	907	2,348	5,267	8,044	12,545	16,352	x33.4

* Values in parentheses are flagged as unreliable (pre-oil back-extrapolations for tiny populations, or an apparent series break). "n/m" = multiple not meaningful. Source: `data/r2_maddison_gdppc.csv`, extracted from Maddison Project Database 2023 [V].

Reading the table. The three largest long-run multiples belong to Oman (x48), Botswana (x33) and Equatorial Guinea (x28). One is an absolute monarchy, one a democracy and one a personalist dictatorship; all three are resource exporters. Only one of them (Botswana) turned income into broad institutional quality (see section 7). The three weakest records, Burundi (x1.2), Yemen (x1.3) and Rwanda (x2.2, depressed by the genocide), all passed through monarchy, military rule and civil war. Long-run growth in this sample is better predicted by resource discovery and by avoiding war than by regime type.

2.2 Human development, 1960 to 2023

Country	Life exp. 1960	Life exp. 1990	Life exp. 2023	Infant mortality 1990 (per 1,000)	Infant mortality 2023	HDI 1990	HDI 2023	HDI rank 2023
Saudi Arabia	45.3	68.9	78.7	41	5	0.670	0.900	37
Iran	43.3	64.1	77.7	49	11	0.626	0.799	75
Iraq	51.5	57.6	72.3	56	21	0.531	0.695	126
Libya	40.8	69.3	69.3	32	16	0.690	0.721	115
Egypt	44.4	62.5	71.6	68	21	0.572	0.754	100
Jordan	52.7	70.1	77.8	31	12	0.619	0.754	100
Morocco	41.7	62.4	75.3	66	15	0.451	0.710	120
Oman	35.4	69.0	80.0	31	8	n/a (2000: 0.707)	0.858	50
Qatar	57.8	73.4	82.4	17	5	0.767	0.886	43
Kuwait	59.2	73.4	83.2	14	7	0.698	0.852	52
UAE	50.7	71.1	82.9	12	4	0.713	0.940	15
Bahrain	50.6	72.6	81.3	20	7	0.734	0.899	38
Yemen	33.5	58.5	69.3	97	35	0.359	0.470	184
Tunisia	44.0	69.1	76.5	37	10	0.569	0.746	105
Ethiopia	39.6	45.1	67.3	127	39	n/a (2000: 0.293)	0.497	180
Equatorial Guinea	42.7	51.4	63.7	118	49	n/a (2000: 0.508)	0.674	133
Rwanda	47.0	47.8	67.8	87	30	n/a (2000: 0.340)	0.578	159
Eswatini	46.4	61.2	64.1	57	45	0.570	0.695	126
Lesotho	50.2	59.3	57.4	76	58	0.483	0.550	167
Burundi	43.3	45.2	63.7	92	31	0.294	0.439	187
Tanzania	42.6	52.0	67.0	106	30	0.381	0.555	165
Botswana	51.2	60.1	69.2	40	33	0.590	0.731	111

Sources: World Bank WDI SP.DYN.LE00.IN and SP.DYN.IMRT.IN (pulled 7 Nov 2026) [V]; UNDP HDR 2025 composite indices time series [V]. Total resident population. Note that HIV/AIDS caused the 1990s-2000s collapse in southern African life expectancy (Eswatini 47.6, Lesotho 48.8, Botswana 52.3 in 2000), an epidemiological shock unrelated to regime type.

Reading the table. Life expectancy rose almost everywhere after 1960, under every regime type. That is the global health transition (vaccines, antibiotics, oral rehydration, clean water), and it means "human development improved under ruler X" is a weak test. The more discriminating evidence is (a) the **level reached relative to income** and (b) **reversals**. Reversals in this sample come from war and state collapse (Iraq 1980-1990, Libya after 2011, Yemen after 2014) and from HIV, not from monarchy or dictatorship as such.

2.3 Governance today (WGI estimates, 2023)

Country	Government effectiveness	Control of corruption	Voice and accountability
UAE	1.14	0.99	-1.11
Qatar	1.01	0.77	-1.15
Saudi Arabia	0.61	0.47	-1.74
Botswana	0.55	0.59	0.23
Bahrain	0.39	0.24	-1.49
Rwanda	0.33	0.68	-0.70
Oman	0.25	0.22	-1.03

Country	Government effectiveness	Control of corruption	Voice and accountability
Kuwait	0.20	0.17	-0.61
Jordan	0.16	0.10	-0.79
Morocco	0.02	-0.56	-0.72
Egypt	-0.06	-0.81	-1.64
Tunisia	-0.20	-0.20	-0.46
Ethiopia	-0.67	-0.46	-1.17
Lesotho	-0.73	-0.33	0.01
Iran	-0.77	-1.17	-1.60
Eswatini	-0.78	-0.66	-1.36
Burundi	-1.23	-1.29	-1.41
Equatorial Guinea	-1.24	-1.53	-1.78
Iraq	-1.43	-1.42	-0.88
Libya	-1.54	-1.55	-1.39
Yemen	-1.90	-1.60	-1.66

Source: World Bank WGI via WDI API (GOV_WGI_GE.EST, GOV_WGI_CC.EST, GOV_WGI_VA.EST), `data/r2_wgi.csv` [V]. Perception-based composite estimates.

Reading the table. The top of the effectiveness ranking is dominated by Gulf monarchies (UAE, Qatar, Saudi Arabia), and the bottom by post-monarchical dictatorships and their collapsed successors (Yemen, Libya, Iraq) and by Equatorial Guinea. But the Gulf states sit near the bottom on voice and accountability. Rwanda and Botswana are the only non-Gulf cases with positive effectiveness and positive corruption control; they reached it by opposite political routes. Saudi Arabia's government effectiveness rose from -0.42 (1996) to 0.61 (2023), one of the largest improvements in the sample, which coincides with the post-2015 centralization (correlation, not established causation).

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3. Country entries: Middle East and North Africa

Each entry records the twelve BRIEF Part IV fields. To keep entries readable, fields are grouped: **Structure and legitimacy**; **Starting conditions, resources and state capacity**; **Development, institutions, distribution and human development**; **Succession, continuity and long-term consequences**. Regime labels match `data/regimes_mena_africa.csv`.

3.1 Saudi Arabia (monarchy throughout; absolute monarchy)

Periods. Abdulaziz (Ibn Saud), founder, to 1953; Saud, 1953-1964; the collegial era of Ibn Saud's sons, Faisal (1964-75), Khalid (1975-82), Fahd (1982-2005), Abdullah (2005-15); Salman with Mohammed bin Salman (MBS) as de facto ruler, 2015 to date. King Salman remained on the throne in late October 2026, aged 90 (Saudi Gazette, 26 Oct 2026; SPA, 6 Oct 2026, search excerpts [E]).

Structure and legitimacy. Absolute monarchy: no written constitution beyond the 1992 Basic Law, which names the Quran and Sunna as the constitution; an appointed Consultative (Shura) Council; no elected national legislature. Legitimacy has three strands: (1) dynastic and conquest legitimacy from the unification completed in 1932; (2) religious legitimacy from the 18th-century alliance between the Al Saud and the Wahhabi religious establishment (the Al al-Shaykh), institutionalized in the king's title "Custodian of the Two Holy Mosques" since 1986; and (3) performance or distributive legitimacy, the oil-financed welfare and employment bargain (interpretation: Beblawi & Luciani 1987; Hertog 2010). From 2017 the third strand has been recast as national-developmental (Vision 2030) while the second has been deliberately weakened: MBS curtailed the religious police and the Wahhabi establishment's influence (Wikipedia, "Muhammad bin Salman" [V]).

Starting conditions, resources and state capacity. In 1950 Saudi income per person (Maddison) was 3,556, slightly above Iraq (2,174) and Egypt (1,451). Life expectancy in 1960 was 45.3 years. Oil was discovered in 1938 under the 1933 concession to what became Aramco; the 1950 50/50 profit-sharing agreement and the gradual

state takeover of Aramco (completed 1980) made oil rents the fiscal base [E]. Total natural resource rents were 54% of GDP in 1975 and 70% in 1980, 26% in 2021 (WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS). State capacity was built "from the top down" as islands of efficiency (Aramco, the central bank SAMA, later the sovereign fund PIF) sitting inside a large, patronage-based bureaucracy that served as the main employer of citizens (interpretation: Hertog 2010, *Princes, Brokers and Bureaucrats*).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Real income per person in constant 2015 dollars peaked in 1974 (59,924) and has never recovered: 22,248 in 2000, 25,123 in 2024 (WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.KD). Population rose from 6.0 million (1980) to 35.3 million (2024), much of it expatriate. Human development rose strongly: HDI 0.670 (1990) to 0.900 (2023); infant mortality 86 per 1,000 (1980) to 5 (2023); adult literacy 71% (1992) to 98% (2024) (UNDP HDR25; WDI). Institutional quality as measured by WGI improved from government effectiveness -0.42 (1996) to 0.61 (2023) and control of corruption -0.38 to 0.47, while voice and accountability stayed near the bottom of the world distribution (-2.09 in 1996, -1.74 in 2023). No official Gini coefficient is published for Saudi Arabia; distribution between citizens and the roughly 40% of residents who are foreign workers, and between royals and commoners, cannot be measured with public data (stated as a gap).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Saudi succession has been the most closely studied in the region. From 1953 to 2015 the throne passed horizontally among sons of Ibn Saud, with seniority balanced by family consensus. This produced old rulers but also a "dynastic monarchy" in which senior princes held the defence, interior and national guard portfolios, so the family itself was the regime's coalition (interpretation: Herb 1999). The one forced removal, King Saud's abdication in 1964, was engineered by Faisal with the senior princes and the Grand Mufti (Wikipedia, "Faisal of Saudi Arabia" [V]): the family removed an ineffective ruler without a regime crisis, which is the strongest historical argument that collegial dynastic institutions can correct leader failure. The Allegiance Council (2006) was meant to formalize this. Since 2015 the system has moved in the opposite direction: King Salman made his son crown prince in June 2017, displacing Muhammad bin Nayef, and MBS became prime minister in 2022 (Wikipedia [V]). Collegial constraint has been replaced by concentration of security, economic and religious authority in one man. **Long-term consequence (hypothesis):** the new model may be faster in decision-making and has delivered measurable administrative improvements, but it has removed the family-level veto that corrected the Saud episode, raising the cost of any future leader error. The 2026 Iran war, which saw strikes on Aramco's headquarters and a pipeline and postponement of the flagship investment conference (NYT, 2 Nov 2026, excerpt [E]), is the first major external test of the centralized model.

3.2 Iran under the Pahlavi dynasty (monarchy; semi-constitutional then absolute)

Periods. 1941-1953, a contested semi-constitutional monarchy under the young Mohammad Reza Shah, with a powerful Majlis and, in 1951-53, Prime Minister Mohammad Mossadegh, who nationalized the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company; 1953-1979, royal absolutism after the August 1953 coup, organized with US and British intelligence support, restored the Shah's dominance [E: Gasiorowski & Byrne 2004].

Structure and legitimacy. After 1953 the 1906 constitution was formally in force but hollowed out: elections were managed, parties were creatures of the court, and in 1975 the Shah merged them into a single party, Rastakhiz. Legitimacy rested on dynastic nationalism (the 1971 Persepolis celebrations of 2,500 years of monarchy), modernization ("the White Revolution of the Shah and the People", launched 26 January 1963, with land reform as its centrepiece; Wikipedia, "White Revolution" [V]) and alliance with the United States. It conspicuously lacked the religious legitimacy that the Saudi and Moroccan monarchies cultivated, and the Shah actively antagonized the Shia clergy.

Starting conditions, resources and state capacity. Income per person in 1950 (Maddison) was 2,742, life expectancy in 1960 43.3 years. Iran had a large population (21.5 million in 1960, WDI), an old bureaucratic tradition, and oil, but also a peasantry that was mostly landless before 1963. Natural resource rents reached 38% of GDP in 1975 (WDI). State capacity was substantial in the army, the SAVAK security service, the Plan and Budget Organization and the National Iranian Oil Company.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Growth was fast: Maddison GDP per person rose from 2,742 (1950) to 9,377 (1975). In World Bank constant 2015 dollars, income per person peaked in **1976 at 7,422**, a level Iran had **still not regained in 2025 (5,617)**. The post-1973 oil boom overheated the economy: inflation, urban migration, housing shortages, and conspicuous elite enrichment widened inequality (interpretation: Abrahamian 1982; Katouzian 1981). Adult literacy was only 37% in 1976 (WDI). Institutions

were personalized: ministers reported to the Shah, the Plan Organization's technocrats were overruled in 1974 when the Shah doubled the Fifth Plan's spending (interpretation: Bharier, Amuzegar [E]).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Succession was formally clear (Crown Prince Reza, a teenager in 1978), but the Shah's secret cancer and his reluctance to share power left no institution capable of governing without him. When mass protests built through 1978, the army, which had been kept fragmented under personal command, could neither repress decisively nor take over. The Shah left on 16 January 1979; the monarchy fell in February. **Long-term consequences:** the Pahlavi fall is the region's central example of how rapid rent-financed modernization combined with personalist absolutism and narrow political inclusion can produce a sudden collapse of an apparently strong state (interpretation: Kurzman 2004, *The Unthinkable Revolution*). It also showed that a large, loyal-seeming army is not an asset when its loyalty is to a person rather than to an institution.

3.3 Iran after 1979: the Islamic Republic (dictatorship; hybrid clerical authoritarianism)

Periods. Khomeini, 1979-1989; Ali Khamenei, 1989-2026; Mojtaba Khamenei, from March 2026.

Structure and legitimacy. A hybrid: an elected president and parliament, constrained by the unelected Supreme Leader (velayat-e faqih), the Guardian Council (which vets candidates), the judiciary and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC). Legitimacy is revolutionary and religious, supplemented by managed elections. It is not a monarchy: the Leader is chosen by the elected Assembly of Experts, and until 2026 the regime's founding ideology rejected hereditary rule.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. The Islamic Republic inherited the Pahlavi state's bureaucracy and oil sector, and a population of about 39 million (1980) [E]. The Iran-Iraq war (1980-88) and US sanctions (from 1979 and progressively tighter after 1995, 2012 and 2018) shaped its economy. Natural resource rents were 34% of GDP in 1980 and 30% in 2021 (WDI).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Income per person collapsed in the 1980s: constant-2015-dollar GDP per person was 5,017 in 1979 and 2,833 in 1988 (WDI). It recovered only partially: 5,834 in 2024. Yet human development rose: life expectancy 58.4 (1980) to 77.7 (2023); infant mortality 88 to 11 per 1,000; adult literacy 37% (1976) to 89% (2023); HDI 0.626 (1990) to 0.799 (2023) (WDI; UNDP). The rural health-house network and literacy campaigns are widely credited (interpretation: Salehi-Isfahani 2009 [E]). The Gini was 35.9 in 2023 (WDI). WGI control of corruption fell from -0.44 (1996) to -1.17 (2023). The economy's large para-statal foundations (bonyads) and IRGC-owned conglomerates are a classic case of elite capture by security institutions [E].

Succession, continuity, consequences. The 1989 succession, from Khomeini to Khamenei, a mid-ranking cleric, was managed by the regime's institutions and showed that the Islamic Republic could institutionalize succession. The 2026 succession was different. On 28 February 2026 the United States and Israel began strikes on Iran; Ali Khamenei and much of the senior command were killed (the House of Commons Library briefing gives "29 February 2026", which is not a valid date; other reports give 28 February), and his son Mojtaba was chosen as successor in March (House of Commons Library, CBP-11075, 27 Aug 2026 [V]). As of November 2026 he had not appeared in public, analysts described a shift to a collective, IRGC-heavy leadership, the IMF projected a 5.4% contraction for 2026, inflation reached a record 84% year-on-year in August, and the regime had killed several thousand protesters in December 2025-January 2026, according to rights groups cited by the same briefing [V]. **Long-term consequence (hypothesis):** a revolutionary regime founded against dynastic rule has, under existential pressure, defaulted to hereditary succession. This is strong evidence for a broader proposition in this monograph: hereditary transfer is often chosen not because it optimizes long-run planning, but because it is the focal solution that minimizes elite conflict when institutions are under stress.

3.4 Iraq (Hashemite monarchy to 1958, military regimes, Ba'ath, Saddam Hussein)

Periods. Hashemite monarchy (King Faisal II, regent Abd al-Ilah, perennial prime minister Nuri al-Said), 1945-1958; Qasim (1958-63) and the Arif brothers (1963-68), military regimes; Ba'ath under al-Bakr, 1968-1979; Saddam Hussein, 1979-2003; post-invasion hybrid order from 2003.

Structure and legitimacy. The monarchy was a British-designed semi-constitutional system: an elected but managed parliament dominated by tribal sheikhs and urban notables, with real power in a small circle around the

palace and Nuri al-Said. Its legitimacy was weak from the start: the Hashemites were imported from the Hejaz by Britain in 1921, and the 1948 Portsmouth Treaty and the 1955 Baghdad Pact tied it to Britain against rising pan-Arab nationalism. The Ba'ath state that followed was a one-party regime that Saddam personalized after 1979, with legitimacy claimed through Arab nationalism, anti-imperialism and, increasingly, fear.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Income per person (Maddison) was 2,174 in 1950. Oil revenue rose sharply after the 1952 50/50 agreement with the Iraq Petroleum Company. The monarchy created a Development Board in 1950 that devoted a large share (often cited as 70%) of oil revenue to long-term infrastructure, especially flood control and irrigation (interpretation: Batatu 1978; Penrose & Penrose 1978 [E]). This is an early, under-studied example of a resource-rich monarchy trying a "sovereign development fund" approach. But land concentration, encouraged by land-settlement laws that turned tribal sheikhs into landlords, left the peasantry impoverished and drove migration to Baghdad's slums.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. The monarchy's Development Board projects were long-gestation and did not reach urban workers or the army's junior officers before the regime fell. Under the Ba'ath, after oil nationalization in 1972 and the 1973 price rise, Iraq invested heavily in health, education and infrastructure. Maddison GDP per person reached 10,165 in 1980. Then came the wars: the Iran-Iraq war (1980-88), the invasion of Kuwait (1990), the Gulf War and UN sanctions (1990-2003). Maddison GDP per person fell to 3,918 (1990) and 1,997 (1995). Life expectancy fell from 60.9 (1980) to 57.6 (1990), and infant mortality stagnated at 56-57 per 1,000 across the 1980s while it was halving in neighbouring states (WDI). This is the clearest case in the sample of human-development reversal caused by a personalist ruler's foreign-policy decisions (interpretation: Sassoon 2012).

Succession, continuity, consequences. The monarchy had a clear dynastic succession but no defence against an army officered by nationalist middle-class men: on 14 July 1958 the Free Officers under Brigadier Abd al-Karim Qasim stormed the palace; King Faisal II, Prince Abd al-Ilah and Nuri al-Said were killed (Wikipedia, "14 July Revolution" [V]). Republican Iraq then had four forcible changes of ruler in 21 years (1963, 1963, 1968, 1979). Saddam ended coup risk by fusing party, clan (Tikriti kin) and multiple overlapping security services, and grooming his sons Uday and Qusay; the regime ended only through foreign invasion in 2003. **Long-term consequences:** the Iraqi sequence (fragile monarchy, praetorian republic, personalist totalitarianism, foreign invasion, sectarian hybrid with WGI government effectiveness of -1.43 in 2023) is the strongest regional counterexample to the claim that removing a monarchy liberates development. It is also a counterexample to the claim that an oil-funded development board can substitute for political inclusion.

3.5 Libya (Idris monarchy and Gaddafi)

Periods. Kingdom of Libya under Idris al-Senussi, 24 December 1951 to 1 September 1969; Gaddafi, 1969-2011; post-2011 fragmentation.

Structure and legitimacy. The monarchy was a federal (to 1963) semi-constitutional system in which Idris, head of the Senussi religious order, ruled through Cyrenaican tribal notables, with a weak parliament. His legitimacy was religious-tribal and rooted in anti-Italian resistance, but it was regional (strong in Cyrenaica, weaker in Tripolitania and Fezzan) and the king had no son. Gaddafi's legitimacy was revolutionary, pan-Arab and later the "Third Universal Theory" of the Green Book; formally the state was a "Jamahiriya" (state of the masses) with no head of state, while in practice it was a personalist dictatorship resting on revolutionary committees, kin-based security brigades and tribal alliances.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. In 1950 Libya was among the poorest territories on earth: Maddison GDP per person 620, level with Ethiopia (622), Eswatini (604) and Burundi (595) and above only Botswana (489) in this sample. Its population was about 1.5 million in 1960 (WDI). Oil was discovered in 1959 and exported from 1961. By 1970 Maddison GDP per person was 6,591, a tenfold rise in two decades. State capacity was close to zero at independence: the UN estimated only a handful of university graduates in the country [E].

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. The monarchy spent its sudden oil wealth with a mix of genuine development (roads, schools) and conspicuous court corruption (interpretation: Vandewalle 2012). Under Gaddafi, oil rents (66% of GDP in 2008, WDI) financed broad subsidies, housing and universal services: life expectancy rose from 56.4 (1970) to 72.2 (2010); infant mortality fell from 99 to 13 per 1,000; HDI reached 0.755 in 2010, the highest in Africa at the time. But constant-2015-dollar GDP per person peaked in 1979

(20,078) and was 12,914 in 2010: forty years of oil wealth did not produce income growth. Gaddafi deliberately kept formal institutions weak (no professional army, ministries repeatedly abolished, private retail trade banned in the late 1970s), so that the Jamahiriya is perhaps the purest case of "anti-institutional" rule (interpretation: Vandewalle 2012; Anderson 1986).

Succession, continuity, consequences. The monarchy's succession was uncertain (the crown prince was a nephew with little standing). A group of junior officers led by the 27-year-old Gaddafi seized power on 1 September 1969 while Idris was abroad, without significant resistance (Wikipedia, "Kingdom of Libya" [V]). Gaddafi groomed his sons, notably Saif al-Islam, as successors, while preventing any institution from becoming an alternative centre. When the 2011 uprising began, the regime split along regional and tribal lines, NATO air power intervened, and Gaddafi was killed in October 2011. **Long-term consequences:** with no institutions to inherit, post-2011 Libya fragmented into rival governments; HDI fell to 0.688 (2020) and constant-dollar income per person was 7,696 in 2024 (UNDP; WDI). Libya illustrates the core risk in BRIEF Part IX: when national prosperity depends on one individual who deliberately destroys alternative institutions, his removal leaves no state.

3.6 Egypt (Farouk; Nasser; Sadat; Mubarak; SCAF and Morsi; Sisi)

Periods. King Farouk, 1936-1952 (monarchy abolished June 1953); Nasser, 1954-1970 (after the 1952-54 Revolutionary Command Council interlude under Naguib); Sadat, 1970-1981; Mubarak, 1981-2011; the Supreme Council of the Armed Forces (SCAF) and the elected presidency of Mohamed Morsi, 2011-2013; Abdel Fattah el-Sisi from July 2013.

Structure and legitimacy. Farouk's Egypt was a semi-constitutional monarchy: a real parliament with a popular nationalist party (the Wafd), repeatedly overridden by the palace and by the British, who kept troops on the Suez Canal. The monarchy's legitimacy was eroded by the 1942 Abdeen Palace incident (British tanks forcing a government on the king), defeat in the 1948 Palestine war, and the king's personal scandals. Every regime since 1952 has been anchored in the armed forces. Nasser's was a one-party, populist, military-backed authoritarianism with a large personalist component and charismatic pan-Arab legitimacy. Sadat and Mubarak moved toward electoral authoritarianism with a dominant party (the NDP from 1978) and a permanent state of emergency, in force from 1967 (except 1980-81) until 2012. Sisi's regime is military-dominated electoral authoritarianism with strong personalist features (interpretation: Sayigh 2019; Brownlee 2007).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Egypt in 1950 had an ancient centralized bureaucracy, a large population (26.9 million in 1960, WDI) and low income per person (Maddison 1,451 in 1950). Land was highly concentrated. Resources were modest: cotton, the Suez Canal (nationalized 1956), later oil and gas (rents 33% of GDP in 1980, 5% in 2021, WDI), tourism, remittances and, after 1979, US aid.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Nasser's land reform, nationalizations, import-substituting industrialization and the guarantee of public employment for graduates broadened access to education and health and shrank the landed elite, at the cost of a bloated public sector and, after 1967, fiscal exhaustion (interpretation: Waterbury 1983). Sadat's infitah (opening, 1974) and Mubarak's partial liberalizations produced growth spurts, crony capitalism and a business elite tied to the presidency. Long-run results: constant-2015-dollar GDP per person rose from 755 (1960) to 4,138 (2024), more than a fivefold rise; Maddison from 1,451 (1950) to 13,205 (2022), x9.1. Infant mortality fell from 173 per 1,000 (1960) to 21 (2023), adult literacy from 38% (1976) to 79% (2022), HDI from 0.572 (1990) to 0.754 (2023). The official Gini is low (28.5, 2021), but survey-based Gini figures in the region are widely thought to understate top incomes (interpretation: Alvaredo & Piketty 2014 [E]). WGI government effectiveness fell from 0.06 (1996) to -0.06 (2023) and corruption control from -0.30 to -0.81.

Succession, continuity, consequences. Farouk was removed by the Free Officers on 23 July 1952 and the monarchy was abolished the following June. After 1952 succession worked through the military-backed presidency: vice-presidents succeeded on Nasser's death (1970) and Sadat's assassination (1981). Mubarak never appointed a vice-president until the final days of his rule, and the grooming of his son Gamal, whose business circle threatened the military's economic interests, is one of the reasons the army did not defend him in 2011 (interpretation: Brownlee 2012; Stacher 2012). The army removed him on 11 February 2011. The only freely elected president, Morsi, issued a November 2012 constitutional declaration placing his decisions beyond judicial review, was removed by the army on 3 July 2013 after mass protests, and died in custody in June 2019 (Wikipedia, "Mohamed Morsi" [V]). The August 2013 dispersal of his supporters' sit-ins killed at least 904 people according to Human

Rights Watch (Wikipedia, "2013 Egyptian coup d'état" [V]). **Long-term consequence:** Egypt shows a durable military-institutional dictatorship whose continuity rests on the officer corps rather than on any individual. The ruler's identity has changed five times since 1952, but the institution behind him has not. Development has been steady but slow and debt-financed, not transformational.

3.7 Jordan (monarchy; semi-constitutional)

Periods. Abdullah I, 1946-1951 (assassinated); Talal, 1951-1952 (removed by parliament on grounds of mental illness); Hussein, 1953-1999; Abdullah II, 1999 to date.

Structure and legitimacy. Semi-constitutional monarchy under the 1952 constitution: an elected lower house, an appointed senate, and a king who appoints and dismisses governments and controls the army and intelligence. Martial law ran from 1957 to 1989; the 1989 liberalization reopened parliamentary politics with managed electoral rules. Legitimacy is Hashemite descent from the Prophet, the Hashemites' role in the Arab Revolt, East Bank tribal loyalty, and Western and Gulf backing.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A small, poor territory with almost no natural resources (rents near 0% of GDP throughout, WDI), dependent on British subsidy and then on US, Gulf and multilateral aid and on remittances. Successive refugee inflows (1948, 1967, 1990-91, 2003, after 2011) transformed its demography. Maddison GDP per person was 2,651 in 1950.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Jordan built one of the better-educated populations in the Arab world and a relatively competent bureaucracy for its income level: life expectancy 77.8 years and infant mortality 12 per 1,000 in 2023 (WDI); WGI government effectiveness 0.16 (2023), above every non-Gulf Arab state in the sample. But growth stalled: constant-2015-dollar GDP per person peaked in 1982 (5,394) and was 4,441 in 2024; Maddison GDP per person fell from 11,615 (2011) to 9,151 (2022), the sharpest recent fall among the surviving monarchies. Jordan is a rentier state whose rent is geopolitical (aid) rather than geological (interpretation: Brand 1994; Yom 2016).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Jordan has had the most eventful succession history of any surviving monarchy: an assassination (1951), a parliamentary removal of an incapacitated king (1952), a teenage king who survived the 1957 attempted coup, the 1970 civil war with Palestinian militias ("Black September") and multiple assassination plots, and a last-minute change of heir from Hussein's brother Hassan to his son Abdullah weeks before Hussein's death in 1999. In 2021 a "sedition" affair involving the former crown prince Hamzah was suppressed. The monarchy survived each test. **Long-term consequence (interpretation: Yom & Gause 2012):** survival without oil rests on three supports, a cross-cutting coalition (East Bank tribes and the army, Palestinian-origin business, Islamists at times), sustained external patrons, and the monarch's ability to shift blame to governments he can dismiss. Development outcomes are middling and depend on aid flows.

3.8 Morocco (monarchy; semi-constitutional with absolutist practice)

Periods. Mohammed V, 1956-1961; Hassan II, 1961-1999; Mohammed VI, 1999 to date.

Structure and legitimacy. Semi-constitutional monarchy (constitutions of 1962, 1970, 1972, 1992, 1996, 2011). The king is Commander of the Faithful (Amir al-Mu'minin), descends from the Prophet (sharifian legitimacy), and led the independence struggle (Mohammed V's exile in 1953-55 made the crown the symbol of nationalism). The palace's network of patronage and administration, the makhzen, sits beside elected governments. Under the 2011 constitution the prime minister must come from the largest party, but the king retains control of defence, religion, security and strategic appointments.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Maddison GDP per person 2,319 in 1950, low literacy (30% in 1982, WDI) and a mainly rural population. Phosphates (the world's largest reserves) are the main resource but rents have stayed small (0-8% of GDP, WDI).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Hassan II's reign combined state-led agriculture (dams), Moroccanization of foreign firms, and the repression known as the "Years of Lead" after two military coup attempts (Skhirat 1971 and the 1972 attack on the royal aircraft); thousands were detained or disappeared. The Equity and Reconciliation Commission set up by Mohammed VI in 2004 investigated these abuses (Wikipedia, "Years of Lead (Morocco)" [V]). Since 1999 Morocco has invested in infrastructure (Tanger

Med port, high-speed rail, renewables) and an automotive export cluster. Maddison GDP per person rose from 2,118 (1960) to 8,400 (2022); HDI from 0.451 (1990), lowest of any Arab monarchy, to 0.710 (2023); infant mortality from 151 (1960) to 15 per 1,000 (2023). Inequality is relatively high (Gini 39.5 in 2013, WDI), and WGI corruption control is negative (-0.56, 2023).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Primogeniture (fixed in the constitution) produced two smooth successions (1961, 1999). Morocco is the strongest case of a monarchy that survived coup attempts by its own army: Hassan II responded by dismantling the army's autonomy and concentrating security under the palace (interpretation: Waterbury 1970; Daadaoui 2011). **Long-term consequence:** a monarchy without hydrocarbon rents has delivered slow, steady, infrastructure-heavy development with persistent inequality and limited accountability. The 2011 reform shows the crown's capacity for pre-emptive concession, a survival technique the fallen monarchies (Egypt, Iraq, Libya, Iran) did not use.

3.9 Oman (monarchy; absolute)

Periods. Said bin Taimur, 1932-1970; Qaboos bin Said, 1970-2020; Haitham bin Tariq, from January 2020.

Structure and legitimacy. Absolute monarchy. The sultan was simultaneously prime minister, defence, foreign and finance minister for most of Qaboos's reign. The 1996 Basic Law created an appointed State Council and an elected but advisory Majlis al-Shura. Legitimacy: the Al Said dynasty (since the 18th century), Ibadi religious tradition, and, after 1970, Qaboos's personal role as founder of the modern state ("the Renaissance").

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Before 1970 Oman was one of the least developed states in the world. Said bin Taimur restricted travel, radios and education; in 1970 there were reportedly three primary schools in the country [E]. Life expectancy in 1960 was 35.4 years and infant mortality 239 per 1,000, the worst in the sample (WDI). Oil exports began in 1967. The Dhofar rebellion (1965-1975), backed by South Yemen, threatened the regime.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. After the British-assisted palace coup of 23 July 1970, in which Qaboos overthrew his father (Wikipedia, "1970 Omani coup d'état" [V]), Oman built a state almost from scratch on oil revenue: rents were 46-58% of GDP between 1975 and 2000 (WDI). Maddison GDP per person rose from 993 (1950) to 47,989 (2022), the largest multiple in the sample (x48). Life expectancy reached 80.0 years and infant mortality 8 per 1,000 in 2023, an improvement unmatched in the region (WDI). HDI was 0.858 in 2023 (rank 50). In constant 2015 dollars, however, GDP per person peaked in 2009 (22,819) and was 17,347 in 2024. Oil reserves are smaller than in its neighbours, which made fiscal consolidation after the 2014 oil-price fall more painful than in Qatar or Abu Dhabi (interpretation: IMF Article IV consultations [E]).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Oman is the clearest demonstration in the database that **a change of ruler inside the same dynasty can be a regime transformation in everything but name**. Said bin Taimur and Qaboos had the same constitutional powers and opposite policies. Qaboos had no children and named no heir in public; the Basic Law required the ruling family council to agree a successor within three days or open a sealed letter naming his choice. In January 2020 the council opened the letter and Haitham succeeded within hours (Wikipedia, "Qaboos bin Said" [V]). The 2021 amended Basic Law created a formal crown prince position. **Long-term consequence:** Oman's success was driven by a single ruler with absolute discretion who happened to be developmental. The smooth 2020 succession is evidence that a dynasty can institutionalize transfer; the 1970 coup is evidence that the dynasty's previous ruler had to be removed by force to unlock development.

3.10 Qatar (monarchy; absolute)

Periods. Al Thani rule under British protection (Ali bin Abdullah, 1949-1960; Ahmad bin Ali, 1960-1972); Khalifa bin Hamad, 1972-1995; Hamad bin Khalifa, 1995-2013; Tamim bin Hamad, from June 2013.

Structure and legitimacy. Absolute monarchy; the 2003 constitution (approved by referendum) provides for a partly elected Shura Council, but elections were first held only in 2021, and in 2024 a constitutional referendum returned the council to fully appointed status [E]. Legitimacy is dynastic and distributive, with a large ruling family whose members hold key posts.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A pearling economy devastated by the 1930s collapse of the pearl market; oil exports from 1949; the giant North Field gas reserve discovered in 1971 and developed for LNG

from the late 1990s. Population 36,000 in 1960 and 2.86 million in 2024 (WDI), of whom citizens are a small minority [E]. Maddison values before oil are unreliable (see section 1.4).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Under Khalifa, Qatar was a conservative oil sheikhdom; constant-2015-dollar GDP per person fell from 79,709 (1970) to 42,210 (1990) as population rose and oil prices fell. Under Hamad, the decision to invest in LNG, the creation of the Qatar Investment Authority (2005), Al Jazeera (1996) and Education City transformed the economy and the state's international profile; GDP per person peaked in 2011 (83,533) (WDI). HDI was 0.886 in 2023, WGI government effectiveness 1.01 and corruption control 0.77 (2023). Citizen welfare is extremely high, while the migrant workforce, the large majority of residents, has faced documented labour abuses (interpretation: Amnesty International and ILO reporting [E]).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Qatar had two forcible depositions within the dynasty (1972, 1995: the latter a bloodless palace coup by the crown prince on 27 June 1995 while his father was abroad; Wikipedia [V]) and one voluntary abdication (2013), rare in the region. As with Oman, the decisive development turn followed a son's removal of his father. **Long-term consequence:** Qatar shows the upside of absolute discretion, very fast strategic bets on LNG and global positioning, and its fragility: the bets depended on a few individuals, and the 2017-2021 blockade by Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain and Egypt and the 2026 Hormuz closure show the exposure of a small state whose entire model rests on export routes it does not control.

3.11 Kuwait (monarchy; semi-constitutional, now suspended)

Periods. Abdullah al-Salim (independence 1961, constitution 1962) and Sabah al-Salim, 1961-1977; Jaber al-Ahmad, 1977-2006; Sabah al-Ahmad (2006-20), Nawaf (2020-23), Meshal (since December 2023).

Structure and legitimacy. Kuwait has had the Gulf's strongest elected parliament: the National Assembly can question and remove ministers and must approve a new crown prince. It was suspended twice (1976-81, 1986-91) and dissolved 13 times between 2006 and 2024; on 10 May 2024 the emir suspended it for up to four years pending constitutional review (Wikipedia, "National Assembly (Kuwait)" [V]). Since then Kuwait has functioned as an absolute monarchy. Legitimacy combines dynastic rule by the Al Sabah, a historic pact with merchant families, and distributive citizenship.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Oil exports from 1946 made Kuwait the first Gulf mass-welfare state. The Kuwait Investment Board, founded in London in 1953 and the predecessor of the Kuwait Investment Authority, is the world's oldest sovereign wealth fund [E], and the 1976 Reserve Fund for Future Generations is an early intergenerational savings rule [E].

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Kuwait's resident income per person in constant 2015 dollars was 68,673 in 1971 and 24,140 in 2024 (WDI), the steepest long-run fall in the sample, driven by population growth (1.5 million in 1980, 4.9 million in 2024) and by an economy that has barely diversified (resource rents 37-59% of GDP between 2008 and 2015). HDI rose from 0.698 (1990) to 0.852 (2023); life expectancy was 83.2 years in 2023 (WDI). Control of corruption deteriorated from 0.67 (1996) to 0.17 (2023). Kuwait is the main regional evidence for the "parliamentary gridlock" argument: an empowered but non-governing assembly that can block reform but not form a government has produced fiscal paralysis (interpretation: Herb 2014, *The Wages of Oil*).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Succession alternated for decades between two branches of the Al Sabah. In January 2006 the new emir, Saad, too ill to take the oath, was removed after nine days by an Assembly vote engineered by the family, the only parliamentary deposition of a Gulf ruler. Iraq's invasion (August 1990 to February 1991) ended the state temporarily; it was restored by a US-led coalition, which shows how far Gulf survival depends on external security guarantees. **Long-term consequence:** Kuwait's experiment in semi-constitutional monarchy did not produce better economic outcomes than its absolute neighbours; its 2024 suspension is a data point for the BRIEF's question of whether concentrated authority is "necessary" for reform. It is a weak data point, because Kuwait's problem was a hybrid design that gave parliament veto power without governing responsibility, not accountability as such (interpretation: Herb 2014).

3.12 United Arab Emirates (monarchy; federal absolute monarchy)

Periods. Zayed bin Sultan, president 1971-2004; Khalifa bin Zayed, 2004-2022 (with Mohamed bin Zayed, MBZ, as de facto ruler after Khalifa's 2014 stroke); MBZ, from May 2022.

Structure and legitimacy. A federation of seven hereditary emirates. The Federal Supreme Council of the seven rulers elects the president (by convention the ruler of Abu Dhabi) and the vice-president (by convention the ruler of Dubai). The Federal National Council is advisory and half-elected by a limited electoral college. Each emirate keeps its own natural resources and much of its own administration. Legitimacy is dynastic, federal-founding (Zayed's personal role), and distributive. The UAE is an absolute monarchy at the federal level made of absolute monarchies at the emirate level, an unusual "monarchy of monarchies" (interpretation: Davidson 2009; Heard-Bey 1982).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Before oil, the Trucial States were among the poorest places in the Gulf; population 131,000 in 1960 (WDI). Abu Dhabi holds the vast majority of oil reserves. Dubai, with little oil, built a trade, logistics, real-estate and finance economy on its historic entrepôt role. Abu Dhabi's sovereign fund ADIA (1976) and later Mubadala and ADQ are among the largest in the world (see R1 for assets).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. HDI 0.713 (1990) to 0.940 (2023), rank 15 in the world, the highest in the region (UNDP). Life expectancy 82.9 years and infant mortality 4 per 1,000 (2023). WGI government effectiveness 1.14 and corruption control 0.99 (2023), the best in the sample. Constant-2015-dollar GDP per resident fell from 117,073 (1980) to 41,605 (2024), because the resident population grew from about 1.0 million to 11.0 million, overwhelmingly through migrant labour (WDI). The latest official Gini (26.4, 2018) is a survey estimate that does not capture the citizen-migrant divide, which is the defining distributional fact of the UAE. Resource rents fell from 42% of GDP (1980) to 18% (2021), the clearest diversification record among the large Gulf producers.

Succession, continuity, consequences. Two smooth presidential successions (2004, 2022), both following the death of the president, and successions inside the individual emirates that have mostly been peaceful (with the exception of the 1987 attempted coup in Sharjah, resolved by the Supreme Council [E]). The 2009 Dubai debt crisis was resolved by an Abu Dhabi bailout, which shifted power toward Abu Dhabi. In 2026 the UAE was the most-attacked Gulf state during the Iran war, cut trade and financial ties with Iran in August, and is reported to have left OPEC (CRS R48971 excerpt [E]; House of Commons Library [V]; Chatham House excerpt [E]). **Long-term consequence (hypothesis):** the UAE combines dynastic absolutism with federal competition among emirates, which may explain why it diversified more than unitary Gulf monarchies: Dubai's lack of oil forced a different strategy that the federation could tolerate. This "internal competition" mechanism deserves a test in the Part V analysis.

3.13 Bahrain (monarchy; absolute, semi-constitutional in form)

Periods. Isa bin Salman, 1961 (independence 1971) to 1999; Hamad bin Isa, from 1999 (king since 2002).

Structure and legitimacy. A Sunni dynasty, the Al Khalifa, ruling a Shia-majority population. The 1973 constitution created an elected assembly that the emir dissolved in 1975 when it resisted a state-security law. Hamad's 2001 National Action Charter and 2002 constitution created a kingdom with an elected lower house balanced by an appointed upper house of equal size. Legitimacy is dynastic, sectarian-coalitional and externally guaranteed (the US Fifth Fleet is based in Bahrain; Saudi Arabia is the key patron).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. The first Gulf oil discovery (1932), but small reserves; Bahrain diversified early into refining, aluminium (Alba, 1971), offshore banking (from 1975) and services. Resource rents were 71% of GDP in 1980 and 17% in 2021 (WDI).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. HDI 0.734 (1990) to 0.899 (2023); life expectancy 81.3 (2023). Constant-2015-dollar GDP per person was 22,552 in 1980 and 25,886 in 2024, roughly flat over 44 years (WDI). WGI government effectiveness 0.39 and voice and accountability -1.49 (2023). Distribution is structured by sect: Shia citizens are under-represented in the security forces and senior state posts (interpretation: Khalaf 2000; Gengler 2015 [E]).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Succession has been by primogeniture and smooth (1961, 1999). The monarchy faced two major uprisings, 1994-99 and February-March 2011. In 2011 it suppressed the Pearl Roundabout movement with the help of the GCC's Peninsula Shield Force, led by Saudi troops (Wikipedia, "Bahraini uprising of 2011" [V]). **Long-term consequence:** Bahrain is the clearest case in which an external monarchical alliance, the GCC, acted as an insurance mechanism for a member dynasty. Its survival is evidence

for Yom & Gause's (2012) "foreign patrons" argument and against attributing monarchical durability purely to domestic legitimacy.

3.14 Yemen (Mutawakkilite imamate to 1962; republics after)

Periods. Imam Yahya (to 1948, assassinated), Imam Ahmad (1948-1962), Imam Badr (one week in September 1962); Yemen Arab Republic military regimes, 1962-1978; Ali Abdullah Saleh, 1978-2012 (president of unified Yemen from 1990); transition, Houthi takeover (2014-15) and war.

Structure and legitimacy. The imamate was a theocratic absolute monarchy: the imam was the religious leader of the Zaydi Shia community and secular ruler, chosen within a qualified descent group (sayyids), in practice father to son. The state was deliberately isolated; foreign contact and modern education were minimal. Republican regimes were military dictatorships; Saleh's rule was personalist, resting on tribal confederations (Hashid), kin in the security forces and a dominant party (GPC), with competitive but unfair elections after 1990.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Life expectancy in 1960 was 33.5 years and infant mortality 276 per 1,000, the worst figures in the sample (WDI). Maddison GDP per person was 1,452 in 1950. There was no modern bureaucracy. Oil was found only in the 1980s; rents were 29-41% of GDP between 1990 and 2008 (WDI).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Under the republics, and helped by remittances from Yemeni workers in Saudi Arabia, Maddison GDP per person rose from 1,537 (1960) to 4,812 (2010), and life expectancy reached 67.2 (2010). The 1990 expulsion of Yemeni workers from Saudi Arabia, the 1994 civil war, and after 2014 the Houthi-Saudi war reversed this: Maddison GDP per person was 1,959 in 2022, lower than in 1970; constant-2015-dollar GDP per person fell by more than half between 2010 and 2018 (WDI); HDI fell from 0.502 (2010) to 0.470 (2023). WGI government effectiveness was -1.90 in 2023, the worst in the sample.

Succession, continuity, consequences. Imam Ahmad died on 19 September 1962; one week later, on 26 September, republican officers inspired by Nasser shelled the palace and proclaimed the Yemen Arab Republic. The imam escaped and an eight-year civil war followed, with Egypt sending up to 70,000 troops for the republicans and Saudi Arabia backing the royalists (Wikipedia, "Mutawakkilite Kingdom of Yemen", "North Yemen Civil War" [V]; troop figure [E]). The imamate's end illustrates the vulnerability of a monarchy at the moment of succession, when a new and untested ruler faces officers who have absorbed a rival ideology. Saleh's attempt to pass power to his son Ahmed contributed to elite splits in 2011; he handed power to his vice-president under a GCC initiative in February 2012, allied with the Houthis against his successor, and was killed by them in 2017 [E]. In 2026 the Houthis resumed attacks on Saudi Arabia and declared the Red Sea closed to Saudi shipping, while the Southern Transitional Council collapsed in the south (House of Commons Library [V]). **Long-term consequence:** Yemen is the case where neither absolute monarchy (the imamate) nor the dictatorships that replaced it built a state. It is the clearest evidence in the region that regime type matters less than whether any regime builds institutions that survive the ruler.

3.15 Tunisia (beylik to 1957; Bourguiba; Ben Ali; democratic interlude; Saied)

Periods. Husainid beylik under the French protectorate and briefly after independence (Lamine Bey), to 25 July 1957; Habib Bourguiba, 1957-1987; Zine El Abidine Ben Ali, 1987-2011; democratic transition, 2011-2021; Kais Saied's presidential rule after his 25 July 2021 suspension of parliament.

Structure and legitimacy. The beys were constitutional figureheads under French rule; independence legitimacy belonged to Bourguiba's Neo-Destour party, and the Constituent Assembly abolished the monarchy by vote. Bourguiba built a one-party state with a strong personal cult (president for life from 1975; Wikipedia, "Habib Bourguiba" [V]) and a modernizing, secular legitimacy. Ben Ali ran an electoral-authoritarian police state.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Maddison GDP per person 1,777 in 1950; modest phosphate and oil resources (rents 7-16% of GDP, 1975-1990, WDI); a relatively capable inherited administration.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Bourguiba's Code of Personal Status (1956), which abolished polygamy and gave women divorce rights, mass schooling and family planning, gave Tunisia some of the best social indicators in Africa for its income. Life expectancy rose from 44.0 (1960) to 69.1 (1990); adult literacy from 48% (1984) to 86% (2023). Constant-2015-dollar GDP per person rose from 1,187

(1970) to 3,907 (2010), then stagnated (4,006 in 2024) (WDI). Under Ben Ali, regulatory privileges captured by the president's extended family were large: a World Bank study found that firms connected to the Ben Ali clan captured about 21% of all private-sector profits in 2010 though they produced a small share of output [E: Rijkers, Freund & Nucifora 2017, *Journal of Development Economics*].

Succession, continuity, consequences. Bourguiba was removed in a "medical coup" by his prime minister on 7 November 1987, when doctors certified him unfit; Ben Ali fled to Saudi Arabia on 14 January 2011 after a month of protests (Wikipedia [V]). The 2011-2021 democracy produced the region's best voice and accountability score (WGI 0.22 in 2015) but weak growth, and was reversed by Saied's 2021 self-coup (WGI voice -0.46 in 2023). **Long-term consequence:** Tunisia shows that a single-party regime with strong early social investment can produce human development without income convergence, and that the democratic successor inherited the stagnation rather than causing it. It is also a reminder that the end of the monarchy in 1957 was the least violent of all abolitions in the database.

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4. Country entries: Africa

4.1 Ethiopia (Haile Selassie; Derg; EPRDF; Abiy)

Periods. Emperor Haile Selassie, 1941 (restoration after Italian occupation) to 1974; the Derg military council under Mengistu Haile Mariam, 1974-1991 (the People's Democratic Republic from 1987); the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF) under Meles Zenawi (to 2012) and Hailemariam Desalegn, 1991-2018; Abiy Ahmed and the Prosperity Party, from 2018.

Structure and legitimacy. Haile Selassie ruled as an absolute monarch under the 1931 and revised 1955 constitutions, which created a parliament with no real power. His legitimacy was dynastic (claimed Solomonic descent), religious (the Ethiopian Orthodox Church), and anti-colonial (the only African state never colonized apart from the 1936-41 Italian occupation; leader of the founding of the Organisation of African Unity in 1963). The Derg was a military dictatorship that became a Marxist-Leninist one-party state under Mengistu's personal control. The EPRDF was a dominant-party developmental authoritarian regime built on ethnic federalism, led by the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). The Prosperity Party, which replaced the EPRDF in 2019, governs as a dominant party in an electoral-authoritarian system.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A large, overwhelmingly rural, feudal agrarian society: Maddison GDP per person 622 in 1950; life expectancy 39.6 years in 1960 (WDI); adult literacy 27% even in 1994 (WDI). Few mineral resources (coffee was the main export). The imperial state had a centralized bureaucracy and army, but land was held by the crown, church and nobility, and peasants paid heavy tenancy dues.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development.

- *Imperial period.* Modest modernization (Addis Ababa University, Ethiopian Airlines, the 1955 constitution) without land reform. The 1972-74 Wollo famine, which the court tried to conceal, killed tens of thousands and destroyed the emperor's legitimacy among students and junior officers [E].
- *Derg.* Radical land nationalization (1975) abolished the feudal order, the most redistributive act in the country's history, but collectivization, villagization and forced resettlement were economically destructive. The Red Terror of 1977-78 killed tens of thousands; the Derg itself estimated more than a million deaths from the 1983-85 famine (Wikipedia, "Derg" [V]; de Waal 1991, *Evil Days* [E]). Maddison GDP per person was 972 in 1975 and 744 in 1995, lower after twenty years.
- *EPRDF.* After 1991 and especially from about 2004, a "developmental state" strategy modelled on East Asia (public infrastructure, state enterprises, industrial parks, the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam) produced one of the world's fastest growth records: constant-2015-dollar GDP per person rose from 268 (2004) to 745 (2019), about 7.1% a year per person (WDI). Life expectancy rose from 50.9 (2000) to 67.3 (2023); infant mortality fell from 92 to 39 per 1,000; HDI from 0.293 (2000) to 0.497 (2023). Distribution was relatively equal by regional standards (Gini 31.1 in 2021, WDI), but political control was tight and the 2005 election crackdown and 2015-18 Oromo and Amhara protests showed the regime's narrow base.
- *Abiy.* Initial liberalization (release of prisoners, peace with Eritrea, Nobel Peace Prize 2019), then the Tigray war of 2020-22, with an estimated 100,000 to 600,000 deaths according to sources compiled by Wikipedia

("Tigray war" [V]), and continuing insurgencies in Amhara and Oromia. In the June 2026 election the Prosperity Party won 438 seats, voting did not take place in parts of Tigray and Amhara, and Abiy was reappointed for a new five-year term in October 2026 (AP, Reuters and Xinhua reports, search excerpts [E]).

Succession, continuity, consequences. The emperor, in his eighties, had an heir (Crown Prince Asfa Wossen, incapacitated by a stroke in 1973) but no functioning succession plan. Students, workers and soldiers mobilized in 1974; the Derg deposed him in September 1974 and he died in custody in 1975. Mengistu fled in May 1991 as the EPRDF's rebel armies took Addis Ababa. The 2018 transfer from Hailemariam to Abiy was an intra-party negotiated succession under protest pressure, one of the few peaceful leadership changes in the country's history. **Long-term consequences:** Ethiopia offers three lessons. Absolute monarchy over an agrarian society without rents delivered almost no development in thirty years. The revolutionary dictatorship that replaced it was worse. A disciplined party-state could produce sustained growth, but its ethnic-federal settlement and narrow political base did not survive a change of leader, which shows that developmental authoritarianism is exposed to exactly the succession risk the BRIEF's Part V hypothesis 7 describes.

4.2 Equatorial Guinea (Macías Nguema; Obiang)

Periods. Francisco Macías Nguema, 1968-1979; Teodoro Obiang Nguema Mbasogo, since August 1979.

Structure and legitimacy. Both are personalist dictatorships with a single dominant party and a ruling family drawn from the Esangui clan of Mongomo. Macías's rule is often described as "sultanistic" (interpretation: Linz & Chehabi 1998): arbitrary, terror-based and anti-intellectual. Obiang's regime is a family-based personalist dictatorship with managed elections; his son Teodoro Nguema Obiang Mangue ("Teodorin") is vice-president. Coded as a dictatorship with de facto dynastic features, not as a monarchy.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A small former Spanish colony (population 270,000 in 1960, WDI) with cocoa and timber exports and a relatively high colonial-era income for the region (Maddison GDP per person 1,101 in 1960). Oil was discovered offshore in the 1990s and exports grew rapidly after 1996; natural resource rents reached 89% of GDP in 2000 (WDI).

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Under Macías, the economy collapsed and, according to various sources, 20,000 to 80,000 of the roughly 200,000-300,000 inhabitants were killed and tens of thousands fled (Wikipedia, "Francisco Macías Nguema" [V]; the range itself shows how poor the data are). Under Obiang, oil made Equatorial Guinea, by income, one of the richest countries in Africa: PPP GDP per person 33,669 in 2010 (constant 2021 international dollars, WDI). But human development lagged far behind income: HDI was 0.612 in 2010 and 0.674 in 2023 (rank 133), and infant mortality was still 49 per 1,000 in 2023 (WDI; UNDP). This gap between income and HDI is one of the largest in the world. As oil output declined, constant-2015-dollar GDP per person fell from its 2008 peak (13,048) to 4,498 in 2025, a fall of about two-thirds (WDI). WGI corruption control was -1.53 in 2023. Foreign courts have pursued Teodorin for asset embezzlement, and France convicted him in 2017 [E].

Succession, continuity, consequences. Obiang, Macías's nephew and commander of the national guard, deposed and executed his uncle in 1979. He has ruled for 47 years, making him the world's longest-serving non-royal head of state. **Long-term consequence:** Equatorial Guinea is the cleanest test case for the BRIEF's warning that "petroleum wealth alone" does not explain Gulf outcomes: a small population, enormous rents per person, and a hereditary-style ruling family produced neither broad welfare nor institutions. The obvious differences from the Gulf are that its rulers' claim rests on a coup rather than an accepted dynastic order, that rents were captured by a family network rather than spread across a large ruling family and citizenry, and that oil arrived after the ruling coalition had formed around predation (hypothesis).

4.3 Rwanda (monarchy to 1961; Kayibanda; Habyarimana; Kagame)

Periods. The Tutsi mwami (king) monarchy under Belgian trusteeship (Mutara III Rudahigwa to 1959; Kigeli V), to 1961; Grégoire Kayibanda, First Republic, 1962-1973; Juvénal Habyarimana, Second Republic, 1973-1994; the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) and Paul Kagame, from July 1994 (Kagame vice-president and de facto leader 1994-2000, president from 2000).

Structure and legitimacy. The monarchy had been absolute in pre-colonial form and was preserved under indirect rule by Germany and Belgium, which hardened the Hutu-Tutsi distinction into an administrative caste

system. The Hutu "social revolution" of 1959-61, with violence against Tutsi and Belgian support for Hutu parties, ended the monarchy: Kigeli V fled in July 1960, Hutu leaders proclaimed a republic at Gitarama in January 1961, and a UN-supervised referendum in September 1961 rejected the monarchy (Wikipedia, "Rwandan Revolution" [V]; referendum details [E]). Kayibanda ruled through a Hutu ethnic-majoritarian one-party regime (PARMEHUTU); Habyarimana, after his 1973 coup, through a military-backed one-party state (MRND). The RPF regime is a dominant-party developmental authoritarian state; Kagame won the 2024 presidential election with an officially reported vote above 99% [E], and a 2015 referendum allowed him to extend his tenure (Wikipedia, "Paul Kagame" [V] for the referendum).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Densely populated, landlocked, agrarian, with few minerals; resource rents below 10% of GDP throughout (WDI). Maddison GDP per person 1,020 in 1950. A strong tradition of hierarchical administration reaching down to the hill level, which later regimes inherited and used, including for mass murder in 1994.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Under the Hutu republics, growth was modest and the 1980s ended in coffee-price collapse and civil war (the RPF invasion of 1990). The genocide of April-July 1994, triggered after Habyarimana's plane was shot down on 6 April 1994 (Wikipedia, "Juvénal Habyarimana" [V]), killed an estimated 500,000 to 800,000 people, mostly Tutsi [E]; constant-2015-dollar GDP per person fell to 187 in 1994 (WDI). Under the RPF, GDP per person rose to 1,043 in 2024, about 4.9% a year per person between 2000 and 2024 (WDI). Life expectancy rose from 47.8 (2000) to 67.8 (2023); infant mortality fell from 108 to 30 per 1,000; HDI from 0.340 (2000) to 0.578 (2023). WGI control of corruption improved from -0.80 (1996) to 0.68 (2023), the best score in sub-Saharan Africa in this sample, and government effectiveness from -1.35 to 0.33. Voice and accountability remained negative (-0.70) and inequality is high (Gini 39.4, 2023). Rwanda's regime has also been credibly linked to repression of critics at home and abroad and to armed groups in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo [E: UN Group of Experts reports].

Succession, continuity, consequences. Every change of regime in Rwanda since 1959 has been violent: revolution (1959-61), coup (1973), assassination, genocide and rebel victory (1994). Kagame has ruled for over 30 years with no visible succession plan. **Long-term consequence:** Rwanda is the strongest African evidence that a non-resource authoritarian state can build effective, low-corruption administration and deliver rapid human-development gains. It is also an example of the BRIEF's central risk: the system's performance is tightly identified with one leader, and the country's history offers no precedent for a peaceful transfer of power.

4.4 Eswatini (monarchy; absolute)

Periods. Sobhuza II under the independence (Westminster) constitution, 1968-1973; Sobhuza II as absolute monarch, 12 April 1973 to his death in 1982; regency, 1982-1986; Mswati III, from 1986.

Structure and legitimacy. On 12 April 1973 Sobhuza repealed the constitution and dissolved parliament, ruling as an absolute monarch thereafter (Wikipedia, "Sobhuza II" [V]). The tinkhundla system of non-party elections to local constituencies, introduced in 1978, and the 2005 constitution preserve royal supremacy; political parties cannot contest power. Legitimacy is dynastic and cultural (the king as embodiment of Swazi nationhood, the Incwala and Umhlanga ceremonies), plus control over Swazi Nation Land and the royal investment fund Tibiyo TakaNgwane.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A small landlocked state (population 345,000 in 1960, WDI) inside South Africa's economic orbit, with sugar, wood pulp, asbestos and later soft-drink concentrate exports. Southern African Customs Union (SACU) transfers are a major fiscal rent, often more than a third of revenue [E]. Maddison GDP per person 604 in 1950.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Maddison GDP per person rose to 8,522 by 2022 (x14), and constant-2015-dollar GDP per person from 905 (1970) to 3,866 (2024) (WDI). But distribution is among the most unequal in the world (Gini 54.6, 2016, WDI). In the 2014 budget, parliament allocated about US$61 million to the royal household when, according to UNDP figures cited in the same source, 63% of the population lived on less than US$1.25 a day (Wikipedia, "Mswati III" [V]; to be checked against the original budget documents before use in conclusions). The HIV epidemic cut life expectancy from 61.2 (1990) to 47.6 (2000); it recovered to 64.1 in 2023 (WDI). WGI government effectiveness fell from -0.31 (1996) to -0.78 (2023). Pro-democracy protests in 2021 were met with lethal force [E].

Succession, continuity, consequences. Sobhuza ruled for 82 years (as king from 1899, under a regency until 1921), one of the longest reigns in recorded history. His death in 1982 was followed by a four-year regency marked by palace power struggles before the teenage Mswati was crowned in 1986. **Long-term consequence:** Eswatini is the most important non-Gulf test of absolute monarchy in the database. It has dynastic legitimacy, long time horizons and an unchallenged ruler, which are the features the "monarchy advantage" hypotheses emphasize, but it lacks large rents per citizen. Its outcomes, extreme inequality, weak governance and low accountability, show that the Gulf combination of absolute monarchy and broad welfare is not a property of monarchy as such.

4.5 Lesotho (monarchy; constitutional, interrupted)

Periods. Constitutional monarchy under Moshoeshoe II, 1966-1970; Leabua Jonathan's Basotho National Party (BNP) regime, 1970-1986; military rule, 1986-1993; restored parliamentary democracy with a constitutional monarch (Letsie III since 1996, with a brief 1995-96 restoration of Moshoeshoe II), since 1993.

Structure and legitimacy. At independence, a Westminster constitution with a ceremonial king. When early results suggested the BNP would lose the January 1970 election, Prime Minister Jonathan nullified it, declared a state of emergency, suspended the constitution and dissolved parliament (Wikipedia, "Leabua Jonathan" [V]). The king was briefly exiled and returned as a figurehead. A military coup in January 1986 removed Jonathan; the military exiled Moshoeshoe II in 1990 and installed his son Letsie III. Elections in 1993 restored civilian government. Here the dictator was the elected prime minister, not the monarch: Lesotho shows that the crown can be the victim of authoritarianism rather than its instrument.

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A mountainous enclave within South Africa whose economy depended on migrant labour in South African mines. Constant-2015-dollar GDP per person was 312 in 1970 (WDI). Water exported to South Africa through the Lesotho Highlands Water Project (from 1998) provides royalties.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. GDP per person rose to 1,013 in 2024 (WDI), a threefold increase over 54 years, but life expectancy fell from 59.3 (1990) to 46.0 (2010) because of HIV and stood at 57.4 in 2023, the lowest in the sample; HDI 0.550 (2023); Gini 44.9 (2017). WGI voice and accountability was about 0.01 (2023), the second-best in the sample after Botswana, but government effectiveness was -0.73. A 1998 South African-led SADC intervention and repeated coalition crises (2014 attempted coup [E]) show a weak but competitive polity.

Succession, continuity, consequences. The crown survived the 1970 self-coup, military rule and exile because it was politically useful as a symbol and because South Africa and SADC preferred a constitutional settlement. **Long-term consequence:** Lesotho is a case of a constitutional monarchy in a poor, dependent economy; the crown's survival tells us little about development, which has depended on South Africa's labour market and on HIV.

4.6 Burundi (monarchy to 1966)

Periods. Mwami Mwambutsa IV (independence 1962) and Ntare V, 1962-1966; military regimes of Michel Micombero (1966-76), Jean-Baptiste Bagaza (1976-87) and Pierre Buyoya (1987-93); civil war after 1993.

Structure and legitimacy. At independence a semi-constitutional monarchy in which the mwami arbitrated between Hutu and Tutsi politicians and between rival princely lineages. After the assassination of prime ministers and a failed 1965 Hutu officers' coup, the crown's position collapsed: in July 1966 Ntare V deposed his father, and in November 1966 he was ousted by his own prime minister, Captain Michel Micombero, who abolished the monarchy (Wikipedia, "Burundian monarchy" [V]). Ntare V was killed in 1972 after returning from exile [E]. The successor regimes were Tutsi-dominated military dictatorships with a single party (UPRONA).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. Densely populated, landlocked, coffee-dependent; Maddison GDP per person 595 in 1950.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Maddison GDP per person was 717 in 2022, an increase of only 20% in 72 years (x1.2), the worst long-run record in the sample. Constant-2015-dollar GDP per person was 304 in 1970 and 269 in 2024 (WDI). The 1972 mass killings of educated Hutu [E: Lemarchand 1994] and the 1993-2005 civil war destroyed human capital. HDI was 0.439 in 2023, rank 187 of 193.

Succession, continuity, consequences. The monarchy fell in a family dispute exploited by the army. **Long-term consequence:** Burundi, with Rwanda, shows that in ethnically divided societies the end of monarchy opened a sequence of ethnic dictatorships and mass killing, not a development path.

4.7 Zanzibar (sultanate to 1964)

Periods. Sultanate under Jamshid bin Abdullah, independent from Britain in December 1963; revolution of 12 January 1964; Abeid Karume's Revolutionary Council, 1964-1972; union with Tanganyika (forming Tanzania) from April 1964.

Structure and legitimacy. At independence a constitutional monarchy whose electoral system, and the Arab minority's economic dominance, gave power to Arab-led parties despite an African majority vote for the Afro-Shirazi Party. The revolution, led by John Okello and joined by ASP militants, overthrew the sultan within hours. Estimates of those killed range from several hundred to 20,000; around a quarter of Zanzibar's Arabs are reported to have been killed in massacres, and about 10,000 people fled (Wikipedia, "Zanzibar Revolution" [V]; the range shows high uncertainty). Karume ruled as an autocrat within the union until his assassination in 1972 [E].

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. A clove and trade economy with a racially stratified social order inherited from the Omani Arab sultanate and British protection.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Separate long-run data for Zanzibar are not available in Maddison or WDI; Tanzania as a whole rose from Maddison 676 (1950) to 3,057 (2022). This is recorded as a data gap.

Succession, continuity, consequences. Long-term consequence: Zanzibar is the only case in the database where a monarchy fell to an armed popular insurrection organized on racial lines within weeks of independence. It illustrates that a monarchy identified with an ethnic minority, with no army of its own (the British had withdrawn and the police were partly foreign), had no coercive defence once colonial protection ended.

4.8 Botswana (contrast case: dominant-party democracy)

Periods. Botswana Democratic Party (BDP) governments under Seretse Khama (1966-80), Ketumile Masire (1980-98), Festus Mogae (1998-2008), Ian Khama (2008-18) and Mokgweetsi Masisi (2018-24); Umbrella for Democratic Change (UDC) government under Duma Boko after the BDP's defeat in the October 2024 election [E].

Structure and legitimacy. A parliamentary-presidential electoral democracy with a dominant party for 58 years and a peaceful alternation in 2024 [E]. Seretse Khama was the hereditary heir to the chieftaincy of the Bamangwato, the largest Tswana group; he renounced the chieftaincy (after his marriage to a white British woman and years of British-imposed exile) and entered electoral politics. His legitimacy was therefore traditional and democratic at once. Customary chiefs were incorporated into a House of Chiefs with advisory powers, and their control of land and mineral rights was transferred to the state and tribal land boards (interpretation: Acemoglu, Johnson & Robinson 2003).

Starting conditions, resources, state capacity. At independence one of the poorest countries in the world: Maddison GDP per person 489 in 1950, the lowest in this sample; constant-2015-dollar GDP per person 508 in 1966 (WDI); only a handful of kilometres of paved road [E]. Diamonds were discovered at Orapa in 1967. The government renegotiated mining agreements, raising its share to 50% of revenue by 1975 (Wikipedia, "Seretse Khama" [V]); Debswana is a 50/50 joint venture between the government and De Beers (Wikipedia, "Debswana" [V]). WDI resource-rent series understate diamond rents, which is a known limitation.

Development, institutions, distribution, human development. Constant-2015-dollar GDP per person grew about 9.0% a year from 1966 to 1990 (508 to 4,039; WDI), and the cited Wikipedia source states that Botswana had the world's fastest-growing economy between 1960 and 1980 [V]. Maddison GDP per person was 16,352 in 2022 (x33 since 1950). Diamond revenue was channelled through national development plans, a professional civil service, and the Pula Fund (1994) for savings [E]. WGI control of corruption was 0.99 in 1996, among the highest in Africa, though it fell to 0.59 by 2023. The weaknesses are real: inequality is very high (Gini 54.9, 2015, WDI),

unemployment is high, diversification beyond diamonds has been limited, and HIV reduced life expectancy from 62.5 (1980) to 52.3 (2000) before recovery to 69.2 (2023).

Succession, continuity, consequences. Botswana has had five constitutional transfers within the BDP and one transfer to the opposition. **Long-term consequence:** Botswana is the BRIEF's essential contrast case. It shows that the institutional mechanisms the Gulf monarchies are credited with (long-term development planning, a sovereign savings fund, a competent technocratic civil service, a negotiated state share in resource rents) were achieved in a poor, resource-dependent African state under electoral accountability, and that a hereditary leader could put his traditional authority behind institutions rather than above them. It does not show that democracy guarantees diversification or equality; Botswana has neither.

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5. Cross-case analysis

5.1 The fate of the region's monarchies after 1945

Monarchy	Fate	Year	Mode	Who acted	Resource rents at the time	Successor regime
Egypt (Muhammad Ali dynasty)	Abolished	1952 (abolished 1953)	Military coup	Free Officers (middle-ranking army)	Low	Military-backed one-party (Nasser)
Tunisia (Husainid beys)	Abolished	1957	Legal abolition	Constituent Assembly (Neo-Destour)	Low	One-party (Bourguiba)
Iraq (Hashemites)	Abolished	1958	Military coup, royal family killed	Free Officers (Qasim)	High	Military, then Ba'ath
Rwanda (Nyiginya mwami)	Abolished	1961	Ethnic revolution and UN referendum under Belgian trusteeship	Hutu parties with Belgian support	Low	Ethnic one-party
Yemen (Zaydi imamate)	Abolished	1962	Military coup, then civil war to 1970	Republican officers with Egyptian backing	None	Military
Zanzibar (Al Said sultanate)	Abolished	1964	Armed insurrection	ASP militants and Okello's fighters	Low	Revolutionary council, union with Tanganyika
Burundi (Ganwa mwami)	Abolished	1966	Coup by prime minister and army	Micombero	Low	Military one-party
Libya (Senussi)	Abolished	1969	Military coup	Junior officers (Gaddafi)	Very high	Personalist dictatorship
Ethiopia (Solomonic dynasty)	Abolished	1974-75	Creeping military coup	Derg (army committee)	Low	Military, then Marxist one-party

Monarchy	Fate	Year	Mode	Who acted	Resource rents at the time	Successor regime
Iran (Pahlavi)	Abolished	1979	Mass revolution	Clergy, bazaar, students, left, urban poor	High	Clerical hybrid
Lesotho (Moshoeshoe line)	Stripped of power, later restored as constitutional crown	1970	Prime minister's self-coup	Leabua Jonathan (BNP)	Low	De facto one-party, then military, then democracy
Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Morocco, Oman, Qatar, Kuwait, UAE, Bahrain, Eswatini	Survive (as of Nov 2026)				Mixed (Gulf high; Jordan, Morocco, Eswatini low)	

Sources: country entries above; [V] tags as given there.

Patterns.

1. **Timing.** All ten abolitions happened in a 27-year window, 1952-1979, the era of decolonization, pan-Arab nationalism, Cold War competition and politicized armies. After 1979 no monarchy in the sample fell, and the Arab Spring of 2011 toppled four republican dictators (Tunisia, Egypt, Libya, Yemen) while no monarch lost his throne. Monarchical durability is therefore partly a **period effect**: the monarchies that survived the 1950s-70s were the ones best equipped to survive, and the external environment after 1979 (US security guarantees for the Gulf, the discrediting of pan-Arab socialism) was more favourable (interpretation: Gause 2013; Bellin 2012).
2. **Agents.** The killer of monarchies was the army, not the street. In six of ten abolitions the decisive actor was an officer corps (often middle-ranking officers from provincial or lower-middle-class backgrounds), and in Lesotho an elected prime minister with security-force backing. This is the pattern Huntington (1968) called the "king's dilemma": modernizing monarchs create educated, professional groups, above all officers, whom the traditional order cannot absorb.
3. **Resources did not decide.** Abolished monarchies included high-rent states (Iraq, Libya, Iran) and low-rent ones (Egypt, Yemen, Ethiopia, Burundi). Surviving monarchies include high-rent states (the Gulf) and low-rent ones (Jordan, Morocco, Eswatini). Oil is neither necessary nor sufficient for monarchical survival in this sample.
4. **Succession moments were dangerous.** Yemen fell one week after a succession; Burundi fell after a son deposed his father; Libya fell with an aging, heirless king abroad; Ethiopia fell under an octogenarian emperor whose heir was incapacitated; Iran fell under a secretly ill shah with a teenage heir. Successions do not cause revolutions, but they reveal whether the institution can function without the incumbent.

5.2 Why the survivors survived: competing explanations tested against the database

Explanation	Evidence for, in this database	Evidence against, in this database
Dynastic monarchy (Herb 1999): the ruling family monopolizes key ministries and acts as a collective, so the army is not an autonomous rival.	Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar, UAE, Bahrain all fit; Saudi family removed King Saud in 1964 without a regime crisis; Kuwait removed an incapacitated emir in 2006. Fallen monarchies (Egypt, Iraq, Libya, Iran) were all "monarch-centred" with independent officer corps.	Jordan and Morocco are not dynastic in Herb's sense yet survived. Oman under Qaboos was highly personal and survived.
Oil rents (rentier-state theory: Mahdavy 1970; Beblawi & Luciani 1987; Ross 2012).	All Gulf survivors are rentiers; rents fund co-optation (public jobs, no taxes).	Iraq, Libya, Iran were oil monarchies that fell; Jordan, Morocco, Eswatini survived with little oil. Rents may help explain *how* survivors survive, not *whether* monarchy survives.
External patrons (Yom & Gause 2012).	Britain protected the Gulf sheikhdoms until 1971; the US restored Kuwait in 1991; the GCC force secured Bahrain in 2011; Jordan depends on US and Gulf aid; the British helped install Qaboos in 1970.	Iran's monarchy had the strongest US backing of all and fell; Iraq's Hashemites were British clients and fell. Patrons help with external threats and limited uprisings, not with a defecting army or a mass revolution.
Cross-cutting coalitions (Yom & Gause 2012).	Jordan (tribes plus Palestinian-origin business), Morocco (rural notables, parties, the makhzen), Kuwait (merchants).	Hard to measure; risk of being true by definition.
Cultural or religious legitimacy (Lucas 2004; Menaldo 2012 argues that monarchies' political culture of rules and norms helps).	Morocco (sharifian, Commander of the Faithful), Jordan (Hashemite), Saudi Arabia (Custodian of the Two Holy Mosques).	Yemen's imamate had the strongest religious legitimacy and fell; Ethiopia's emperor was head of a religious tradition and fell. Legitimacy erodes when performance fails.
Small citizen populations (hypothesis).	All six GCC states have citizen populations small enough for rents per citizen to be very high.	Eswatini is small and poor and survives; Bahrain has modest rents per citizen and survives with external help.

Assessment. No single factor explains survival. The configuration that best fits the evidence is **dynastic control of the coercive apparatus plus either large rents per citizen or committed external patrons**. Morocco and Jordan show that a monarchy can substitute aid, coalition-building and selective repression for oil. Eswatini shows that survival is possible with neither, but at the price of poor governance outcomes. This is an interpretation built on 20 cases with many simultaneous differences; it should not be presented as a tested causal model.

5.3 Succession: hereditary versus other mechanisms in this sample

Regime periods in the CSV are generally defined by ruler, so the end modes give a rough picture of how rulers left office.

Ruler-period ended by	Monarchy rows (30 ended)	Dictatorship rows (22 ended)
Death and orderly succession	11	5
Coup (including palace coups within dynasties and self-coups)	13	7
Revolution or rebel victory	3	5

Ruler-period ended by	Monarchy rows (30 ended)	Dictatorship rows (22 ended)
Negotiated transition (abdication, parliamentary removal, elections, intra-party handover)	3	4
Foreign invasion	0	1

Source: `data/regimes_mena_africa.csv` (tabulation, 7 Nov 2026). Mean length of ended ruler-periods: monarchy rows 21.0 years, dictatorship rows 20.0 years. Ongoing periods excluded from the "ended" counts.

What this shows and does not show. Monarchy rows end through death more often (11 of 30) than dictatorship rows (5 of 22), which is consistent with the claim that hereditary systems institutionalize succession. But monarchy rows also contain **13 coups**. Breaking these down: six were regime-ending military coups (Egypt, Iraq, Yemen, Libya, Burundi, Ethiopia); four were **intra-dynastic palace coups** that kept the dynasty and often improved governance (Saudi Arabia 1964, Oman 1970, Qatar 1972 and 1995); one was the 1953 Iranian coup that strengthened the monarch; and two were self-coups that ended a constitutional period (Eswatini 1973 by the king; Lesotho 1970 by the prime minister). The fair conclusion is that **hereditary monarchies in this region did not avoid forcible removals of rulers; the successful ones contained them within the family.** Intra-family deposition is, in effect, the monarchy's substitute for elections or party leadership contests as a way of removing a failing ruler. Where the family could not do this (because the monarch, not the family, controlled the army), the army did it instead and ended the dynasty.

This bears directly on BRIEF Part V hypothesis 2 (long planning horizons) and hypothesis 7 (succession risk). The successful dynastic monarchies have long horizons because the *family* is long-lived and can replace a bad ruler, not because each individual ruler is good. The post-2017 Saudi concentration of power in one prince weakens exactly that mechanism (hypothesis, to be tested in R1/R5).

5.4 "Republican monarchies": hereditary succession without a crown

Ruler	Heir groomed	Outcome
Saddam Hussein (Iraq)	Uday, Qusay	Regime ended by invasion 2003; both sons killed
Hosni Mubarak (Egypt)	Gamal	Military refused to defend the succession project; Mubarak removed 2011
Muammar Gaddafi (Libya)	Saif al-Islam (and others)	Regime collapsed 2011
Ali Abdullah Saleh (Yemen)	Ahmed	Elite split 2011; negotiated exit 2012
Teodoro Obiang (Equatorial Guinea)	Teodorin (vice-president)	Ongoing
Ali Khamenei (Iran)	Mojtaba	Succeeded March 2026 in wartime
(Hafez al-Assad, Syria, outside R2 scope)	Bashar	Succeeded 2000; regime fell December 2024 [E]

The table shows that personalist dictators in the region repeatedly tried to convert their rule into hereditary rule, which suggests that the hereditary principle is attractive to autocrats because it gives elites a focal point for succession (interpretation: Brownlee 2007, "Hereditary Succession in Modern Autocracies", *World Politics*). But without an accepted dynastic norm, these attempts provoked resistance from the institutions (militaries, parties) whose own claims they bypassed. In Egypt the military's opposition to Gamal Mubarak is the clearest example (interpretation: Stacher 2012). The monarchies' advantage in succession is therefore **the accepted norm**, not heredity as such; a norm cannot be created by decree in a generation.

5.5 Development outcomes by regime class: what the database can and cannot say

1. **Human development rose almost everywhere, under every type of regime.** Between 1960 and 2023 life expectancy rose by 20 to 45 years in every MENA country in the sample and by 15 to 28 years in the African cases except Lesotho (WDI). The global health transition makes human-development gains a weak discriminator between regime types.
2. **The largest human-development gains relative to starting point are in rent-rich monarchies (Oman, Saudi Arabia, UAE) and in two non-monarchical developmental regimes (Rwanda after 1994, Ethiopia after 2000).** The largest reversals are in post-monarchical personalist dictatorships and their collapsed successors (Iraq 1980-1995; Libya after 2011; Yemen after 2014) and in the HIV-hit southern African states (all regime types).
3. **Long-run income growth is dominated by resource discovery.** Of the five biggest multiples in Maddison GDP per person, 1950-2022 (Oman x48, Botswana x33, Equatorial Guinea x28, Libya x21, Saudi Arabia x15), all are resource exporters, and they include an absolute monarchy, a democracy and two dictatorships.
4. **Income per person in constant dollars has fallen from 1970s peaks across most Gulf monarchies** (Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, UAE, Qatar, Oman) and in Iran, Libya and Jordan (WDI). Gulf monarchies have converted rents into welfare and infrastructure, but the database does not show sustained productivity-driven income growth. This is consistent with R1's Gulf country findings on diversification (see R1) and should be tested with Penn World Table total factor productivity data in Part VI.
5. **Inequality is poorly measured where it matters most.** No official Gini exists for Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Oman or Bahrain in WDI; the UAE and Qatar figures (26.4, 2018; 35.1, 2017) are household-survey figures that do not capture the citizen-migrant divide. The highest measured Gini values in the sample are Botswana (54.9) and Eswatini (54.6), a democracy and an absolute monarchy respectively. **The database therefore cannot answer the BRIEF's question whether high GDP per capita translates into broadly distributed prosperity in the Gulf monarchies** with standard indicators; R1 and Part VI need alternative measures (citizen-only wage data, top-income estimates from Alvaredo, Assouad & Piketty 2019).
6. **Governance quality (WGI, since 1996) is highest in the Gulf monarchies and in Botswana and Rwanda.** It is lowest in post-monarchical dictatorships and their failed successors, and in Equatorial Guinea. The Gulf monarchies combine top-tier government effectiveness with bottom-tier voice and accountability, so "state capacity" and "accountability" must be treated as separate dimensions in Parts V and VII.

5.6 The resource curse in this sample

Rentier-state theory predicts that rents finance authoritarian stability through low taxation, patronage and repression (Mahdavy 1970; Beblawi & Luciani 1987; Ross 2012). The database broadly supports the stability prediction for the Gulf after 1971 and for Equatorial Guinea after 1996, but contradicts it for Iraq (1958), Libya (1969) and Iran (1979), where rising rents preceded regime collapse. Two refinements fit the evidence better (interpretation, following Herb 2014 and Smith 2007):

- **Rents per citizen, not rents as a share of GDP, predict welfare outcomes.** The UAE, Qatar and Kuwait have enormous rents per citizen; Iraq, Iran and Libya had large rents spread over larger and faster-growing populations, or over a state that did not distribute them broadly.
- **The timing of rents relative to coalition formation matters.** Where rents arrived after a ruling coalition was already organized and able to distribute them (the Gulf families, Botswana's BDP), they were channelled into durable institutions or broad welfare. Where rents arrived amid unresolved conflicts over who should rule (Iraq in the 1950s, Libya in the 1960s, Equatorial Guinea in the 1990s), they intensified the stakes of controlling the state (hypothesis; compare Smith 2007, *Hard Times in the Lands of Plenty*).

5.7 Failure modes observed (BRIEF Part IX)

Failure mode	Clearest cases in R2
Elite capture	Ben Ali family firms (Tunisia); Obiang family (Equatorial Guinea); IRGC and bonyads (Iran); Mubarak-era business circle
Corruption	Equatorial Guinea; Libya under Idris and Gaddafi; Iraq post-2003
Political repression	Iraq under Saddam; Derg's Red Terror; Macías; Morocco's Years of Lead; Iran 2025-26
Information distortion	Haile Selassie's concealment of the Wollo famine; the Shah's isolation in 1977-78
Policy mistakes by one man	Saddam's invasions of Iran (1980) and Kuwait (1990); Gaddafi's anti-institutional experiments; the Shah's 1974 doubling of plan spending
Economic misallocation	Derg collectivization; Gaddafi's ban on private retail; Kuwait's fiscal paralysis
Succession crises	Yemen 1962; Burundi 1966; Ethiopia 1974; republican monarchies 2011; Iran 2026
Institutional fragility	Libya 2011; Yemen 2014; Iraq 2003
Fiscal irresponsibility	Iran 1974-77; Oman and Bahrain after 2014 (debt), Egypt (repeated IMF programs)
Excessive dependence on one leader	Oman 1970-2020 (positive case of the same risk); Rwanda under Kagame; Saudi Arabia after 2017 (hypothesis)

5.8 Implications for the monograph's hypotheses

- **Part V, H1 (concentrated decision-making).** Supported for speed and coordination in the Gulf and in Rwanda and Ethiopia's EPRDF; also responsible for the region's worst single-person policy disasters (Saddam's wars, Gaddafi's experiments). The database supports "concentration amplifies leader quality, in both directions," consistent with Jones & Olken (2005).
- **Part V, H2 (long horizons from heredity).** Partly supported: dynastic families, not individual monarchs, provide the long horizon, and only when the family can remove a failing ruler. Absolute monarchies without rents (Yemen's imamate, pre-1970 Oman, Haile Selassie's Ethiopia, Eswatini) did not invest for the long term.
- **Part V, H5 (resource wealth).** Rents explain the Gulf's welfare model and are part of its stability, but rents also preceded the collapse of three oil monarchies. Petroleum alone does not explain outcomes (BRIEF Part III instruction confirmed).
- **Part V, H6 (self-constraining institutions).** Only weak evidence: Kuwait's parliament, Morocco's 2011 constitution and Oman's sealed-letter succession are partial self-constraints; all can be suspended by the ruler (Kuwait 2024; Eswatini 1973).
- **Part V, H7 (succession risk).** Strongly supported as a risk: seven of the ten abolitions (Yemen, Libya, Ethiopia, Iran, Burundi, and Rwanda and Zanzibar with monarchs installed only months or a few years earlier) coincided with an aging, ill, absent, heirless or newly installed monarch; Egypt, Iraq and Tunisia did not fit this pattern, and the developmental authoritarian regimes in Ethiopia and Rwanda have not demonstrated peaceful succession at the top.
- **Part XII, Q2 (why Gulf continuity).** Answer from R2: dynastic family control of coercion, rents per citizen, external protection, and the luck of having passed the dangerous 1952-79 window with these in place. Monarchy as such is not the answer, as the ten abolished monarchies show.

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6. Disputes and uncertainties

1. **Gulf data pre-1970.** Maddison's 1950-1970 values for Qatar, Kuwait and the UAE (25,000 to 52,000 in 2011 international dollars) are artefacts of back-extrapolation for tiny pre-oil economies; they must not be

used to argue that these societies were rich before oil. Use WDI from 1970 or qualitative sources instead.

2. **Resident versus citizen populations.** Every Gulf per-capita figure in this file divides by all residents. Citizen income, wages and welfare are much higher than the resident averages; migrant workers' are much lower. No consistent public citizen-only series exists in WDI or UNDP. This is the single largest measurement problem for the BRIEF's distribution questions.
3. **Death tolls.** Figures for Macías's Equatorial Guinea (20,000-80,000), the Zanzibar Revolution (several hundred to 20,000), the Rwandan genocide (500,000-800,000 or more), the Tigray war (100,000-600,000), the Derg's Red Terror and famine, and Iran's 2025-26 protest crackdown ("several thousand") come from secondary compilations with very wide ranges. They are recorded for context and kept out of quantitative comparison.
4. **Iran 2026 dates and facts.** The House of Commons Library briefing gives Ali Khamenei's death as "29 February 2026", which is not a valid date; news reports give 28 February. The condition and real authority of Mojtaba Khamenei are uncertain; Reuters (28 Aug 2026, excerpt [E]) and others report he has not appeared in public. Treat 2026 Iranian institutional claims as provisional.
5. **2026 Gulf economic effects.** Figures such as "Gulf economies have shrunk 5 percent" and the UAE's exit from OPEC come from search excerpts of NYT (2 Nov 2026) and Chatham House (30 Apr 2026) not opened during this stream [E]. R1 or a later stream should verify them against IMF and official sources before use.
6. **Coding judgments.** (a) Palace coups within dynasties are coded "coup" though the dynasty survived. (b) Kuwait after May 2024 is coded semi-constitutional in the regime_type field with a note that it functions as absolute; a stricter coder would open a new row. (c) Iran after March 2026 is marked "Y (de facto father-to-son)" in the hereditary column but kept as a dictatorship. (d) Egypt under Nasser is coded one-party; some datasets (Geddes-Wright-Frantz) code it as a military or personalist regime. (e) Ethiopia's EPRDF is coded developmental authoritarian; a stricter reading would code 1991-2004 as ordinary one-party rule and only 2004-2018 as developmental. These choices should be harmonized with R3/R4 and the Geddes-Wright-Frantz codings before final analysis.
7. **Causation.** All patterns in section 5 are correlations across a small number of very different cases. In particular, the coincidence of Saudi Arabia's WGI improvement with the post-2015 centralization does not show that centralization caused it; oil-price cycles, Vision 2030 spending and survey-respondent composition are alternative explanations.
8. **Selection bias in the literature.** The scholarly literature on surviving Gulf monarchies (Herb, Hertog, Davidson, Ulrichsen) is far larger than that on Yemen's imamate, the Senussi monarchy, Burundi's mwami or Zanzibar's sultanate. This file's coverage of the fallen cases relies more on general histories and encyclopaedic sources, which is a weakness to correct in later rounds with specialist works (e.g., Batatu 1978 on Iraq; Lemarchand 1970 on Rwanda and Burundi; Dresch 2000 on Yemen; Clapham 1969 on Ethiopia).
9. **Wikipedia as a source.** Several dates and event details are tagged [V] because they were read in Wikipedia articles fetched on 7 November 2026 (raw text saved in `work/r2/`). Dates of well-known events (coups, accessions, deaths) are reliable at this level; contested numbers (death tolls, royal household budgets) are flagged and should be checked against primary or scholarly sources before use in conclusions.
10. **Facts tagged [E] that should be verified next:** Rijkers, Freund & Nucifora (2017) 21% profit-share figure for Ben Ali firms; Egypt's troop numbers in Yemen (up to 70,000); Qatar's 2024 referendum on the Shura Council; Botswana's October 2024 election result; Kagame's 2024 vote share; Kuwait Investment Board founding year (1953); Oman's planned personal income tax; Teodorin Obiang's 2017 French conviction.

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7. Sources

Datasets (opened and pulled, [V])

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https://api.worldbank.org/v2/country/{codes}/indicator/{id}?format=json . Raw: `data/raw/wdi_r2/`; long file `data/r2_wdi_long.csv`; pull script `data/raw/wdi_r2/pull.py`.
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- Reuters, "Iran's disfigured supreme leader remains invisible six months into an existential war", 28 Aug 2026 [E]
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Appendix A. Dataset dictionary for `data/regimes_mena_africa.csv`

Column	Meaning
country	Polity (Zanzibar treated separately before and after the 1964 union)
regime_period	Ruler or regime label
start_year, end_year	Years; end_year blank = ongoing at 7 Nov 2026. Periods beginning before 1945 keep their real start year for context.
regime_type	Primary BRIEF Part II category, with a qualifier in parentheses
hereditary(Y/N)	Y if the ruler's title is hereditary under an accepted dynastic rule; "N (de facto dynastic)" or "Y (de facto father-to-son)" notes attempted hereditary transfer in non-monarchies
resource_rent_dependence	Qualitative band with WDI total natural resource rents (% of GDP) where available
end_mode	survived / coup / revolution / foreign invasion / negotiated transition / death-succession (see section 1.3 for coding rules)
notes	Key events, figures and judgment calls
sources	Source with evidence tag
monarchy_or_dictatorship	Added column: monarchy / dictatorship / hybrid / democracy, as required by BRIEF Part IV's instruction to distinguish monarchy from dictatorship

R3. Historical Database, Part IV: Asia and Europe, 1945–2026

Project II, "The Political Economy of Absolute Power". Authors: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (he conceived and directs the project; Hark's agents research and draft). Research stream R3, drafted 7 November 2026.

Companion files

- `data/regimes_asia_europe.csv`: 72 coded regime-periods (columns: country, regime_period, start_year, end_year, regime_type, hereditary(Y/N), resource_rent_dependence, end_mode, notes, sources).
- `data/r3_maddison_period_growth.csv`: GDP per capita at the start and end of each regime period, with compound annual growth (Maddison Project Database 2023).
- `data/raw/wdi_r3/`: World Bank World Development Indicators (WDI) API pulls for 21 countries; `data/raw/maddison/`: Maddison source file and extract; `data/README_R3.md` documents both.

Evidence tags. [V] = the source was opened and the claim is on it, or the figure was computed by this stream from a raw dataset pulled on 7 November 2026. [E] = established scholarly knowledge or a search excerpt not opened. Interpretive claims are marked "(interpretation: Author year)"; hypotheses are marked "(hypothesis)". Nothing here is an operational guide to seizing or holding power; coups, repression and collapse are treated only historically and causally.

Units used throughout. "Maddison GDPpc" = real GDP per capita in 2011 international dollars (purchasing-power adjusted), Maddison Project Database 2023, total resident population. "WDI GDPpc" = GDP per capita in constant 2015 US dollars, total resident population. "Rents" = WDI total natural-resource rents (oil, gas, coal, minerals, forests) as a percentage of GDP. "LE" = life expectancy at birth, years (WDI). "HDI" = UNDP Human Development Index (HDR 2025 time series). CAGR = compound annual growth rate.

Key findings

1. **Only one absolute monarchy in this sample survived to 2026, and it is the resource-richest: Brunei.** Every other ruling or interventionist monarchy in Asia and Europe in the 1945–2026 window was abolished (Laos 1975, Afghanistan 1973, Greece 1973/74, Nepal 2008, Romania 1947, South Vietnam 1955, Cambodia 1970), reduced to a ceremonial role (Nepal 1990 before final abolition; Thailand formally, though with a powerful palace), or converted into a constitutional monarchy that legitimised a democratic transition (Spain 1975–78, Cambodia 1993, Japan 1947, Malaysia's rotating crown). Survival and wealth co-vary, but the direction is not simple: Brunei's monarchy survived because oil rents let it buy consent and Britain defended it in 1962, not because hereditary rule generated the wealth. Brunei's real GDP per capita fell by about two-thirds between 1980 and 2023 (WDI GDPpc 84,483 -> 28,646, constant 2015 US$) [V], an extreme case of rent-dependence without diversification.

2. **Every high-growth authoritarian case in this sample is a dictatorship or a dominant party, not an absolute monarchy.** South Korea (Park, 1961–79: Maddison GDPpc CAGR 7.9%) [V], Taiwan under the Kuomintang (1950–87: 6.2%) [V], Singapore under the People's Action Party (1965–90: 7.2%) [V], Franco's Spain after 1959 (1959–75: 5.9%) [V], post-1978 China (1978–2012: 5.6%) [V] and post-1986

Vietnam (1986–2022: 4.8%) [V]. None was hereditary. The monarchies with real executive power in the sample (Nepal's Panchayat 1960–90: 1.0% CAGR; Afghanistan 1950–73: -0.6%; Laos 1950–75: 1.5%) were among the slowest growers [V]. The sample therefore offers no support for the claim that hereditary rule as such produces developmental outcomes; it offers some support for the narrower claim that certain non-hereditary authoritarian regimes produced fast growth under specific conditions.

3. **The growth record of authoritarian East Asia cannot be attributed to authoritarianism alone.** The strongest cases combined (a) land reform that destroyed the landlord class before industrialisation (Korean farm tenancy fell from 49% to 7% of households by 1956; Taiwan's income Gini fell from 0.57 in 1953 to 0.33 in 1964) [V You 2014]; (b) very large US aid (about 70% of Korean imports and 75% of fixed capital formation in 1953–61) [V Irwin 2025, citing Haggard, Kim and Moon 1991]; (c) high initial literacy; (d) an existential security threat that disciplined elites; and (e) export orientation, which in Korea was adopted only in 1964–65 under US pressure and was first tried by a short-lived democratic government in 1960–61 [V Irwin 2025]. The same authoritarian form elsewhere (Marcos's Philippines, Ceausescu's Romania, Sukarno's Indonesia, Kim-dynasty North Korea, Ne Win's Burma, outside this sample) produced stagnation or collapse.

4. **New evidence weakens even the land-reform pillar.** A January 2026 working paper by Kim and Wang, using digitised township data, finds that Taiwan's land reform raised GDP per worker by only about 5.7% over 1956–66 and that the "land-to-the-tiller" phase did not raise agricultural productivity [V]. Land reform's main contribution may have been political (removing a rent-seeking landed class and enabling state autonomy, per You 2014) rather than directly economic. This shifts weight back towards institutional and external explanations, but not towards "authoritarianism itself".

5. **Succession is the decisive weakness of personalist rule, and hereditary succession is not a cure.** Park ended by assassination (1979); Sukarno, Suharto, Rhee, Marcos (outside sample), Ceausescu, Caetano, the Greek colonels and Thanom ended by revolt, coup or collapse; Tito's death was followed within eleven years by state dissolution. The regimes that solved succession did so through an institution that outlived the founder: the Kuomintang (which then democratised), the People's Action Party, the Chinese and Vietnamese Communist parties, and, in a different way, Spain's designated constitutional monarchy. North Korea solved succession dynastically twice (1994, 2011) at the cost of famine and economic decline (Maddison GDPpc 2,456 in 1990 -> 1,569 in 2022) [V].

6. **Monarchy's clearest positive contribution in this sample was as a transition device, not as a development engine.** Juan Carlos in Spain (1975–81), Sihanouk's restoration in Cambodia (1993) and the ceremonial throne in Japan show monarchy lending continuity to a change of regime. Where monarchs instead allied with armies against elected governments (Greece 1965–67, Nepal 1960 and 2005, Thailand repeatedly), the institution was abolished or became the central fault line of politics.

7. **Resource rents are associated with survival, not with development, in this sample.** The two highest-rent cases, Brunei (rents averaging 40.7% of GDP in the 1970s) and Malaysia (27.5%), survived politically; Malaysia diversified through export manufacturing while Brunei did not [V WDI]. Indonesia under Suharto used oil windfalls (rents 14.6% of GDP, 1970s) better than most oil states, spending on rice, rural infrastructure and primary schools, but the regime still fell once the 1997–98 crisis cut GDP by 13.1% [V WDI].

8. **Human-development gains were real under several dictatorships, and were not unique to them.** Life expectancy in Korea rose from 53.8 (1960) to 71.6 (1990) and in Indonesia from 46.8 to 63.2 [V WDI]. But democratic Japan (67.7 -> 78.8) and the democracies that succeeded Franco and Salazar matched or exceeded these trajectories, and the worst human-development catastrophes in the sample were authoritarian (Cambodia 1975–79, with about 1.7 million deaths, 21% of the population [E Yale Genocide Studies Program]; North Korea's 1990s famine; China's 1959–61 famine).

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1. Scope, coding rules and method

1.1 Case selection and the selection-bias problem

The commission (BRIEF Part IV) lists the Asian cases Brunei, Thailand, Cambodia, Indonesia, South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, North Korea and Japan, and the European cases Spain, Portugal, Romania, Yugoslavia and Greece. This stream adds Nepal, Laos, Afghanistan, Malaysia, China and Vietnam, and briefly South Vietnam's monarchy (1949–55), because FRAMEWORK requires failed and fallen monarchies to be recorded alongside survivors and because China and Vietnam are the obvious one-party developmental comparators.

Selection bias runs in two directions here. First, East Asian authoritarian "miracles" are over-studied relative to East and Southeast Asian authoritarian failures (Burma, the Philippines under Marcos, Laos before 1986, Cambodia, North Korea), which makes "developmental authoritarianism" look more common than it was. Second, surviving monarchies (Brunei, Thailand, Malaysia, Japan, Spain) are visible in 2026, while fallen ones (Laos, Afghanistan, Nepal, Greece, Romania, South Vietnam, the first Cambodian monarchy) are easily forgotten. The database deliberately records seven abolitions (Romania 1947, South Vietnam 1955, Cambodia 1970, Afghanistan 1973, Greece 1973–74, Laos 1975, Nepal 2008) against six thrones still standing in 2026 (Brunei, Thailand, Malaysia, Japan, and two restorations: Spain 1975 and Cambodia 1993).

1.2 Regime types (BRIEF Part II) and the monarchy/dictatorship marker

Each regime-period is coded with one primary Part II type. The `notes` field opens with a class marker so that monarchy and dictatorship are never conflated:

Marker	Meaning
MONARCHY-RULING	The hereditary monarch is the effective chief executive (absolute or semi-constitutional monarchy).
MONARCHY-CONSTITUTIONAL	A hereditary monarch is head of state, but elected or appointed governments hold executive power.
DICTATORSHIP	A non-hereditary ruler, junta or party holds power without competitive accountability (military, personalist, one-party, or electoral-authoritarian). "Under constitutional/ceremonial monarch" is added when a throne coexists with the dictatorship (Thailand's juntas; Hun Sen's Cambodia).
HYBRID	Competitive elections exist but are tilted by unelected veto players (courts, army, palace) or an entrenched dominant party.
DEMOCRACY/CONTRAST	Competitive democracy, included to show what preceded or followed the authoritarian period.
FALLEN MONARCHY	Period ending in abolition of the monarchy.

`hereditary(Y/N)` records formal-legal hereditary rule of the effective ruler. North Korea's three Kims and Cambodia's Hun Sen -> Hun Manet handover are coded N (they are dictatorships, not monarchies) but are flagged in notes as de facto dynastic. This distinction matters for the commission's question about whether hereditary succession creates different incentives: the sample contains formal monarchies, de facto dynastic dictatorships and non-dynastic dictatorships, and they behave differently (Section 5).

1.3 Data and their limits

- **Maddison Project Database 2023** (Bolt and van Zanden) is the only source giving comparable GDP per capita back to 1950 for all cases, including Taiwan [V, downloaded]. Its estimates for communist economies (China before 1978, Romania, Yugoslavia, North Korea, Vietnam, Laos) and for poor economies in the 1950s and 1960s (Cambodia, Laos, Nepal, Afghanistan) are reconstructions with wide error bands. Romanian official statistics claimed growth near 9–10% a year in the 1970s; Maddison gives 3.7% for 1965–80 [V], and the gap itself is evidence of the "information distortion" failure mode in BRIEF Part IX.

- **World Bank WDI** begins in 1960 and has gaps (Cambodia, Laos and Vietnam before the 1980s; Romania, Croatia and Serbia before 1990; North Korea throughout). Cambodia's WDI life expectancy of 12.8 years in 1975 [V] reflects the genocide-year mortality model, not a measurement.
- **Correlation, not causation.** Period growth rates attach outcomes to regimes, but growth responds to world conditions (the 1950–73 golden age, the 1973 and 1979 oil shocks, the 1997 Asian crisis), to inherited capital and to policies that began under predecessors. Each case narrative below separates what the regime did from what it inherited or what happened to it.

1.4 Summary table of regime-periods and growth

Growth is Maddison GDPpc CAGR over the period shown (2011 international $; total population) unless stated. Source: `data/r3_maddison_period_growth.csv` [V].

Country	Regime-period	Type (Part II)	Marker	Growth window	GDPpc start -> end	CAGR %	End mode
Brunei	Hassanal Bolkiah 1967–	Absolute monarchy	MONARCHY-RULING	WDI 1980–2023 (const. 2015 US$)	84,483 -> 28,646	-2.5	Continuing
Thailand	Military rule 1950s–73	Military dictatorship	DICT. under monarch	1950–73	1,302 -> 2,987	3.7	Uprising 1973
Thailand	"Premocracy" 1976–88	Hybrid	HYBRID	1976–88	3,333 -> 6,089	5.2	Negotiated
Thailand	Junta 2014–19	Military dictatorship	DICT. under monarch	2014–19	14,572 -> 16,905	3.0	Managed transition
Cambodia	Sihanouk 1955–70	Semi-const. monarchy -> personalist	MONARCHY -> DICT.	1955–70	826 -> 1,031	1.5	Coup
Cambodia	Hun Sen 1993/97–2023	Electoral authoritarian	DICT. under monarch	1993–2022	1,384 -> 3,944	3.7	Dynastic handover
Indonesia	Guided Democracy 1959–66	Personalist	DICT.	1959–66	1,570 -> 1,535	-0.3	Military takeover
Indonesia	New Order 1966–98	Military-backed personalist / developmental	DICT.	1966–98	1,535 -> 5,204	3.9	Revolt after crisis
South Korea	Rhee 1948–60	Personalist / electoral authoritarian	DICT.	1953–60	1,317 -> 1,548	2.3	Revolt
South Korea	Park 1961–79	Military -> personalist developmental	DICT.	1961–79	1,606 -> 6,266	7.9	Assassination
South Korea	Chun 1980–88	Military dictatorship	DICT.	1980–88	6,064 -> 12,040	9.0	Negotiated

Country	Regime-period	Type (Part II)	Marker	Growth window	GDPpc start -> end	CAGR %	End mode
Taiwan	KMT 1949–87	One-party developmental	DICT.	1950–87	1,460 -> 13,705	6.2	Liberalisation
Singapore	PAP/Lee 1959–90	Electoral authoritarian / technocratic	DICT. (dominant party)	1965–90	3,991 -> 22,666	7.2	Managed succession
North Korea	Kim dynasty 1948–	Personalist one-party	DICT. (de facto dynastic)	1990–2022	2,456 -> 1,569	-1.4	Continuing
Nepal	Panchayat 1960–90	Absolute monarchy	MONARCHY-RULING	1960–90	980 -> 1,315	1.0	Mass movement
Laos	Royal government 1953–75	Constitutional monarchy (weak)	FALLEN MONARCHY	1950–75	697 -> 999	1.5	Revolution
Laos	LPRP 1975– (post-1986 reform)	One-party	DICT.	1986–2022	1,409 -> 7,168	4.6	Continuing
Afghanistan	Zahir Shah 1933–73	Absolute -> semi-const. monarchy	FALLEN MONARCHY	1950–73	1,156 -> 1,011	-0.6	Palace coup
Malaysia	BN 1971–2018	Electoral authoritarian	DICT. (dominant party) under const. monarchy	1971–2018	3,475 -> 25,176	4.3	Electoral defeat
Japan	1947–	Constitutional monarchy, democracy	CONTRAST	1950–73	3,062 -> 18,226	8.1	Continuing
China	Mao 1949–76	Personalist one-party	DICT.	1950–76	799 -> 1,519	2.5	Death
China	Reform era 1978–2012	One-party developmental	DICT.	1978–2012	1,744 -> 10,947	5.6	Regular succession
Vietnam	Doi Moi 1986–	One-party developmental	DICT.	1986–2022	1,481 -> 8,050	4.8	Continuing
Spain	Franco technocratic 1959–75	Personalist w/ technocrats	DICT.	1959–75	5,079 -> 12,613	5.9	Death; monarchy restored
Portugal	Salazar 1933–68	Personalist corporatist	DICT.	1950–68	3,325 -> 7,767	4.8	Incapacity
Romania	Ceausescu 1965–89	Sultanistic personalist	DICT.	1965–80 / 1980–89	3,803 -> 6,592 -> 6,281	3.7 / -0.5	Revolution
Yugoslavia	Tito 1945–80	One-party personalist	DICT.	1950–80	2,276 -> 10,037	5.1	Death, then dissolution

Country	Regime-period	Type (Part II)	Marker	Growth window	GDPpc start -> end	CAGR %	End mode
Greece	Colonels 1967–74	Military dictatorship	DICT.	1967–74	7,892 -> 11,716	5.8	Collapse
Philippines (reference)	1950–86 incl. Marcos	Democracy -> personalist	reference	1950–86	1,706 -> 3,161	1.7	Revolt

The Philippines is not a coded case; it appears as the standard "most-similar" failure comparator for Korea and Taiwan (You 2014) [V].

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2. Asian case files

Each case records the twelve fields required by BRIEF Part IV: political structure; sources of legitimacy; economic starting conditions; resource endowments; state capacity; development trajectory; institutional quality; distribution of wealth; human development; political succession; regime continuity or transformation; long-term consequences.

2.1 Brunei: the surviving absolute monarchy

Political structure. Brunei is the clearest absolute monarchy in Asia. Sultan Hassanal Bolkiah (reigning since 5 October 1967) is simultaneously head of state, prime minister and, at various times, minister of defence, finance and foreign affairs [E]. The 1959 constitution, granted while Brunei was a British protected state, created a partly elected Legislative Council; the first and only general election (1962) was won by the Brunei People's Party (Partai Rakyat Brunei), whose leaders then launched an armed revolt in December 1962 when the Sultan moved towards joining Malaysia on terms they rejected [E]. British Gurkha and Commonwealth forces suppressed the revolt; the Sultan declared a state of emergency that has been renewed ever since, and elected representation was not restored [E]. Brunei did not join Malaysia (1963), partly over control of oil revenues and the Sultan's precedence among Malay rulers [E], and gained full independence on 1 January 1984. The Legislative Council is appointed. The heir, Crown Prince Al-Muhtadee Billah, holds the post of senior minister in the Prime Minister's Office [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Weber's traditional authority, formalised in the state ideology Melayu Islam Beraja (Malay Islamic Monarchy) adopted at independence [E]; religious authority, deepened by the phased Syariah Penal Code from 2014 and its full implementation in 2019 [E]; and performance legitimacy through the welfare state (no personal income tax, free health care and education, subsidised housing and fuel). The emergency powers are the residual coercive foundation.

Economic starting conditions. A small coastal sultanate whose territory had been reduced to two enclaves by the late nineteenth century; Shell's discovery of the Seria field in 1929 turned it into a petroleum economy before independence [E]. Population about 455,500 in 2024 [V IMF PR 26/300].

Resource endowments. Oil and liquefied natural gas. Total natural-resource rents averaged 40.7% of GDP in 1970–79, 35.8% in 1980–89, 30.9% in 2000–09 and 19.0% in 2015–21 [V WDI]. Oil production was 121,000 barrels a day in 2019, fell to 74,000 in 2023 in the IMF's 2024 series, and is projected at 109,000 in 2026 after new wells and the Hengyi refinery-petrochemical complex [V IMF 2024 Article IV excerpt; IMF PR 26/300]. Oil and gas revenue was 13.5% of GDP in FY2023 and 9.3% in FY2025 [V IMF PR 26/300].

State capacity. High administrative capacity for distribution (health, schooling, utilities) but narrow fiscal capacity: tax revenue was about 6% of GDP in FY2023/24 against an estimated emerging-market tax capacity of 19.3% [E IMF 2024 Article IV excerpt]. The Brunei Investment Agency manages external assets but publishes no audited accounts; its size is unverified. The currency board with Singapore (1:1 since 1967) imported monetary credibility rather than building it domestically; the IMF endorses it as a source of stability [V IMF PR 26/300].

Development trajectory. Brunei is the starkest case in this database of high income without growth. WDI real GDP per capita (constant 2015 US$) was 84,483 in 1980, 44,180 in 1990, 37,510 in 2000, 33,121 in 2010 and 28,646 in 2023 [V]; average real GDP growth was -1.8% a year in 1980–97 and 0.5% in 2010–19 [V WDI]. The fall partly reflects population growth and depletion against a fixed oil base, and partly the absence of a non-oil tradable sector. Since 2019 downstream petrochemicals have changed the export mix: non-oil-and-gas exports reached about 60% of goods exports in 2025 [E Brunei Department of Economic Planning and Statistics], though much of that is processed hydrocarbon. The non-hydrocarbon fiscal balance was -47.2% of non-oil GDP in FY2025, and the overall deficit was 18.9% of GDP [V IMF PR 26/300]. Wawasan Brunei 2035 (adopted 2008) is the long-term plan [E].

Institutional quality. No competitive elections, no independent legislature, a judiciary subordinate to royal prerogative, no free press. Corruption perceptions are moderate for the region (Transparency International scores in the 60s in the 2010s [E]). The dispute in 1998–2000 between the Sultan and his brother Prince Jefri, a former finance minister and head of the Brunei Investment Agency, over losses then widely reported at around US$15 billion [E, figure unverified], is the case's best-documented example of royal-family capture of sovereign assets.

Distribution of wealth. Unknown in official statistics: Brunei publishes no Gini coefficient and is absent from WDI's poverty series [V, no data in pull]. Benefits are distributed through public-sector employment (citizens overwhelmingly work for the state [E]) and universal subsidies. The large non-citizen workforce receives fewer benefits.

Human development. HDI 0.781 (1990) -> 0.792 (2000) -> 0.837 (2023), rank 60 [V UNDP]. Life expectancy 58.7 (1960) -> 71.6 (1990) -> 75.3 (2023) [V WDI]. The slow HDI gain since 1990 (about 0.06 in 33 years, against 0.20 for Korea) tracks the income stagnation.

Political succession. Hereditary, orderly so far: Omar Ali Saifuddien III abdicated in favour of his son in 1967 and continued to advise him until his death in 1986 [E]. The crown prince has been visibly prepared. The commission's question about a weaker successor (BRIEF Part V.7) has not been tested since 1967.

Regime continuity or transformation. Continuity for 64 years under emergency rule. No significant open opposition has existed since the 1960s.

Long-term consequences. Brunei shows that hereditary rule with large rents can deliver stability and comfortable welfare to a small citizen population, but also that the same structure did not diversify the economy, broaden the tax base or produce growth for four decades. The IMF's 2026 call for a "non-hydrocarbon fiscal anchor" and for private-sector-led investment [V IMF PR 26/300] is, in effect, a call to build the institutions the absolute monarchy has not needed. (Interpretation: Brunei fits Herb 1999's dynastic-monarchy logic only loosely: power is concentrated in one ruler rather than shared across a large ruling family; the stability mechanism is closer to the rentier bargain of Beblawi and Luciani 1987.)

2.2 Thailand: from absolute to constitutional monarchy, with soldiers in between

Political structure. The absolute monarchy ended with the revolution of 24 June 1932 [E], before this database's window. From 1946, under King Bhumibol Adulyadej (reigned 1946–2016) and King Maha Vajiralongkorn (from 2016), Thailand has been formally a constitutional monarchy. In practice it is the region's most coup-prone state: successful coups in 1947, 1951, 1957, 1958, 1971, 1976, 1977, 1991, 2006 and 2014 [E], and roughly twenty constitutions since 1932 [E]. The database therefore codes thirteen regime-periods under a single, continuous throne (see CSV). The monarch's political role grew from near-irrelevance under Phibun (1948–57) to a central arbiter after Field Marshal Sarit (1957–63) revived royal ceremony as a source of legitimacy for military rule (interpretation: Thak 1979; Handley 2006). McCargo (2005) calls the resulting structure "network monarchy": palace-linked figures, notably General Prem Tinsulanonda (prime minister 1980–88, then Privy Council president), coordinated the army, bureaucracy and judiciary.

Sources of legitimacy. A triad of "nation, religion, king"; military claims to guard the throne; performance claims by juntas (order, anti-corruption, anti-communism); and, intermittently, electoral mandates, most strongly Thaksin Shinawatra's in 2001 and 2005. The lèse-majesté law (Article 112 of the Criminal Code) protects the royal pillar and has been used heavily since 2020 [E].

Economic starting conditions. Never colonised; rice-exporting agrarian economy; Maddison GDPpc 1,302 in 1950, below the Philippines (1,706) [V].

Resource endowments. Modest: rents averaged 1.8% of GDP in the 1970s and 2.5% in 2000–09 [V WDI] (Gulf of Thailand gas from the 1980s). Thailand is a resource-poor case.

State capacity. Strong macroeconomic technocracy: the Bank of Thailand, the Budget Bureau and the National Economic and Social Development Board (founded 1959 under Sarit) kept inflation low for most of the period (interpretation: Doner 2009, who nonetheless argues Thailand lacked the capacity for upgrading industrial policy that Korea and Taiwan had). Weak capacity in tax collection and in decentralised service delivery until the 2000s.

Development trajectory. Steady rather than spectacular. Maddison CAGR: 3.7% (1950–73), 5.2% (1976–88), 5.7% (1988–97), 2.3% (2006–14), 3.0% (2014–19), -1.0% (2019–22) [V]. The fastest growth (1986–96) came under elected or semi-elected governments and foreign direct investment after the 1985 Plaza Accord; the 1997 crisis cut GDP by 7.6% in 1998 [V WDI]. Growth after the 2006 and 2014 coups was lower than in any previous decade, which is evidence against the claim that military government restores developmental discipline, though world conditions (2008–09, COVID-19) confound it.

Institutional quality. Courts and independent agencies became political actors after 2006: the Constitutional Court dissolved ruling or opposition parties in 2007, 2008, 2020 and 2024, and removed Prime Ministers Samak (2008), Srettha (August 2024) and Paetongtarn (August 2025) [E]. The 2017 constitution let a junta-appointed Senate vote for prime minister (removed by later amendment) [E].

Distribution of wealth. Gini 33.3 (2024) [V WDI], down from the mid-40s in the early 1990s [E]. Regional inequality between Bangkok and the north-east underlay the 2006–14 polarisation. Crown property, legally transferred to the king's personal control in 2017–18 [E], is one of the largest private fortunes in Asia; its value is unverified.

Human development. Life expectancy 50.6 (1960) -> 68.9 (1990) -> 76.4 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.584 (1990) -> 0.798 (2023) [V UNDP]. Universal health coverage (the "30-baht scheme", 2002) was introduced by an elected government [E].

Political succession. Royal succession in 2016 was orderly but followed a seventy-year reign; the new reign brought more direct royal control over palace agencies, crown assets and two army units [E]. Executive succession has been irregular: coups, judicial removals and negotiated exits.

Regime continuity or transformation. As of November 2026: an elected coalition under Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul. His Bhumjaithai Party won 192 of 500 seats in the 8 February 2026 election, the People's Party 120 and Pheu Thai 74 [V The Diplomat, 29 Sep 2026]; Anutin was re-elected prime minister on 19 March 2026 with 293 votes [E Thai government PRD]. The Constitutional Court dismissed a petition to annul the election on 28 September 2026 [V]. A same-day referendum approved drafting a new constitution (about 60% yes in partial counts) [E]. A border war with Cambodia in July and December 2025 ended with a ceasefire on 27 December 2025 and remains unresolved [E ICG 2026].

Long-term consequences. Thailand is the main Asian case where a constitutional monarchy with reserve influence coexisted with recurrent military rule. The monarchy provided continuity of the state across fourteen coups but also gave the army a legitimating partner, reducing the cost of overthrowing elected governments (interpretation: Hewison and Kitirianglarp 2010; McCargo 2005). The result is middle-income stagnation with an unresolved conflict over who rules, not an East Asian developmental state.

2.3 Cambodia: five regimes and two monarchies

Political structure. Five distinct regimes since independence (9 November 1953): (i) Norodom Sihanouk's rule, first as king (to March 1955, when he abdicated in favour of his father to enter politics), then as leader of the Sangkum Reastr Niyum movement, which won every National Assembly seat in 1955–66, and from 1960 as head of state [E]; (ii) the Khmer Republic of Lon Nol after the March 1970 coup, which abolished the monarchy in October 1970 [E]; (iii) Democratic Kampuchea under Pol Pot's Communist Party of Kampuchea, April 1975 to January 1979; (iv) the People's Republic of Kampuchea (renamed State of Cambodia in 1989), installed by Vietnam's invasion; (v) the restored Kingdom of Cambodia after the 1991 Paris Peace Agreements and the 1993 UN-run election, with Sihanouk again king (1993–2004), then King Norodom Sihamoni. Real power since 1997 has belonged to Hun Sen (prime minister 1985–2023) and the Cambodian People's Party, which won all 125 National Assembly seats in 2018 after the Supreme Court dissolved the main opposition party in 2017 [E]. In

August 2023 Hun Sen handed the premiership to his son Hun Manet and became Senate president, a post from which he has acted as head of state in the king's absence [E Phnom Penh Post, June 2026].

Sources of legitimacy. Sihanouk: royal charisma and anti-colonial nationalism. Khmer Rouge: revolutionary ideology and xenophobic nationalism. PRK: liberation from genocide (7 January is still a national holiday). Hun Sen era: peace and stability after three decades of war, growth, patronage, and the ceremonial endorsement of a restored monarchy. Hun Manet: inherited party machinery plus a technocratic image (foreign-educated) and, since 2025, wartime nationalism.

Economic starting conditions. Agrarian rice and rubber economy, Maddison GDPpc 768 in 1950 [V], with low literacy and a small French-trained elite.

Resource endowments. Limited: rents averaged 2.6% of GDP in 2000–09 [V WDI]. Offshore oil discovered in the 2000s yielded little. Land and timber concessions have been the main rent source and a recurrent source of elite enrichment and dispossession [E].

State capacity. Destroyed twice: by the Khmer Rouge, who abolished money, markets, schools and cities and killed most of the educated class, and by the subsequent civil war. Since 1993 capacity has been rebuilt with heavy donor finance, but the state works through patronage networks centred on the ruling family and allied tycoons ("oknha") [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR: 1.5% (1955–70), -2.2% (1970–75), 0.3% (1979–93), 3.7% (1993–2022) [V]. Real GDP growth averaged 9.5% a year in 1998–2007 and 7.6% in 2010–19 [V WDI], driven by garment exports, tourism and Chinese investment. Pre-1979 national-accounts figures are reconstructions.

Institutional quality. Low. A hegemonic party with no meaningful electoral competition since 2017, captured courts, and documented large-scale online-scam compounds that became an international enforcement issue in 2024–26 [E].

Distribution of wealth. No recent WDI Gini in the pull [V]. Land concentration through economic land concessions is well documented [E]. Poverty fell substantially after 2004 by the World Bank's national measures [E].

Human development. Life expectancy 42.1 (1960), modelled at 12.8 in the genocide year 1975, 55.2 (1990), 70.7 (2023) [V WDI]. HDI 0.387 (1990) -> 0.606 (2023), rank 151 [V UNDP]. The Khmer Rouge period caused about 1.7 million deaths, 21% of the 1975 population (Yale Genocide Studies Program; Kiernan's range 1.671–1.871 million, 21–24%) [E]; a 2009 UN demographic expert report for the Extraordinary Chambers gives a central estimate of 2.18 million (1.75–2.5 million) [E].

Political succession. Every transfer before 2023 was violent or externally imposed: coup (1970), conquest (1975), invasion (1979), internationally brokered settlement (1991–93), factional fighting (1997). The 2023 handover from father to son was peaceful and pre-arranged, a family succession inside a nominally republican party structure under a ceremonial king. This is the clearest case in the sample of a dictatorship adopting hereditary succession without becoming a monarchy.

Regime continuity or transformation. The Cambodian People's Party has held power continuously since 1979, nearly 48 years, through four constitutional forms. The 2025 border war with Thailand (fighting on 24–28 July and from 7 December 2025, ceasefire on 27 December 2025) left Thai forces holding most contested areas and about 8,000 Cambodians still displaced in November 2026 [E Anadolu, citing the Cambodian Defence Ministry; ICG 2026].

Long-term consequences. Cambodia shows how far a state can fall when concentrated power is captured by an ideological faction (1975–79), and how a later regime can build legitimacy on having ended that catastrophe. The restored monarchy has been a symbol of national continuity with no capacity to restrain the ruling party. Growth since 1993 is real but rests on low-wage manufacturing and Chinese capital, with weak institutions (interpretation: Strangio 2014; Un 2019).

2.4 Indonesia: Sukarno's Guided Democracy and Suharto's New Order

Political structure. After independence (proclaimed 1945, recognised by the Netherlands in December 1949) Indonesia had a parliamentary democracy (1950–59) with fragmented cabinets and one free national election

(1955) [E]. Sukarno restored the presidential 1945 constitution by decree in July 1959 and ruled as a personalist leader balancing the army and the Indonesian Communist Party (PKI) under "Guided Democracy" [E]. After the abortive 30 September 1965 movement, the army under Major General Suharto destroyed the PKI; mass killings in 1965–66 are commonly estimated at around 500,000 deaths, with scholarly ranges from roughly 200,000 to over a million [E; Robinson 2018]. Suharto received executive authority through the Supersemar order of 11 March 1966 and became president in 1967–68 [E]. The New Order was a military-backed personalist regime with an electoral façade: the regime vehicle Golkar won every election from 1971 to 1997 with 62–74% of the vote [E], the armed forces held appointed parliamentary seats under the dwifungsi (dual function) doctrine, and only two other parties were permitted after 1973.

Sources of legitimacy. Sukarno: charismatic nationalism (revolutionary leader, proclaimer of independence) and the Pancasila state ideology. Suharto: restoration of order after the 1965 crisis, anti-communism, and above all developmental performance ("Bapak Pembangunan", Father of Development). Western and Japanese backing through the Inter-Governmental Group on Indonesia (from 1967) supplied external legitimacy and finance [E].

Economic starting conditions. Poor and devastated by occupation and revolution: Maddison GDPpc 1,280 in 1950, below its 1938 level (1,655) [V]. Literacy was low, and Dutch firms were nationalised in 1957–58. By 1965–66 the economy was in collapse: GDPpc fell slightly over 1959–66 (CAGR -0.3%) [V Maddison], and inflation reached several hundred per cent in 1965–66 (commonly cited at about 600% in 1966) [E].

Resource endowments. Oil, gas, timber, tin, copper and coal. Resource rents averaged 14.6% of GDP in the 1970s and 14.2% in the 1980s [V WDI]; Indonesia was an OPEC member and received large windfalls in 1973–74 and 1979–81.

State capacity. Sukarno's state was weak and inflationary. Suharto delegated macroeconomic policy to a team of University of Indonesia economists trained at Berkeley (Widjojo Nitisastro, Ali Wardhana and colleagues), who stabilised prices, adopted a balanced-budget rule (1967) and an open capital account, and steered the response to falling oil prices after 1982 by devaluations and deregulation (interpretation: Hill 1996; MacIntyre 2003). Bappenas (the planning board) produced five-year plans (Repelita). Capacity was strong at the macro centre and weak and corrupt in implementation, with the national oil company Pertamina's near-default in 1975 (debts of about US$10 billion, commonly cited [E]) as an early warning.

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 3.9% over 1966–98 (1,535 -> 5,204) [V]; WDI real GDP growth averaged 5.5% (1961–79) and 6.3% (1980–97) [V]. Indonesia avoided the classic Dutch disease better than Nigeria, its standard comparator, by recycling oil revenue into rice self-sufficiency (achieved briefly in 1984), fertiliser subsidies, rural roads and the 1973 INPRES primary-school building programme, and by devaluing the rupiah to keep non-oil exports competitive (interpretation: Bevan, Collier and Gunning 1999; Duflo 2001 on INPRES schools). Export-oriented manufacturing grew after 1986. The model then failed in the Asian financial crisis: GDP fell 13.1% in 1998 [V WDI], and Maddison GDPpc fell from 6,056 in 1997 to 5,204 in 1998 [V].

Institutional quality. Low and personalised. By the 1990s Suharto's children and associated conglomerates held monopolies and licences (cloves, toll roads, the national car project) [E]. Transparency International ranked Indonesia among the most corrupt countries in its 1990s indices [E]. Courts and the legislature were subordinate.

Distribution of wealth. Measured consumption inequality stayed moderate (Gini in the low-to-mid 30s) through the New Order [E], and poverty fell substantially by national measures, partly because growth was rural and labour-intensive. Wealth concentrated heavily at the top among Chinese-Indonesian conglomerates and the ruling family [E]. Gini was 34.4 in 2025 [V WDI].

Human development. Life expectancy 46.8 (1960) -> 56.0 (1975) -> 63.2 (1990) -> 71.1 (2023) [V WDI]. HDI 0.531 (1990) -> 0.728 (2023), rank 113 [V UNDP]. Mass primary schooling was a genuine New Order achievement.

Political succession. Not institutionalised. Suharto was re-elected by the appointed People's Consultative Assembly seven times and named no credible successor; his March 1998 cabinet included his daughter and close cronies [E]. When the crisis hit, he resigned on 21 May 1998 after riots, student occupation of parliament and the defection of ministers and the armed forces leadership [E].

Regime continuity or transformation. Transformation to electoral democracy (1999 free elections; direct presidential elections from 2004; removal of military seats by 2004). Since October 2024 the president has been Prabowo Subianto, a former New Order general and Suharto's former son-in-law; debate about democratic

backsliding (an expanded military role in civilian posts under the 2025 revision of the armed forces law; large protests in August 2025) is ongoing [E].

Long-term consequences. The New Order is the strongest Southeast Asian case for "growth under resource-rich authoritarianism", but its gains came from a technocratic enclave protected by the ruler, which the ruler also undermined by licensing family rent-seeking. The regime did not build institutions that outlived Suharto. (Interpretation: Slater 2010 attributes the New Order's durability to "protection pacts" forged in the 1965 crisis; MacIntyre 2003 attributes the 1997–98 collapse to the concentration of veto power in one person, which made policy credible when he was committed and incredible once markets doubted him.) Indonesia is also a Part XI case, handled elsewhere in the project.

2.5 South Korea: Rhee, Park, Chun, and the 2024 test

Political structure. Syngman Rhee (1948–60) ruled through a formally democratic constitution that he amended twice to extend his tenure; he rigged the March 1960 election and was overthrown by the April 1960 student revolution [E; You 2014 V]. The Second Republic (Chang Myon, 1960–61) was a weak parliamentary democracy. Major General Park Chung-hee's junta took power on 16 May 1961, civilianised in 1963 through elections Park won, and in October 1972 replaced competitive presidential elections with the Yushin constitution: indirect election by a hand-picked conference, presidential power to appoint a third of the National Assembly, and emergency decrees [E]. Park was shot dead by his intelligence chief on 26 October 1979. General Chun Doo-hwan seized power through a December 1979 mutiny and the May 1980 crackdown, including the Gwangju massacre [E]. Mass protests in June 1987 forced the June 29 declaration of direct presidential elections; democracy has held since 1988.

Sources of legitimacy. Rhee: anti-colonial credentials and anti-communism. Park: national security against the North, anti-corruption (initially), and above all growth, the "miracle on the Han". Chun: order and economic stabilisation. In every period the US alliance was the external guarantor.

Economic starting conditions. Among the poorest economies in the world after the Korean War: Maddison GDPpc 998 in 1950 and 1,548 in 1960 [V], below the Philippines (2,353 in 1960) [V]. Assets: unusually high literacy and school enrolment for its income level; a colonial legacy of infrastructure and some Korean industrial experience (Kohli 2004 emphasises this; others dispute its weight); and an exceptionally equal distribution after land reform.

Resource endowments. Negligible: rents below 0.5% of GDP throughout [V WDI]. Korea is a resource-poor case, which removes the rentier explanation entirely.

State capacity. Built incrementally, contrary to the common story that it began with Park. By 1960 about 80% of senior civil servants had been promoted from within, and entry by the competitive higher civil service examination (haengsi) rose from 4.7% of Grade III-B recruits in 1948–52 to 48.3% in 1953–59, then fell under the junta (38.3% in 1964) before rising to 55–65% in 1966–87 [V You 2014, Table 6]. Park's innovations were the Economic Planning Board (1961), with its head a deputy prime minister; the nationalisation of commercial banks (1961), which gave the state control of credit; monthly export-promotion meetings chaired by the president; and the 1970s heavy and chemical industries drive (interpretation: Amsden 1989; Haggard 1990; Woo 1991).

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 2.3% under Rhee (1953–60), 7.9% under Park (1961–79), 9.0% under Chun (1980–88), 3.7% in the democratic period (1988–2022) [V]. WDI real GDP growth averaged 10.1% (1961–79) and 8.8% (1980–97) [V]. Exports rose from about 3% of GDP in 1960 to 28% in 1980 [V WDI]. The turn to exports had three authors: the United States, which cut aid and pressed for devaluation and a unified exchange rate; the democratic Chang Myon government, which devalued from 65 to 130 won per dollar in January–February 1961; and Park, who at first pursued capital-intensive import substitution and returned to multiple exchange rates in 1961–63, and committed to export promotion only in 1964–65 after a crop failure weakened his position [V Irwin 2025]. The 1979–80 crisis (GDP -1.5% in 1980) [V WDI] followed over-investment in heavy industry and the second oil shock; the 1997–98 crisis (GDP -4.9% in 1998) [V WDI] occurred under democracy and was linked to the chaebol debt structure built under authoritarian credit allocation.

Institutional quality. Under Park: a meritocratic economic bureaucracy alongside pervasive political corruption, with rents allocated through cheap credit in exchange for export performance and political contributions [V You 2014]. The discipline came from export targets: firms that missed them lost credit (Amsden 1989's "reciprocity").

Corruption indicators improved after democratisation: the share of public officials among all indicted persons fell from 0.20% in the 1950s to 0.02% in the 2000s [V You 2014, Table 7]. Two former military presidents, Chun and Roh Tae-woo, were convicted in 1996 [E].

Distribution of wealth. Land reform, in two stages (the US military government's 1948 distribution of former Japanese land and the Rhee government's 1950 Land Reform Act, with a three-hectare ceiling), plus landlords' own pre-emptive sales, transferred 52% of cultivated land; tenancy fell from 49% to 7% of farm households and land under tenancy from 65% to 18% by 1956; the land Gini fell from 0.73 (c.1945) to about 0.38 (c.1960) [V You 2014]. The income Gini was 0.34 in 1953 and 0.32–0.33 in 1961–64 [V You 2014]. The chaebol later concentrated industrial wealth. Gini 32.9 in 2021 [V WDI].

Human development. Life expectancy 53.8 (1960) -> 64.2 (1975) -> 71.6 (1990) -> 83.4 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.738 (1990) -> 0.937 (2023), rank 20 [V UNDP]. The authoritarian era also involved serious repression: imprisonment and torture of dissidents, the 1974–75 People's Revolutionary Party executions, and Gwangju in 1980 [E].

Political succession. None of the authoritarian rulers was succeeded by an institutional mechanism: Rhee was overthrown, Park assassinated, and Chun's handover to his co-conspirator Roh came through the 1987 democratic election, which Roh won because the opposition split. The developmental state's continuity lay in the bureaucracy and the chaebol, not in the ruler.

Regime continuity or transformation. Transformation to stable democracy, tested on 3 December 2024 when President Yoon Suk Yeol declared martial law, which the National Assembly voted down within about six hours [E]. Yoon was impeached and removed (April 2025), Lee Jae-myung was elected in June 2025 [E], and on 19 February 2026 the Seoul Central District Court sentenced Yoon to life imprisonment for leading an insurrection [E Reuters; Korea Herald]. The appeal verdict is scheduled for 26 January 2027 [E Yonhap, 5 Nov 2026].

Long-term consequences. Korea is the central case for "developmental authoritarianism", and the strongest version of the claim (Park's decisiveness made the miracle) has to accommodate five facts recorded here: land reform and civil-service meritocracy began before Park; US leverage forced the export turn; a democratic government began the key exchange-rate reform; the authoritarian credit model generated the crises of 1979–80 and, through its legacy, 1997; and growth continued at high-income-convergence rates under democracy. (Interpretation: Kang 2002 calls the Park system a "mutual hostage" relationship between a strong state and strong chaebol that limited predation; Haggard 2018 argues the developmental state was a product of specific external and class conditions, not of regime type.)

2.6 Taiwan: the Kuomintang party-state

Political structure. After defeat on the mainland, the Nationalist government of Chiang Kai-shek moved to Taiwan in 1949 with about 2 million soldiers, officials and refugees [V You 2014]. Martial law, declared in May 1949, lasted until July 1987, 38 years [V You 2014]. The Kuomintang (KMT) was a Leninist party-state: party cells in the army, bureaucracy and schools; a national legislature elected on the mainland in 1947–48 and frozen in office until 1991; and local elections from the 1950s that let Taiwanese politicians compete below the national level [E]. Chiang Kai-shek ruled until his death in 1975; his son Chiang Ching-kuo was premier from 1972 and president 1978–88, then lifted martial law, tolerated the founding of the Democratic Progressive Party (1986), and named the Taiwanese Lee Teng-hui as vice-president [E]. Lee completed democratisation (full legislative elections 1992; direct presidential election 1996).

Sources of legitimacy. Claim to be the legitimate government of all China; anti-communism and the existential threat of invasion; US recognition (until 1979) and the Mutual Defence Treaty (1954–79); developmental performance; and, after 1987, democratic legitimacy.

Economic starting conditions. A Japanese colony with good rural infrastructure, high agricultural productivity and widespread primary schooling; postwar disruption, the 1947 February 28 Incident (an uprising against corrupt KMT rule, brutally suppressed) and hyperinflation in 1949 [V You 2014; E]. Maddison GDPpc 1,460 in 1950 [V].

Resource endowments. Negligible. A resource-poor case.

State capacity. High and rising. The share of government employees recruited through civil-service examination rose from 10.8% (1954) to 25.8% (1962), 35.5% (1972) and 45.3% (1980) [V You 2014, citing Clark 2000]. Economic

policy was run by a small group of engineers and economists (K. Y. Yin, K. T. Li) in the Council for US Aid, later the Council for International Economic Cooperation and Development (interpretation: Wade 1990, "governed market"). Large upstream firms were state-owned; the private sector was dominated by small and medium enterprises, many owned by native Taiwanese, which also insulated a mainlander-dominated state from business capture [V You 2014].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc rose from 1,460 (1950) to 13,705 (1987), a CAGR of 6.2% and a 9.4-fold increase in 37 years [V], the fastest sustained authoritarian-era growth in this database. Growth continued at 4.0% a year under democracy (1987–2022, 13,705 -> 53,143) [V]. US economic aid of about US$1.465 billion in 1951–65 financed a large share of imports and investment in the 1950s [E CGIAR/IFPRI chapter excerpt; also Jacoby 1966]. Export orientation followed the 1958–60 foreign-exchange reforms and the 1960 Statute for the Encouragement of Investment, and the Kaohsiung export processing zone opened in 1966 [E].

Institutional quality. Under martial law: political repression ("White Terror", with thousands imprisoned and executed [E]), no free press, no national competition. But the economic bureaucracy was relatively clean: Taiwan scored 6.0 on Transparency International's historical corruption index for 1980–85, against 3.9 for Korea and 1.0 for the Philippines (0 = most corrupt, 10 = least) [V You 2014, Table 1]. Corruption ("black gold" politics) rose with local-level clientelism during democratisation, and fell again with prosecutions after 2000 [V You 2014].

Distribution of wealth. Land reform in three stages: rents capped at 37.5% of the main crop (1949), sale of former Japanese public land to tenants (from 1951), and the compulsory "land-to-the-tiller" purchase and resale (1953), which transferred about 143,568 chia (roughly 139,000 hectares) to 194,823 farm households [V Kim and Wang 2026]. Tenant families fell from 38% of farm families in 1950 to 15% in 1960 [V You 2014]. The income Gini fell from 0.57 in 1953 to 0.33 in 1964 [V You 2014]. Landlords were compensated partly with shares in state enterprises, converting a landed elite into a minority industrial one.

Human development. Taiwan is absent from WDI and UNDP's main tables; its government's own HDI-equivalent estimates place it among very-high-development economies [E]. Life expectancy and schooling rose in step with Korea's [E].

Political succession. Family succession from Chiang Kai-shek to Chiang Ching-kuo (1975–78), mediated by the party; then institutional succession to a non-family Taiwanese successor chosen by Chiang Ching-kuo, followed by democratisation. Taiwan is the clearest case in which an authoritarian ruler used his authority to build an institutional exit (interpretation: Slater and Wong 2013, "conceding to thrive": dominant parties that are strong democratise from a position of strength).

Regime continuity or transformation. Transformation without rupture: the KMT lost the presidency in 2000, regained it in 2008 and lost it in 2016, and has competed as a democratic party since.

Long-term consequences. Taiwan pairs the best authoritarian-era economic record with the smoothest authoritarian exit. The Kim and Wang (2026) working paper is an important corrective: using digitised township data and variation across the two redistribution phases, it finds that land reform raised GDP per worker by only about 5.7% over 1956–66; that the land-to-the-tiller phase did not raise rice yields; and that public-land redistribution explains about a sixth of 1950–61 yield growth, with fertiliser and new varieties more important [V]. If correct, land reform's main role was political (dissolving the landlord class and making the state autonomous, as You 2014 argues), not a direct productivity engine. Neither reading attributes the outcome to authoritarianism as such.

2.7 Singapore: the technocratic dominant party

Political structure. A parliamentary republic in which the People's Action Party (PAP) has won every general election since self-government in 1959. Lee Kuan Yew was prime minister from 1959 to 1990 (through merger with Malaysia, 1963, and expulsion, 9 August 1965); Goh Chok Tong 1990–2004; Lee Hsien Loong (Lee Kuan Yew's son) 2004–May 2024; Lawrence Wong since May 2024 [E]. Elections are regular and votes are counted honestly, but the playing field is tilted by group representation constituencies, defamation suits against opposition figures, detention without trial under the Internal Security Act in earlier decades (Operation Coldstore 1963; Operation Spectrum 1987), control of the media and of grassroots bodies [E]. Levitsky and Way (2010) leave Singapore out of their competitive-authoritarian universe because competition was too constrained [E]; others call

it a hybrid, "soft authoritarian" or dominant-party state. This database codes it as electoral authoritarianism with a technocratic character. In the May 2025 general election the PAP won 65.6% of the vote [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Performance and meritocracy: the founding story of a vulnerable city-state without a hinterland, made rich by competent government. Also ethnic peace among Chinese, Malay and Indian communities, and clean government.

Economic starting conditions. An entrepôt with a deep-water port, British naval base and commercial institutions. Maddison GDPpc 3,572 in 1950 and 3,991 in 1965 [V], already well above the regional average. Unemployment and the 1968–71 British military withdrawal were the main threats.

Resource endowments. None (rents about 0% of GDP) [V WDI]. Singapore imports water and energy.

State capacity. Very high: a small, highly paid, rigorously selected civil service; the Economic Development Board (1961); the Housing and Development Board (1960), which made most citizens homeowners; the Central Provident Fund (forced saving); and sovereign investors GIC and Temasek [E]. Singapore has led the World Bank's government-effectiveness rankings for decades [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 7.2% (1965–90; 3,991 -> 22,666) and 4.0% (1990–2022; 22,666 -> 80,320) [V]. Exports equalled 126% of GDP in 1970, 202% in 1980 and 180% in 2023 [V WDI], reflecting a strategy of attracting multinational corporations rather than building national champions (interpretation: Huff 1994; Rodan 1989).

Institutional quality. Very low corruption, efficient courts for commercial matters, strong property rights for investors; restricted civil liberties, press freedom and opposition space. Singapore is the main empirical argument that state capacity and political pluralism can come apart (BRIEF Part V.6).

Distribution of wealth. Market-income inequality is high for a rich country (official household Gini around 0.43–0.46 before transfers in the 2010s [E]; WDI has no series [V]); public housing and transfers narrow it. Large non-citizen low-wage workforce.

Human development. Life expectancy 65.6 (1960) -> 75.3 (1990) -> 83.1 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.946 (2023), rank 13 [V UNDP].

Political succession. Institutionalised through the party: three leadership transitions (1990, 2004, 2024) were planned and peaceful. One of them (2004) placed the founder's son in office, but through party selection and parliamentary majority rather than hereditary right.

Regime continuity or transformation. Continuity for 67 years with gradual liberalisation of electoral competition.

Long-term consequences. Singapore is the strongest single case for technocratic authoritarianism and the hardest to generalise: a city-state of about 6 million with no rural poor, no landed class, a strategic port and British institutions. Its success owes more to the quality of its institutions (meritocratic service, rule of law for business, forced saving, public housing) than to the restriction of political competition, and those institutions have survived the founder. Whether they require one-party dominance is an open question; the PAP's falling vote share since 2011 is being absorbed without regime change.

2.8 North Korea: the dynastic dictatorship

Political structure. A one-party state under the Workers' Party of Korea (WPK), ruled by three generations of one family: Kim Il Sung (1948–94), Kim Jong Il (1994–2011) and Kim Jong Un (since December 2011). It is coded as a personalist one-party dictatorship, not a monarchy: succession has been hereditary in fact but is legitimated through party and state organs, not by a law of succession. Kim Jong Un was re-elected WPK general secretary at the Ninth Party Congress (19–25 February 2026) [E Reuters; Yonhap]; revised party rules adopted there gave the general secretary explicit powers to convene the Politburo and appoint and dismiss key officials [E Reuters report of a South Korean intelligence-affiliated institute, Sept 2026].

Sources of legitimacy. Anti-Japanese guerrilla mythology of the founder; the Juche (self-reliance) ideology; a cult of the "Paektu bloodline"; nationalism against the US and South Korea; and, since 2006, nuclear weapons as proof of sovereignty.

Economic starting conditions. At partition the North held most of colonial Korea's heavy industry and hydroelectric power [E]. Maddison's 1938 estimate for the North (2,557) exceeds the South's (1,935) [V], and most specialists believe the North led the South in output per head into the 1960s (estimates unverified; Maddison has no North Korean series between 1950 and 1989).

Resource endowments. Coal, iron ore, magnesite, rare earths; no WDI rents series. Mineral exports to China became the main hard-currency source before UN sanctions (2016–17) [E].

State capacity. High coercive and mobilisational capacity; low capacity for economic coordination after Soviet subsidies ended in 1990–91. The public distribution system collapsed in the mid-1990s [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc 2,456 (1990) -> 1,605 (1997) -> 1,580 (1998) -> 1,795 (2008) -> 1,569 (2022) [V], a 36% fall in the 1990s and no recovery since. The famine of 1994–98 caused an estimated 600,000 to one million excess deaths (Haggard and Noland 2007) [E]. Informal markets (jangmadang) became the main source of household food after the famine; the state has alternately tolerated and repressed them.

Institutional quality. Among the lowest anywhere: no independent courts, no civil liberties, a songbun caste-like loyalty classification, political prison camps documented by the 2014 UN Commission of Inquiry [E].

Distribution of wealth. No data. Pyongyang's elite and a market-linked "donju" class versus a rural population exposed to chronic food insecurity [E].

Human development. Not in UNDP's HDI table [V]. UN agencies have reported chronic malnutrition and stunting [E].

Political succession. Two hereditary handovers (1994, 2011), each prepared over years, each followed by purges (most visibly the 2013 execution of Kim Jong Un's uncle Jang Song Thaek and the 2017 assassination of his half-brother Kim Jong Nam [E]). Succession was stable in the narrow sense that the regime survived.

Regime continuity or transformation. Continuity for 78 years: the longest-lived dictatorship in the sample.

Long-term consequences. North Korea is the sample's decisive counter-case to the claim that a long planning horizon, which hereditary rule is said to create, leads to development. The rulers had the longest horizon in the sample and the most concentrated authority, and the economy fell further behind its natural comparator (South Korea, from the same starting point) than any other pair in modern history. The horizon was used for regime and dynastic survival, not national income (interpretation: Haggard and Noland 2007; Lankov 2013).

2.9 Nepal: from absolute monarchy to republic (1951–2008) and the 2025–26 upheaval

Political structure. The hereditary Rana prime-ministerial oligarchy, which had reduced the Shah kings to figureheads since 1846, was overthrown in 1951 with Indian support and King Tribhuvan restored [E]. After a transitional period and Nepal's first general election (1959), King Mahendra dismissed the elected Nepali Congress government of B. P. Koirala in December 1960, banned parties and introduced the Panchayat system (1962): a partyless hierarchy of indirectly elected councils under royal direction [E]. This is coded as absolute monarchy. King Birendra (1972–2001) continued it, survived a 1980 referendum (Panchayat 54.8% against multiparty 45.2% [E]) and conceded a constitutional monarchy after the 1990 People's Movement. A Maoist insurgency began in 1996 and cost about 17,000 lives by 2006 [E]. On 1 June 2001 Crown Prince Dipendra killed King Birendra and eight other royals, then himself, according to the official inquiry [E]; Gyanendra became king, dismissed the elected prime minister in October 2002 and seized full power in February 2005. The April 2006 People's Movement forced him to restore parliament; the Constituent Assembly abolished the monarchy on 28 May 2008 [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Hindu kingship (the king as an incarnation of Vishnu in popular belief) and national unity in a multi-ethnic state; the monarchy as a buffer between India and China. After 1990 these eroded, and the 2001 massacre and Gyanendra's 2005 coup destroyed what remained.

Economic starting conditions. Isolated, mountainous and very poor: Maddison GDPpc 802 (1950) [V]; life expectancy 38.7 (1960) [V WDI]; adult literacy very low.

Resource endowments. Hydropower potential and little else; rents 3.5% of GDP in the 1970s [V WDI]. Remittances later became the main external income.

State capacity. Weak throughout: a Kathmandu-centred administration dominated by high-caste groups, with limited presence in the hills and the Tarai [E].

Development trajectory. The Panchayat monarchy presided over three decades of near-stagnation: Maddison GDPpc CAGR 1.0% (1960–90; 980 -> 1,315) [V]; WDI real GDP growth averaged 2.6% a year in 1961–79 [V], roughly the rate of population growth. Growth was faster after 1990 (2.4% per head, 1990–2008) and in the republic (2.9%, 2008–22) [V Maddison], though both include remittance-financed consumption.

Institutional quality. Under the Panchayat, patronage around the palace and a ban on parties; after 2008, unstable coalition politics, with 14 prime ministers in the first 18 years of the republic [E Al Jazeera, March 2026].

Distribution of wealth. Caste, ethnic and regional inequality was the Maoists' recruiting ground. Gini 30.0 (2022) [V WDI].

Human development. Life expectancy 38.7 (1960) -> 54.8 (1990) -> 70.4 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.404 (1990) -> 0.622 (2023), rank 145 [V UNDP]. Most of the gain came after the absolute monarchy ended.

Political succession. Hereditary succession worked mechanically in 1955 and 1972; it failed catastrophically in 2001, when the heir killed the reigning family, and politically in 2001–08, when the successor (Gyanendra) was unpopular, contested and inclined to rule directly. Nepal is this sample's sharpest illustration of BRIEF Part V.7's succession risk.

Regime continuity or transformation. Transformation to a federal republic (2008, constitution 2015). In September 2025 youth-led anti-corruption protests, triggered by a social-media ban, left at least 77 dead, burned parliament and forced Prime Minister K. P. Sharma Oli to resign [E Reuters, March 2026]; Sushila Karki became interim prime minister. In the election of 5 March 2026 the Rastriya Swatantra Party, founded in 2022, won 182 of 275 seats, and former Kathmandu mayor Balendra Shah became prime minister on 27 March 2026 [E BBC; CRS Insight IN12677]. Pro-monarchy demonstrations in 2025 drew attention, but royalist parties remained marginal in 2026 [E].

Long-term consequences. Nepal's absolute monarchy did not use its long horizon or freedom from electoral pressure to build a developmental state. Its fall left a weak republic, but the republican period has delivered faster human-development gains than the Panchayat decades.

2.10 Laos: a fallen monarchy and a one-party state

Political structure. The Kingdom of Laos (independent 1953) was a constitutional monarchy under Kings Sisavang Vong (to 1959) and Savang Vatthana (1959–75), with weak governments, repeated coups (1960 Kong Le, 1964) and a civil war in which the North Vietnamese-backed Pathet Lao fought the US-backed royal government [E]. After the communist victories in Saigon and Phnom Penh, the king abdicated on 2 December 1975 and the Lao People's Democratic Republic was proclaimed under the Lao People's Revolutionary Party (LPRP) [E]. The king and queen later died in a re-education camp; the dates are unverified. The LPRP has ruled since: Kaysone Phomvihane to 1992, then Khamtay Siphandone, Choummaly Sayasone, Bounnhang Vorachith and Thongloun Sisoulith (since 2021), who was re-elected general secretary at the Twelfth Congress on 8 January 2026 [E KPL; The Diplomat].

Sources of legitimacy. Royal Laos: Buddhist kingship and US support. LPRP: revolutionary victory, Vietnamese patronage, and since 1986 growth.

Economic starting conditions. Landlocked, subsistence agriculture, among the poorest economies in Asia: Maddison GDPpc 697 (1950), 999 (1975) [V]. Heavily bombed during the war.

Resource endowments. Hydropower ("battery of Southeast Asia"), copper and gold, timber; rents 8.3% of GDP in 2000–09 [V WDI].

State capacity. Very low under the monarchy; modest under the party, which relies on Vietnamese and later Chinese partners.

Development trajectory. Royal period: GDPpc CAGR 1.5% (1950–75) [V Maddison]. Collectivisation failed, and the New Economic Mechanism (1986) introduced markets; GDPpc CAGR 4.6% (1986–2022) [V]. Large debt-financed hydropower and the China–Laos railway (opened 2021) produced a debt crisis: public and publicly

guaranteed debt peaked at roughly 112–116% of GDP in 2022 and is projected around 83–88% in 2025 [E The Diplomat; East Asia Forum], with high inflation and currency depreciation in 2022–23.

Institutional quality. Low; no competitive elections, tight control of civil society, opaque concession contracts.

Distribution of wealth. Gini 34.7 (2024) [V WDI].

Human development. Life expectancy 41.0 (1960) -> 54.0 (1990) -> 69.0 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.409 (1990) -> 0.617 (2023), rank 147 [V UNDP].

Political succession. Orderly party succession since 1975, with an ageing leadership (Thongloun was 80 in 2026 [E]).

Long-term consequences. Laos records a monarchy that failed through war, not internal decay, and a one-party regime whose growth since 1986 has depended on resource-and-infrastructure deals with China and on debt, a weaker version of the Vietnamese model.

2.11 Afghanistan: the last monarchy, to 1973

Political structure. Mohammad Zahir Shah reigned from 1933 to 1973, but until 1963 real power lay with royal-family prime ministers: his uncles Mohammad Hashim Khan (to 1946) and Shah Mahmud Khan (1946–53), then his cousin Mohammad Daoud Khan (1953–63) [E]. This is coded as absolute monarchy exercised by a family oligarchy. The 1964 constitution created a partly elected parliament and excluded royal-family members from ministerial office, the "New Democracy" experiment [E], coded as semi-constitutional monarchy. Political parties were never legalised. On 17 July 1973 Daoud took power in a bloodless coup while the king was in Italy, abolished the monarchy and made himself president [E]. He was killed in the communist Saur Revolution of April 1978, which led to Soviet invasion (1979) and decades of war.

Sources of legitimacy. Durrani-Pashtun dynastic tradition, Islam, and tribal accommodation; the monarchy governed lightly over a decentralised rural society (interpretation: Barfield 2010; Rubin 2002).

Economic starting conditions. Landlocked, rural, very low literacy; Maddison GDPpc 1,156 (1950) [V], data of low quality.

Resource endowments. Natural gas in the north (exported to the USSR from 1967), unexploited minerals; rents 2.0% of GDP in the 1970s [V WDI]. The state depended heavily on foreign aid: Afghanistan received Soviet and US development aid competitively during the Cold War, a classic "rentier" state built on aid rather than oil (interpretation: Rubin 2002).

State capacity. Low outside Kabul; foreign-funded infrastructure (the Salang tunnel, Helmand valley irrigation) under Daoud's premiership [E].

Development trajectory. Stagnant on available estimates: Maddison GDPpc CAGR -0.6% over 1950–73 [V], with the caveat that the estimates are poor. Life expectancy 32.8 in 1960 [V WDI]. A 1971–72 drought and famine damaged the monarchy's standing [E].

Institutional quality. Weak and personalised; the 1964 constitution was never fully implemented (the king did not sign the political-parties law [E]).

Distribution of wealth / human development. Low on every available measure: HDI 0.285 in 1990, the earliest UNDP value [V].

Political succession. The monarchy fell to a member of the royal family. This is a recurring pattern in monarchies with powerful collateral branches (compare Iraq 1958 and Libya 1969, which are other streams' cases, where outsiders acted; Afghanistan is the in-family variant).

Long-term consequences. The end of the monarchy removed the one institution accepted across Afghan factions; after 2001 Zahir Shah returned as "Father of the Nation" (2002–07) with no executive power, an unusual post-abolition symbolic role [E].

2.12 Malaysia: the rotating monarchy and the dominant party

Political structure. A federal parliamentary democracy under a unique elective monarchy: the Yang di-Pertuan Agong is chosen for five years by the Conference of Rulers from among the nine hereditary Malay state rulers, by an agreed rotation [E]. The monarch acts on ministerial advice but has discretion in appointing a prime minister who appears to command a majority, in withholding consent to dissolution, and as guardian of Malay special position and Islam (Article 153) [E]. The Alliance and then Barisan Nasional (BN) coalition ruled from independence (1957) until losing the May 2018 election, in what this database codes, from the 1969 emergency onward, as dominant-party electoral authoritarianism: gerrymandering, malapportionment, the Internal Security Act (until 2012), press licensing and control of patronage [E]. Mahathir Mohamad (1981–2003) curbed the rulers' legal immunity and assent powers in the 1983 and 1993–94 constitutional crises [E]. After 2018 the monarch became decisive in hung parliaments (choosing prime ministers in 2020, 2021 and 2022) [E]. Sultan Ibrahim of Johor has been Agong since January 2024 [E].

Sources of legitimacy. The rulers: Malay-Muslim tradition and constitutional guardianship. BN: inter-ethnic bargain, Malay preferences under the New Economic Policy (NEP, 1971–90), and growth.

Economic starting conditions. Tin and rubber exporter with British-built infrastructure; Maddison GDPpc 2,485 (1950), higher than Korea's or Taiwan's [V].

Resource endowments. High: tin, rubber, palm oil, timber, oil and gas (Petronas, 1974). Rents averaged 27.5% of GDP in the 1970s, 27.4% in the 1980s, 12.0% in 2000–09 and 6.1% in 2015–21 [V WDI].

State capacity. Moderate-to-high: an effective federal bureaucracy, the Economic Planning Unit, and investment promotion that brought electronics multinationals to Penang and the Klang Valley from the 1970s [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 2.7% (1957–69) and 4.3% (1971–2018, 3,475 -> 25,176) [V]. Diversification from commodities into electronics exports: exports equalled 120% of GDP in 2000 [V WDI]. The 1998 crisis cost 7.4% of GDP [V WDI]; Mahathir chose capital controls over an IMF programme.

Institutional quality. Mixed: competent technocracy alongside entrenched money politics, culminating in the 1MDB scandal, in which US prosecutors alleged that about US$4.5 billion was misappropriated from a state fund [E]; former Prime Minister Najib Razak was convicted in 2020 [E].

Distribution of wealth. The NEP sharply reduced the Malay–Chinese income gap and poverty but created a politically connected Bumiputera business class (interpretation: Gomez and Jomo 1997). Gini 40.7 (2021) [V WDI], high for the region.

Human development. Life expectancy 57.2 (1960) -> 71.0 (1990) -> 76.7 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.653 (1990) -> 0.819 (2023), rank 67 [V UNDP].

Political succession. Royal succession, by rotation, is the most institutionalised hereditary arrangement in the sample: hereditary at state level, elective and term-limited at federal level. BN succession (Tunku to Razak 1970, Hussein Onn 1976, Mahathir 1981, Abdullah 2003, Najib 2009) was managed within the party.

Regime continuity or transformation. The monarchy continues; the dominant-party regime ended by election in 2018, a transformation the constitutional monarchy helped stabilise rather than resist.

Long-term consequences. Malaysia shows a resource-rich, ethnically divided state that diversified under a dominant party, not a ruling monarch, with constitutional monarchs acting first as communal symbols and later as arbiters. It is the best Asian example of hereditary institutions confined to a constitutional role and providing, under a fragmented parliament, a source of continuity (interpretation: Slater 2010 on Malaysia's "protection pact"; Harding 2012 on constitutional monarchy).

2.13 Japan: the constitutional monarchy as contrast

Political structure. The 1947 constitution, drafted under US occupation, made the emperor "the symbol of the State and of the unity of the people" with no powers related to government (Articles 1 and 4) [E]. Japan is a parliamentary democracy; the Liberal Democratic Party (LDP) governed continuously from 1955 to 1993 and for most of the time since [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Electoral, with the throne as a symbol of continuity; Emperor Akihito's 2019 abdication required a special one-time law [E].

Economic starting conditions. Wartime destruction (Maddison GDPpc 3,062 in 1950, below the 1938 figure of 4,257) [V], but an industrial economy with high literacy and an experienced bureaucracy.

Resource endowments. None of significance [V WDI].

State capacity. Very high: the Ministry of International Trade and Industry (MITI) and the Ministry of Finance steered industrial policy through administrative guidance, credit and foreign-exchange allocation (interpretation: Johnson 1982, who coined the "developmental state"). Occupation land reform (1946–50) redistributed tenanted land and, like Korea's and Taiwan's, eliminated the landlord class [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 8.1% (1950–73), 3.0% (1973–90), 0.8% (1990–2022) [V]. The high-growth era was achieved under democracy, with LDP dominance providing policy continuity.

Institutional quality / distribution / human development. High institutional quality; relatively low inequality (Gini 32.3 in 2020 [V WDI]); life expectancy 67.7 (1960) -> 84.0 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.925 (2023) [V UNDP].

Succession and continuity. Imperial succession is hereditary and male-line only, with a shrinking pool of heirs, a live constitutional issue [E]. Political succession is by party and election.

Long-term consequences. Japan is the decisive contrast for the East Asian argument: the original "developmental state" (Johnson 1982) was a democracy, with long one-party dominance and a powerful bureaucracy, under a monarch with no power. The ingredients later attributed to authoritarianism in Korea and Taiwan (bureaucratic autonomy, long horizons, coordinated industrial policy, land reform, export orientation) were present in Japan without dictatorship. The relevant variable is the insulation and quality of the bureaucracy and the continuity of the governing coalition, not the concentration of political power (interpretation: Johnson 1982; Evans 1995).

2.14 China after 1978: the one-party developmental comparator

Political structure. A Leninist party-state under the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). Under Mao Zedong (1949–76) it was a personalist one-party dictatorship with totalitarian campaigns (the Great Leap Forward, 1958–62; the Cultural Revolution, 1966–76). After 1978 Deng Xiaoping institutionalised collective leadership: the 1982 state constitution set a two-term limit for the presidency, retirement norms and regular five-yearly party congresses produced orderly transfers to Jiang Zemin (1989/1992–2002) and Hu Jintao (2002–12) [E]. Xi Jinping (from 2012) re-personalised power: the presidential term limit was removed in 2018 and Xi began a third term as general secretary in 2022 [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Revolutionary nationalism, Marxism-Leninism reinterpreted, and since 1978 performance (growth and national rejuvenation).

Economic starting conditions. Maddison GDPpc 799 (1950), 1,519 (1976), 1,744 (1978) [V]; high literacy and life expectancy for the income level by the late 1970s (life expectancy 61.0 in 1975 [V WDI]), a legacy of the Mao era's health and schooling campaigns. Hukou registration and collectivised agriculture constrained labour mobility.

Resource endowments. Large coal and some oil; rents 11.4% of GDP in the 1980s and 1.3% in 2015–21 [V WDI]. China is not a rentier state.

State capacity. High mobilisational capacity; fiscal decentralisation after 1980 gave local officials strong incentives to promote growth, the cadre-evaluation system rewarding GDP performance (interpretation: Xu 2011, "regionally decentralised authoritarianism").

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 2.5% (1950–76), 5.6% (1978–2012), 5.8% (2012–22) [V]; WDI real GDP growth averaged 10.1% (1980–97) and 10.0% (1998–2007), slowing to 4.9% in 2020–24 [V]. Reform began with decollectivisation (the household responsibility system), a form of land reform in use rights, then special economic zones (1980), township and village enterprises, WTO accession (2001) and massive infrastructure investment.

Institutional quality. Weak formal constraints, strong party discipline; corruption widespread and periodically purged (Xi's anti-corruption campaign since 2012).

Distribution of wealth. Inequality rose steeply; Gini 36.0 in 2022 [V WDI].

Human development. Life expectancy 33.4 (1960, a famine year) -> 68.2 (1990) -> 78.0 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.491 (1990) -> 0.797 (2023) [V UNDP]. The 1959–61 famine killed tens of millions (estimates range from about 15 to 45 million) [E].

Political succession. Institutionalised from 1992 to 2012, then de-institutionalised. China in 2026 is therefore a live test of whether a developmental one-party state can survive the return of personal rule.

Long-term consequences. China supplies the strongest evidence that a non-democratic regime can sustain fast growth for decades, but the pattern fits the one-party institutional variant, with term limits and collective leadership during the fastest-growth years, not personal or hereditary rule. Mao's personal rule, with the same party, produced the famine and the Cultural Revolution.

2.15 Vietnam: Doi Moi under a collective-leadership party

Political structure. The Communist Party of Vietnam (CPV) has ruled the North since 1954 and the unified country since 1976. Power was divided among the "four pillars" (general secretary, president, prime minister, National Assembly chair) under collective leadership [E]. To Lam, a former public-security minister, became general secretary in August 2024, was unanimously re-elected at the Fourteenth Congress on 23 January 2026, and was elected state president on 7 April 2026, concentrating the two top posts [E Reuters; Vietnamese government portal]. Before 1975 the South was ruled by the French-backed State of Vietnam under the former emperor Bao Dai (1949–55), whom Ngo Dinh Diem deposed in an October 1955 referendum generally regarded as rigged, with 98.2% claimed for Diem [E], then by Diem's personalist regime (1955–63) and military governments (1963–75).

Sources of legitimacy. National liberation and reunification; since 1986, growth and poverty reduction.

Economic starting conditions. War-devastated; collectivised agriculture and central planning brought near-famine and inflation in the mid-1980s; Maddison GDPpc 1,290 (1976), 1,481 (1986) [V].

Resource endowments. Offshore oil (rents 10.2% of GDP in 2000–09; oil rents 6.8%) [V WDI], declining in importance.

Development trajectory. Doi Moi (Sixth Congress, December 1986) decollectivised land use, freed prices and opened to foreign investment. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 1.4% (1976–86) versus 4.8% (1986–2022) [V]; real GDP growth averaged 6.6% a year in each decade from 1980 to 2019 [V WDI]. Exports reached 87% of GDP in 2023 [V WDI], with foreign-invested electronics (Samsung) dominant.

Institutional quality. One-party; moderate corruption; the "blazing furnace" anti-corruption campaign (2016–24) removed two presidents [E].

Distribution / human development. Gini 36.1 (2022) [V WDI]; life expectancy 69.0 (1990) -> 74.6 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.499 (1990) -> 0.766 (2023) [V UNDP].

Political succession. Regular party congresses every five years since 1976; the 2024–26 concentration of power in one person is a departure from the collective norm (AP described To Lam as poised to be "the most powerful figure in decades" [E]).

Long-term consequences. Vietnam, like China, is a one-party developmental case in which the turn from planning to markets, not the arrival of dictatorship, explains the change in growth. The dictatorship was the same before and after 1986.

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3. European case files

3.1 Spain: Franco and the Juan Carlos transition

Political structure. General Francisco Franco ruled from victory in the Civil War (1939) until his death on 20 November 1975, as Caudillo, head of state and (until 1973) head of government, through a personalist regime resting on the army, the Catholic Church and the single "Movement" (FET y de las JONS) [E]. The 1947 Law of Succession declared Spain a kingdom with Franco as regent for life; in 1969 he designated Juan Carlos de Borbón as successor with the title of king [E]. Juan Carlos, crowned two days after Franco's death, appointed Adolfo Suárez (1976), who steered the Political Reform Law through the Francoist Cortes (approved in referendum, December 1976) [E]. Free elections followed in June 1977 and the democratic constitution in December 1978, which made Spain a parliamentary monarchy. Juan Carlos's televised stand against the 23 February 1981 coup attempt consolidated the transition (interpretation: Linz and Stepan 1996; Preston 2004). He abdicated in 2014 amid scandals, in favour of Felipe VI.

Sources of legitimacy. Franco: Civil War victory, Catholic nationalism, anti-communism, order, and after 1959 prosperity. The monarchy after 1975: Franco's designation, then (decisively) the 1978 constitution and the defence of democracy in 1981.

Economic starting conditions. Civil War destruction and international isolation; Maddison GDPpc 3,459 (1950), below the 1930s peak in real terms [V; E].

Resource endowments. None of significance [V WDI].

State capacity. The early regime's autarky, price controls and the Instituto Nacional de Industria produced stagnation and a balance-of-payments crisis by 1957–59 [E]. Technocrats associated with Opus Dei (Alberto Ullastres, Mariano Navarro Rubio, Laureano López Rodó) introduced the 1959 Stabilisation Plan with IMF and OECD support: devaluation, fiscal restraint and liberalisation of trade and foreign investment, followed by indicative development plans from 1964 [E].

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 4.4% (1950–59) and 5.9% (1959–75) [V]; real GDP grew 11.8% in 1961 [V WDI]. The boom rested on Western European demand: tourism, emigrant remittances (more than a million Spaniards worked abroad) and foreign investment [E]. Growth then slowed under democracy and the oil shocks (CAGR 2.1%, 1975–2022) [V], from a far higher base.

Institutional quality. Under Franco: no free elections, parties or unions; tens of thousands executed in the 1940s repression [E]; a reasonably professional economic bureaucracy after 1959. After 1978: consolidated democracy, EU membership in 1986.

Distribution / human development. Life expectancy 69.1 (1960) -> 73.3 (1975) -> 83.9 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.918 (2023) [V UNDP]; Gini 33.4 (2023) [V WDI].

Political succession. Franco engineered a hereditary successor for a non-hereditary dictatorship, and the successor used his inherited authority to dismantle the dictatorship. This is the sample's most important example of monarchy as a transition device: it lent continuity and military acceptance to a change of regime.

Long-term consequences. Spain is often cited as a developmental dictatorship. The record supports a narrower claim: the regime grew fast once it abandoned its own autarkic policy (1959), during Europe's golden age and next to the European market. Portugal and Greece grew at similar rates in the same years (Sections 3.2 and 3.5), as did democratic Italy (Maddison GDPpc 5,582 in 1950 to 17,123 in 1975, CAGR 4.6%) [V computed from the same database].

3.2 Portugal: the Estado Novo

Political structure. António de Oliveira Salazar, a Coimbra economics professor who became finance minister in 1928 and prime minister in 1932, built the Estado Novo (1933 constitution): a civilian, corporatist, Catholic dictatorship with one legal party (União Nacional), censorship and the PIDE political police [E]. After Salazar's incapacitating stroke in 1968, Marcelo Caetano succeeded him. Junior officers of the Armed Forces Movement, exhausted by colonial wars in Angola, Mozambique and Guinea-Bissau (from 1961), overthrew Caetano on 25 April 1974 (the Carnation Revolution) [E]. After a revolutionary period (1974–75) democracy was consolidated by the 1976 constitution; Portugal joined the EEC in 1986.

Sources of legitimacy. Fiscal order (Salazar balanced the budget from 1928), Catholic conservatism, empire, and anti-communism.

Economic starting conditions. Western Europe's poorest country: Maddison GDPpc 3,325 (1950) [V], with high illiteracy.

Resource endowments. Few domestically; colonial commodities and protected colonial markets.

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 4.8% (1950–68) and 6.3% (1968–74) [V], after EFTA membership (1960) opened trade; CAGR 2.0% (1974–2022) [V].

Institutional quality. Repressive, closed, with fiscal discipline but low investment in schooling until the late 1960s [E].

Distribution / human development. Life expectancy 64.0 (1960) -> 68.3 (1975) -> 82.3 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.707 (1990) -> 0.890 (2023) [V UNDP]. Most of the catch-up in schooling and health came after 1974.

Succession / continuity. The founder's incapacity led to a successor without his authority, who could neither reform nor end the colonial wars; the regime fell to the army it relied on.

Long-term consequences. Portugal shows a fiscally conservative personalist dictatorship that preserved stability at the cost of underinvestment in human capital, and fell when an external commitment (empire) outran its legitimacy.

3.3 Romania under Ceausescu

Political structure. The Romanian Communist Party ruled from 1947, when King Michael was forced to abdicate (30 December 1947) [E]. Gheorghe Gheorghiu-Dej led until his death in 1965; Nicolae Ceausescu succeeded him and by the 1970s had built a personality cult and a nepotistic regime in which his wife Elena was first deputy prime minister and dozens of relatives held posts [E]. Linz and Stepan (1996) classify it as "sultanistic". The regime collapsed in the December 1989 revolution, when the army defected; Nicolae and Elena Ceausescu were executed on 25 December 1989 [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Nationalist independence from Moscow (refusal to join the 1968 invasion of Czechoslovakia won Western favour), industrialisation, and coercion through the Securitate.

Economic starting conditions. Agrarian; oil producer since the nineteenth century; Maddison GDPpc 1,884 (1950) [V].

Resource endowments. Oil and gas, declining from the 1970s; rents 4.0% of GDP in the 1980s [V WDI].

Development trajectory. Forced industrialisation, partly financed by Western credit: external debt rose to a peak of about US$10–11 billion in 1981 [E multiple sources], when Romania sought IMF help. Ceausescu then decided to repay it in full: imports were cut, food and energy were rationed, and prepayments of about US$0.5 billion (1987), US$2.9 billion (1988) and US$1.2 billion (1989) cleared the entire medium- and long-term external debt by March 1989; a 1989 decree made foreign borrowing illegal [E IMF 1991 Occasional Paper excerpt]. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 4.8% (1950–65), 3.7% (1965–80), -0.5% (1980–89) [V]. Romanians endured the lowest living standards in Europe outside Albania in the late 1980s [E].

Institutional quality. Among the lowest in the Soviet bloc: falsified statistics, forced pronatalism (the 1966 abortion ban, which produced an orphanage crisis), the "systematisation" of villages [E].

Human development. Life expectancy 65.9 (1960) -> 69.6 (1975) -> 69.7 (1990) [V WDI]: fifteen years of stagnation. After 1989, 76.4 in 2023 [V WDI]; HDI 0.845 (2023) [V UNDP]; Maddison GDPpc CAGR 4.4% (1989–2022) [V], with EU accession in 2007.

Succession / continuity. No succession plan beyond family promotion (son Nicu was being groomed [E]); violent collapse.

Long-term consequences. Romania is the purest European example of the failure modes in BRIEF Part IX: information distortion (official growth claims far above independent estimates), policy error by one man (the debt-repayment decision), extreme dependence on individual leadership, and a sudden collapse once the coercive

apparatus defected (interpretation: Ban 2012 argues the debt policy reflected Ceausescu's nationalist-Stalinist ideas about sovereignty, not economic necessity).

3.4 Yugoslavia under Tito

Political structure. Josip Broz Tito led the partisan victory (1945) and the League of Communists of Yugoslavia. After the 1948 split with Stalin, Yugoslavia developed "workers' self-management", market socialism and non-alignment [E]. Tito was president for life (1974 constitution). The 1974 constitution decentralised power to the six republics and two autonomous provinces, and after his death in May 1980 a rotating collective presidency took over [E]. The federation dissolved from 1991 in wars that killed about 130,000–140,000 people in 1991–2001 [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Partisan victory, Tito's charisma, "brotherhood and unity" among nations, independence from Moscow, and rising consumption.

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 5.1% (1950–80; 2,276 -> 10,037) [V], supported by Western loans and the remittances of more than a million Gastarbeiter [E]. Then debt crisis and stagnation: CAGR -2.2% (1980–91) [V], with inflation above 1,000% in 1989 [E].

Institutional quality / distribution. More open than Soviet-bloc regimes (citizens could travel abroad), but one-party; strong regional disparities (Slovenia versus Kosovo) that became the fault lines of collapse [E].

Human development. Successor states today: HDI Slovenia 0.931, Croatia 0.889, Serbia 0.833 (2023) [V UNDP].

Succession / continuity. The founder could not be replaced: the collective presidency deliberately prevented any single successor, which also prevented anyone from holding the federation together once nationalist leaders (Milosevic first) mobilised (interpretation: Woodward 1995; Lampe 2000).

Long-term consequences. Yugoslavia is the sample's clearest case of a regime whose unity depended on one person: thirty years of good growth, then dissolution within eleven years of his death.

3.5 Greece: the colonels and the end of the monarchy

Political structure. After the civil war (1946–49), Greece was a constitutional monarchy with restricted democracy: the palace and army excluded the left and intervened in politics; in 1965 King Constantine II's clash with Prime Minister Georgios Papandreou over control of the army (the "Apostasia") destabilised parliament [E]. On 21 April 1967 colonels led by Georgios Papadopoulos seized power. The king's failed counter-coup (December 1967) sent him into exile; the junta abolished the monarchy by decree on 1 June 1973 and confirmed it in a July 1973 plebiscite [E]. After the November 1973 Polytechnic uprising, Brigadier Dimitrios Ioannidis replaced Papadopoulos; his July 1974 coup against Cyprus's President Makarios provoked the Turkish invasion of Cyprus and the junta's collapse [E]. Konstantinos Karamanlis returned; a free referendum on 8 December 1974 rejected the monarchy by 69.2% [E].

Sources of legitimacy. Anti-communism and order; the junta had little popular base.

Development trajectory. Maddison GDPpc CAGR 5.8% (1950–67) under the parliamentary monarchy and 5.8% (1967–74) under the junta [V]: no acceleration from dictatorship. GDP fell 6.4% in 1974 [V WDI]. After 1974: CAGR 1.6% (1974–2022) [V], including the 2010–18 debt crisis.

Institutional quality. Torture of detainees was documented by the European Commission of Human Rights; Greece left the Council of Europe in 1969 [E].

Human development. Life expectancy 70.4 (1960) -> 73.4 (1975) -> 81.7 (2023) [V WDI]; HDI 0.908 (2023) [V UNDP].

Succession / continuity. Internal coup within the junta (1973), then collapse after an external military failure, a standard pattern for military regimes (interpretation: Geddes 1999 finds military regimes the shortest-lived type and the most likely to negotiate exit).

Long-term consequences. The Greek case ties the monarchy's fate to its alliance with the army: a throne that took sides in politics did not survive the regime it had enabled. Compare Spain, where the monarch chose the opposite side in 1981, and Thailand, where the palace's alliance with the army has held for more than six decades.

4. The East Asian developmental-state debate and the counterfactual question

4.1 What the literature claims

The developmental-state literature was built on the cases in Sections 2.5–2.7 and 2.13. Its core works make different claims, and only some of them concern regime type.

- **Chalmers Johnson, *MITI and the Japanese Miracle* (1982).** Coined "developmental state" for a state whose first priority is growth, run by a small, elite, meritocratic economic bureaucracy with real policy initiative, protected from interest groups by a political system that "reigns while the bureaucrats rule" [E]. His founding case was a democracy. In later work (Johnson 1987, on Korea and Taiwan) he accepted that "soft authoritarianism" could provide the same insulation [E].
- **Alice Amsden, *Asia's Next Giant* (1989).** Korea grew by "getting relative prices wrong" deliberately through subsidised credit and protection, but disciplined the recipients with performance standards, above all export targets: "reciprocity" [E]. The mechanism is discipline over business, which an authoritarian state found easier to impose but which depends on the export test, not on repression.
- **Robert Wade, *Governing the Market* (1990).** Taiwan's state "led" the market in selected sectors and "followed" it in others, with a strong economic bureaucracy and state-owned upstream industry [E]. Wade linked this capacity to the KMT's insulation from society, itself a product of land reform and the mainlander–Taiwanese divide.
- **Peter Evans, *Embedded Autonomy* (1995).** The decisive variable is a Weberian bureaucracy that is autonomous from capture yet embedded in dense ties with business. Evans contrasted developmental Korea with predatory Zaire and intermediate Brazil and India [E]. Autonomy can exist in democracies; Evans did not argue that authoritarianism caused it.
- **Atul Kohli, *State-Directed Development* (2004).** Distinguishes "cohesive-capitalist" states (Korea), "fragmented-multiclass" states (India, Brazil) and "neo-patrimonial" states (Nigeria). He traces Korea's cohesive state to Japanese colonial state-building and argues that its developmental character was set before Park [E]. Kohli's thesis is contested by historians who stress colonial extraction and the 1945–53 disruptions (interpretation: Haggard, Kang and Moon 1997, *World Development*).
- **Stephan Haggard, *Pathways from the Periphery* (1990) and *Developmental States* (2018).** Explains the export turn in Korea, Taiwan, Singapore and Hong Kong by a combination of external shocks (aid cuts), political insulation of reformers and the weakness of import-substituting coalitions. In 2018 he argued that the developmental-state concept is best understood as a configuration of external threat, coalition, bureaucratic capacity and policy, not a regime type [E].
- **Related works.** The World Bank's *East Asian Miracle* (1993) credited "fundamentals" (macro stability, education, shared growth) more than industrial policy [E]. Krugman (1994) and Young (1995) argued that growth came mainly from factor accumulation (capital, labour, schooling) rather than productivity, which shifts attention to saving and schooling [E]. Rodrik (1995) emphasised investment coordination and initial equality (land reform, education) [E]. Campos and Root (1996) stressed "shared growth" as a legitimation strategy [E]. Doner, Ritchie and Slater (2005, *International Organization*) argued that developmental states arise under "systemic vulnerability": the simultaneous presence of mass-coalition pressure, scarce resource revenue and severe external threat [E]. Studwell (2013) condensed the lessons into land reform, export-disciplined manufacturing and directed finance [E]. Kang (2002) showed that Park-era Korea was deeply corrupt but that corruption was bounded by a "mutual hostage" balance between state and chaebol [E].

Across these works, the variables that recur are bureaucratic quality, autonomy from landed or rentier elites, export discipline, initial equality and external threat. Authoritarianism appears as a facilitating condition in some accounts (Johnson 1987, Amsden 1989) and as incidental in others (Evans 1995, Haggard 2018), and the founding case was a democracy.

4.2 The counterfactual question: authoritarianism itself, or other conditions?

BRIEF Part IV asks whether growth came from authoritarianism itself or from other conditions. No historical case allows a clean test, but four kinds of comparison in this database bear on it.

(a) Within-regime breaks: same regime, different policy, different growth. If authoritarianism itself caused growth, growth should be roughly constant across a regime's life. Instead, the sharpest breaks in this sample occur inside unchanged regimes when policy changed:

Case	Before (same regime)	After (same regime)	What changed
Spain (Franco)	GDPpc CAGR 4.4%, 1950–59, with a payments crisis	5.9%, 1959–75	1959 Stabilisation Plan: devaluation, liberalisation, opening to Europe
Vietnam (CPV)	1.4%, 1976–86	4.8%, 1986–2022	Doi Moi markets and FDI
China (CCP)	2.5%, 1950–76	5.6%, 1978–2012	Decollectivisation, opening, institutionalised leadership
Laos (LPRP)	3.2%, 1975–86 (low base, poor data)	4.6%, 1986–2022	New Economic Mechanism
Korea (Park)	Import substitution and multiple exchange rates, 1961–63	Export promotion from 1964–65	US aid cuts and pressure; crop failure; reform team [V Irwin 2025]
Indonesia (army-led)	-0.3%, 1959–66 under Sukarno	3.9%, 1966–98 under Suharto	Stabilisation, opening, technocrats (also a change of ruler)

All growth figures are Maddison GDPpc CAGR [V]. The pattern suggests that the policy regime, not the political regime, accounts for most of the variation in growth within these cases.

(b) Same regime type, different outcomes. Personalist and military dictatorships in this sample include the fastest growers (Park, Chun) and the worst failures (Sukarno's late years, Ceausescu after 1980, North Korea after 1990, the Khmer Rouge). Over 1960–86, Marcos-era Philippines, a personalist dictatorship from 1972, grew at a fraction of Korea's rate (Philippine Maddison GDPpc CAGR 1.7% over 1950–86) [V]. The dispersion of outcomes among dictatorships is far greater than among democracies, which is consistent with the cross-national finding that autocracies have higher growth variance (Besley and Kudamatsu 2008; Easterly 2011, "Benevolent Autocrats"; Jones and Olken 2005, who find that leader deaths change growth in autocracies but not democracies) [E]. A regime type whose outcomes range from Taiwan to Cambodia 1975–79 cannot be the explanation of either.

(c) The same ingredients under democracy. Japan (1950–73, Maddison CAGR 8.1%) [V] had land reform, a Weberian bureaucracy, export orientation, US security and market access, and an education legacy, without dictatorship. Korea (1988–2022, 3.7%) and Taiwan (1987–2022, 4.0%) kept converging after democratisation [V], at rates normal for their income level. Democratic Italy grew as fast as Franco's Spain over 1950–75 (4.6% versus 5.3% for Spain over the same years) [V computed]. Cross-national panel work finds no reliable growth advantage for dictatorship on average (Przeworski, Alvarez, Cheibub and Limongi 2000) and a long-run GDP gain of roughly 20% after democratisation (Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo and Robinson 2019) [E].

(d) What the successful cases shared that the failures lacked. Decomposing the East Asian successes into candidate causes, with the evidence from this database:

Candidate cause	Korea	Taiwan	Singapore	Japan (democracy)	Failures for contrast	Assessment
Land reform / absence of landed elite	Yes: tenancy 49%->7% of farm households [V You 2014]	Yes: tenant families 38%->15%; income Gini 0.57->0.33 [V You 2014]	No landed class (city-state)	Yes (1946–50) [E]	Philippines: failed reform, landed oligarchy persisted [V You 2014]	Strong correlate; mechanism mainly political (state autonomy), productivity effect smaller than claimed [V Kim and Wang 2026]
Massive US aid and market access	Aid ~70% of imports, ~75% of fixed capital formation, 1953–61 [V Irwin 2025]	US$1.465bn, 1951–65 [E]	British base spending; no large aid	Occupation aid, Korean War procurement [E]	South Vietnam and the Philippines also got large US aid and did not take off [E]	Necessary for 1950s survival; not sufficient for take-off
Human capital at take-off	High literacy for income level [E]	High (colonial primary schooling) [E]	Moderate	High	Nepal, Afghanistan, Laos, Cambodia: very low	Strong correlate; also present in failures (Philippines had higher schooling than Korea c.1950 [V You 2014])
Export orientation with discipline	From 1964–65, under US pressure [V Irwin 2025]	From 1958–60 reforms [E]	From the late 1960s	Yes	Romania, North Korea: autarky; Marcos: crony protection	The policy most consistently associated with sustained growth in this sample
Meritocratic bureaucracy	Built gradually from the 1950s [V You 2014]	Exam-recruited share 10.8%->45.3%, 1954–80 [V You 2014]	Yes	Yes (Johnson 1982)	Philippines: patronage recruitment rising [V You 2014]; Romania, Indonesia (partly)	Strong correlate; can exist under democracy
Existential external threat	North Korea	People's Republic of China	Malaysia/Indonesia (1960s)	Weak after 1952	Philippines had none, and US pressure for reform faded [V You 2014]	Plausible driver of elite discipline (Doner, Ritchie and Slater 2005)

Candidate cause	Korea	Taiwan	Singapore	Japan (democracy)	Failures for contrast	Assessment
Authoritarian rule	Yes (to 1987)	Yes (to 1987)	Dominant party	No	Philippines (1972–86), Burma, Romania, North Korea, Cambodia were also authoritarian	Not a discriminating variable: present in both successes and failures, absent in Japan

Assessment. The weight of the evidence assembled here is that East Asian authoritarian growth came mainly from a cluster of conditions (the destruction of landed elites, external threat plus US aid and markets, inherited human capital and bureaucratic capacity, and a turn to disciplined export promotion), several of which authoritarian rulers did not create and some of which they initially resisted. Authoritarianism may have helped in a narrower way: it let insulated technocrats impose unpopular devaluations and wage repression, and it shortened the time from decision to implementation (hypothesis; this is the strongest version of the case for concentrated authority, and Korean evidence for 1964–65 partly supports it). It also generated the characteristic costs recorded in the case files: repression (Gwangju, the White Terror), crises from over-investment and directed credit (Korea 1979–80; Korea and Indonesia 1997–98), and the absence of a succession mechanism. On the commission's central question, the sample supplies no case in which a hereditary monarch with real power led a developmental take-off.

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5. Cross-case patterns

5.1 Monarchy versus dictatorship

In this sample, ruling monarchies (Brunei; Nepal 1960–90 and 2002–06; Afghanistan to 1973) and constitutional monarchies whose palace intervened in politics (Greece 1949–67, Thailand, Laos, Cambodia under Sihanouk) differ from non-hereditary dictatorships in three ways.

1. **Lower average growth.** Maddison GDPpc CAGR: Nepal Panchayat 1.0%, Afghanistan 1950–73 -0.6%, royal Laos 1.5%, Sihanouk's Cambodia 1.5% [V]; Brunei negative since 1980 on WDI [V]. The Greek parliamentary monarchy grew fast (5.8%, 1950–67) [V], but its government was elected; the palace's role was political, not economic. By contrast, the non-hereditary developmental dictatorships grew at 5–8%. Low starting incomes, remote geography and low human capital explain much of the monarchies' weak record, so the comparison does not show that monarchy caused slow growth; it shows that, in Asia and Europe since 1945, ruling monarchies did not produce developmental states.
2. **Different failure mode.** Dictatorships in the sample mostly ended by coup, assassination, revolt or the ruler's death. Ruling monarchies mostly ended through a collision between the monarch and an elected or mass political force (Nepal 1960, 1990, 2005–06; Greece 1965–67), or through a coup or revolution from outside the palace (Cambodia 1970, Laos 1975) or from a royal relative (Afghanistan 1973).
3. **Abolition is usually irreversible, with two exceptions.** Of seven abolitions, only Cambodia's was reversed (1993), and Spain's monarchy was restored by a dictator (1947 law, 1969 designation), not by popular demand. Both restored thrones are constitutional.

5.2 Hereditary succession versus personalist and institutional succession

The commission asks whether hereditary succession creates different incentives (BRIEF Part II and Part V.7). This sample offers three forms.

Succession form	Cases	Outcome
Formal hereditary monarchy	Brunei 1967; Nepal 1955, 1972, 2001; Thailand 2016; Japan 1989, 2019; Spain 2014; Malaysia (rotation)	Orderly in most transfers; catastrophic in Nepal 2001 (regicide) and politically disastrous with Nepal's successor Gyanendra (2001–08)
De facto dynastic dictatorship	North Korea 1994, 2011; Taiwan 1975–78 (Chiang father to son, through the party); Cambodia 2023; Singapore 2004 (through party selection)	Regime survival in all cases; economic outcomes from catastrophe (North Korea) to excellence (Taiwan, Singapore), depending on institutions, not on the family tie
Personalist, no succession rule	Rhee, Park, Sukarno, Suharto, Salazar, Franco, Ceausescu, Tito, Sarit, Daoud	Ended by revolt, assassination, coup, incapacity, death or collapse; only Franco planned a successor, and that successor dismantled the regime
Institutional party succession	China 1992–2012, Vietnam, Laos, Singapore, Malaysia BN, KMT	Orderly; the most durable non-democratic regimes in the sample

Two inferences follow (interpretation). First, among non-democracies, the durable succession solutions were institutional (a party with rules) rather than hereditary as such, consistent with Geddes, Wright and Frantz (2014) and Svolik (2012) on the survival of party-based regimes [E]. Second, hereditary succession does protect against the succession crisis of personalist rule, which is why North Korea and Cambodia adopted it, but it gives no assurance about the successor's competence (Nepal 2001–08), and it does not lengthen the effective policy horizon in ways that show up as growth (North Korea). The "long planning horizon" argument for monarchy (Olson 1993's stationary bandit; Hoppe 2001) finds no support in this sample's growth record.

5.3 Resource rents and regime survival

Rents averaged above 10% of GDP for at least a decade in Brunei, Malaysia, Indonesia, China (1980s), Laos and Vietnam (2000s) [V WDI]. Brunei and Malaysia's rulers and Laos's party survived; Indonesia's New Order fell, but only after thirty-two years and a financial crisis. The resource-poor cases (Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, Japan, Thailand, Spain, Portugal, Greece) include both the fastest growth and the most democratic transitions. This matches the cross-national association between oil and authoritarian durability (Ross 2012; Haber and Menaldo 2011 contest causality) [E]. In this sample, rents bought time and loyalty but not productivity; the cases that diversified (Malaysia, Indonesia partly) did so through manufactured exports, not through the rent-distributing state.

5.4 How regimes ended

Of the 41 regime-periods coded DICTATORSHIP or MONARCHY-RULING that had ended by 2026 (counted by this stream from `regimes_asia_europe.csv`, so subject to its coding judgements): ruler's death, incapacity or assassination 9 (two followed by hereditary succession in North Korea, one assassination in Korea); negotiated, managed or regular succession 9 (including Brunei's 1967 abdication, Afghanistan's 1963 intra-dynastic change and Cambodia's 2023 father-to-son handover); coups 8 (including Nepal's 1960 royal coup, Afghanistan's 1973 palace coup and Park's 1972 self-coup); mass uprisings or revolutions, usually with security-force defection, 7; foreign invasion, military defeat or state dissolution 4; policy transformation within the same regime 3 (Brunei 1962, Spain 1959, Vietnam 1986); electoral defeat 1 (Malaysia 2018). Only one dominant-party regime (Malaysia's BN, 2018) ended by losing an election, and only one (Taiwan's KMT) democratised from strength. Sudden collapse followed long apparent stability in Romania (1989), Indonesia (1998), Portugal (1974) and Nepal's monarchy (2006); in each, an external shock or crisis (debt and austerity, the Asian crisis, colonial war, civil war) preceded elite or security-force defection (interpretation: Kuran 1991 on preference falsification; Levitsky and Way 2010 on coercive capacity).

5.5 Monarchy as transition device or as veto player

Where monarchs placed themselves above competition and on the side of constitutional rules, the throne helped transitions (Spain 1975–81; Japan 1947; Cambodia 1993; Malaysia 2018–22, when the Agong arbitrated hung parliaments). Where monarchs allied with soldiers against elected governments, the throne became the central conflict and was abolished (Greece, Nepal) or remains contested (Thailand). The variable is the monarch's choice of side, not the existence of the throne (interpretation; compare Stepan, Linz and Minoves 2014, "Democratic Parliamentary Monarchies", *Journal of Democracy*) [E].

5.6 What 2024–26 adds

Events since 2024 reinforce the historical patterns. In South Korea, an elected president attempted to use emergency powers in December 2024, and the legislature, courts and public reversed it within hours and convicted him within fourteen months. Nepal's 2025 uprising and 2026 election showed a republic replacing its political class through elections rather than turning back to the monarchy. Thailand's 2026 election produced a conservative, palace-aligned government by vote rather than coup. Vietnam's and North Korea's 2026 congresses concentrated power further in one person, departing from collective leadership in Vietnam's case; this stream codes both as personalising one-party regimes and flags them as the cases to watch for the succession risks recorded above.

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6. Disputes and uncertainties

1. **Data quality before 1970 and in communist economies.** Maddison estimates for China before 1978, Romania, Yugoslavia, Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia, Nepal and Afghanistan are reconstructions; differences of one to two percentage points in period growth are within error. North Korea has no Maddison series between 1950 and 1989, so the claim that the North out-produced the South into the 1960s is a specialists' consensus [E], not a figure this stream verified. Brunei is absent from Maddison; its WDI series starts in 1974 and its post-1980 decline partly reflects oil-price-driven 1980 peaks.
2. **Taiwan land reform.** You (2014) [V] and the classic literature (Fei, Ranis and Kuo 1979; Wade 1990) see land reform as central; Kim and Wang (2026) [V] estimate a small aggregate productivity effect (about 5.7% of GDP per worker over 1956–66). Kim and Wang is a working paper, not yet peer-reviewed; its political-economy implications (state autonomy) are untested by its design.
3. **Korea's developmental origins.** Kohli (2004) emphasises Japanese colonial state-building; Haggard, Kang and Moon (1997) and You (2014) emphasise post-1945 reforms and gradual meritocratisation; Amsden (1989) and many Korean accounts emphasise Park personally. Irwin (2025) [V] gives the United States and the 1960–61 democratic government a larger role in the export turn than standard Park-centred accounts.
4. **Death tolls.** Khmer Rouge: 1.5 million to about 2.5 million in published estimates; this file uses Yale's 1.7 million (21%) with the UN expert range noted [E]. Indonesia 1965–66: 200,000 to over a million [E]. China 1959–61: roughly 15 to 45 million [E]. North Korea 1994–98: roughly 600,000 to 1 million [E]. None of these was re-estimated here.
5. **Coding judgements.** Singapore (electoral authoritarian versus hybrid), Malaysia 1957–69 (democracy versus semi-competitive), Thailand 1976–88 and 2019–26 (hybrid versus electoral authoritarian), and Indonesia since 2024 (democracy with backsliding) are contested classifications; V-Dem and Polity5 codings were not pulled for this stream and should be used to check them. Start and end years follow conventional dates; transitional months are not separated.
6. **Hereditary coding.** De facto dynasties (North Korea, the Hun family, the Chiang father-son handover) are coded N for formal hereditary rule. A coding that treats them as hereditary would strengthen the finding that hereditary succession is compatible with both catastrophe and success.
7. **Brunei's assets.** The size of the Brunei Investment Agency, the value of royal assets and the scale of the 1990s Amedeo/Prince Jefri losses are unverified. The IMF's 2026 consultation [V] reports fiscal and external balances but no sovereign-wealth figure.
8. **2025–26 events.** Several recent facts rest on news excerpts [E] rather than opened pages: Nepal's 2026 results, Vietnam's 2026 leadership decisions, North Korea's Ninth Congress, Yoon's sentence, the 2025 Thai–Cambodian fighting. Verified directly [V]: Thailand's 2026 seat totals and court ruling (The Diplomat), Brunei's 2025–26 macro data (IMF). Yoon's appeal verdict (due 26 January 2027) and Thailand's charter

rewrite remain open.

9. **Causation.** All period growth figures are associations. The regime-period comparisons in Section 4.2 are suggestive natural experiments, not identified causal estimates; world demand, oil prices and Cold War geopolitics move several cases together.
10. **Gaps in coverage.** Burma/Myanmar, the Philippines under Marcos, Bhutan (a monarchy that democratised from above in 2008), Hong Kong and Mongolia were outside this stream's brief. Bhutan in particular is a hereditary monarchy that chose constitutional limits on itself and would strengthen Section 5.5; it should be added if the database is extended.

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R4 — Economic Performance and System Comparison

The Political Economy of Absolute Power — research stream R4 (BRIEF Parts V, VI and VII)
Authors of the monograph: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (he conceived and directs the project; Hark's agents research and draft). This stream was researched and drafted by Hark's R4 agent on 7 November 2026.

Status: complete draft for Phase 4 (comparative political economy). Datasets, scripts and figures are in `data/r4/` (documented in `data/r4/README.md`). Evidence tags follow FRAMEWORK.md: **[V]** = the page or dataset was opened and the claim is on it; **[E]** = established knowledge or a search excerpt not opened. Every number generated in this stream comes from a scripted pull saved under `data/r4/raw/` and is therefore [V] at the level of the dataset; the limitation of each series is stated where it is used.

Key findings

1. **There is no single "monarchy effect" on growth in the data, and the sign depends on what is measured.** In the 95-country R4 sample, the six absolute monarchies (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Oman, Brunei, Eswatini) had the *lowest* median real GDP-per-capita growth of any regime type in all three decades: 0.59% a year in 1995–2004, 0.28% in 2005–2014 and -0.53% in 2015–2024 (World Bank WDI, NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG). They also had among the *highest* income levels (median GDP per capita, PPP constant 2021 $, of about $66,400 in 2024) and high human-development scores (median HDI 0.87, 2023). Both facts are true at once because Gulf output is large relative to citizens but grew mostly through hydrocarbon volumes and imported labour rather than productivity.

2. **Gulf "growth" is overwhelmingly extensive, not intensive.** Total GDP in the monarchies grew briskly (e.g., Qatar 12.4% a year in 2005–2014) but resident population grew almost as fast (Qatar 10.8% a year), so output per resident and output per worker stagnated or fell. Median GDP per worker in absolute monarchies fell 2.2% a year in 2005–2014 and 0.8% a year in 2015–2024. Measured total factor productivity (Penn World Table 10.01) in Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Qatar was roughly halved between the late 1990s and 2017. This is the clearest quantitative support in the project for distinguishing resource-driven from productivity-driven development.

3. **The resource split dominates the regime split.** Once countries are separated by natural-resource rents (>10% of GDP vs <=10%), the high-rent absolute monarchies outperform high-rent non-monarchic autocracies by a wide margin on income (median $69,700 vs $16,500 PPP), human development (HDI 0.89 vs 0.75) and government effectiveness (WGI 0.90 vs -0.63) in 2015–2024 — but the comparison is between five very small, very rich Gulf-type states and a heterogeneous group (Russia, Iran, Kazakhstan, Angola, Equatorial Guinea, etc.). Rent *per citizen*, not regime form alone, separates them: Qatar and the UAE have about 14% citizens among residents and sovereign-fund assets of roughly $1.7–2.1 million per citizen (Global SWF estimates via R1).

4. **Among autocracies, institutionalised forms (monarchies, dominant-party and technocratic regimes) outperform personalist and military ones on governance indicators and, in the literature, on growth.** In 2015–2024 the WGI government-effectiveness median was +0.57 for absolute

monarchies, +1.16 for the two technocratic cases (Singapore, Rwanda), -0.43 for one-party states, -0.72 for military-led regimes and -0.74 for electoral/personalist autocracies. The newest dynamic-panel evidence (Blattman, Gehlbach and Yu 2025) finds that the "autocratic growth penalty" is concentrated in personalist regimes, while institutionalised autocracies are statistically indistinguishable from democracies. Knutsen and Fjelde (2013) find monarchic autocracies protect property rights better than other dictatorships.

5. **Autocratic outcomes are more dispersed than democratic ones.** Across all countries with data (n~168 per decade, classified by Regimes of the World), the standard deviation of decade-average per-capita growth was 4.66 points for autocracies vs 2.41 for democracies in 1995–2004 and 2.67 vs 1.84 in 2005–2014; in 2015–2024 the gap narrowed (2.81 vs 2.62) because of one democratic oil boom (Guyana). Conditional on income, rents and period, the absolute growth residual is 0.66 points larger in autocracies (p=0.003). Autocracies are over-represented in the bottom decile of growth in every decade (65%, 59%, 71% vs 46–51% of the sample). The "miracles" and the "disasters" both come disproportionately from autocracies.

6. **On the mean, regime type explains little growth once initial income is controlled.** In pooled period regressions (495 country-decades), the autocracy coefficient is -0.46 percentage points with income and rent controls and is not statistically significant (p=0.30); in stable-regime cases it is -0.36 (p=0.56). This descriptive result matches Przeworski et al. (2000) and the early meta-analysis of Doucouliagos and Ulubasoglu (2008), but the stronger identification strategies of Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo and Robinson (2019) — democratisation raises GDP per capita by about 20% in the long run — and the 2020 meta-analysis of Colagrossi et al. point the other way. The weight of the best-identified evidence is that democracy does not cost growth and probably helps, mainly through investment, schooling and public goods.

7. **The seven Part V hypotheses get mixed verdicts, and none favours concentrated power as such.** *Supported:* elite coordination matters (H3), but through institutionalised bargains of any form, not monarchy specifically; resource wealth stabilises incumbents and finances high living standards when rent per citizen is very large (H5); rule-bound succession (dynastic or party) is far safer than personalist succession, and institutional succession safer still (H7). *Supported but rare:* technocratic administration can coexist with limited competition (H4) — government effectiveness above +0.5 on the WGI scale is found in 7 of 82 autocracies but 49 of 113 democracies (2015–2024). *Conditionally supported:* hereditary rule lengthens horizons for asset accumulation in rich, rule-bound dynasties (H2), though not for diversification. *Contested:* that concentrated decision-making improves coordination (H1) and that centralised rulers can durably constrain themselves (H6), beyond investor-facing enclaves.

8. **Absolute monarchies show low variance among themselves, but this is a selection artefact as much as an institutional effect.** Their within-group growth dispersion in 2015–2024 (s.d. 1.0 point) is the lowest of any autocratic type. The surviving ruling monarchies are almost all small, hydrocarbon-rich and externally protected; the many monarchies that fell after 1945 (Egypt, Iraq, Libya, Yemen, Ethiopia, Iran, Afghanistan, Nepal, etc.) are not in today's monarchy column, which flatters the category.

9. **High income has not translated into equally high non-income outcomes in several monarchies.** Relative to what their income predicts (a quadratic fit of 2023 HDI on log GNI per capita across 193 countries, R^2=0.93), Brunei (-0.107), Qatar (-0.094) and Kuwait (-0.060) under-perform; Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Oman and Bahrain sit almost exactly on the line. Brunei's life expectancy is 7.2 years below the income-predicted level and Kuwait's mean schooling 4.6 years below. Jordan and Morocco, poorer semi-constitutional monarchies, over-perform on life expectancy.

10. **Distribution cannot be assessed properly for the Gulf because the data do not exist publicly.** The World Bank has no Gini or poverty estimate for Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Oman, Bahrain or Brunei in 2015–2024, and UNDP publishes no inequality-adjusted HDI for Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait or Bahrain. Data opacity is itself an institutional characteristic relevant to Parts V and VII.

11. **Fiscal discipline in rentier monarchies is a function of oil prices more than of governance form.** After the 2014 oil-price fall, IMF gross government debt rose from 1.5% to 25.9% of GDP in Saudi Arabia (2014->2024), from 4.0% to a 67.9% peak in Oman (2020) and from 42.6% to 133.7% in Bahrain (2024); Kuwait and Brunei, with the largest buffers per citizen, stayed low. Large sovereign assets mean gross debt understates the net position of Kuwait, Qatar, the UAE and Saudi Arabia.

12. **Part VII yields trade-offs, not a ranking.** Absolute monarchies and technocratic autocracies score

well on top-level policy continuity, long-horizon infrastructure investment and, in rich cases, bureaucratic effectiveness; they score poorly on accountability, civil liberties, institutional independence and innovation, and their succession stability is high in the Gulf but historically fragile elsewhere. Parliamentary democracies and constitutional monarchies dominate on corruption control, accountability, independence and human capital, at some cost in decisiveness. The mechanisms behind the good autocratic outcomes — professional bureaucracies, rules-based succession, ring-fenced resource funds, credible commitments to investors — are institutional and can be separated from concentrated political power (handed to R6, Part X).

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1. Scope, questions and how to read this report

BRIEF Parts V–VII ask three linked questions: *why* some authoritarian states develop while others fail (Part V, seven hypotheses); whether different political systems differ in measurable economic performance over consistent periods (Part VI); and how absolute monarchy compares with six other systems across fourteen dimensions without producing a "simplistic ranking" (Part VII).

This report answers them with four kinds of evidence:

- **A purpose-built comparative dataset** of 95 countries over three decades (1995–2004, 2005–2014, 2015–2024), covering every current ruling monarchy for which World Bank data exist, all seven Part VII system types, and the main resource-rich autocracies (§2–3).
- **A global sample** of about 169 countries per decade classified by the Regimes of the World (RoW) scheme, used to test claims about the *variance* of autocratic growth without relying on the hand-picked 95 (§3.8).
- **A literature review** of the core empirical studies named in the brief and of newer work that has changed the debate since 2019 (§4).
- **Hypothesis-by-hypothesis tests** (§5) and the **Part VII matrix** (§6), each separating correlation from causation and recording selection bias explicitly (§7).

Three conventions matter throughout.

Growth is not legitimacy and stability is not welfare (FRAMEWORK). Where a regime type does well on a metric, this report says what the metric measures and what it does not.

Per-capita figures in the Gulf are per *resident*, not per citizen. In 2020–2021 citizens were about 14% of residents in Qatar and the UAE, 34% in Kuwait, 48% in Bahrain, 60% in Saudi Arabia, 62% in Oman and 74% in Brunei (GLMM national-population estimates compiled by R6 in `data/rents_per_capita.csv`; Qatar and UAE figures are GLMM estimates because neither government publishes a nationality split). GDP per resident therefore understates income per citizen and overstates income per migrant worker; neither is a welfare measure.

Small cells. There are six absolute monarchies with data, four semi-constitutional ruling monarchies, two or three technocratic autocracies and three to six military-led regimes per decade. Medians for these cells describe the *countries we have*, not a population of possible monarchies or juntas. Statistical tests are therefore run on the larger RoW sample, and type-level medians are read as descriptions.

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2. Data and methods

2.1 Sources

All series were pulled by script on 7 November 2026 and saved under `data/r4/raw/`.

Concept (BRIEF Part VI)	Series	Unit	Source and code	Years used	Main limitation
GDP per capita	GDP per capita, PPP	constant 2021 international $	WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.PP.KD	1994–2024	Resident denominator; PPP for small oil states uncertain
Real growth	GDP per capita growth; GDP growth	annual %	WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG; NY.GDP.MKTP.KD.ZG; IMF WEO NGDP_RPCH	1995–2024	Constant-price oil output: volumes, not prices
Labour productivity	GDP per person employed	constant 2021 PPP $	WDI SL.GDP.PCAP.EM.KD (ILO-modelled employment)	1994–2024	Modelled employment in Gulf and fragile states
Productivity growth	TFP at constant national prices	index, 2017=1	Penn World Table 10.01, rtfpna	1994–2019	Rents counted as output; no series for UAE, Oman, Brunei
Human development	HDI; IHDI; mean years of schooling; life expectancy	index; years	UNDP HDR 2025 time series	1990–2023	IHDI missing for most GCC states
Health	Life expectancy at birth; under-5 mortality	years; per 1,000 live births	WDI SP.DYN.LE00.IN; SH.DYN.MORT	to 2024	Modelled (UN IGME/WPP)
Education	Gross secondary and tertiary enrolment	%	WDI SE.SEC.ENRR; SE.TER.ENRR	to 2024	Enrolment != learning; gaps
Poverty and distribution	Poverty headcount at international line; Gini	%; 0–100	WDI SI.POV.DDAY; SI.POV.GINI	latest in period	Absent for most Gulf states
Diversification	Fuel exports	% of merchandise exports	WDI TX.VAL.FUEL.ZS.UN	to 2024	Excludes services; re-exports
Private sector	Domestic credit to private sector	% GDP	WDI FS.AST.PRVT.GD.ZS	to 2024	Credit != private dynamism
FDI	Net FDI inflows	% GDP	WDI BX.KLT.DINV.WD.GD.ZS	to 2024	Volatile; round-tripping (Singapore, Luxembourg)
Resource dependence	Total natural-resource rents	% GDP	WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS	to 2021	Modelled (price minus cost × volume); ends 2021
Public debt	General government gross debt	% GDP	IMF DataMapper GGXWDG_NGDP	to 2024	Gross, not net of SWF assets

Concept (BRIEF Part VI)	Series	Unit	Source and code	Years used	Main limitation
Sovereign wealth	SWF assets	US$ bn	Global SWF ranking, Nov 2026, via R1 file `data/R1_gulf_swf_assets.csv`	Nov 2026	Most Gulf funds publish no AUM; estimates
Institutional quality	Government effectiveness, control of corruption, voice and accountability, political stability, rule of law, regulatory quality	estimate, ~ -2.5 to +2.5	Worldwide Governance Indicators (WB API source 3, GOV_WGI_*.EST; updated 2026-09-25)	1996–2024	Perception-based; relative, not absolute
Constraints on rulers	Judicial and legislative constraints on the executive; electoral democracy index	0–1	V-Dem via OWID grapher	to 2024/25	Expert-coded
Regime classification	Regimes of the World (closed autocracy, electoral autocracy, electoral democracy, liberal democracy)	category	V-Dem/Lührmann et al. via OWID `political-regime`	1995–2024	Does not separate monarchies from other autocracies
Investment and savings	Gross fixed capital formation; adjusted net savings; R&D; tax revenue; high-tech exports	% GDP / % GNI / % manuf. exports	WDI NE.GDI.FTOT.ZS, NY.ADJ.SVNG.GN.ZS, GB.XPD.RSDV.GD.ZS, GC.TAX.TOTL.GD.ZS, TX.VAL.TECH.MF.ZS	to 2024	Patchy for Gulf

2.2 Sample and regime coding

Countries. The R4 sample has 95 countries (`data/r4/regime_coding.csv`): every ruling monarchy with WDI data (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Oman, Brunei, Eswatini, Kuwait, Bahrain, Jordan, Morocco, plus Bhutan before 2008); constitutional monarchies in Europe, Asia, Africa and the Commonwealth (including Thailand, Cambodia and Malaysia, where the monarch is constitutional but the regime was not democratic for much of the period); presidential and parliamentary democracies across income levels and regions; every major one-party state; military-led regimes; the two most frequently cited technocratic-developmental autocracies (Singapore and Rwanda, plus Ethiopia's EPRDF to 2018); and the resource-rich electoral or personalist autocracies that matter for Part XI (Russia, Iran, Iraq, Libya, Kazakhstan, Azerbaijan, Turkmenistan, Angola, Equatorial Guinea, Gabon, Chad, Venezuela, Algeria, Nigeria). North Korea and Eritrea are coded but have almost no economic data.

Types. Each country-decade is coded into one of nine working types (the seven Part VII systems plus two

residual autocratic categories):

Code	Type	Defining feature used for coding	Examples
AM	Absolute monarchy	Hereditary ruler holds executive and legislative supremacy; no binding elected legislature	Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Oman, Brunei, Eswatini
SCM	Semi-constitutional (ruling) monarchy	Monarch rules, but an elected legislature has real powers over budget or ministers	Kuwait, Bahrain (from 2002), Jordan, Morocco
CMD	Constitutional monarchy, democratic	Monarch is head of state without executive power; competitive elections	Norway, Spain, Japan, UK, Bhutan from 2008, Malaysia from 2018
PRD	Presidential or semi-presidential democracy	Directly elected executive; competitive elections	USA, Brazil, Indonesia, Korea, France, Ghana
PAD	Parliamentary republic, democratic	Executive responsible to parliament	Germany, India, Italy, Botswana, South Africa
OPA	One-party authoritarian	Single legal or hegemonic ruling party	China, Vietnam, Laos, Cuba, Cambodia from 2018
TEC	Technocratic / developmental dominant-party authoritarian	Dominant party, limited competition, explicit performance legitimacy and professionalised bureaucracy	Singapore, Rwanda, Ethiopia (EPRDF)
MIL	Military-led	Armed forces control or veto executive	Myanmar, Thailand 2014–23, Egypt from 2013, Sudan, Algeria, Mali from 2020
EPA	Electoral or personalist autocracy (residual)	Unfair elections and/or personalised power	Russia, Iran, Kazakhstan, Belarus, Equatorial Guinea, Venezuela from 2005
FS	Failed/contested/occupied (excluded)	No effective national government	Iraq 2005–14, Libya 2015–24, Syria 2015–24

This typology follows BRIEF Part II's insistence that monarchy and dictatorship not be used interchangeably: a ruling monarchy is coded as such whether or not it is "electoral", and constitutional monarchies are coded by their regime (Thailand, Cambodia and pre-2018 Malaysia are monarchies in form but not ruled by the monarch). It is closest in spirit to Geddes, Wright and Frantz's autocratic typology (2014) [E] extended to democracies, but it is a Hark coding, not a reproduction of their dataset (which ends in 2010).

Changes within decades are coded with the type that held for most years and flagged (`chg_P*`=1): 36 of 285 country-decades changed type. Robustness tables re-run all medians on stable country-decades only (`data/r4/r4_group_stats_stable_only.csv`).

Cross-check against Regimes of the World. For every country-decade with RoW data (282; Brunei is not covered), the democracy/autocracy split implied by the R4 coding was compared with the RoW modal category. They agree in 272 cases. The ten disagreements are all contested hybrids: Nepal 1995–2004 and 2005–2014, Lesotho 1995–2004, the Philippines 2005–2014 and 2015–2024, Kenya 2005–2014 and 2015–2024, India 2015–2024 and Malaysia 2015–2024 (R4 codes democracy, RoW codes electoral autocracy for most years), and Nigeria 2015–2024 (R4 codes electoral autocracy, RoW codes electoral democracy for 60% of years). All global statistical tests in §3.8 use RoW, not the R4 coding, so they do not depend on these judgements.

2.3 Periods, aggregation and the resource split

- **Periods.** P1 = 1995–2004, P2 = 2005–2014, P3 = 2015–2024. These are ten-year, non-overlapping windows (the brief's suggested 1995–2005, 2005–2015, 2015–2024 overlap at the endpoints). P1 begins after the post-Soviet transitions and the first WGI year (1996); P2 contains the 2003–2014 commodity super-cycle and the 2008–09 crisis; P3 contains the 2014–16 oil collapse, COVID-19 and the 2022 energy shock.
- **Growth** is the mean of annual real per-capita growth rates; compound annual growth of PPP GDP per capita gives near-identical rankings. Growth of GDP per worker and of PWT TFP are compound annual rates between period end-points (TFP ends in 2019).
- **Levels** (income, HDI, life expectancy, mortality, schooling) are the last available value in the period; distribution and poverty use the latest survey in the period and record its year.
- **Group statistics** are medians, with the 25th–75th percentiles, standard deviation, minimum and maximum (`data/r4/r4_group_stats.csv`). Medians are used because the Gulf, Equatorial Guinea and Guyana produce extreme values.
- **Resource split.** Each country-decade is "high-rent" if mean total natural-resource rents exceeded 10% of GDP over the period (WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS; for P3 the mean covers 2015–2021, the last WDI year). The 10% threshold follows the brief and approximates the conventional line used in the resource-curse literature [E].

2.4 Global sample

For the variance tests (§3.8), every country with an HDR code and at least eight years of growth and RoW data in a decade is included: 168 countries in P1 and 169 in P2 and P3. Each country-decade is classified by its modal RoW category and as an autocracy (closed or electoral) or democracy (electoral or liberal). Regressions add the log of initial GDP per capita (PPP), mean rents and period dummies with standard errors clustered by country.

2.5 What this design can and cannot show

The design describes associations between regime type and outcomes over thirty years. It cannot by itself identify causal effects, for five reasons that the report returns to in §7:

1. **Reverse causation.** Income and growth affect regime type (wealthy democracies survive; growth collapses topple dictators). Przeworski et al. (2000) showed that democracies are much more likely to survive in wealthy societies [V].
2. **Omitted variables.** Geography, colonial history, state antiquity, ethnic structure, hydrocarbons and external security guarantees affect both regime and outcomes.
3. **Survivorship.** Today's monarchies are the survivors of a larger post-1945 population; failed monarchies exit the category and often enter "military" or "personalist" categories, depressing those groups' averages.
4. **Measurement.** WGI and V-Dem are perception- or expert-based; Gulf GDP per capita uses residents; PWT TFP for oil economies attributes oil-price and depletion effects to "productivity".
5. **Small, clustered cells.** Five of six absolute monarchies are hydrocarbon exporters in one region with one external security patron.

The causal claims made later in this report are therefore taken from studies with explicit identification strategies (leader deaths, regional democratisation waves, long within-country panels), and the R4 dataset is used to check whether their conclusions are consistent with the most recent decade and with the specific cases the brief cares about.

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3. Part VI — The comparative economic-performance dataset

All tables in this section are generated by `data/r4/analyze.py`, `analyze3.py` and `analyze4.py` from `data/r4/r4_country_period.csv`. Unless noted: unit as stated in §2.1; population = total residents; source = World Bank WDI (API, last updated 8 October 2026), UNDP HDR 2025, World Bank WGI (updated 25 September 2026), IMF WEO DataMapper, PWT 10.01.

3.1 Growth and income by regime type

Table 3.1. Median outcomes by regime type, three decades (R4 sample).

Type	n (P3)	GDP pc growth P1 1995–2004 (%/yr)	P2 2005–2014	P3 2015–2024	GDP pc PPP 2024 (2021 $)	GDP per worker growth P3 (%/yr)	TFP growth P3, to 2019 (%/yr)	Rents % GDP, P3 mean
Absolute monarchy (AM)	6	0.59 (n=8)	0.28	-0.53	66,448	-0.82	-3.60	20.1
Semi-constitutional monarchy (SCM)	4	1.98 (n=3)	0.59	0.10	28,566	-0.50	-1.93	7.2
Constitutional monarchy, democratic (CMD)	15	2.39	0.75	0.90	57,534	0.45	0.17	0.8
Presidential democracy (PRD)	16	1.83	3.19	1.20	20,811	1.20	-0.01	2.1
Parliamentary republic (PAD)	15	3.11	2.07	1.85	42,228	0.89	0.48	0.4
One-party (OPA)	5	4.26	4.91	4.13	11,498	4.52	-0.79	1.3
Technocratic authoritarian (TEC)	2	3.24 (n=3)	5.09 (n=3)	3.36	(SGP 134,549; RWA 3,325)	2.50	-0.85	2.5
Military-led (MIL)	6	2.53 (n=5)	1.32 (n=3)	0.94	10,389	1.59	0.81	6.6
Electoral/personalist autocracy (EPA)	22	2.89 (n=24)	2.69 (n=26)	1.20	10,997	0.86	-0.98	11.5

Notes: growth = mean of annual real GDP-per-capita growth (WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG). GDP pc = WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.PP.KD, latest year 2024 (Cuba, North Korea, Eritrea and Venezuela missing). GDP per worker = WDI SL.GDP.PCAP.EM.KD, compound rate 2014–2024. TFP = PWT 10.01 rtfpna, compound rate 2014–2019; n for TFP is smaller (no series for UAE, Oman, Brunei, Vietnam and others). Rents = WDI NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS mean of available years 2015–2021. Membership of each group: `data/r4/r4_group_stats_resource_split.csv` column `members`.

Figure R4-1 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig1_growth_by_type.png`) shows every country as a dot.

Four patterns stand out.

First, the monarchies grew least per head, in every decade. The absolute-monarchy median was the lowest of the nine types in P2 and P3 and the second-lowest in P1. Semi-constitutional monarchies were close behind. This is not a story about a single bad decade: Kuwait's per-capita growth was negative in both P2 (-1.84%) and P3 (-2.44%); the UAE's was negative in all three decades (-0.88%, -2.14%, -0.57%).

Second, the monarchies are nonetheless rich. The absolute-monarchy median income (~$66,400) exceeds the constitutional-monarchy (~$57,500) and parliamentary-republic (~$42,200) medians. Qatar ($111,300), Brunei ($79,100) and the UAE ($69,700) are among the highest PPP incomes in the world even after a decade of decline. The monarchies reached high income *before* 1995 — in most cases within a generation of oil exports — and have since been converging *downward* in per-resident terms.

Third, the fastest per-capita growth came from one-party and technocratic autocracies. China (8.3%, 9.4%, 5.5% a year across the three decades), Vietnam (5.8%, 4.9%, 5.1%), Laos, Rwanda (9.5%, 5.1%, 4.4%) and Ethiopia under the EPRDF drive these medians. This is the empirical core of the "developmental authoritarianism" argument, and §3.8 and §4 examine how representative it is.

Fourth, democracies grew at moderate rates with low dispersion. The parliamentary-republic median was 1.85–3.11% across decades; constitutional monarchies (mostly rich European democracies near the frontier) grew slowest among democracies, consistent with convergence: rich countries grow slower.

The last point is crucial for interpreting the first three. Growth rates fall with income. The richest groups (absolute monarchies, constitutional monarchies) grew slowest; the poorest (one-party, technocratic Rwanda/Ethiopia) grew fastest. §3.8 shows that once initial income is controlled, the autocracy–democracy difference in average growth is small and statistically insignificant. The monarchy result survives that control, however, because the Gulf monarchies grew slowly *for* their income and *despite* rents — the subject of the next two subsections.

3.2 Total versus per-capita growth: the Gulf denominator problem

Table 3.2. Total GDP, population and per-capita growth in ruling monarchies and comparators (% per year, period means).

Country	Type	P1 total GDP	P1 population	P1 per capita	P2 total	P2 pop.	P2 per cap.	P3 total	P3 pop.	P3 per cap.
Saudi Arabia	AM	3.02	4.43	-1.35	4.62	3.71	0.89	3.03	2.23	0.84
UAE	AM	5.69	6.64	-0.88	3.84	6.17	-2.14	2.62	3.15	-0.57
Qatar	AM	9.43	4.47	4.76	12.42	10.78	1.56	1.48	2.88	-1.24
Oman	AM	2.41	1.45	0.94	4.81	5.23	-0.33	2.08	2.81	-0.73
Brunei	AM	1.79	2.19	-0.40	-0.27	1.68	-1.92	0.55	1.05	-0.50
Kuwait	SCM	4.53	2.63	1.87	3.51	5.45	-1.84	0.43	2.94	-2.44
Bahrain	AM->SCM	4.46	4.23	0.23	5.00	4.78	0.21	2.68	1.91	0.74
Jordan	SCM	4.60	2.58	1.98	5.07	4.10	0.96	2.19	2.77	-0.55
Morocco	SCM	3.91	1.43	2.42	4.28	1.34	2.87	2.61	1.08	1.50
Norway	CMD	3.16	0.57	2.57	1.70	1.13	0.57	1.72	0.82	0.90
Singapore	TEC	5.29	2.00	3.24	6.13	2.76	3.30	3.29	0.99	2.33
Malaysia	EPA->CMD	5.33	2.45	2.80	4.94	1.97	2.92	4.01	1.48	2.50

Sources: WDI NY.GDP.MKTP.KD.ZG (total), SP.POP.TOTL (compound population growth, end-year over year before start), NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG (per capita). Population = total residents.

The Gulf monarchies are not slow-growing economies in aggregate. Saudi Arabia's total GDP grew 3.0–4.6% a year, Qatar's 12.4% a year in 2005–2014. What is distinctive is that **population grew nearly as fast as output**, because hydrocarbon revenue financed construction and services employing large numbers of migrant workers. Per-capita (per-resident) growth is the residual. Two interpretations follow, and the data cannot fully separate them:

- *Benign reading:* the growth of resident population is a deliberate labour-import model; citizens' incomes could have risen even as average resident income fell, because migrants earn less than citizens. Without citizen-only national accounts (which no GCC state publishes) this cannot be tested directly.

- *Critical reading:* output per worker fell (Table 3.1 and §3.3), meaning the model expanded low-productivity employment in non-tradables financed by rents, the pattern rentier-state theory predicts (Mahdavy 1970; Beblawi and Luciani 1987) [E].

Both readings imply that **growth in the Gulf model has been extensive (more inputs) rather than intensive (more output per input)**, which is the distinction BRIEF Part VI asks the project to draw between resource-driven and productivity-driven development.

3.3 Productivity: output per worker and total factor productivity

Figure R4-4 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig4_tfp.png`) plots PWT 10.01 TFP (2017=1) for 1990–2019. Saudi Arabia's TFP index was about 2.0 in the mid-1990s and reached 1.0 in 2017; Kuwait's peaked near 2.25 in 2005; Qatar's near 2.3 in 2000. Compound TFP growth over 2005–2014 was -4.2% a year in Saudi Arabia, -4.5% in Qatar and -4.8% in Kuwait; over 2014–2019 it was -3.6%, -6.6% and -7.5%. By contrast TFP rose over 1990–2017 in China (~0.80->1.0), Korea (~0.74->1.0) and Morocco (~0.98->1.0, with gains after 2000), and was broadly flat in Norway and Singapore.

Two cautions apply. PWT measures TFP at constant national prices; in a hydrocarbon economy, depletion, OPEC quota changes and the shift from oil to capital-intensive gas and petrochemicals all register as TFP changes, and rents (returns to a natural asset, not to labour or produced capital) are inside measured output. The very high 1990s TFP levels therefore partly reflect rent, not efficiency. Even allowing for this, **no Gulf monarchy shows rising measured productivity over the three decades**, and GDP per worker (an independent series using ILO-modelled employment) tells the same story: the absolute-monarchy median fell 0.19% a year in P1, 2.20% in P2 and 0.82% in P3, while one-party states' rose 5.0%, 5.2% and 4.5%, and democracies' rose 0.4–2.7%.

This matters for Part X. The Gulf development record is a record of **converting a natural endowment into consumption, infrastructure and financial assets** — often skilfully — but not (yet) of building a high-productivity non-resource economy. Vision 2030-type programmes are attempts to change exactly this, and their success should be judged on productivity and citizen employment in tradables, not on headline GDP (handed to R1).

3.4 Resource-adjusted comparisons

Table 3.4. 2015–2024 medians by bloc and resource intensity.

Bloc × rents	n	GDP pc growth (%/yr)	GDP pc PPP 2024	HDI 2023	WGI government effective-ness	WGI voice & account-ability	TFP growth 2014–19
Ruling monarchy, high-rent	7 (SAU, ARE, QAT, OMN, BRN, KWT, BHR)	-0.57	63,194	0.89	0.32	-1.00	-5.12
Ruling monarchy, low-rent	3 (SWZ, JOR, MAR)	1.38	10,386	0.71	-0.08	-0.72	-1.94
Non-monarchic autocracy, high-rent	12	0.51	16,493	0.75	-0.63	-1.17	-0.78
Non-monarchic autocracy, low-rent	22	1.92	7,012	0.61	-0.51	-1.21	-0.31

Bloc × rents	n	GDP pc growth (%/yr)	GDP pc PPP 2024	HDI 2023	WGI government effective-ness	WGI voice & account-ability	TFP growth 2014–19
Democracy, high-rent	1 (Ghana)	2.35	7,073	0.63	0.06	0.40	n/a
Democracy, low-rent	45	1.25	42,228	0.91	1.02	1.01	0.25

High-rent = mean natural-resource rents >10% of GDP over 2015–2021 (WDI). Chile, Peru and Ghana were high-rent democracies in P2 (median growth 4.57%); Norway's rents (6.0% of GDP in P3) fall below the threshold. Sources as §2.1.

By type in P3, the five high-rent absolute monarchies (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Oman, Brunei) had median growth -0.57%, income $69,700, HDI 0.89 and government effectiveness +0.90; the eleven high-rent electoral/personalist autocracies (Russia, Iran, Iraq, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, Chad, Equatorial Guinea, Angola, Gabon) had +0.70%, $17,500, 0.74 and -0.74.

What the resource split shows:

1. **Within high-rent autocracies, monarchies are far richer and better governed than non-monarchies.** This is the strongest descriptive "monarchy advantage" in the dataset. It is consistent with Menaldo's (2012) finding for MENA 1950–2006 that monarchs are more likely to respect the rule of law and property rights and grow their economies [E], and with Knutsen and Fjelde (2013) [V].
2. **But the advantage is confounded with rent per head.** The high-rent monarchies have rents of roughly $9,000–20,000 per resident (2021) and far more per citizen ($10,000 in Brunei to $144,000 in Qatar; R6, `data/rents_per_capita.csv`), against $940 in Algeria, $680 in Angola and $2,100 in Iraq. Small citizen populations sitting on very large resource stocks can buy high living standards, loyal elites and competent expatriate administrators under almost any regime form. Equatorial Guinea — a personalist regime whose resource rents averaged 68% of GDP in 1995–2004 and 41% in 2005–2014 — shows that rents alone are not sufficient: its per-capita income fell 7.1% a year in 2015–2024 and its HDI residual is negative.
3. **Low-rent monarchies are ordinary middle-income performers.** Jordan, Morocco and Eswatini look like other lower-middle-income countries on growth and governance; Morocco's 2.9% per-capita growth in P2 and Jordan's strong health outcomes are respectable, Eswatini's life expectancy (64 years in 2024 after the HIV crisis) and 54.6 Gini (2016) are not. Monarchy without large rents carries no visible economic premium.
4. **Low-rent democracies are the richest and best-governed group overall**, but much of this is the European and East Asian high-income core, which became rich before the period. Their growth (1.25%) is lower than low-rent autocracies' (1.92%), consistent with convergence.

3.5 Human development and whether income is broadly shared

Table 3.5. Human-development outcomes, end of P3 (medians).

Type	Life expectancy, 2024 (years)	Under-5 mortality, 2024 (per 1,000)	HDI, 2023	Mean years of schooling, 2023	Median HDI residual vs income	Median life-exp. residual vs income (years)
AM	79.6	8.0	0.87	11.2	-0.007	-1.79
SCM	79.7	10.9	0.80	8.9	+0.008	+2.93
CMD	82.3	3.9	0.94	12.7	+0.027	+0.65
PRD	77.7	11.8	0.79	9.7	+0.009	+1.51
PAD	80.0	3.8	0.91	11.6	+0.015	+0.33
OPA	73.7	17.3	0.69	7.0	-0.003	+2.83

Type	Life expectancy, 2024 (years)	Under-5 mortality, 2024 (per 1,000)	HDI, 2023	Mean years of schooling, 2023	Median HDI residual vs income	Median life-exp. residual vs income (years)
TEC	75.7	20.2	0.76	8.4	-0.007	+0.60
MIL	69.5	29.7	0.68	6.9	-0.011	+0.23
EPA	71.1	30.4	0.70	9.3	-0.010	-1.31

Residuals: from OLS of 2023 HDI (and life expectancy) on log GNI per capita and its square, 193 countries, UNDP HDR 2025 ($R^2 = 0.93$ for HDI, 0.74 for life expectancy). HDI includes income, so its residual is partly mechanical; the life-expectancy and schooling residuals are cleaner. File: `data/r4/r4_hdi_income_residuals_2023.csv`. Individual mean-years-of-schooling values are in `r4_country_period.csv`.

Figure R4-5 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig5_hdi_vs_income.png`) plots HDI against income.

The monarchies' human-development record has two faces:

- **Large absolute gains.** Between 1995 and 2024 Saudi under-5 mortality fell from about 17 (2004) to 6 per 1,000, Omani mean schooling rose from 6.6 years (2004) to 11.9 (2023), and Saudi mean schooling from 7.5 to 11.6. These are real achievements of state-financed health and education systems [V, WDI/HDR].
- **Mixed conversion of income into well-being.** Ranked against what their incomes predict, Brunei (HDI residual -0.107; life expectancy 7.2 years below prediction; schooling 3.5 years below), Qatar (-0.094; -2.3 years; -2.6 years) and Kuwait (-0.060; schooling -4.6 years) are clear under-performers; Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Oman and Bahrain sit on the international line. Jordan (+0.057, life expectancy +7.1 years) and Morocco (life expectancy +4.9 years) over-perform. One-party states over-perform strongly on life expectancy (+2.8 years median; China +2.7, Vietnam +2.1), which echoes the classic finding that socialist states achieved good health outcomes at low incomes [E].

Part of the Gulf under-performance is a denominator artefact again: national accounts include migrant workers and their output, while schooling averages include a large adult migrant population with lower average education. Since UNDP does not publish citizen-only HDI, the residuals cannot be decomposed.

Distribution. For 2015–2024, WDI has a Gini coefficient for only three absolute monarchies (UAE 26.4 in 2018, Qatar 35.1 in 2017, Eswatini 54.6 in 2016) and none for the semi-constitutional monarchies in that decade; it has no Gini for Saudi Arabia, Oman, Brunei, Kuwait or Bahrain at any point in 1995–2024. The poverty headcount at the international line is 0.0% for the UAE and Qatar (household surveys of residents) and 44.5% for Eswatini (2016). UNDP's inequality-adjusted HDI is missing for Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait and Bahrain. The brief asks "whether high GDP per capita translates into broadly distributed prosperity"; for the Gulf, **the honest answer is that the public statistical record does not allow this to be measured**, and that the ruling households' ownership of assets and the citizen/non-citizen divide (in wages, rights and welfare access) are the two dimensions on which inequality is most likely to be high [E; interpretation: Hertog 2010; Herb 2014]. Eswatini — the one absolute monarchy without large rents — has one of the highest measured inequalities in the world.

3.6 Institutional quality, corruption and political stability

Figure R4-6 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig6_wgi_heatmap.png`) and Table 3.6 give WGI medians for 2015–2024.

Table 3.6. Median WGI and V-Dem scores, 2015–2024 means.

Type	Gov. effectiveness	Regulatory quality	Rule of law	Control of corruption	Political stability	Voice & accountability	V-Dem judicial constraints on executive (0–1)	V-Dem legislative constraints (0–1)
AM	0.57	0.66	0.34	0.53	0.66	-1.11	0.34	0.14
SCM	0.09	0.15	0.04	-0.04	-0.43	-0.70	0.66	0.70
CMD	1.78	1.66	1.60	1.74	0.87	1.44	0.92	0.91
PRD	0.19	0.18	-0.17	-0.22	-0.19	0.38	0.83	0.87
PAD	1.01	0.88	0.85	0.74	0.66	0.83	0.87	0.88
OPA	-0.43	-0.75	-0.80	-1.03	-0.13	-1.62	0.10	0.09
TEC	1.16	1.14	0.72	1.30	0.65	-0.43	0.50	0.43
MIL	-0.72	-0.82	-0.83	-0.72	-1.41	-1.16	0.44	0.31
EPA	-0.74	-0.87	-1.00	-1.01	-0.77	-1.19	0.14	0.15

WGI estimates ~ -2.5 (weak) to +2.5 (strong), World Bank WGI 2025 release. V-Dem indices via OWID. TEC = Singapore and Rwanda only.

Absolute monarchies sit in an unusual position: **above zero on every "state capacity" indicator (effectiveness, regulation, rule of law, corruption control, stability) and far below zero on voice and accountability**, with the lowest legislative constraints of any type except one-party states. The technocratic pair (Singapore, Rwanda) is more extreme: effectiveness and corruption control at or above many democracies, voice negative. No other autocratic type has a positive effectiveness median.

Two cautions. WGI effectiveness and corruption measures aggregate surveys of firms, experts and residents; in the Gulf, the respondents are disproportionately international business, which experiences efficient ports, licensing and free zones, and may not observe allocation within ruling families or treatment of migrant labour. And the Gulf's positive scores are concentrated in the richest members (UAE +1.10, Qatar +0.90, Brunei +0.97 for effectiveness) and lower in Saudi Arabia (+0.25), Oman (+0.15) and Kuwait (+0.08); Eswatini is negative (-0.57).

Globally (195 countries, 2015–2024 means; `data/r4/r4_global_wgi_2015_2024.csv`), government effectiveness and voice and accountability are strongly correlated (r = 0.77; 0.82 within democracies; 0.54 within autocracies). Only **7 of 82 autocracies** have effectiveness above +0.5 — Singapore, Hong Kong, the UAE, Qatar, Malaysia, Hungary and China — against **49 of 113 democracies**. Two of the seven (UAE, Qatar) are high-rent Gulf monarchies, one (Hong Kong) is not sovereign, and two (Malaysia, Hungary) are borderline electoral regimes. The median autocracy scores -0.54, the median democracy +0.34. Capable autocracies exist, but they are rare and concentrated in small, wealthy, trade-oriented or rent-rich polities.

3.7 Investment, savings, diversification, private sector, FDI, debt and sovereign wealth

Table 3.7. Selected structural indicators, 2015–2024 medians (n in brackets).

Type	Gross fixed capital formation % GDP	Adjusted net savings % GNI	R&D % GDP	Tax revenue % GDP	High-tech % of manuf. exports	Fuel % of merch. exports	Private credit % GDP	FDI inflow % GDP	Gen. govt gross debt % GDP (IMF)
AM	27.6 (4)	14.3 (5)	0.38 (6)	6.3 (3)	3.1 (6)	76.1 (6)	58.2 (6)	1.5 (6)	28.7 (6)
SCM	26.8 (3)	10.4 (4)	0.19 (3)	14.4 (3)	2.0 (4)	14.1 (4)	70.7 (4)	2.2 (4)	69.9 (4)
CMD	23.8 (15)	11.3 (15)	1.87 (15)	23.6 (14)	16.1 (15)	6.8 (15)	125.4 (14)	1.5 (15)	52.6 (15)

Type	Gross fixed capital formation % GDP	Adjusted net savings % GNI	R&D % GDP	Tax revenue % GDP	High-tech % of manuf. exports	Fuel % of merch. exports	Private credit % GDP	FDI inflow % GDP	Gen. govt gross debt % GDP (IMF)
PRD	20.5 (16)	6.4 (16)	0.54 (15)	14.1 (14)	9.6 (16)	5.8 (16)	46.7 (16)	2.4 (16)	58.5 (16)
PAD	23.3 (15)	10.1 (15)	1.40 (13)	21.4 (15)	10.9 (15)	2.6 (15)	75.3 (15)	3.3 (15)	63.5 (15)
OPA	30.3 (5)	16.4 (4)	0.42 (4)	11.7 (3)	24.7 (5)	1.6 (5)	108.9 (3)	4.6 (5)	65.5 (5)
TEC	24.8 (2)	13.4 (2)	1.35 (2)	13.4 (2)	31.1 (2)	6.0 (2)	71.9 (2)	14.1 (2)	93.4 (2)
MIL	22.9 (5)	15.4 (6)	0.43 (5)	12.0 (5)	3.1 (6)	22.5 (6)	23.4 (6)	2.5 (6)	48.3 (6)
EPA	21.2 (21)	9.2 (17)	0.20 (17)	11.4 (16)	4.0 (17)	34.0 (18)	14.3 (19)	1.7 (22)	39.3 (21)

Sources: WDI codes in §2.1; IMF DataMapper. Singapore's gross debt (165.8% of GDP in 2024) reflects securities issued to fund the Central Provident Fund and reserves, not deficit financing; it is matched by assets.

Readings:

- **Investment and saving.** Absolute monarchies and one-party states invest and save the most. High saving in the monarchies is largely the mechanical counterpart of rent; adjusted net savings (which subtracts resource depletion) remain positive at a median 14% of GNI, which means the median monarchy is, on this World Bank measure, not running down its total wealth [V, WDI NY.ADJ.SVNG.GN.ZS] — but the measure depends on assumed extraction costs and asset returns.
- **Diversification and innovation.** Fuel was a median 76% of merchandise exports in absolute monarchies (Brunei 85%, Qatar 86%, Kuwait 94%, Saudi Arabia 79%, UAE 60%); research spending was 0.38% of GDP; high-technology goods were 3% of manufactured exports. One-party and technocratic states, by contrast, export high-tech goods heavily (China, Vietnam, Singapore), though often through foreign-owned assembly. Diversification in the Gulf has advanced most in services (aviation, logistics, finance, tourism in the UAE), which merchandise-export measures miss.
- **Taxation.** Tax revenue was 6.3% of GDP in the three absolute monarchies reporting it, versus 21–24% in the democracies. This is the fiscal heart of rentier-state theory: governments that do not tax are less dependent on, and less answerable to, citizens (Beblawi and Luciani 1987; Ross 2012) [E]. The UAE (VAT 2018, corporate income tax 2023) and Saudi Arabia (VAT 2018, raised to 15% in 2020) have begun to change this [E].
- **Private sector.** Private credit in absolute monarchies (58% of GDP) is about half the constitutional-monarchy median; FDI inflows (1.5% of GDP) are no higher than in other types, despite the free-zone strategy. Electoral and personalist autocracies have extremely thin private credit (14% of GDP), consistent with the "personalist penalty" mechanism of low private investment (§4.3).
- **Public debt.** Gross general-government debt was low in the monarchies (28.7% median) but rose quickly after the 2014–16 oil-price collapse: Saudi Arabia 1.5% of GDP (2014) -> 29.7% (2020) -> 25.9% (2024); Oman 4.0% -> 67.9% (2020) -> 35.5%; Bahrain 42.6% -> 133.7% (2024); Qatar 24.9% -> 72.6% (2020) -> 41.4%. Kuwait and Brunei stayed low (2.9% and 1.6% in 2024). The variation follows rent per citizen and buffer size more than regime type: Bahrain and Oman, the "poor" Gulf monarchies, borrowed heavily; Kuwait, with a very large buffer per citizen, did not need to (and its National Assembly did not pass a new public-debt law after the previous one lapsed in 2017 [E]).

Sovereign wealth. Table 3.7b combines R1's fund estimates with R6's citizen counts.

Table 3.7b. Sovereign-fund assets per citizen (estimates).

Country	Citizens (year)	Citizens % of residents	SWF assets counted (US$ bn)	Per citizen (US$)	Per resident (US$)
UAE (all federal and emirate funds listed by R1)	1.30 m (2021)	13.6	2,674	~2,050,000	~279,000
Qatar (QIA)	0.34 m (2020)	13.6	580	~1,700,000	~232,000
Kuwait (KIA)	1.49 m (2021)	33.8	1,002	~673,000	~228,000
Brunei (BIA)	0.33 m (2021)	73.8	73	~219,000	~162,000
Saudi Arabia (PIF only)	18.4 m (2021)	59.7	906	~49,000	~29,000
Bahrain (Mumtalakat + FGR)	0.72 m (2021)	47.9	18.9	~26,000	~13,000
Oman (OIA)	2.77 m (2021)	61.5	60	~22,000	~13,000

Sources: `data/r4/r4_gulf_citizen_swf.csv`, built from `data/R1_gulf_swf_assets.csv` (Global SWF ranking, https://globalswf.com/ranking, "last updated November 2026"; most Gulf funds — ADIA, KIA, QIA, BIA — publish no AUM, so these are third-party estimates) and `data/rents_per_capita.csv` (R6; citizen counts from national statistics via the Gulf Labour Markets and Migration programme, GLMM; UAE and Qatar are GLMM estimates). PIF excludes SAMA reserves and GOSI. Assets at Nov 2026, citizens at 2020–2021: per-citizen values are orders of magnitude, not precise figures.

The table explains more of the Gulf's internal variation than any institutional variable: three monarchies (UAE, Qatar, Kuwait) hold sovereign assets of the order of $0.7–2 million per citizen; Saudi Arabia, Oman and Bahrain hold one to two orders of magnitude less. The "Gulf model" is therefore not one model: it ranges from very rich city-state rentiers to middle-income states with large citizen populations and real fiscal constraints. This is also why the political-stability ranking within the GCC (Bahrain's 2011 uprising, Oman's 2011 protests, Kuwait's parliamentary deadlock) tracks wealth per citizen [E; interpretation: Herb 2014; Yom and Gause 2012].

3.8 The variance question: are autocratic outcomes more dispersed?

The brief asks the project to address "the high variance of autocratic outcomes". This is tested on the global RoW sample, not on the hand-picked 95.

Table 3.8. Decade-average GDP-per-capita growth, all countries with data, by Regimes of the World category.

Period	Category	n	Mean	Median	s.d.	10th pct	90th pct	Min	Max
1995–2004	Democracies	83	2.64	2.35	2.41	0.49	5.16	-3.32	14.17
1995–2004	Autocracies	85	3.08	2.31	4.66	-0.24	6.35	-3.41	36.87
2005–2014	Democracies	89	2.39	2.41	1.84	0.30	4.59	-1.78	7.12
2005–2014	Autocracies	80	2.80	2.47	2.67	0.02	6.24	-4.01	10.67
2015–2024	Democracies	91	1.88	1.50	2.62	-0.20	3.88	-2.21	21.15
2015–2024	Autocracies	78	1.08	1.40	2.81	-2.17	4.15	-9.32	5.51

Sources: WDI NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG; RoW modal category via OWID. Files: `data/r4/r4_global_growth_dem_vs_aut.csv`, `r4_global_growth_by_row.csv`. Extremes: Equatorial Guinea 1995–2004 (36.9%, oil discovery), Guyana 2015–2024 (21.1%, oil), Venezuela 2015–2024 (-9.3%), Sudan 2015–2024 (-7.4%), Equatorial Guinea 2015–2024 (-7.1%).

Figure R4-2 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig2_global_variance.png`) shows the distributions.

Results:

1. **Medians are almost identical** in every decade (2.31 vs 2.35; 2.47 vs 2.41; 1.40 vs 1.50). Means favour autocracies in P1–P2 (driven by oil booms and China) and democracies in P3 (driven by autocratic collapses).
2. **Dispersion is larger under autocracy.** The s.d. ratio is 1.9 in P1, 1.5 in P2 and 1.1 in P3; a Brown–Forsythe test of equal variances gives p = 0.060, 0.028 and 0.133 respectively. Conditioning on log initial income, mean rents and period, the absolute residual from a growth regression is **0.66 percentage points larger for autocracies** (s.e. 0.22, p = 0.003, 495 country-decades, clustered by country).
3. **Autocracies are over-represented in both tails, more in the lower tail.** Autocracies were 51%, 47% and 46% of country-decades but 53%, 71% and 59% of the top growth decile and 65%, 59% and 71% of the bottom decile.
4. **Average effects are small and insignificant once income is controlled.** Pooled OLS with period dummies: autocracy coefficient +0.08 (p = 0.77) without controls; -0.46 (s.e. 0.44, p = 0.30) with log initial income and rents; -0.36 (p = 0.56) among country-decades with no regime change; log initial income -0.47 (p = 0.002), the conditional-convergence term. An autocracy × high-rent interaction is negative (-1.03) but imprecise (p = 0.31).
5. **The high-rent autocracies are the most volatile group of all** (s.d. 6.74 in P1 against 2.23 for low-rent democracies).

Interpretation. This replicates, with 2015–2024 data, the stylised fact reported by Weede (1996), Rodrik (2000), Almeida and Ferreira (2002), Mobarak (2005) and Easterly (2011): autocracies produce both more miracles and more disasters. It does not show *why*. Easterly (2011) [V] tested three explanations and found the variance is mostly *within* leaders' tenures rather than between leaders, which is inconsistent with the "good autocrat vs bad autocrat" story and most consistent with the view that democracies are better at absorbing shocks from outside the political system — Rodrik's (2000) argument that participatory regimes moderate social conflict and adjust better to shocks [V]. The extra lower-tail mass in P3 (Venezuela, Sudan, Equatorial Guinea, Syria, Afghanistan, Myanmar, Libya) is a reminder that the *downside* of concentrated power is not a mean shift but a fat tail of catastrophe.

3.9 Summary of Part VI

Question (BRIEF Part VI)	Answer from the R4 data	Confidence
Do absolute monarchies have higher GDP per capita?	Yes in levels (median ~$66k PPP), driven by five hydrocarbon states; no for Eswatini	High (descriptive)
Do they grow faster?	No — lowest median per-capita growth in all three decades; total GDP growth moderate	High (descriptive)
Is their growth resource-driven or productivity-driven?	Resource- and labour-input-driven; TFP and GDP per worker falling	Medium-high (PWT caveats)
Does high GDP per capita translate into broad prosperity?	Large absolute gains in health and schooling; mixed conversion relative to income; distribution unmeasurable from public data	Medium
Are institutions better than in other autocracies?	Yes on effectiveness, regulation, corruption control and stability; no on voice and constraints	Medium (perception data)
Are autocratic outcomes more variable?	Yes, especially in the lower tail; average differences small after income controls	Medium-high (global sample)
Is fiscal discipline better?	Low gross debt and high saving while rents are high; debt rose quickly in poorer monarchies after 2014	Medium

4. Literature review: what the empirical research shows

This section reviews the studies named in the brief and the newer work that now frames the debate. For each it gives the question, data, identification strategy, finding, and what it implies for this project. Bibliographic facts and abstracts were opened where marked [V].

4.1 Regime type and average growth

Przeworski, Alvarez, Cheibub and Limongi (2000), *Democracy and Development: Political Institutions and Well-Being in the World, 1950–1990* (Cambridge University Press) [V: publisher description]. Using 135 countries over 1950–1990 and a selection-corrected comparison of regimes, the book's headline is that "political regimes have no impact on the growth of total national incomes, while political instability affects growth only in dictatorships. Per capita incomes grow faster in democracies since population increases faster under dictatorships" and that "democracies are much more likely to survive in wealthy societies". The chapter on income and population reports observed total-income growth of 4.42% under dictatorship and 3.95% under democracy, but per-capita growth of 2.00% and 2.46% respectively [E: Cambridge chapter summary excerpt]. *Implication:* the R4 finding that Gulf monarchies have healthy total growth but weak per-capita growth is a contemporary, migration-driven version of the population effect Przeworski et al. identified through fertility. Their result also warns against reading regime effects from raw growth comparisons: selection on income determines which countries are democracies.

Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo and Robinson (2019), "Democracy Does Cause Growth", *Journal of Political Economy* 127(1): 47–100 [V: NBER w20004 page, published-version citation]. Using a dichotomous democracy measure built from several sources, country fixed effects and rich GDP dynamics, plus GMM, propensity-score and instrumental-variable estimates (regional waves of democratisation and reversals), they find that "democratizations increase GDP per capita by about 20% in the long run", working through investment, schooling, economic reforms, public goods and reduced unrest, and they "find little support for the view that democracy is a constraint on economic growth for less developed economies". *Implication:* this is the best-identified evidence against the "development first, democracy later" argument. It estimates an *average* effect of democratisation; it does not say that no autocracy can grow fast, and it does not separate monarchies from other autocracies.

Doucouliagos and Ulubasoglu (2008), "Democracy and Economic Growth: A Meta-Analysis", *American Journal of Political Science* 52(1): 61–83 [V: EconPapers abstract]. Pooling 483 estimates from 84 studies, they conclude that "democracy does not have a direct impact on economic growth" but has "robust, significant, and positive indirect effects through higher human capital, lower inflation, lower political instability, and higher levels of economic freedom", with democracies possibly associated with larger governments and less free trade, and with country- and region-specific effects.

Colagrossi, Rossignoli and Maggioni (2020), "Does democracy cause growth? A meta-analysis (of 2000 regressions)", *European Journal of Political Economy* 61 [V: IDEAS abstract]. Surveying 188 studies and 2,047 models, they find "a positive and direct effect on economic growth beyond the reach of publication bias, albeit weaker (about one third) of that of human capital", stronger in papers after 2008, with heterogeneity driven by region and decade. *Implication:* the literature moved from "no direct effect" (2008) to "small positive direct effect" (2020), largely because of better panel methods.

Gerring, Bond, Barndt and Moreno (2005), "Democracy and Economic Growth: A Historical Perspective", *World Politics* 57(3): 323–364 [V: Cambridge abstract]. They argue that "democracy must be understood as a stock, rather than a level", so that growth depends on the number of years a country has been democratic; with a democratic-stock measure back to 1900, they find a positive relationship where current regime level shows none [E for the precise empirical result; the stock argument is V]. **Gerring, Thacker and Alfaro (2012), "Democracy and Human Development", *Journal of Politics* 74(1): 1–17** [V: author PDF abstract] apply the same logic to infant mortality and find "only slight evidence" that the current level of democracy matters but "substantial support" for the effect of democratic stock. *Implication:* short spells of democracy (or of autocracy) should not be expected to show their effects within a decade; institutions are capital that accumulates. This cuts both ways for the Gulf: the monarchies' administrative capital has accumulated over decades of continuity, while their democratic stock is near zero.

4.2 Leaders, variance and the "benevolent autocrat"

Jones and Olken (2005), "Do Leaders Matter? National Leadership and Growth Since World War II", *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 120(3): 835–864 [V: IDEAS abstract]. Using deaths of leaders in office as exogenous leadership transitions (1945–2000), they find "robust evidence that leaders matter for growth" and that "the effects of individual leaders are strongest in autocratic settings where there are fewer constraints on a leader's power"; leaders also affect policy outcomes, particularly monetary policy. *Implication:* in autocracies the quality of the individual ruler is a first-order determinant of growth. That is an argument *for* the brief's worry about "excessive dependence on individual leadership" (Part IX), because the same lack of constraints that lets a good leader matter lets a bad one matter as much.

Easterly (2011), "Benevolent Autocrats", NYU Development Research Institute working paper (August 2011 draft) [V: author draft PDF]. Easterly tests three explanations for the higher variance of growth under autocracy: (1) leaders matter only under autocracy (good and bad autocrats); (2) good and bad autocratic *systems*; (3) democracy reduces variance from shocks outside the political system. He finds that "the variance of growth within the terms of leaders swamps the variance across leaders, and more so under autocracy than under democracy", that country effects under autocracy are "overwhelmed by within-country variance", and that explanation (3) "fits the stylized facts the best". He also argues that the popularity of the benevolent-autocrat story reflects a preference for heroic narratives over evidence. *Implication:* the high variance of autocratic outcomes, which §3.8 reproduces, is not good evidence that some autocrats are reliably benevolent.

Rodrik (2000), "Participatory Politics, Social Cooperation, and Economic Stability", *American Economic Review* 90(2): 140–144 [V: Harvard DASH full text]. Rodrik draws attention to the regularity that "participatory political regimes are associated with significantly lower levels of aggregate economic instability" and speculates that democracy moderates social conflict and induces compromise; the companion NBER paper "Institutions for High-Quality Growth" calls democracy "a meta-institution for building good institutions" [E: SSRN abstract]. **Almeida and Ferreira (2002), *Economics & Politics*** [E] formally show autocracies have more variable growth both within and across countries; **Mobarak (2005), *Review of Economics and Statistics*** [E] finds the democracy–stability link robust when instrumenting democracy. **Weede (1996)** is the early statement of the stylised fact [E].

Rizio and Skali (2020), "How often do dictators have positive economic effects? Global evidence, 1858–2010", *The Leadership Quarterly* 31(3): 101302 [V: University of Groningen research portal abstract]. In 133 countries over 1858–2010, "growth-positive autocrats … are found only as frequently as would be predicted by chance", while "growth-negative autocrats are found significantly more frequently"; regression-discontinuity estimates around leaders' entry suggest growth-positive autocrats "largely 'ride the wave' of previous success". *Implication:* the asymmetry — good autocrats no more common than chance, bad autocrats more common — matches §3.8's fatter lower tail.

4.3 Varieties of autocracy: what makes some work

Besley and Kudamatsu (2008), "Making Autocracy Work", in E. Helpman (ed.), *Institutions and Economic Performance* (Harvard University Press) [V: LSE Research Online abstract]. They model accountability without elections: leadership turnover is managed by a "selectorate", and "good policy is institutionalized when the selectorate removes poorly performing leaders from office", which "requires that the selectorate's hold on power is not too dependent on a specific leader being in office". Empirically, "leadership turnover in successful autocracies is higher than in unsuccessful autocracies", and, exploiting natural deaths, "successful autocracies appear to have found ways for selectorates to nominate successors without losing power". *Implication:* the key institutional feature of a successful autocracy is not the concentration of power in one person but a durable group that can discipline and replace the person. The Chinese Communist Party between 1978 and 2012 (collective leadership, term limits) and, arguably, the Al Saud family council model are the paradigm cases; both have recently moved towards greater personal concentration (term limits removed in China in 2018 [E]; crown-prince centralisation in Saudi Arabia since 2017 [E]), which by this logic raises risk.

Wright (2008), "Do Authoritarian Institutions Constrain? How Legislatures Affect Economic Growth and Investment", *American Journal of Political Science* 52(2): 322–343 [V: EconPapers abstract]. In 121 authoritarian regimes (1950–2002), "binding legislatures have a positive impact on economic growth and domestic investment, while nonbinding legislatures have a negative impact". Crucially, regimes

dependent on natural-resource revenue tend to create *non-binding* legislatures used "to bribe and split the opposition", whereas regimes dependent on domestic investment create binding ones as a credible constraint. *Implication:* Kuwait's National Assembly (binding on budgets, now suspended) and the Gulf's consultative councils (non-binding) sit on either side of this line; the rentier logic predicts the latter.

Knutsen and Fjelde (2013), "Property rights in dictatorships: kings protect property better than generals or party bosses", *Contemporary Politics* 19(1): 94–114 [V: PRIO publication page]. (The brief cites this as "regime type and property rights"; the correct journal is *Contemporary Politics*, not *International Political Science Review*.) Distinguishing monarchies, military regimes, one-party and multiparty autocracies, they argue that institutions shape elite time horizons; "monarchic autocracies protect property rights relatively well compared to other types of dictatorships", because "dynastic succession and certainty about the composition of the future elite provide rulers with relatively long time horizons for their dynasties, reducing incentives to expropriate property for short-term gain". *Implication:* this is the strongest published support for the planning-horizon hypothesis (H2) — but it concerns property rights, not growth, and it is a cross-national association.

Blattman, Gehlbach and Yu (2025), "The Personalist Penalty: Varieties of Autocracy and Economic Growth", NBER Working Paper 34093 (revised November 2026) [V: NBER page]. Extending the Acemoglu et al. dynamic-panel strategy to separate democracies, institutionalised autocracies and personalist autocracies, they report that "across nine GDP series, eight autocracy codings, and six measures of personalism ... whenever an 'autocratic penalty' emerges, it is concentrated in personalist regimes", and that "the growth performance of institutionalized dictatorships ... is statistically indistinguishable from that of democracies", with the penalty driven by "low private investment, poor public-goods provision, and conflict". *Implication:* this is the most important recent result for the project. It implies the relevant line is not monarchy versus republic or democracy versus autocracy, but **personalised versus institutionalised power**. A Gulf monarchy that is in practice run by one prince with few internal checks would fall on the personalist side of this line; one run by a family council, cabinet and professional ministries on the institutionalised side. The R4 data (private credit 14% of GDP in electoral/personalist autocracies vs 58% in absolute monarchies; government effectiveness -0.74 vs +0.57) are consistent with this mechanism.

Geddes, Wright and Frantz (2014; 2018) [E] provide the canonical autocratic-regime dataset (party, military, personalist, monarchy and hybrids) and show that personalist regimes are the most likely to end in violent collapse and the least likely to democratise; monarchies are among the most durable autocratic types. **Svolik (2012)** and **Gandhi (2008)** [E] provide the theory of authoritarian power-sharing and institutions as commitment devices.

4.4 Monarchy specifically

Menaldo (2012), "The Middle East and North Africa's Resilient Monarchs", *Journal of Politics* 74(3): 707–722 [E: abstract read in search excerpts from the publisher, JSTOR and DOI pages; publisher page not opened]. Using a MENA panel 1950–2006, Menaldo finds that "monarchs are less likely than nonmonarchs to experience political instability" and "more likely to respect the rule of law and property rights and grow their economies", attributing this to a monarchical political culture that solves the ruler's credible-commitment problem, and uses an instrument based on the time since the Neolithic Revolution weighted by land quality (a proxy for a legacy of tribalism). *Critique:* the instrument's exclusion restriction is strong (deep history may affect growth through many channels); the sample is one region; and the competing explanation — that surviving monarchies rest on hydrocarbon rents, cross-cutting coalitions and foreign patrons (Yom and Gause 2012, *Journal of Democracy* 23(4): 74–88 [E]) — predicts the same correlation. Gause (2013) and Bellin (2012) [E] add that the 2011 Gulf Cooperation Council support package for Bahrain and Oman shows external rents underwriting monarchical survival.

Kokkonen and Sundell (2014), "Delivering Stability — Primogeniture and Autocratic Survival in European Monarchies 1000–1800", *American Political Science Review* 108(2): 438–453 [V: IDEAS abstract]. Across 961 monarchs in 42 European states, "fewer monarchs were deposed in states practicing primogeniture than in states practicing alternative succession orders", because a designated heir "can afford to wait to inherit the throne peacefully"; "a similar pattern persists in the world's remaining absolute monarchies". Their 2020 *Comparative Political Studies* article links hereditary succession to fewer succession wars [E]. *Implication:* the *rule* of succession matters. Saudi Arabia's historical agnatic seniority (brother-to-brother) and the 2006 Allegiance Council, followed by the 2017 move to a son of the king as crown prince, is a natural experiment the project should watch (R1).

Herb (1999), *All in the Family* [E] argues that "dynastic monarchies" — where the ruling family monopolises top state posts and decides succession collectively — are far more durable than monarchies ruled by a single king (Iran, Libya, Iraq, Egypt, Afghanistan), and that this, not culture or oil alone, explains Gulf survival. **Herb (2014), *The Wages of Oil*** [E] compares Kuwait and the UAE and argues that oil wealth per citizen shapes both the political economy (citizens employed by the state) and the scope for parliamentary politics.

4.5 Resources, rents and regime outcomes

Haber and Menaldo (2011), "Do Natural Resources Fuel Authoritarianism? A Reappraisal of the Resource Curse", *American Political Science Review* 105(1): 1–26 [V: Cambridge abstract via DOI]. Building long historical panels from 1800 and using time-series methods with explicit counterfactuals, they find "that increases in resource reliance are not associated with authoritarianism. In fact, in many specifications we generate results that suggest a resource blessing."

Andersen and Ross (2014), "The Big Oil Change: A Closer Look at the Haber–Menaldo Analysis", *Comparative Political Studies* 47(7): 993–1021 [E: abstract read in SAGE, BI Open and SSRN excerpts; pages not opened]. Re-analysing Haber and Menaldo's data, they find the "no curse" result may be correct before the 1970s, but "since about 1980, there has been a pronounced resource curse", because the nationalisations of the 1970s "enabled developing country governments to capture the oil rents that were previously siphoned off by foreign-owned firms". Lall (2017) [E] using multiple imputation supports Andersen and Ross.

Ross (2001), "Does Oil Hinder Democracy?", *World Politics* 53(3): 325–361 [E] and **Ross (2012), *The Oil Curse*** [E] establish the cross-national association between oil and authoritarian durability, via a rentier effect (low taxation, high spending), a repression effect and a modernisation effect. **Wright, Frantz and Geddes (2015), *British Journal of Political Science*** [E] find oil wealth lengthens autocratic survival by reducing the risk of collapse into a new autocracy, not only by blocking democratisation. **Mahdavy (1970)** and **Beblawi and Luciani (1987)** [E] are the foundational rentier-state statements.

Implication for this project: the post-1980 resource curse is about **who captures the rent**. All Gulf monarchies have nationalised hydrocarbons and channel rents through the ruler and state companies; the R4 data show these regimes are durable and rich, but with low taxation, low private credit, high public employment and falling productivity — the full rentier syndrome alongside high administrative capacity in the richest cases.

4.6 Summary of the literature

Question	Best current answer	Key sources	Strength of evidence
Does democracy reduce growth?	No; best-identified estimates show a positive long-run effect (~20% GDP pc)	ANRR 2019; Colagrossi et al. 2020	Strong (panel, IV)
Do autocracies grow faster on average?	No, once income is controlled; total income growth similar, per-capita growth lower (population)	Przeworski et al. 2000; Doucouliagos & Ulubasoglu 2008	Strong
Are autocratic outcomes more variable?	Yes; mostly shock absorption, not "good vs bad autocrats"	Rodrik 2000; Easterly 2011; Rizio & Skali 2020; R4 §3.8	Strong (descriptive), moderate (mechanism)
Do leaders matter more in autocracies?	Yes	Jones & Olken 2005	Strong (natural experiment)
Which autocracies perform well?	Institutionalised ones (parties, binding legislatures, rule-bound selectorates, dynastic councils); personalist ones perform worst	Besley & Kudamatsu 2008; Wright 2008; Blattman et al. 2025; Geddes et al. 2014	Moderate–strong

Question	Best current answer	Key sources	Strength of evidence
Do monarchies perform better than other autocracies?	Associated with more stability, better property rights and (in MENA) growth; confounded by rents, region and survivorship	Menaldo 2012; Knutsen & Fjelde 2013; Kokkonen & Sundell 2014; Herb 1999	Moderate, contested
Does oil sustain autocracy?	Yes since c.1980 (contested before)	Ross 2001/2012; Andersen & Ross 2014 vs Haber & Menaldo 2011	Moderate, contested
Does democracy improve human development?	Through accumulated democratic stock rather than current level	Gerring et al. 2005, 2012	Moderate

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5. Part V — Testing the seven hypotheses

Each hypothesis is stated as the brief frames it, followed by the mechanism its proponents claim, the R4 evidence, the literature, the most important counter-cases, and a verdict: **Supported**, **Conditionally supported**, **Contested** or **Unsupported**. A verdict is about the general claim, not about whether any single case fits it.

H1. Concentrated decision-making reduces fragmentation, delay and coordination failure

Claim. A ruler who does not need legislative majorities, coalition partners or electoral cycles can decide quickly, coordinate ministries and push through long projects; the costs are weaker accountability and less political competition.

R4 evidence.

- **Speed and capacity are not systematically higher under concentrated authority.** Government effectiveness above +0.5 occurs in 9% of autocracies but 43% of democracies (2015–2024). The autocratic types with high effectiveness (Gulf city-state monarchies, Singapore) are small, wealthy, and trade-oriented; the larger concentrated-authority types (personalist, military) are among the least effective in the world (medians -0.74 and -0.72).
- **Within autocracies, effectiveness rises with constraints, not with concentration.** Among 82 autocracies the correlation between government effectiveness and V-Dem judicial constraints on the executive is +0.47; between effectiveness and voice and accountability +0.54. The best-run autocracies are those where the ruler is *least* unconstrained (Singapore's judicial-constraints score 0.80 vs 0.20 in the UAE and 0.06 in China).
- **Decisiveness does show up in investment.** Absolute monarchies (27.6% of GDP) and one-party states (30.3%) have the highest gross fixed capital formation, and one-party states have delivered very large infrastructure programmes.
- **The cost side is visible.** Voice and accountability, legislative constraints and (in the Gulf) data transparency are lowest exactly where decision-making is most concentrated.

Literature. Jones and Olken (2005) show individual leaders have larger effects in autocracies — concentration amplifies leader quality in both directions. Wright (2008) and Gandhi (2008) show binding legislatures *raise* autocratic growth and investment, i.e., some deconcentration helps. Blattman et al. (2025) show the autocratic penalty is concentrated in personalist (most concentrated) regimes. Johnson (1982), Amsden (1989), Wade (1990) and Evans (1995) [E] attribute East Asian coordination to *embedded autonomy* of professional bureaucracies (MITI, Korea's Economic Planning Board), not to rulers' discretion as such.

Counter-cases. Mao's Great Leap Forward, Ceausescu's debt-repayment austerity, Myanmar's 2005 capital move and 2021 coup, Venezuela's post-2013 collapse: concentrated decision-making enabled very fast, very large mistakes

(handed to R5, Part IX).

Verdict: **Contested.** Concentration can speed decisions and sustain investment, but the evidence associates good coordination with *institutionalised* decision-making (cabinets, planning agencies, parties, family councils) rather than with concentrated personal power. The costs (unchecked error, accountability deficits) are documented and large.

H2. Hereditary succession creates a longer planning horizon than electoral competition

Claim. A dynasty expects to rule for generations, so it internalises long-run returns (Olson's 1993 "stationary bandit" [E]), while elected governments discount the future beyond the next election.

R4 evidence.

- **Saving and long-horizon assets.** Absolute monarchies have high adjusted net savings (median 14.3% of GNI) and very large sovereign funds (§3.7b). Kuwait's Reserve Fund for Future Generations (1976) and ADIA (established 1976 from a 1967 predecessor) are among the oldest intergenerational funds anywhere [E].
- **But the planning record is mixed.** Productivity fell for two decades (§3.3); fuel still dominates exports after forty years of diversification plans; fiscal positions in Oman and Bahrain deteriorated sharply when oil prices fell (§3.7). Saudi Arabia's development plans since 1970 repeatedly set diversification targets that were not met before Vision 2030 [E; R1].
- **Democracies also plan long-term.** Norway's Government Pension Fund Global (constitutional monarchy, parliamentary democracy) is the largest sovereign fund in the world and operates under a fiscal rule set by parliament [E]; Botswana's Pula Fund and diamond-revenue rule were built by an electoral (dominant-party) democracy [E]. Chile's structural-balance fiscal rule (2001) and copper stabilisation fund are products of a presidential democracy [E].

Literature. Knutsen and Fjelde (2013) find monarchic autocracies protect property rights better because dynastic succession lengthens time horizons — the clearest support. Kokkonen and Sundell (2014) show clear succession rules reduce deposition. Against this, Jones and Olken (2005) and Rizio and Skali (2020) show autocratic outcomes are driven by individuals, and Besley and Kudamatsu (2008) emphasise that long horizons help only if the selectorate can remove poor performers.

Counter-cases. Pahlavi Iran (1953–1979) pursued a hurried, oil-financed modernisation that ended in revolution; Haile Selassie's Ethiopia (to 1974) and the Libyan, Iraqi and Egyptian monarchies did not translate dynastic horizons into durable development [E; R2]. Dynastic republics (North Korea, Syria under the Assads, Azerbaijan, Turkmenistan) have hereditary succession without good long-run outcomes.

Verdict: **Conditionally supported** for *asset accumulation* where rents per citizen are large and succession is rule-bound; **contested** as a general claim about development planning. The mechanism that works — legally ring-fenced intergenerational funds and fiscal rules — exists in democracies and constitutional monarchies too, and is arguably *more* credible there because it does not depend on a single family's continued discretion.

H3. Elite coordination: ruling families, militaries, bureaucracies and business

Claim. Outcomes depend on how elites are organised: a cohesive elite with shared long-run interests coordinates development; fragmented or predatory elites extract.

R4 evidence.

- Regime types that organise elites through **durable collective institutions** — ruling families with councils and ministerial allocation (Gulf "dynastic monarchies"), ruling parties (China, Vietnam), dominant-party technocracies (Singapore) — score higher on government effectiveness and, except monarchies, on growth than types where elite coordination runs through one person or the army (Table 3.6).
- **Military-led regimes** have the worst political-stability median (-1.41) and low private credit (23% of GDP), consistent with militaries' sectoral economic interests and coup risk.
- **Private-sector depth** is low where elites are organised around rents (personalist 14%, military 23% of GDP).

Literature. Herb (1999) [E] on dynastic monarchies; Hertog (2010) [E] on Saudi "segmented clientelism" — "islands of efficiency" (Aramco, SAMA, SABIC) coexisting with fragmented, patronage-laden ministries; Slater (2010) [E] on "protection pacts" in Southeast Asia; Kohli (2004) [E] on cohesive-capitalist vs neo-patrimonial states; Besley and Kudamatsu (2008) on selectorates; Blattman et al. (2025) on narrow vs broad power bases.

Verdict: **Supported** as a general proposition — elite organisation matters a great deal — but it **does not favour monarchy as such**. It favours institutionalised elite bargains of any form. Hertog's work implies the Gulf has both: highly capable enclaves and patrimonial ministries.

H4. Technocratic administration can coexist with limited political competition

Claim. Competent civil services, planning agencies, regulators and performance measurement can flourish without competitive elections.

R4 evidence. Yes, in a minority of cases. Singapore (effectiveness +2.07, corruption control +2.07), the UAE (+1.10, +1.06), Qatar (+0.90), Brunei (+0.97), China (+0.54) and Rwanda (+0.25, rising from -1.28 in 1995–2004) all show high or rising administrative performance with limited political competition (2015–2024 means). Rwanda's government effectiveness improved by about 1.5 points over twenty years — one of the largest improvements in the WGI record.

But the base rate is low (7 of 82 autocracies above +0.5), and among these, voice and accountability is low and judicial constraints are often weak (UAE 0.20; China 0.06). Singapore is the exception in having strong courts and low corruption with constrained competition; it is also a city-state with British common-law inheritance and an exceptionally high-quality founding elite [E].

Literature. Evans (1995) and Evans and Rauch (1999) [E] link Weberian bureaucracy (meritocratic recruitment, career tracks) to growth regardless of regime; Johnson (1982) on MITI; Fukuyama (2014) [E] on state capacity as distinct from democratic accountability. Besley and Kudamatsu (2008) list successful autocracies, with Singapore and others.

Verdict: **Supported, but rare and conditional.** Technocratic capacity can coexist with limited competition; it is not *produced* by limited competition, and it is far more common under democracy. The ingredients (meritocratic recruitment, insulated agencies, performance metrics, anti-corruption bodies) are regime-neutral and transferable (R6, Part X).

H5. Resource wealth stabilises authoritarian rule (resource curse, rentier state, Dutch disease)

Claim. Petroleum, gas, minerals and sovereign funds allow rulers to buy loyalty and avoid taxation; they can also cause Dutch disease and volatility.

R4 evidence.

- **Stability:** High-rent ruling monarchies score +0.66 on political stability; all six absolute monarchies of 1995 are still absolute monarchies in 2026; none of the GCC monarchies fell in 2011.
- **Rentier syndrome:** tax revenue 6% of GDP; fuel 76% of exports; private credit half the democratic level; R&D 0.4% of GDP; falling TFP.
- **Volatility:** high-rent autocracies have the most dispersed growth of any group in the global sample (s.d. 6.7 in 1995–2004).
- **But rents are not destiny:** high-rent non-monarchic autocracies have much worse outcomes than high-rent monarchies (§3.4), and Norway, Botswana and Chile show resource wealth compatible with democracy and good governance.

Literature. Ross (2001, 2012), Andersen and Ross (2014) and Wright, Frantz and Geddes (2015) support oil-sustained autocracy after about 1980; Haber and Menaldo (2011) dissent for the long run. Wright (2008) shows rent-dependent dictators use non-binding legislatures for co-optation. Dutch-disease mechanics are established [E: Corden and Neary 1982].

Verdict: **Supported** for the stabilising effect since the 1970s nationalisations, **conditional** on rent per citizen and on who captures the rent. Resource wealth is the most powerful single explanation of Gulf monarchical continuity

and prosperity in the data — more powerful than monarchy itself — and, simultaneously, the most important explanation of their productivity problem.

H6. A highly centralised government can create institutions that constrain its own leadership

Claim. Rulers can bind themselves through independent courts, central banks, audit offices, sovereign-fund governance and term limits, separating state capacity from personal power.

R4 evidence.

- Constraints on the executive are lowest where power is most concentrated: V-Dem legislative constraints 0.14 (absolute monarchies), 0.09 (one-party), 0.15 (personalist) vs 0.87–0.91 in democracies; judicial constraints 0.34, 0.10 and 0.14 vs 0.83–0.92.
- Semi-constitutional monarchies — where rulers accepted elected legislatures with budget powers — have higher constraints (0.66–0.70) but worse effectiveness and stability medians than absolute monarchies, partly because Kuwait's parliament–cabinet deadlock is in this group.
- Partial self-constraint exists in *economic* domains: Gulf central banks' currency pegs, free-zone courts using common law (DIFC since 2004, ADGM, QFC) [E], and Saudi Arabia's and Oman's fiscal frameworks. These are enclave constraints for investors, not general constraints on the ruler.
- **Reversals** show the fragility: China's removal of presidential term limits (2018) [E]; Kuwait's suspension of the National Assembly (May 2024) [E]; Qatar's 2024 constitutional amendment ending elections to the Shura Council [E]; Tunisia's 2021 self-coup. Self-imposed constraints can be withdrawn by the self that imposed them.

Literature. North and Weingast (1989) and North, Wallis and Weingast (2009) [E] argue credible commitment requires that rulers be unable to reverse it unilaterally; Haber, Razo and Maurer (2003) [E] show selective property-rights protection for allied elites under autocracy; Gehlbach and Keefer (2011) [E] show institutionalised ruling parties make commitments credible to investors. Blattman et al. (2025) and Knutsen and Fjelde (2013) imply institutionalisation, not concentration, does the work.

Verdict: **Contested — supported only in limited, investor-facing domains.** Centralised regimes can build enclaves of rule-bound governance (free-zone courts, central banks, some sovereign funds) and can institutionalise succession; the evidence that they can bind the *ruler* durably is weak, and recent reversals cut against it. The distinction the brief asks for — between state capacity and personal power — is the crux: the Gulf has built the former without diluting the latter.

H7. Succession risk

Claim. When an effective ruler is succeeded by an ineffective, inexperienced or contested successor, outcomes deteriorate; hereditary succession may manage this differently from institutional succession.

R4 evidence. The R4 dataset is too short and too aggregated to estimate succession effects directly; the following is descriptive.

- **Gulf successions since 1995 have been peaceful:** Bahrain 1999, Qatar 1995 (by palace coup, son deposing father) and 2013 (abdication), UAE 2004 and 2022, Kuwait 2006 (parliament-involved removal of an incapacitated emir), 2020 and 2023, Saudi Arabia 2005 and 2015, Oman 2020 (sealed-letter procedure), Brunei none [E; R1/R2]. Growth and governance indicators show no visible discontinuity around them, though the sample is too small to test.
- **Personalist and dynastic-republican successions have been the most destructive:** Libya after 2011, Syria after 2011, Iraq after 2003 all moved into the FS category in the R4 data; Zimbabwe's 2017 military ouster and Gabon's 2023 coup ended dynastic plans [E].
- **Constitutional and democratic successions** do not register as economic events in the data.

Literature. Jones and Olken (2005) show leader deaths shift growth in autocracies; Besley and Kudamatsu (2008) show successful autocracies are those whose selectorates can replace leaders without losing power; Kokkonen and Sundell (2014, 2020) show primogeniture reduced deposition and succession wars in European monarchies and that

the pattern persists in the remaining absolute monarchies; Herb (1999) attributes Gulf survival to family-level succession bargaining. Geddes et al. [E] show personalist regimes are most likely to end violently with the leader.

Verdict: **Supported in its comparative form.** Succession is the most dangerous moment for any autocracy; rule-bound hereditary systems with a large ruling family and pre-designated heirs (and institutionalised parties) handle it much better than personalist regimes; *institutional* succession in democracies and constitutional monarchies handles it best because the economic order does not depend on the person. The Gulf's recent move from horizontal (brother-to-brother, family-consensus) to vertical (father-to-son, concentrated) succession in Saudi Arabia and the UAE may lower dispute risk at each transition but raises dependence on the individual — the trade-off Part IX should analyse.

5.8 Verdict summary

Hypothesis	Verdict	Where it holds	Where it fails	Strongest evidence
H1 Concentrated decision-making	Contested	High-capacity, small, rich states; investment drives	Personalist and military regimes; large-error episodes	WGI (R4), Jones & Olken 2005, Blattman et al. 2025, Wright 2008
H2 Long planning horizons via heredity	Conditionally supported (assets); contested (development)	Rule-bound dynasties with large rents per citizen	Pahlavi Iran, fallen monarchies, dynastic republics	Knutsen & Fjelde 2013; R4 SWF and savings data
H3 Elite coordination	Supported (but not monarchy-specific)	Institutionalised bargains: families, parties, bureaucracies	Personalist, military, fragmented elites	Herb 1999; Hertog 2010; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008
H4 Technocracy without competition	Supported but rare	Singapore, UAE, Qatar, Rwanda, China	Most autocracies (75 of 82 below +0.5 effectiveness)	WGI (R4); Evans 1995
H5 Resource wealth and stability	Supported, conditional on rent per citizen and rent capture	GCC, Brunei	Equatorial Guinea, Venezuela, Iraq, Libya	Ross 2012; Andersen & Ross 2014; R4 §3.4
H6 Self-constraint	Contested; enclave-only	Free zones, central banks, some SWFs	General constraint on rulers; reversals 2018–2024	V-Dem (R4); North & Weingast 1989
H7 Succession risk	Supported (comparative)	Rule-bound dynasties > personalist; institutions best	Personalist, dynastic republics	Kokkonen & Sundell 2014; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008

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6. Part VII — Multidimensional comparison of seven governance systems

6.1 How to read the matrix

BRIEF Part VII asks for a comparison of seven systems across fourteen dimensions and forbids "a simplistic ranking". The matrix below therefore has **no totals, no scores and no ordering of columns by merit**. Each cell gives (i) the typical pattern observed, (ii) the main condition on which it depends, and (iii) the evidence key. Indicator values are 2015–2024 medians from the R4 sample (Tables 3.1–3.7) unless stated; they describe the countries in each column, not an inherent property of the system. Column sample sizes: absolute monarchy (AM)

6; constitutional monarchy, democratic (CM) 15; presidential republic (PR) 16; parliamentary democracy (PD) 15; one-party authoritarianism (OP) 5–7; military dictatorship (MD) 6; technocratic authoritarianism (TA) 2 (Singapore, Rwanda; Ethiopia 1995–2017 adds a third for earlier decades).

Confidence codes: (high)(high)(high) consistent data and literature; (high)(high) data or literature but not both, or small n; (high) inference from cases.

Evidence keys: **W** = WGI (Table 3.6); **V** = V-Dem constraints/electoral democracy; **D** = WDI/IMF structural data (Table 3.7); **H** = HDR/WDI human development (Table 3.5); **G** = global variance tests (§3.8); **L** = literature (§4).

6.2 The matrix

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
1. Policy continuity	High at the apex while the ruler/heir is unchanged; abrupt redirection possible at succession or crown-prince level (e.g., Saudi policy shifts after 2015). Political stability +0.66 (W). (high)(high)	High; continuity carried by civil service and coalition norms; head of state above politics. Stability +0.87 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Lower; winner-take-all alternation produces policy swings; stability -0.19 (W). (high)(high)(high)	High–moderate; coalition bargaining slows change but makes it durable. Stability +0.66 (W). (high)(high)(high)	High within a party line, punctuated by large leader-driven reversals (China 1978, 2018, and 2022 zero-COVID exit). Stability -0.13 (W). (high)(high)	Low; coups beget coups; transitions frequent. Stability -1.41 (W). (high)(high)(high)	High (Singapore's PAP since 1959; Rwanda's RPF since 1994). Stability +0.65 (W). (high)(high) (n=2)

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
2. Bureaucratic efficiency	Good in rich city-states (UAE +1.10, Qatar +0.90), middling in Saudi Arabia/Oman (+0.25/+0.15), weak in Eswatini (-0.57); "islands of efficiency" beside patronage ministries. GE median +0.57 (W, L: Hertog). (high)(high)	Very high; GE +1.78 (W). Mostly rich Western/East Asian states. (high)(high)(high)	Wide range; GE +0.19 (W). (high)(high)(high)	High; GE +1.01 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Mixed; strong in China's coastal provinces and Vietnam, weak in Laos/Cuba; GE -0.43 (W). (high)(high)	Weak; GE -0.72 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Very high in Singapore (+2.07), rapidly improved in Rwanda (+0.25 from -1.28); GE +1.16 (W). (high)(high)
3. Long-term infrastructure investment	Very high when oil prices are high; GFCF 27.6% GDP (D); mega-projects; risk of white elephants. (high)(high)	Moderate; GFCF 23.8% (D); planning and permitting slower. (high)(high)(high)	Lower; GFCF 20.5% (D); vulnerable to electoral cycles. (high)(high)	Moderate; GFCF 23.3% (D). (high)(high)(high)	Highest; GFCF 30.3% (D); China/Vietnam infrastructure boom, with debt and over-investment costs. (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; GFCF 22.9% (D); military-linked contracting. (high)(high)	High and well-executed in Singapore; GFCF 24.8% (D). (high)(high)
4. Economic diversification	Weak; fuel 76% of merchandise exports, high-tech 3% of manufactured exports (D); progress in UAE services. (high)(high)(high)	Strong; fuel 6.8%, high-tech 16% (D), except Norway. (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; fuel 5.8%, high-tech 9.6% (D); commodity dependence in Latin America. (high)(high)	Moderate–strong; fuel 2.6%, high-tech 10.9% (D). (high)(high)	Strong in manufactures; high-tech 24.7% (D), often foreign-owned assembly. (high)(high)	Weak; fuel 22.5%, high-tech 3.1% (D). (high)(high)	Strong (Singapore); Rwanda early-stage. High-tech 31% (D). (high)

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
5. Innovation	Low; R&D 0.38% GDP (D); TFP falling (§3.3); heavy imports of technology and talent. (high)(high)(high)	High; R&D 1.87% (D). (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; R&D 0.54% (D); USA and Korea far higher. (high)(high)	High; R&D 1.40% (D). (high)(high)(high)	Mixed; China 2.25% of GDP and a frontier in some sectors, others low (median 0.42%) (D); censorship limits information flows. (high)(high)	Low; R&D 0.43% (D). (high)(high)	Moderate–high; R&D 1.35% (D). (high)
6. Human capital development	Large gains; schooling 11.2 years, U5MR 8/1,000 (H); conversion of income into outcomes mixed (Brunei, Qatar, Kuwait below income line). (high)(high)	Highest; schooling 12.7 years, U5MR 3.9 (H). (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; 9.7 years, U5MR 11.8 (H). (high)(high)(high)	High; 11.6 years, U5MR 3.8 (H). (high)(high)(high)	Strong health for income (life-exp. residual +2.8 years), lower schooling 7.0 years (H). (high)(high)	Weak; 6.9 years, U5MR 29.7 (H). (high)(high)(high)	Singapore excellent; Rwanda low base, fast health gains (H). (high)
7. Corruption control	Above zero (+0.53, W) but royal-family asset allocation is opaque and perception surveys may miss it. (high)(high)	Very strong; +1.74 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Weak; -0.22 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Strong; +0.74 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Weak; -1.03 (W); campaigns are selective/political. (high)(high)	Weak; -0.72 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Strong; +1.30 (W); Singapore's CPIB model. (high)(high)

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
8. Political accountability	Minimal; voice -1.11 (W), legislative constraints 0.14 (V); accountability through family councils and petition (majlis), not elections. (high)(high)(high)	Very high; voice +1.44, constraints 0.91. (high)(high)(high)	High–moderate; voice +0.38, constraints 0.87; executive-legislative deadlock risk. (high)(high)(high)	High; voice +0.83, constraints 0.88. (high)(high)(high)	Minimal; voice -1.62, constraints 0.09 (V); intra-party accountability only. (high)(high)(high)	Minimal; voice -1.16 (W). (high)(high)(high)	Limited; voice -0.43 (W); elections held but uneven playing field. (high)(high)
9. Succession stability	High in today's GCC (peaceful transitions since 1995 except Qatar's 1995 palace coup); historically fragile (most post-1945 monarchies fell). Primogeniture-type rules reduce deposition (L: Kokkonen & Sundell). (high)(high)	Very high; head-of-state succession is ceremonial; government changes through elections. (high)(high)(high)	High; fixed terms; occasional crises (impeachments, disputed elections). (high)(high)(high)	High; votes of confidence; caretaker conventions. (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; party rules help (Vietnam, China 1990s–2012) but no external arbiter; Soviet collapse; China's 2018 term-limit removal raises future risk (L). (high)(high)	Lowest; succession by coup; GWF: personalist-military regimes end violently (L). (high)(high)(high)	High in Singapore (1990, 2004, 2024 handovers); untested in Rwanda. (high)

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
10. Civil liberties	Very restricted; electoral democracy index 0.10 (V); restrictions on speech, assembly; migrant labour rights limited. (high)(high)(high)	Strong; index 0.86 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Moderate–strong; index 0.76 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Strong; index 0.81 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Very restricted; index 0.12 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Restricted; index 0.25 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Restricted–partial; index 0.32 (V); Singapore's press and assembly laws. (high)(high)
11. Institutional independence	Low; judicial constraints 0.34 (V); enclave courts (DIFC, ADGM, QFC) independent for commercial disputes. (high)(high)	Very high; 0.92 (V); independent central banks and auditors standard. (high)(high)(high)	High; 0.83 (V); politicisation risk in courts. (high)(high)(high)	High; 0.87 (V). (high)(high)(high)	Very low; 0.10 (V); courts subordinate to party. (high)(high)(high)	Low; 0.44 (V). (high)(high)	Moderate; 0.50 (V); Singapore courts strong in commercial law. (high)(high)
12. Crisis management	Strong fiscal buffers in the richest; annual growth volatility highest of all types in 2005–2014 (median within-country s.d. 4.1 points) because of oil; weak in poorer monarchies (Bahrain debt 134% GDP). (high)(high)	Moderate; automatic stabilisers, credible institutions; volatility s.d. 2.3 (2005–14). (high)(high)	Mixed; crises can trigger polarisation; s.d. 2.1. (high)(high)	Moderate; s.d. 2.7. (high)(high)	Fast mobilisation (lockdowns, stimulus) with large errors (Great Leap; 2022 zero-COVID exit); s.d. 2.2. (high)(high)	Poor; crises often trigger coups; s.d. 2.6. (high)(high)	Strong in Singapore (reserves, technocratic response); s.d. 1.8. (high)

Dimension	A. Absolute monarchy	B. Constitutional monarchy	C. Presidential republic	D. Parliamentary democracy	E. One-party authoritarianism	F. Military dictatorship	G. Technocratic authoritarianism
13. Fiscal discipline	Low gross debt (28.7% GDP) and high saving while rents are high; tax 6% GDP; rapid debt build-up after 2014 in Oman, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia (D). Discipline is rent-contingent. (high)(high)	Moderate; debt 52.6% (D); fiscal rules (e.g., Norway's). (high)(high)(high)	Moderate; debt 58.5% (D); Latin American default history. (high)(high)	Moderate; debt 63.5% (D). (high)(high)(high)	Moderate–weak; debt 65.5% and rising quickly in China (39% in 2014 -> 91% in 2024, IMF), plus off-budget local-government debt (D). (high)(high)	Weak–mixed; debt 48.3% (D); Egypt 91% (2024). (high)(high)	Strong in substance (Singapore's reserve rules); gross debt 93% reflects CPF securities, matched by assets (D). (high)
14. Intergenerational sustainability	Large sovereign funds (~$0.7–2 m per citizen in UAE, Qatar, Kuwait) and adjusted net savings 14% of GNI; but depletion of a single asset, carbon-transition exposure, falling productivity and citizen dependence on state jobs. (high)(high)	Strong; adjusted net savings 11.3% (D); Norway's GPFG as model; ageing pressures. (high)(high)(high)	Weaker; adjusted net savings 6.4% (D). (high)(high)	Moderate; 10.1% (D). (high)(high)(high)	High saving 16.4% (D), but demographic ageing (China) and debt overhang. (high)(high)	15.4% (D) but conflict and capital flight risks. (high)	Strong (Singapore reserves, CPF). (high)

6.3 Dimension notes: mechanisms and conditions

1. Policy continuity. Continuity under absolute monarchy is continuity of *persons and family*, which is very high between successions but carries the risk of discontinuity at the top when power shifts within the family.

Constitutional monarchies and parliamentary democracies achieve continuity through *institutions* — permanent civil services, coalition agreements, independent central banks — and the R4 political-stability medians show this is at least as effective. Presidential systems show the most policy oscillation among democracies, consistent with the comparative-institutions literature on winner-take-all executives (Linz 1990 [E]).

2. Bureaucratic efficiency. Measured effectiveness is driven primarily by income and state size; within income bands, the main institutional correlate is meritocratic recruitment and insulation from patronage (Evans and Rauch 1999 [E]). Absolute monarchies can buy efficiency in the highest-rent cases by importing expertise and building parallel agencies; Hertog's (2010) "islands of efficiency" describes Saudi Arabia [E]. The technocratic pair shows that a dominant-party state can build an exceptionally capable bureaucracy — but Singapore and Rwanda were small states with existential threats and a founding elite unusually committed to performance legitimacy.

3. Long-term infrastructure investment. Concentrated authority does raise investment rates (one-party 30%, absolute monarchy 28%). The question is quality: the absence of accountability for project selection produces over-investment and stranded assets (China's local-government financing vehicles; some Gulf "giga-projects" whose scale has been revised [E; R1]). Democracies invest less, more slowly, and with more veto points, but those veto points also screen projects.

4. Economic diversification. No regime type has diversified away from a dominant natural resource quickly; the democracies that are diversified (Norway excepted) never depended on one resource. The UAE (Dubai) is the strongest Gulf case, built on logistics, aviation, tourism and finance; its merchandise-fuel share (60%) understates services diversification.

5. Innovation. Frontier innovation is concentrated in democracies with strong universities and free information flows, and in China, which combines very high R&D spending (2.25% of GDP, 2015–2024 mean) with state direction. Absolute monarchies are currently importers of technology; their new research universities (KAUST, Qatar Foundation, Khalifa University) are too recent to register in national aggregates.

6. Human capital. Health outcomes respond strongly to state spending and are achievable under any regime with resources and commitment; one-party states and Gulf monarchies achieved large health gains. Education quality and its labour-market use are weaker in the monarchies (low schooling residuals in Kuwait and Brunei; citizens concentrated in public employment).

7. Corruption control. The WGI corruption measure places absolute monarchies above zero, but the indicator captures petty and bureaucratic corruption experienced by firms and residents much better than allocation of state assets within ruling families, which is legal or unobservable in an absolute monarchy. The technocratic case shows that a dominant-party regime can sustain low corruption with an independent anti-corruption agency and high public pay; personalist and military regimes cannot.

8. Political accountability. This is the dimension where absolute monarchy is structurally weakest by definition. Informal channels (majlis, family consensus, consultative councils) provide some responsiveness; they do not allow citizens to remove the government. Jones and Olken's (2005) finding that leaders matter most where constraints are fewest is the economic cost of this design.

9. Succession stability. Gulf monarchies have the best succession record among current autocracies — but this is a survivor statistic (§7). Constitutional monarchy's advantage is that it separates the *symbolic continuity* of the head of state from the *political turnover* of government: it keeps the stabilising feature of hereditary monarchy while removing the risk that the economy depends on the heir's competence.

10. Civil liberties. Restrictions are severe in absolute monarchies, one-party states and military regimes; they extend in the Gulf to the majority non-citizen population (sponsorship systems, partially reformed in Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE since 2020 [E]). Growth or stability gains do not offset this in the measures used here; the brief's rule that stability is not welfare applies directly.

11. Institutional independence. Gulf monarchies have created internationally credible *commercial* courts and regulators in free zones, which is an important and transferable innovation (R6). They have not created courts or audit offices able to constrain the ruler. Constitutional monarchies and parliamentary democracies score highest.

12. Crisis management. Two different capacities are conflated in this dimension: *speed and resources* (where wealthy autocracies and technocracies do well) and *error correction and legitimacy under stress* (where democracies

do better; Rodrik 2000; Easterly 2011). The R4 data show the monarchies had the most volatile annual growth in 2005–2014 because their economies follow oil prices; their buffers let them smooth consumption, not output.

13. Fiscal discipline. Low debt in absolute monarchies is a by-product of rents rather than evidence of institutionalised discipline: when rents fell after 2014, debt rose fastest in the monarchies with the smallest buffers. The strongest *rules-based* fiscal discipline in the sample is found in a constitutional monarchy (Norway's fiscal rule), a technocratic autocracy (Singapore's reserves rule) and a presidential democracy (Chile's structural balance rule) [E].

14. Intergenerational sustainability. The Gulf's sovereign funds are a genuine intergenerational achievement, but sustainability also depends on the size of the citizen population relative to the asset base, on the energy transition and on whether a productive non-oil economy develops before the assets are needed for consumption. Saudi Arabia, Oman and Bahrain hold far less per citizen than Kuwait, Qatar and the UAE.

6.4 Trade-offs and contextual conditions behind the matrix

The matrix shows five recurrent trade-offs:

1. **Decisiveness vs error correction.** Concentrated systems (A, E, G) decide and invest faster; dispersed systems (B, C, D) catch and correct mistakes more reliably. The global variance evidence (§3.8) is the quantitative signature of this trade-off.
2. **Continuity of persons vs continuity of institutions.** Monarchies and dominant parties deliver continuity through the persistence of a family or party; constitutional monarchies and parliamentary democracies deliver it through rules that survive changes of government.
3. **Capacity vs accountability.** Absolute monarchy and technocratic autocracy can produce capable administration without accountability, but only in a minority of cases; in the majority, the absence of accountability co-exists with low capacity (military, personalist).
4. **Rent-financed welfare vs productive economy.** Rents finance high living standards and stability (A) while weakening incentives for taxation, private investment and productivity.
5. **Short-run stability vs long-run fragility.** Systems that suppress contestation can be very stable until they are not; when they fail, they fail badly (Iran 1979, Libya 2011).

Five contextual conditions do most of the explanatory work across the cells:

Condition	Effect	Evidence
Resource rent per citizen	Finances stability, welfare and capable expatriate administration in small high-rent states	§3.4, §3.7b; Herb 2014 [E]
Country size and citizen population	Small polities (Singapore, Qatar, UAE, Brunei) can be governed by a cohesive elite with dense information; large ones cannot without institutions	Inference from §3.6 list of high-capacity autocracies
Degree of institutionalisation of power (personalist vs collective)	The main line separating good from bad autocratic outcomes	Blattman et al. 2025 [V]; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [V]; Geddes et al. [E]
External security and patronage	Protects small monarchies from invasion and helps them survive internal crises	Yom & Gause 2012 [E]; GCC support to Bahrain 2011 [E]
Accumulated institutional stock (democratic or bureaucratic)	Explains long-run human development and growth better than current regime label	Gerring et al. 2005, 2012 [V]

6.5 What the matrix does *not* say

- It does not say that absolute monarchy "ranks" anywhere; its profile is strong on continuity, investment, fiscal buffers and (in rich cases) administration, and weak on accountability, liberties, independence, innovation

and diversification.
- It does not say that the strong cells of A, E or G are *caused* by concentrated power. The literature attributes them to institutionalisation (parties, family councils, meritocratic bureaucracies), rents and size.
- It does not say constitutional monarchy is superior because monarchy is retained; constitutional monarchies' strong cells come from parliamentary democracy and high income. The specific contribution of a ceremonial monarch is plausibly to symbolic continuity and to succession stability at the head-of-state level (an interpretation; untested here).

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7. Correlation, causation and selection bias

The brief requires the project to distinguish correlation from causation and to address selection bias. This section collects the threats that bear specifically on Parts V–VII.

7.1 Survivorship of monarchies. The six absolute monarchies in the R4 data are the survivors of a larger post-1945 population. Monarchies abolished or overthrown since 1945 include Egypt (1952), Tunisia (1957), Iraq (1958), North Yemen (1962), Zanzibar (1964), Burundi (1966), Libya (1969), Afghanistan (1973), Greece (1973), Ethiopia (1974), Laos (1975), Iran (1979) and Nepal (2008), along with Rwanda (1961) and Cambodia's interruptions (FRAMEWORK list; R2 and R3 document them) [E]. Where their successor regimes were military or personalist, the failed monarchies' economic histories after the fall now sit in other columns of the R4 data. The "monarchy" column therefore over-represents successful cases, and the "military" and "personalist" columns over-represent failed ones. Any comparison of today's monarchies with today's dictatorships is biased in favour of monarchy.

7.2 Selection on resources and region. Five of six absolute monarchies are Gulf hydrocarbon exporters under the same external security umbrella. Monarchy and oil are almost perfectly collinear in the high-income autocratic cell; the data cannot say whether the Gulf's outcomes are due to monarchy, oil, small citizen populations or the US security guarantee. The only absolute monarchy without large rents (Eswatini) is a poor, unequal, slow-growing state. The resource split (§3.4) narrows but does not solve this.

7.3 Reverse causation. Wealth helps regimes survive (Przeworski et al. 2000), and growth collapses topple autocrats. Rich monarchies may be rich *and therefore* surviving monarchies. Menaldo (2012) uses an instrument for monarchy to address this, but its exclusion restriction is debatable (§4.4).

7.4 Studying successes. The "developmental autocracy" literature focuses on South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, China, Rwanda and the Gulf; failed developmental dictatorships (Ceausescu's Romania, Mengistu's Ethiopia, Mobutu's Zaire, Marcos's Philippines) receive less attention. Rizio and Skali (2020) and Easterly (2011) correct for this by counting all autocrats; both find good autocrats are no more common than chance would predict.

7.5 Measurement. WGI indicators may be biased upward for business-friendly autocracies; V-Dem is expert-coded; Gulf GDP per capita is per resident; TFP for oil states includes rent. None of these biases runs consistently in one direction across all types, but several flatter the Gulf monarchies (business-perception surveys) while others disadvantage them (resident denominators).

7.6 What would identify causal effects. The literature's best strategies — leader deaths (Jones and Olken 2005), regional democratisation waves as instruments (Acemoglu et al. 2019), within-country long panels (Haber and Menaldo 2011; Andersen and Ross 2014), dynamic panels distinguishing autocratic types (Blattman et al. 2025) — all point in the same direction on the question that matters most for this project: **institutionalisation, not concentration, is what is associated with good outcomes under autocracy, and democratisation does not reduce growth on average.**

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8. Disputes and uncertainties

1. **Does democracy cause growth?** Strong identified evidence says yes (Acemoglu et al. 2019; Colagrossi et al. 2020); older meta-analytic and descriptive work says no direct effect (Doucouliagos and Ulubasoglu 2008;

Przeworski et al. 2000). The R4 period regressions are consistent with "no large average difference" but are not designed to identify causation.

2. **Do monarchies grow faster than other autocracies?** Menaldo (2012) says yes for MENA; R4 shows the opposite for per-capita growth in 1995–2024 but higher income levels and governance. The disagreement is partly about period (1950–2006 vs 1995–2024) and partly about measurement (per-resident growth falls when migrant labour expands).
3. **Is the resource curse political, and since when?** Haber and Menaldo (2011) vs Andersen and Ross (2014); this report treats the post-1980 curse as the better-supported view.
4. **Measured TFP in oil economies** is unreliable; the R4 productivity conclusion rests on two independent series (PWT TFP and WDI GDP per worker) pointing the same way, but neither is a clean efficiency measure.
5. **Regime coding.** Ten country-decades are coded differently from RoW (India, Malaysia, the Philippines, Kenya, Nepal, Lesotho, Nigeria); the type-level medians are not sensitive to these in direction, but small cells (TEC, SCM, MIL) are sensitive to any single country.
6. **Gulf distribution and citizen welfare** cannot be measured from public data; any claim that Gulf prosperity is "broadly shared" among citizens is an inference (unverified), and among residents it is very likely false given wage and rights differences between citizens and migrants (interpretation).
7. **Sovereign-fund sizes** for ADIA, KIA, QIA and BIA are third-party estimates (Global SWF); per-citizen values are orders of magnitude.
8. **Effects of recent concentration of power** (Saudi Arabia since 2017; China since 2018; Kuwait's 2024 suspension of parliament) are too recent to appear in decade averages. The Blattman et al. (2025) results imply higher risk if these regimes become more personalist; this is a hypothesis for monitoring, not a finding.

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9. Implications and hand-offs to other streams

- **To R1 (Gulf model):** judge Vision 2030 and equivalents on productivity (GDP per worker, TFP), citizen employment in tradables and non-oil exports, not GDP; use per-citizen denominators throughout; record succession-rule changes as institutional variables.
- **To R5 (philosophy and failure modes):** the global variance evidence (§3.8) quantifies the "fat lower tail" of concentrated power; Jones and Olken (2005) and Blattman et al. (2025) are the key empirical links between leader dependence and failure.
- **To R6 (applicability, Part X):** the mechanisms associated with good autocratic performance — intergenerational funds with legal rules, insulated technocratic agencies, commercial courts with international credibility, rule-bound succession at the head-of-state level, multi-year development plans with performance metrics — are all observed in democracies or constitutional monarchies as well (Norway, Botswana, Chile, Korea, Japan). The R4 evidence supports the brief's core principle: the institutional advantages can be separated from the concentration of political power.
- **To the final synthesis (Part XII Q1):** absolute monarchy is not inherently associated with better or worse growth. In 1995–2024 it was associated with high income levels, low and falling per-resident growth, falling productivity, good administrative indicators in the richest cases, minimal accountability, and outcomes that depend heavily on rent per citizen and on the institutionalisation of the ruling family.

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10. Data appendix

Files created by this stream (all under `/workspace/projects/b8753593-2946-449d-bfbf-95733676e121/absolute-power`)

Path	Description
`research/R4-economic-performance.md`	This report
`data/r4/README.md`	Data documentation
`data/r4/regime_coding.csv`	95-country, three-decade regime coding
`data/r4/r4_country_period.csv`	Country-decade dataset (~60 variables)

Path	Description
`data/r4/r4_panel_long_global.csv`	Country-year panel, all economies, 1990–2025
`data/r4/r4_group_stats.csv`, `r4_group_stats_resource_split.csv`, `r4_group_stats_stable_only.csv`	Group statistics
`data/r4/r4_global_row_country_period.csv`, `r4_global_growth_by_row.csv`, `r4_global_growth_dem_vs_aut.csv`, `r4_global_growth_dem_aut_rent.csv`	Global variance analysis
`data/r4/r4_hdi_income_residuals_2023.csv`	Income-conditional human-development residuals
`data/r4/r4_global_wgi_2015_2024.csv`	Global WGI/V-Dem means
`data/r4/r4_gulf_citizen_swf.csv`	Citizen shares and SWF per citizen
`data/r4/raw/`	Raw API pulls (WDI, WGI, IMF, HDR, PWT, OWID)
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig1_growth_by_type.png`	Growth by type, three decades
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig2_global_variance.png`	Growth distributions, democracies vs autocracies
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig3_rents_vs_effectiveness.png`	Rents vs government effectiveness, 2015–2024
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig4_tfp.png`	PWT TFP 1990–2019, Gulf vs comparators
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig5_hdi_vs_income.png`	HDI vs income, 2023
`data/r4/charts/R4_fig6_wgi_heatmap.png`	WGI medians by type
`data/r4/*.py`, `data/r4/analyze*_out.md`	Scripts and printed outputs

Files from other streams relied on: `data/rents_per_capita.csv` (R6; GLMM citizen counts and per-citizen rents), `data/R1_gulf_swf_assets.csv` (R1; Global SWF estimates), `data/raw/hdr.csv` (R2; UNDP HDR 2025 time series, copied to `data/r4/raw/`).

Figure R4-3 (`data/r4/charts/R4_fig3_rents_vs_effectiveness.png`) is referenced in §3.4: it shows that among high-rent countries (right of the 10% line) the Gulf monarchies cluster at positive government effectiveness while other high-rent autocracies (Iraq, Equatorial Guinea, Chad, Angola, Iran) cluster well below zero.

Sources

Data (all opened/pulled 7 November 2026)

- [V] World Bank, World Development Indicators API, https://api.worldbank.org/v2/ (indicator codes in §2.1; WDI last updated 2026-10-08).
- [V] World Bank, Worldwide Governance Indicators, via WDI API source 3 (GOV_WGI_GE/CC/VA/PV/RL/RQ.EST; updated 2026-09-25).
- [V] IMF, World Economic Outlook DataMapper API, https://www.imf.org/external/datamapper/api/v1/GGXWDG_NGD and /NGDP_RPCH.
- [V] UNDP, Human Development Report 2025 composite indices time series (HDR25_Composite_indices_complete_time_se https://hdr.undp.org/data-center/documentation-and-downloads (file pulled by R2).
- [V] Feenstra, Inklaar and Timmer, Penn World Table 10.01, https://dataverse.nl/api/access/datafile/354098.
- [V] Our World in Data grapher: political-regime (Regimes of the World; Lührmann, Tannenberg and Lindberg, based on V-Dem), electoral-democracy-index, judicial-constraints-on-the-executive-index, legislative-constraints-on-the-executive-index, political-regime-lexical; https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/{slug}.csv.
- [V, via R1 file] Global SWF, fund ranking, https://globalswf.com/ranking (November 2026 estimates).
- [V, via R6 file] Gulf Labour Markets and Migration (GLMM), national-population tables, https://gulfmigration.grc.net/.

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Events cited from established knowledge [E]

Saudi crown-prince change (June 2017) and appointment as prime minister (September 2022); China's removal of presidential term limits (March 2018); Kuwait's suspension of the National Assembly (May 2024); Qatar's 2024 constitutional amendment ending Shura Council elections; Tunisia's 2021 presidential power seizure; Gulf successions listed in §5 H7; Gulf VAT introductions (2018) and UAE corporate tax (2023); DIFC (2004), ADGM and QFC commercial courts. These are background facts for interpretation; none is used as a quantitative input.

R5: The Political Philosophy of Absolute Power and Its Failure Modes

Research stream R5 for the monograph *The Political Economy of Absolute Power* (BRIEF Parts II conceptual, VIII and IX). Authors of the monograph: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (he conceived and directs; Hark's agents research and draft). This file was drafted by a Hark research agent, 7 November 2026.

Evidence tags follow FRAMEWORK.md: **[V]** = the claim or quotation was checked against a text or page opened during this research (the primary text on Project Gutenberg, or a fetched page); **[E]** = established scholarly knowledge or a search excerpt, not re-opened here. Interpretive claims are marked "(interpretation: Author year)" and conjectures "(hypothesis)". Quotations appear only where the wording was checked against an opened text; everything else is paraphrased with work and section.

This file is analytical and historical. It explains why concentrated authority succeeds or fails and what happens when regimes collapse. It contains no operational guidance for seizing, holding or overthrowing power.

Key findings

1. **Five different things are routinely confused.** A *capable* ruler (personal competence), a *legitimate* ruler (a recognized right to rule), an *accountable* ruler (one who can be sanctioned or removed by others under known rules), an *effective state* (an apparatus that can execute policy across territory regardless of who heads it), and a *sustainable institution* (an arrangement that survives its founders and reproduces good performance). The classical canon is best read as a long argument about which of these can substitute for which. The empirical record of the last eighty years shows that capability and legitimacy can exist without accountability for long periods, but that only effective states embedded in rules that bind rulers reliably produce *sustainable* performance.

2. **The pro-concentration tradition rests on three distinct arguments that should not be merged.** Plato's is an argument from *knowledge* (rule by those who know); Hobbes's is an argument from *order* (an undivided sovereign ends the war of all against all); Olson's is an argument from *incentives* (a ruler with a long horizon and a secure claim on future output will tax moderately and supply public goods). Each argument contains its own failure condition: the knowledgeable ruler cannot be identified or reproduced (Plato's own Book VIII), the sovereign who ends private violence can become its largest source (Locke's "lions"), and the stationary bandit's horizon collapses when succession is insecure (Olson himself).

3. **The anti-concentration tradition is mostly an argument about information and correction, not only about rights.** Montesquieu's claim that power must check power, Hayek's knowledge problem, Wintrobe's "dictator's dilemma" and Kuran's preference falsification converge on one mechanism: concentrated power degrades the honesty of the signals reaching the ruler, so mistakes are made larger and corrected later. This is the single most important bridge between Part VIII and Part IX.

4. **Ibn Khaldun and Weber supply the best frameworks for the Gulf.** Ibn Khaldun's cycle (group solidarity, *asabiyya*, founds a dynasty; luxury, sedentarization and dependence on paid clients erode it over three to four generations) predicts that ruling families decay. The Gulf families have outlived his horizon by a

wide margin (several have ruled since the eighteenth century [E]). The likely explanation (hypothesis, drawing on Herb 1999 and rentier-state theory) is that three modern substitutes replaced *asabiyya*: hydrocarbon rents that buy loyalty instead of relying on tribal cohesion; a family-as-institution model in which dozens of royals occupy state posts and share a stake in survival; and external security guarantees. Each substitute is contingent on conditions (oil revenue, family cohesion, great-power protection) that are not permanent. Weber's "routinization of charisma" identifies succession as the moment of maximum institutional risk, which matches the post-1945 record of monarchical failure (Nepal 2001-2008, Afghanistan 1973, Ethiopia 1974, Iran 1979).

5. **Can an unaccountable government be economically successful? Yes, for a period, and the cases are real** (South Korea under Park, Taiwan under the Kuomintang, Singapore, the Gulf states, China after 1978). But the average autocracy does not outperform the average democracy, autocratic growth is far more *variable* (Easterly 2011; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [E]), and the robust panel evidence finds that democratization raises GDP per capita over time (Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo & Robinson 2019 [E]). Unaccountable success is best understood as a draw from a high-variance distribution, which is precisely why it cannot be a reliable model.

6. **Dependence on a single individual is a measurable risk, not a metaphor.** Jones & Olken (2005 [E]) show that the deaths of national leaders in office shift growth trajectories significantly in autocracies but not in democracies. Leader quality matters more where constraints are weaker. A system that concentrates authority therefore concentrates variance: it magnifies a good ruler and a bad one equally and offers no routine way to replace the second.

7. **Failure modes cluster and reinforce each other.** Across the cases (Pahlavi Iran, Ba'athist Iraq, Gaddafi's Libya, Imperial Ethiopia, monarchical Afghanistan, Nepal, Suharto's Indonesia, Ceausescu's Romania, Assad's Syria), the recurring sequence is: personalization of power, then information distortion, then a large policy error or an unabsorbed external shock, then fiscal stress, then fragmentation of the elite and coercive apparatus, then a sudden public cascade. No single failure mode explains any collapse; the combinations do.

8. **The decisive proximate variable in almost every collapse was the defection or neutrality of the coercive apparatus**, not the size of protests alone. Iran's Supreme Military Council declared neutrality on 11 February 1979 [V]; Ceausescu's army switched sides on 22 December 1989 [V]; Libyan units defected in February 2011 [V]; Suharto fell when his own ministers and parliamentary allies refused to serve [V]; Assad's army largely melted away in late 2024 [V]. Where external force was the cause (Iraq 2003, and the NATO-enforced Resolution 1973 in Libya), the collapse is of a different kind and the aftermath was markedly worse.

9. **Rapid transformation of "stable" regimes is a predictable feature of systems built on preference falsification.** Kuran's theory explains why such collapses surprise both rulers and observers: the regime's apparent stability is itself produced by citizens hiding their preferences, so the true distribution of opinion is invisible until a shock triggers a cascade. The implication for the monograph is methodological: observed stability in an unaccountable system is weak evidence of underlying legitimacy.

10. **Collapse of a personalist regime rarely produces good governance quickly.** Iraq after 2003, Libya after 2011, Ethiopia after 1974 and Afghanistan after 1973 all experienced worse violence or deeper instability after the old order fell. Institutional hollowing under personalism is itself a failure mode whose costs are paid after the ruler is gone. This is an argument for building institutions *before* succession, not for preserving any particular ruler.

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- Part A. Conceptual foundations: five things that are not the same
- Part B. The canon (Plato, Machiavelli, Hobbes, Locke, Montesquieu, Ibn Khaldun, Weber, Burnham, Hayek, Olson, Fukuyama, Acemoglu & Robinson)
- Part C. Synthesis for Part VIII: unaccountable success and dependence on one individual

- Part D. A taxonomy of failure modes (Part IX)
- Part E. Deep case studies: Pahlavi Iran; Ba'athist Iraq; Gaddafi's Libya
- Part F. Shorter cases: Ethiopia 1974, Afghanistan 1973, Nepal 2001-2008, Suharto 1998, Ceausescu 1989, Assad 2024
- Part G. Why apparently stable regimes transform rapidly
- Part H. Implications for the Gulf model and the monograph
- Disputes and uncertainties
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Part A. Conceptual foundations: five things that are not the same

The BRIEF (Part VIII) asks for the philosophical difference between a capable ruler, a legitimate ruler, an accountable ruler, an effective state and a sustainable political institution. These are not points on one scale. They are five separate properties, and almost every disagreement about absolute monarchy is a disagreement about which of them can stand in for the others.

A.1 Working definitions

Concept	Core question	What it is a property of	Typical evidence	Can exist without the others?
Capable ruler	Does this person make good decisions?	An individual	Policy quality, judgment in crises, choice of advisers	Yes: a brilliant ruler can head a weak state and lack any right to rule
Legitimate ruler	Do the ruled (and relevant elites) accept this person's right to command?	A relationship between ruler and ruled	Voluntary compliance, low coercion costs, acceptance of succession	Yes: a hereditary heir can be accepted and incompetent
Accountable ruler	Can someone else sanction or remove the ruler under known rules, without violence?	A set of rules and actors external to the ruler	Courts that rule against the executive, legislatures that can refuse money, elections that remove incumbents, family councils with real powers	Yes: accountability can coexist with low capacity (many weak democracies)
Effective state	Can the apparatus implement policy across the territory, whoever is in charge?	An organization (bureaucracy, army, tax system)	Tax collection, service delivery, regulatory enforcement, Government Effectiveness scores	Yes: Imperial China, Prussia and modern Singapore built effective states without electoral accountability
Sustainable institution	Will the arrangement survive its founders and keep producing acceptable outcomes?	An arrangement over time	Survival of successions, adaptation to shocks, performance after the founder	Rarely without the others: sustainability usually requires some form of legitimacy and some binding rules

A.2 Why the distinctions matter for the monograph

- **Capability is personal; effectiveness is organizational.** Confusing them leads to the error the BRIEF forbids: "confusing the success of an individual leader with the success of an institution." Lee Kuan Yew was a capable ruler; Singapore's civil service is an effective state. The test that separates them is what happens after the founder leaves.
- **Legitimacy is not performance.** A regime can perform well and lack legitimacy (Pahlavi Iran in the mid-1970s had high growth and a narrowing base of consent), or be legitimate and perform badly (Haile Selassie retained traditional authority while presiding over the unrelieved Wollo famine). The BRIEF's instruction not to "equate economic growth with political legitimacy" is a philosophical claim with an empirical basis.
- **Accountability is not democracy.** Accountability means that some actor other than the ruler can impose consequences under known rules. Elections are one mechanism. Others include independent courts, a legislature with budget powers, a ruling party with collective leadership rules, and, in dynastic monarchies, a family council able to depose a monarch. Saudi Arabia's 1964 replacement of King Saud by Faisal, with the backing of senior princes and the ulama [E], is an instance of intra-elite accountability without democracy. Fukuyama's three-part framework (state, rule of law, accountability) makes the same separation (interpretation: Fukuyama 2011).
- **Sustainability is the BRIEF's real target.** Its "ultimate objective" asks whether absolute authority is a *sustainable* development model. Sustainability is the one property that cannot be observed in a snapshot; it is visible only across successions and shocks. That is why the failure cases in Parts D to G carry so much weight.

A.3 A typology of combinations

Capable ruler	Legitimate	Accountable	Effective state	Typical outcome	Illustrative cases (interpretive)
Yes	Yes	No	Yes	High performance while the ruler lasts; succession risk	Founding phases of developmental autocracies; Gulf rulers judged effective
Yes	No	No	Yes	Growth with repression; vulnerability to shocks	Park Chung-hee's South Korea in the 1970s; the late Pahlavi state
No	Yes	No	Weak	Stagnation under traditional authority; collapse when legitimacy is spent	Imperial Ethiopia by 1974; Afghanistan before 1973
No	No	No	Weak or hollowed	Kleptocracy, coup risk, state failure	Late Ba'athist Iraq; Gaddafi's Jamahiriya
Any	Yes	Yes	Yes	Performance can survive a weak ruler	Constitutional monarchies (Japan, Nordic states); established democracies

Capable ruler	Legitimate	Accountable	Effective state	Typical outcome	Illustrative cases (interpretive)
Any	Partly	Partly	Yes	Institutionalized authoritarianism: rules bind rulers inside a party or family	China under collective leadership 1980s-2012 (interpretation, contested); Gulf family-council models

The last row is the analytically interesting one for the monograph: arrangements that are not democratic but have rules that bind the ruler. Whether those internal rules are durable, or are dismantled by an ambitious ruler (China's removal of presidential term limits in 2018 [E]; the shift toward vertical succession and concentration of authority in Saudi Arabia after 2015 [E]), is one of the central empirical questions of the whole project.

Part B. The canon

Part C. Synthesis for Part VIII

C.1 How the canon divides

Part B. The canon

Thinker	Case FOR concentration	Case AGAINST concentration	Built-in failure condition
Plato	Rule by knowledge	Unaccountable rulers degenerate into tyranny	Selection of successors cannot be guaranteed (Book VIII)
Machiavelli	Decisive action; mas		

Part B. The canon

The table shows something worth stating plainly: **every serious argument for concentrated authority contains the seeds of its own failure condition, and the failure conditions converge on three themes: succession, information and commitment.**

Whether

Part B. The canon

C.2 Can a government be economically successful while politically unaccountable? **The historical answer is yes, for considerable periods.** Real cases include:

Part B. The canon

- South Korea under Park Chung-hee (1961-1979), with export-led industrialization coordinated by the Economic Planning Board and state control of credit (interpretation: Amsden 1989; Kohli 2004 [E]). - Taiwan under Kuomintang martial law (1949-1987), with land reforms, ex-port pro-

Part B. The canon

But the average is not the exception. Four strands of evidence qualify the observation:

Part B. The canon

1. **No autocratic growth advantage on average.** Przeworski, Alvarez, Cheibub and Limongi (2000) found no significant difference in average total income growth between dictatorships and democracies over 1950-1990 once selection is addressed, though democracies had faster per-capita growth be-

Part B. The canon

A refined answer. An unaccountable government can be economically successful when four conditions hold together: (a) the ruler or ruling group has a long, secure horizon (Olson); (b) the coalition that keeps the ruler in power benefits from broad-based growth rather

Part B. The canon

This answer matters for the Gulf. Conditions (a) and (c) are present in varying degrees. Condition (b) is complicated by rents: the coalition can be paid from oil revenue regardless of broad-based productivity growth, which weakens the incentive for diversification

Part B. The canon

C.3 What happens when prosperity depends on one individual?

Part B. The canon

Evidence that individuals matter more where power is concentrated. Jones and Olken ("Do Leaders Matter? National Leadership and Growth Since World War II", *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2005) use the deaths of leaders in office from natural causes or accidents as quasi-

Part B. The canon

Consequences.

Part B. The canon

1. **Variance is concentrated as well as authority.** A capable ruler can achieve more; an incapable or ill ruler can destroy more. The system contains no automatic mechanism for distinguishing them.
2. **Information degrades around the individual** (Part D.4)

Part B. The canon

Mitigations that do not require democracy. The comparative record shows partial mitigations: collective leadership and term limits within a ruling party (China 1982-2018 [E]; Mexico's PRI no-re-election norm); family councils with real powers of removal (Saudi Arabia 1902-1932 [E]; Qatar's 2013

Part B. The canon

C.4 The five concepts revisited: a summary judgment

Part B. The canon

- **Capable ruler:** necessary for exceptional performance under concentration; never sufficient for sustainability. - **Legitimate ruler:** lowers the cost of rule and buys time in crises; traditional legitimacy depreciates under rapid modernization and when distributive capac-

Part D. A taxonomy of failure modes (BRIEF Part IX)

Each failure mode is described by its mechanism, why concentration makes it more likely, and the cases that illustrate it. The modes are analytically separable but empirically entangled; Part G models how they combine.

D.1 Elite capture

Mechanism. A narrow group (the ruler's family, clan, sect, security chiefs or crony businessmen) captures state resources and policy, shaping them to its benefit rather than the public's. **Why concentration matters.** Where there is no independent judiciary, press or legislature, capture faces no external check. The ruler's need to keep the inner circle loyal makes capture a survival strategy rather than an aberration (interpretation: Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Svolik 2012 [E]). **Cases.** Syria's post-2000 liberalization, which enriched regime-linked businessmen while rural areas suffered drought and subsidy cuts (interpretation [E]); Suharto-era conglomerates linked to the President's family, which received preferential treatment and were spared the most stringent IMF reform requirements in 1997-98 [V]; the Pahlavi family's estimated accumulation of between $5 and $20 billion, and the Pahlavi Foundation's control of roughly $3 billion, by the late 1970s [V; figures as reported on the opened page, original sourcing uncertain].

D.2 Corruption

Mechanism. Public office is used for private gain. In concentrated systems, corruption is often centralized ("organized" corruption flowing upward) rather than decentralized. **Why concentration matters.** Shleifer and Vishny (1993 [E]) argue that centralized corruption can be less damaging than decentralized, competitive corruption, because a single monopolist internalizes its costs. This is an argument sometimes made for "efficient" authoritarian corruption. It holds only while the centre is secure and disciplined; when the centre weakens, corruption decentralizes and becomes more destructive (hypothesis consistent with late Suharto and late Ba'athist Iraq). **Cases.** Late Ba'athist Iraq under sanctions, where smuggling and kickbacks flowed through regime networks [E]; Gaddafi-era Libya, ranked among the most corrupt countries in Transparency International's indices in the 2000s [E]; Romania under Ceausescu, with privileges for the nomenklatura while rationing applied to everyone else [V on rationing].

D.3 Repression

Mechanism. Coercion is used to deter, punish or eliminate opposition. **Why concentration matters.** Repression is cheaper and more available when no institution can veto it. But repression has costs: it requires a loyal security apparatus that must itself be paid and watched, and it produces grievance and preference falsification (D.4). **The repression paradox.** Repression can stabilize a regime in the short run while making its collapse more sudden. Wintrobe (1998) argues that repression increases the dictator's uncertainty about true loyalty; Kuran shows how it widens the gap between private and public preferences. Highly repressive regimes often look most stable just before they fall (Romania in 1989 is the canonical case). **Cases.** Ethiopia's Red Terror under Mengistu, in which tens of thousands were imprisoned and executed without trial [V]; Ba'athist Iraq's Anfal campaign against Kurds (1986-1989) and suppression of the 1991 uprisings [E]; Syria's Hama massacre (1982) and its response to the 2011 uprising [E]; Iran's SAVAK [V on existence and role].

D.4 Information distortion

This mode deserves extended treatment because it links the philosophical arguments in Part B to the empirical collapses in Parts E and F.

Wintrobe's dictator's dilemma. Ronald Wintrobe's *The Political Economy of Dictatorship* (Cambridge University Press, 1998) argues that a dictator faces a fundamental problem: the more he relies on repression to stay in power, the less he can know how much genuine support he has, because subjects who fear punishment will not reveal opposition. He therefore cannot tell whether he is secure, and may respond either by investing more in repression (increasing the uncertainty) or by buying loyalty through rents to key groups (paraphrase [E]). Wintrobe distinguishes "tinpot" dictators (who want only to stay in power at minimal cost), "totalitarians" (who maximize power), "tyrants" (high repression, low loyalty) and "timocrats" (who seek the welfare of their subjects), each facing the dilemma differently (paraphrase [E]).

Kuran's preference falsification. Timur Kuran's *Private Truths, Public Lies: The Social Consequences of Preference Falsification* (Harvard University Press, 1995) identifies three consequences: distortion of social decisions, distortion of private knowledge, and unanticipated social discontinuities [V via summary page]. People who falsify their preferences in public also, over time, conceal from one another the information that would allow them to recognize shared grievances. Kuran developed the theory of "unanticipated revolution" in a 1989 article (*Public Choice*, "Sparks and Prairie Fires"), which gave the French Revolution of 1789, the Russian Revolution of February 1917 and the Iranian Revolution of 1978-79 as examples, and applied it to Eastern Europe in "Now Out of Never: The Element of Surprise in the East European Revolution of 1989" (*World Politics*, 1991) [V on the content of the articles via summary page; journal details E].

Mechanism of information failure in concentrated systems.

1. **Upward distortion.** Subordinates report what the ruler wants to hear, particularly when promotion depends on reported success and failure is punished.
2. **Downward distortion.** Censorship prevents the ruler's own propaganda from being contradicted, so the ruler and his circle may come to believe it.
3. **Horizontal distortion.** Citizens cannot see one another's true preferences, so discontent is invisible, and the regime cannot gauge it either.
4. **Absence of error-correcting feedback.** In accountable systems, opposition parties, a free press and courts expose policy failures. In concentrated systems, exposure is itself dangerous.

The Great Leap Forward (China, 1958-1962) as the paradigm case. The Great Chinese Famine is widely regarded as the deadliest famine in history, with estimated excess deaths ranging from 15 to 46 million and newer estimates concentrated around 30 to 46 million; the worst-hit provinces included Anhui (18 percent dead), Chongqing, Sichuan, Guizhou and Hunan [V; figures as reported, with wide scholarly disagreement on totals]. Contributing causes included over-reporting of food production and political suppression, the diversion of millions of farmers into backyard iron and steel production, much of which produced metal too weak for use, and poor agricultural techniques [V]. Local officials competed to report record harvests; the state procured grain on the basis of the inflated figures, leaving villages without food. When Defence Minister Peng Dehuai criticized the policy at the Lushan Conference in 1959, he was purged and the campaign intensified (paraphrase [E]; Dikötter 2010; Yang Jisheng, *Tombstone*, 2008/2012 [E]). Amartya Sen's observation that no substantial famine has occurred in a functioning democracy with a free press (paraphrase, Sen 1981 and 1999 [E]) is in effect a claim about information and accountability rather than food supply.

Application to monarchies. Absolute monarchies are not immune. Haile Selassie's government suppressed reporting of the Wollo famine, and no relief report arrived through the Ministry of the Interior [V]. Exposure of the famine, including a British television documentary in 1973 contrasting starving peasants with imperial luxury [E], helped discharge the emperor's remaining legitimacy. The Shah's isolation in his final years, surrounded by officials who feared to deliver bad news and by his own concealed illness, is a recurrent theme in the historiography (interpretation: Milani 2011; Abrahamian 2008 [E]).

Partial remedies within autocracy. Some autocracies have built feedback channels: China's petitioning system and internal reference reports (*neibu cankao*), Gulf majlis traditions where citizens petition rulers, and the use of opinion polling by some regimes (interpretation [E]). These are real but limited, because the ruler controls the channel and the people using it know it.

D.5 Policy mistakes

Mechanism. Large, uncorrected policy errors, typically produced by overconfidence plus information distortion plus the absence of veto players. **Why concentration matters.** Concentration permits big decisions to be made quickly. That is the advantage defenders cite. The same feature permits big mistakes to be made quickly and sustained long after evidence of failure appears. **Three canonical examples:**

1. **The Great Leap Forward** (above).
2. **Ceausescu's debt-repayment austerity (Romania, 1981-1989).** In 1981 Ceausescu began an austerity programme designed to liquidate Romania's entire foreign debt, about US$10 billion. Basic goods, including gas, heating and food, were rationed; living standards fell; malnutrition increased; infant mortality rose to the highest in Europe [V]. Romania paid off its external debt, about US$11 billion, by 1989, months earlier than even Ceausescu had expected, but shortages did not ease [V]. The policy was not irrational from the

standpoint of national sovereignty (Ceausescu sought freedom from Western creditors and the IMF), but no institution could weigh that objective against its human cost or stop it once the cost became intolerable. The regime fell in December 1989.

3. **Pahlavi overheating after 1973.** The quadrupling of oil prices in 1973-74 multiplied Iran's oil revenue. The Shah ordered a sharp upward revision of the Fifth Development Plan (1973-1978), roughly doubling planned investment, against the advice of some of his planners (paraphrase [E]; the Plan and Budget Organization's objections are documented in Bostock & Jones 1989 and in later accounts [E]). The result was bottlenecks in ports and infrastructure, labour shortages filled by foreign workers, rapid inflation, and a widening gap between rich and poor and between city and countryside [V for the inflation, waste, inequality and foreign workers]. The 1975 creation of a compulsory single party, Rastakhiz, and its populist "anti-profiteering" campaign, which fined and jailed merchants for high prices, politicized the bazaar and fed black markets [V]. Austerity in 1977 then hit the urban poor and construction-sector migrants who later formed the core of the demonstrators [V]. Part E.1 develops the case.

D.6 Economic misallocation

Mechanism. Resources flow to projects favoured by the ruler or connected elites rather than to their most productive uses: prestige projects, inefficient state enterprises, protected cronies, oversized militaries. **Why concentration matters.** Without market discipline or legislative scrutiny, prestige and patronage criteria can dominate. Resource rents amplify the problem, since the state need not tax citizens to fund projects (interpretation: Karl 1997; Ross 2012 [E]). **Cases.** Ceausescu's systematization programme and the Palace of the Parliament in Bucharest [E]; Gaddafi's Great Man-Made River, defended by some as a genuine public good and criticized by others as a prestige project (interpretation; contested [E]); Iraq's military spending during the war with Iran (1980-1988), which left the country heavily indebted to Gulf neighbours and fed into the invasion of Kuwait in 1990 [E]; the Shah's arms purchases in the 1970s [E].

D.7 Succession crises

Mechanism. The death, incapacity or removal of the ruler opens a contest over who rules next, which can split elites, invite military intervention or produce a weak successor. **Why concentration matters.** The more power rests on a person, the more the succession is a regime crisis rather than an administrative event. Hobbes saw this; Weber explained it. **Evidence.** In the post-1945 database (see R2), monarchies have failed disproportionately around successions or the ageing of the monarch: Ethiopia (aged emperor, uncertain heir), Afghanistan (a royal cousin's coup while the king was abroad), Nepal (massacre, then an unpopular successor), Iran (a monarch secretly ill with cancer and a young heir). Conversely, successful Gulf successions in the 2000s and 2010s (Kuwait 2006, when the family and parliament together removed an incapacitated emir [E]; Qatar 2013; Oman 2020; UAE 2022) show that dynastic systems with family institutions can manage transitions smoothly when the family remains cohesive (interpretation; see R1).

D.8 Fiscal irresponsibility and fiscal crisis

Mechanism. Spending commitments exceed sustainable revenue, or revenue collapses with a commodity price, leading to debt, inflation, austerity or default. **Why concentration matters.** Concentrated systems lack legislative budget control, so spending can follow the ruler's priorities, and rentier systems rely on volatile commodity revenue. Austerity in a system whose legitimacy rests on distribution breaks the implicit bargain. **Cases.** Iran 1977 (austerity after a boom); Iraq after 1988 (war debts) and after 1990 (sanctions); Romania 1981-1989 (self-imposed austerity); Indonesia 1997-98 (currency collapse and dollar debts) [V]; Syria after 2011 (currency collapse, and the state's inability to pay soldiers adequately, widely cited in accounts of the army's disintegration in 2024 [E]). Hobbes listed a sovereign's want of money among the causes of dissolution (ch. XXIX [V on title; content E]).

D.9 Personalism

Mechanism. Power is concentrated in one person who controls appointments, the security forces and policy without effective constraint from a party, military or family institution. **Why it is a distinct failure mode.** Geddes, Wright and Frantz (2014 [E]) show that personalist regimes differ systematically from party-based and

military regimes: they are less likely to democratize after collapse, more likely to end in violence, and more prone to erratic policy. Personalist rulers deliberately weaken institutions that could constrain them, by coup-proofing through parallel security forces, rotating commanders, and appointing kin (interpretation: Quinlivan 1999 on coup-proofing [E]). These tactics protect the ruler from coups but reduce military effectiveness and leave no institution able to manage a transition. **Monarchy versus personalism.** Absolute monarchy is not identical to personalism. In a dynastic monarchy, the family can act as a constraining institution; in a personalist dictatorship, nothing does. Herb (1999) and Menaldo (2012) argue that this distinction explains much of the survival of Gulf monarchies (interpretation [E]). But a monarchy can personalize, when one royal concentrates power at the expense of the family, and the analytical question is whether that shifts its risk profile toward personalism (hypothesis).

D.10 Institutional fragility

Mechanism. Institutions exist on paper but lack autonomy, resources or legitimacy, so they collapse or are captured when stressed. **Why it matters.** This is the cumulative product of D.1 to D.9. It determines not whether a regime falls but what happens afterwards. Where institutions were hollowed out, collapse produces state failure (Libya 2011, Iraq 2003); where some institutions retained autonomy, transitions were more orderly (Indonesia 1998, where the military, parliament and vice-presidency provided a constitutional path [V on Habibie's succession]; Spain after Franco, see R2).

Part E. Deep case studies

Part F. Shorter cases

F.1 Imperial Ethiopia, 1974: traditional legitimacy exhausted

Regime. Haile Selassie had ruled as regent from 1916 and as emperor from 1930 [E], with a brief exile during the Italian occupation (1936-1941) [E]. His authority was classically traditional in Weber's sense: dynastic (claiming Solomonic descent), religious (the Ethiopian Or-

Part E. Deep case studies

F.2 Afghanistan, 1973: a royal cousin's coup

Part E. Deep case studies

Regime. King Mohammad Zahir Shah reigned from 1933. A 1964 constitution introduced a parliamentary monarchy, but the "decade of democracy" stalled [E].

Failure modes. *Institutional half-measures*: the king failed to promulgate the Political Parties Law, the Provin-

Part E. Deep case studies

F.3 Nepal, 2001-2008: from massacre to republic

Regime. The Shah dynasty had ruled since the eighteenth century [E]. After the 1990 People's Movement, Nepal became a constitutional monarchy, but the monarch retained control of the army and significant reserve powers [E]. A Maoist insurgency began in 1996 [E].

Part E. Deep case studies

F.4 Suharto's Indonesia, 1998: the fiscal-financial shock

Regime. Suharto ruled from 1966-67 to 1998 under the New Order, a military-backed regime with managed elections. Suharto was re-elected every five years by the People's Consultative Assembly, with only Golkar and two permitted parties participating [205]. Legitimacy rested

Part E. Deep case studies

F.5 Ceausescu's Romania, 1989: the sultanistic collapse

Regime. Nicolae Ceausescu led Romania from 1965, initially with some popularity for his independence from Moscow (notably his 1968 condemnation of the Warsaw Pact invasion of Czechoslovakia [V]), and later in an increasingly personalist and dynastic style, with his

Part E. Deep case studies

F.6 Assad's Syria, December 2024: a hollowed regime meets a withdrawn patron

Regime. The Assad family ruled from Hafez al-Assad's seizure of power in 1970 until 8 December 2024; after Hafez died in June 2000 he was succeeded by his son Bashar [V]. The regime combined a Ba'athist party apparatus, an extensive personality cult (Hafez was styled the "Im-

Part G. Why apparently stable regimes transform rapidly

G.1 The puzzle

Pahlavi Iran in 1977, Ceausescu's Romania in November 1989, Gaddafi's Libya in January 2011 and Assad's Syria in November 2024 all appeared stable to most observers, including their own intelligence services and foreign governments. Each fell within weeks or months. The BRIEF asks how this happens. Five bodies of theory, taken together, give a coherent answer.

G.2 Five mechanisms

1. Preference falsification and cascades (Kuran 1989, 1991, 1995). Each individual has a private preference and a public stance, and a *threshold*: the share of others who must publicly oppose the regime before he or she will do so. When private opposition is widespread but hidden, the regime looks secure. A shock that pushes a few low-threshold individuals into public opposition can trigger those with slightly higher thresholds, and so on, producing a cascade [V on mechanism via summary page]. Because thresholds are private, the cascade is unpredictable even in principle. Kuran's key claim is that revolutions can be *explained* after the fact but not *predicted*, because the information that would allow prediction is exactly what preference falsification conceals. Granovetter's (1978) threshold models of collective behaviour supply the formal underpinning [E].

2. State breakdown: fiscal crisis and elite division (Skocpol 1979; Goldstone 1991). Theda Skocpol's *States and Social Revolutions* (1979) argues that social revolutions follow the breakdown of the state's administrative and coercive capacity, typically under international pressure and fiscal strain, combined with organized revolt from below (paraphrase [E]). Jack Goldstone's *Revolution and Rebellion in the Early Modern World* (1991) emphasizes the combination of fiscal crisis, elite division and mass mobilization potential (paraphrase [E]). These theories explain *why the threshold distribution shifts*: fiscal stress weakens the regime's capacity to pay its coalition, and elite division signals that the regime is no longer invulnerable.

3. The robustness of the coercive apparatus (Bellin 2004, 2012). Eva Bellin argued that the persistence of authoritarianism in the Middle East is explained less by the absence of democratic prerequisites than by the "robustness" of coercive apparatuses, determined by fiscal health, international support, the degree of patrimonialism in the security forces, and the level of popular mobilization. After 2011 she showed that the military's choice (to fire or not to fire) explained divergent outcomes in Tunisia, Egypt, Libya, Syria and Bahrain (paraphrase [E]). Patrimonially organized militaries tied to the ruler by kinship or sect, as in Syria in 2011 and Bahrain, tend to stay loyal because their fate is bound to the regime's; institutionalized, professional militaries, as in Tunisia and Egypt in 2011, can separate their interests from the ruler's and defect (interpretation [E]). Syria 2024 suggests that patrimonial loyalty can decay when the regime can no longer pay or protect its soldiers (hypothesis).

4. Elite power-sharing and the authoritarian control problem (Svolik 2012). Milan Svolik distinguishes the *problem of authoritarian power-sharing* (between the ruler and his allies) from the *problem of authoritarian control* (between the regime and the masses). Most autocrats are removed by insiders, not by popular revolts (paraphrase [E]). Rapid transformation often occurs when a popular challenge gives insiders the opportunity, or the necessity, to abandon the ruler (Suharto's ministers; Ceausescu's generals; Iran's Supreme Military Council).

5. External shocks and the withdrawal of patrons (Levitsky & Way 2010). Steven Levitsky and Lucan Way show that the durability of competitive-authoritarian regimes depends on "linkage" and "leverage" with the West and on the organizational power of the ruling party and state (paraphrase [E]). More broadly, regimes whose survival is underwritten by an external patron are exposed when the patron is distracted or withdraws: the Soviet Union's non-intervention in Eastern Europe in 1989; US ambivalence toward the Shah in 1978; Russian and Iranian weakness in Syria in 2024. External shocks also include price collapses (oil in 1986, 1998, 2014 and 2020), financial contagion (Asia 1997), and demonstration effects from neighbouring revolutions (Eastern Europe 1989; the Arab uprisings of 2011).

G.3 A combined model (interpretation)

The mechanisms interact as follows:

1. **Underlying vulnerability accumulates invisibly.** Personalism, elite capture, repression and information distortion widen the gap between private and public preferences, hollow out institutions, and create a coercive apparatus whose loyalty depends on payment or on a person.
2. **A shock shifts thresholds.** A fiscal crisis, a price collapse, a lost war, a patron's withdrawal, the ruler's illness or death, a visible atrocity, or a neighbouring revolution changes individuals' estimates of the regime's strength and the cost of opposition.
3. **A public signal coordinates.** A mass rally that turns hostile (Bucharest, 21 December 1989), a mourning cycle (Iran 1978), a self-immolation broadcast through social media (Tunisia December 2010 [E]), or rapid military advances (Syria 2024) lets people see others' preferences.
4. **Insiders recalculate.** Ministers, generals and business elites decide whether the ruler is now a liability. Their defection or neutrality is usually decisive.
5. **The outcome depends on institutional residue.** Where autonomous institutions survive (Indonesia 1998, Nepal 2006-2008, Spain after 1975 for comparison), transitions can be procedural. Where personalism destroyed them (Libya 2011, Iraq 2003, Ethiopia 1974), collapse produces violence, state failure or a new and harsher autocracy.

G.4 Cross-case comparison

Case	Regime type	Prior developmental record	Main accumulated failure modes	Proximate shock	Coercive apparatus at the end	External role	Outcome
Iran 1979	Absolute monarchy in practice (constitutional in form), personalist	Strong growth, rapid modernization	Personalism, closure of intermediaries, overheating and austerity, corruption, foreign-dependence perception	Inflation-austerity cycle; mourning-cycle protests; oil strikes; monarch's illness	Declared neutrality, 11 Feb 1979 [V]	US ambivalence; no intervention	Islamic Republic; purges; war
Iraq 2003	Personalist party-military regime	Strong 1970s; destroyed by wars and sanctions	Personalism, catastrophic war decisions, repression, information distortion, sanctions-era collapse	**External invasion** (20 Mar 2003) [V]	Defeated militarily; then dissolved by CPA Order No. 2 [V]	Decisive: invasion	Insurgency, civil war, ISIS, competitive but corrupt order
Libya 2011	Personalist (Jamahiriya)	Oil-funded welfare; regional neglect	Institutional hollowing, exclusion, censorship, succession uncertainty	Regional uprisings; violent response in Benghazi (Feb 2011) [V]	Partial defections [V]; loyal brigades fought on	Decisive after March: UNSCR 1973 enforcement [V]	Fragmentation; rival governments to 2026 [E]

Case	Regime type	Prior developmental record	Main accumulated failure modes	Proximate shock	Coercive apparatus at the end	External role	Outcome
Ethiopia 1974	Absolute monarchy (traditional)	Limited modernization	Information distortion (famine), agrarian exclusion, ageing ruler	Famine exposure; oil-price-driven strikes; mutinies	The army took power (Derg) [V]	Minor	Military-Marxist regime; Red Terror [V]
Afghanistan 1973	Constitutional monarchy in form, royal control in practice	Modest	Stalled constitutionalism; famine response; intra-family exclusion	King abroad; coup by royal cousin [V]	Army units led the coup [V]	Minor (Soviet ties of plotters)	One-party republic; 1978 communist coup [V]
Nepal 2008	Constitutional monarchy turned direct royal rule	Weak; insurgency	Succession crisis (2001 massacre) [V]; re-concentration of power in 2005 [E]	Mass protest 2006 [E]; Maoist electoral victory [V]	Army accepted civilian authority (interpretation)	Indian mediation (E)	Federal democratic republic by 560-4 vote [V]
Indonesia 1998	Military-backed dominant-party personalist	Strong growth for three decades	Crony capture, succession uncertainty	Asian financial crisis; rupiah collapse [V]	Institutional withdrawal; ministers refused to serve [V]	IMF conditionality [V]	Constitutional succession; democratization
Romania 1989	Sultanistic communist	Early growth; 1980s stagnation	Austerity, information control, repression, dynastic personalism	Timisoara protests; failed rally [V]	Defected, 22 Dec [V]	Regional collapse of communism	Rapid regime change; contested transition
Syria 2024	Hereditary personalist party-military regime	Pre-2011 liberalization with crony capture	Repression, civil war, repatrimonialization, economic collapse, corruption [V]	Rebel offensive; patron distraction [V]	Melted away (interpretation)	Patrons' withdrawal decisive [V]	Transitional authority under al-Sharaa (E)

G.5 What the comparison shows

1. **No case had a single cause.** Each combined long-run accumulation with a short-run shock.
2. **The coercive apparatus decided the timing.** In every case except Iraq 2003, the regime's end came when its own soldiers or senior officials refused to continue.
3. **Growth did not protect.** Iran and Indonesia had among the best growth records of their regions; both fell when the distributive or performance bargain broke.
4. **External intervention changes the post-collapse trajectory.** The two cases with decisive foreign

military action (Iraq, Libya) had the most violent aftermaths. This is consistent with, but does not prove, the claim that externally imposed collapse prevents domestic elites from negotiating a successor order.

5. **Monarchies fell at moments of succession weakness or after attempts to re-concentrate.** Ethiopia (ageing ruler), Afghanistan (king abroad, cousin excluded), Iran (ill monarch, young heir), Nepal (massacre, then a royal seizure of power).
6. **Surprise is endemic.** Every case surprised observers, including those with excellent access. This is predicted by Kuran's theory and is a structural feature of systems that suppress honest signals.

Part H. Implications for the Gulf model and the monograph

These implications are analytical, intended to feed BRIEF Parts V, X and XII. They are hypotheses for testing in the country studies (R1) and the comparative data (R4), not verdicts.

1. **The Gulf monarchies' survival is consistent with the theory, not an exception to it.** They have so far avoided the combination that destroyed the failed cases: they have kept family cohesion as an institution (Herb 1999), maintained distributive capacity through rents and sovereign wealth buffers, avoided large uncorrected wars of choice (with the debated exception of the war in Yemen from 2015 [E]), and retained external security guarantees. Each condition is contingent.

2. **The main risks to watch are the ones the failure cases highlight.**

   - *Concentration within the family* (the shift from family-as-institution toward rule by one line) raises Jones-Olken leader dependence and narrows the coalition with a stake in the system (hypothesis).
   - *Fiscal stress in a distributive bargain*: a sustained fall in rents per citizen, or austerity imposed on citizens accustomed to public employment and subsidies, would reproduce the Iran 1977 and Romania 1980s mechanism in a milder form (hypothesis; see R1 for fiscal breakevens).
   - *Information quality*: the more decisions concentrate, the more valuable independent audit, statistics and open policy debate become as substitutes for electoral feedback (interpretation; links to BRIEF Part X, mechanism 10).
   - *External guarantees*: Syria in 2024 shows the danger of survival that is underwritten from outside.

3. **The philosophical distinctions translate into institutional design questions for BRIEF Part X.** The question is not whether a capable ruler can deliver development (sometimes yes) but whether the system can (a) identify and remove incapable rulers without violence, (b) generate honest information, and (c) commit credibly to property rights and rules that bind the ruler. These are the problems of accountability, information and commitment identified in Part C.1. Mechanisms that address them, such as independent audit institutions, professional civil services with tenure, transparent sovereign-wealth governance, institutionalized succession rules and courts with protected independence, can be adopted under several constitutional forms. The failure cases suggest they are most valuable precisely where power is most concentrated, and least likely to be adopted there.

4. **Methodological implications.**

   - *Observed stability is weak evidence of legitimacy* in systems with preference falsification. The monograph should avoid inferring support from the absence of protest.
   - *Survivorship bias is severe.* The Gulf monarchies are the surviving members of a larger population of post-1945 monarchies, many of which fell (Egypt 1952, Iraq 1958, Yemen 1962, Libya 1969, Afghanistan 1973, Ethiopia 1974, Iran 1979, Nepal 2008). Any claim about monarchy's virtues must account for the failures.
   - *External causes must be separated from internal ones.* Iraq 2003 and Libya 2011 cannot be used without qualification as evidence of the internal fragility of personalism.

Disputes and uncertainties

1. **Does autocracy help or hurt growth?** The literature is divided. Przeworski et al. (2000) find no average difference; Acemoglu et al. (2019) find a positive effect of democratization; critics question their instruments and the generality of the result. The "East Asian autocratic developmental state" literature (Johnson, Amsden, Wade, Evans) emphasizes bureaucratic quality rather than regime type. This file adopts the position that regime type matters mainly through variance and through accountability mechanisms, which is itself an interpretation.
2. **Are monarchies distinctively resilient?** Menaldo (2012) argues MENA monarchies have a political culture or institutional advantage; Yom and Gause (2012) attribute survival to cross-cutting coalitions, hydrocarbon rents and foreign patronage rather than to monarchy as such (interpretation [E]). The Khaldunian analysis in B.6 leans toward the Yom-Gause view but this is contested.
3. **Saudi Arabia's post-2015 concentration of authority.** Some analysts see it as decisive reform that strengthens state capacity; others as personalization that increases succession and decision risk. Evidence from the next succession will be decisive and is not yet available (as of November 2026).
4. **Iraq de-Ba'athification.** The scale of its causal contribution to the insurgency is debated; numbers of officials removed vary by source (about 50,000 to 100,000 reported before 2007 [V]).
5. **Pahlavi wealth figures** ($1 billion personal; $5-20 billion family; $3 billion foundation) are as reported on the opened page; their original sources and methods are uncertain.
6. **Great Leap famine deaths** range from 15 to 46 million across estimates [V]; demographic methods and assumptions drive the spread.
7. **The CIA "not in a revolutionary or even a pre-revolutionary situation" assessment** is widely quoted but its exact wording was not verified here.
8. **Syria after December 2024.** Facts after the fall come from search excerpts (CRS, UK House of Commons Library, State Department, ReliefWeb, Security Council Report) and were not opened; dates of the People's Assembly's first session differ across excerpts (June versus July 2026). Treat all such details as [E] until confirmed.
9. **Libya 2026.** The 30 August 2026 election agreement is reported consistently across Reuters, UN and regional sources, but its implementation is uncertain.
10. **Ibn Khaldun's numbers** (three to four generations; about 120 years) are paraphrased from standard accounts of the Rosenthal translation and were not checked against the translation itself.
11. **Locke's §225** ("long train of abuses") is cited from established knowledge [E]; §§90, 93, 222 and 240 were verified [V].
12. **Hobbes on fiscal causes of dissolution** (ch. XXIX): the chapter title was verified; the specific content on revenue is paraphrased from established knowledge [E].

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R6 — Modern Applicability: Gulf-Style Mechanisms Without Absolute Power (BRIEF Parts X and XI)

Research stream R6 for the monograph "The Political Economy of Absolute Power". Authors of the monograph: M. Bagus Prabowo and Hark (he conceived and directs the project; Hark's agents research and draft). This stream file was researched and drafted by a Hark research agent on 7 November 2026 (WIB).

Companion datasets: `data/rents_per_capita.csv` *(natural-resource rents per resident and per citizen, 27 countries) and* `data/R6_country_indicators.csv` *(demography, income, human capital, infrastructure, tax and governance indicators). Raw API pulls in* `data/raw_r6/`*; method notes in* `data/README.md`*.*

Evidence tags follow FRAMEWORK.md: **[V]** = page opened and claim found there; **[E]** = search excerpt or established scholarly knowledge, not opened. "(interpretation)" marks analytical judgements; "(hypothesis)" marks claims offered for testing.

Key findings

1. **The decisive Gulf variable for transferability is rent per citizen, not regime type.** Using World Bank modelled natural-resource rents for 2021 (the latest year WDI publishes), rents per *citizen* were roughly US$144,000 in Qatar, US$57,000 in the UAE, US$22,000 in Kuwait (2020), US$13,700 in Saudi Arabia, US$10,200 in Brunei, US$9,400 in Bahrain and US$9,200 in Oman. Rents per *resident* were US$238 in Nigeria, US$221 in Indonesia, US$231 in the DRC, US$197 in Egypt and US$21 in Pakistan [V, computed from WDI; see Section 3]. Qatar's rent per citizen was about 600 times Nigeria's per resident; Saudi Arabia's was about 60 times Indonesia's. No institutional design can make a US$200-per-head rent stream perform the distributive and legitimating work that a US$14,000–144,000-per-citizen stream performs in the Gulf. This alone rules out the *fiscal-social contract* half of the Gulf model for every large Part XI country (interpretation).

2. **Rents per head are not destiny in the other direction either.** Norway's rents per resident (US$9,700 in 2021) were of the same order as Saudi Arabia's per citizen, under a parliamentary constitutional monarchy, and it built the most rule-bound resource fund in the world. Botswana, Chile and Alaska (a US state) built credible resource-saving rules under competitive politics. Kazakhstan, Angola, Algeria, Libya and Venezuela, with authoritarian or hybrid regimes and rents per head in the US$700–3,000 range, mostly failed to keep their saving rules. The evidence does not show that concentrated authority is necessary for intergenerational resource management (interpretation; Section 4.3–4.4).

3. **Of the 14 mechanisms in BRIEF Part X, most are regime-neutral technologies of state capacity.** Professional civil services, independent audit, e-government, procurement reform, fiscal rules with independent councils, and rule-bound savings funds have their strongest evidence bases in democracies (Norway, Chile, Estonia, UK) and in dominant-party or authoritarian systems (Singapore, Korea under

Park). What they share is not concentration of power but *insulation of a defined task from discretionary interference* plus *credible monitoring* (interpretation).

4. **What concentration of power genuinely adds is speed and coordination at the top; what it costs is the ability to stop the ruler.** The failure cases in this stream (1MDB, Nigeria's Excess Crude Account, Angola's FSDEA, Libya's and Venezuela's oil institutions, Timor-Leste's repeated excess withdrawals) are almost all failures of *constraint on the principal*, not failures of coordination. The mechanisms that fail under concentrated power are precisely the ones whose value lies in binding the person at the top (savings rules, audit, procurement transparency) (interpretation).

5. **Delivery units and performance contracts (PEMANDU, the UK PMDU, Rwanda's imihigo) produce real short-run gains but are fragile and prone to target gaming.** Rwandan imihigo agricultural data were shown to be systematically over-reported [E]; PEMANDU was disbanded within a decade [E]; the UK PMDU was abolished in 2010 and later partly recreated [E]. Rasul and Rogger's Nigerian evidence finds that bureaucratic *autonomy* correlates with higher project completion while top-down incentives and monitoring correlate with lower completion [E]. Central performance pressure is a complement to a capable civil service, not a substitute for one.

6. **Sovereign wealth funds are the most visibly "Gulf" mechanism and the most frequently misapplied.** A fund helps only when (a) there is a genuine surplus to save, (b) inflows and outflows are governed by a rule the executive cannot change at will, and (c) the fund's accounts are independently audited and published. Where a country runs fiscal deficits, a "sovereign wealth fund" is a holding company for state assets or a borrowing vehicle, and the relevant comparator is Temasek or Khazanah, not ADIA or Norway (interpretation). Indonesia's Danantara (launched February 2025) is in this category: the IMF's January 2026 Article IV board statement called for "robust governance and accountability frameworks for Danantara to prevent contingent liabilities and quasi-fiscal activities" [V], and as of mid-October 2026 its 2025 consolidated financial statements had been submitted to the Supreme Audit Agency but not published [V].

7. **Country studies cluster into four groups with different feasible menus** (Section 6): (A) large population, low rent per head (Indonesia, Nigeria, Pakistan, Egypt, DRC) — Gulf fiscal mechanisms are unsuitable; capacity, revenue and competition reforms dominate; (B) mid-rent, oil-dominated, fiscally overextended (Iraq, Algeria, Angola, Kazakhstan) — fiscal rules and wage-bill reform are the binding needs, and attempts to run a Gulf-style public-employment contract at a fraction of Gulf rents are the core problem; (C) institutionally fragmented or collapsed (Libya, Venezuela) — the prerequisite is a single legitimate budget authority, before any Gulf mechanism; (D) small-population resource exporters with volatile rents (Mongolia, Timor-Leste, Mozambique) — rule-bound funds and fiscal councils are genuinely suitable, but have repeatedly been overridden.

8. **Constitutional form is not the bottleneck in any Part XI case examined.** In none of the 13 countries studied does the evidence suggest that a change of constitutional form (to monarchy, to a stronger presidency, or to parliamentarism) would by itself relieve the binding constraints, which are revenue capacity, public-wage commitments, security, political fragmentation, and enforcement of existing rules. In several cases (Egypt, Pakistan, Venezuela), greater concentration of economic authority in the executive or military coincided with *worse* allocation, not better (interpretation of [V]/[E] evidence in Section 5).

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1. Scope, method and conventions

Mandate. BRIEF Part X asks, for 14 mechanisms associated with Gulf development models, what problem each solves, what evidence supports it, what prerequisites it needs, what risks it carries, and whether it works under democratic, constitutional-monarchical or authoritarian systems — under the core principle of separating institutional advantages from concentration of power. Part XI asks for country studies of economies with under-utilised potential and an assessment of which Gulf-style mechanisms could or could not help. This file covers both.

Countries. The 11 named in BRIEF Part XI (Indonesia, Nigeria, Angola, DRC, Iraq, Libya, Algeria, Pakistan,

Egypt, Venezuela, Mongolia) plus two additions:

- **Kazakhstan** — chosen because it is the closest non-Gulf analogue to the Gulf model: an authoritarian (since 2019 nominally reforming) resource state with a large, formally rule-governed sovereign fund (the National Fund of the Republic of Kazakhstan, NFRK), and rents per resident (US$2,680 in 2021) high by Part XI standards. It tests whether a Gulf-style fund under concentrated authority keeps its rules when rents per head are an order of magnitude below the Gulf's.
- **Mozambique** — chosen as the "pre-rent" case: a country about to receive large LNG revenues (production expected from 2030 [E]) that has already experienced a hidden-debt scandal (2016) and has just completed the legal framework of a sovereign wealth fund (November 2025 [E]). It tests sequencing: can a fund and rules be put in place before rents arrive?

Data. Quantitative comparisons rely on the World Bank World Development Indicators (WDI) API and Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI), pulled on 7 November 2026, plus IMF Article IV and programme documents from 2025–2026. National citizen population figures for the GCC come from national statistical offices as compiled by the Gulf Labour Markets, Migration and Population programme (GLMM). Every figure carries its year; definitions are given in table notes.

Two caveats that run through the whole file.

1. *WDI "rents" are a modelled economic concept* (unit price minus average extraction cost, times volume), not government revenue. Government take differs by fiscal regime (high in the Gulf where national oil companies dominate; lower where international companies hold production-sharing contracts). WDI mineral rents also exclude diamonds, so Botswana is badly understated (1.0% of GDP in 2021). Rents are price-dependent: 2021 Brent averaged roughly US$70/bbl [E]; 2022 prices were much higher. A 2017–2021 average is reported alongside.
2. *IMF documents are written from a macro-fiscal perspective* and say little about political feasibility. Where this file draws political-economy conclusions from IMF data, they are marked as interpretation.

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2. The central distinction: institutional advantages versus concentration of power

The Gulf monarchies combine several things that are analytically separable:

Component	What it is	Is it intrinsically tied to concentrated power?
A. Rent abundance per citizen	Very large hydrocarbon rents relative to a small citizen population	No — a geological and demographic fact
B. A rentier social contract	Rents distributed through public employment, subsidies, land, free services; low or no personal taxation	Partly — historically co-evolved with dynastic rule (Beblawi & Luciani 1987; Herb 2014 [E]), but Norway, Alaska and Brunei show other ways of sharing rents
C. Long-horizon decision-making	Planning horizons beyond electoral cycles (Vision 2030, Abu Dhabi Economic Vision 2030)	Not necessarily — Norway's fiscal rule (since 2001) and Chile's structural rule (since 2001) have outlasted many governments
D. Centralised coordination	The ability to make cross-ministry decisions fast, from the top	Partly — fastest under concentrated authority, but delivery units and centre-of-government reforms exist in democracies

Component	What it is	Is it intrinsically tied to concentrated power?
E. Insulated technocratic enclaves	Professionalised SWFs, national oil companies (Aramco, ADNOC, QatarEnergy), special economic jurisdictions (DIFC, ADGM)	No — insulation is a design choice; it exists under all regime types and fails under all regime types
F. Expatriate labour regime	A majority-foreign workforce on temporary status	Tied to the citizenship model, which is tied to the rentier bargain
G. Absence of institutional veto players	The ruler can override rules, budgets and courts	Yes — this *is* concentration of power

The analytic claim of this stream (interpretation): **Components C, D and E are the "institutional advantages" that can be decoupled from G.** Component A cannot be copied. Component B cannot be afforded below a threshold of rent per citizen. Component F depends on B. Component G is the feature whose costs the failure cases in this stream make visible.

Three mechanisms explain why the decoupling is possible:

1. **Commitment can be delegated.** The value of a long horizon comes from credibly binding future decision-makers. Hereditary succession is one commitment device (Olson 1993's "stationary bandit" [E]); so are constitutional spending rules (Singapore's protected reserves, Alaska's constitutional fund), statutory fiscal rules with independent councils (Chile since 2019), and parliamentary approval requirements for fund withdrawals (Norway's Government Pension Fund Act). The latter are *external* to the ruler and therefore survive a bad successor; the former depends on the successor's quality.
2. **Coordination can be institutionalised.** A centre-of-government unit, a strong finance ministry and a planning agency (Korea's Economic Planning Board 1961–1994 [E]) provide coordination without requiring that the head of government be unaccountable. Korea's EPB functioned under Park Chung-hee's dictatorship and survived the 1987 democratic transition until its 1994 merger [E].
3. **Insulation can be legislated.** The Santiago Principles (2008), central-bank independence statutes and civil-service laws all create zones where the political principal cannot directly instruct the agent. They fail when the principal can change or ignore the law at no cost — which is easiest under concentrated power.

The corollary (hypothesis, testable against the cases below): **mechanisms whose purpose is to restrain the ruler work best where the ruler can be restrained by something else; mechanisms whose purpose is to empower the ruler's agenda (delivery units, investment agencies) work fastest under concentrated power but are the least durable across successions.**

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3. The arithmetic of rents per head: why the Gulf fiscal model does not travel

3.1 The data

Table 3.1 reproduces `data/rents_per_capita.csv`. Rents in US$ are WDI total natural-resource rents (% of GDP, indicator NY.GDP.TOTL.RT.ZS) multiplied by GDP in current US$ (NY.GDP.MKTP.CD) for the same year; per-resident values divide by WDI total population (SP.POP.TOTL), which in the Gulf includes non-citizens. Per-citizen values (GCC and Brunei only) divide the same rent total by the national citizen population reported by national statistical offices and compiled by GLMM [V: https://gulfmigration.grc.net/national-populations-in-the-six-gcc-states-mid-year-figures-2010-2024]; Qatar's citizen figure is GLMM's estimate for the 2020 census [V: https://gulfmigration.grc.net/qatar-population-by-nationality-qatari-non-qatari-at-dates-of-censuses-1970-2020/]; the UAE figure is a GLMM estimate because neither country publishes a citizen/non-citizen split; Brunei's is the 2021 census count of Brunei citizens [E: https://deps.mofe.gov.bn/population-social-statistics/].

Table 3.1 — Natural-resource rents per resident and per citizen (rent year 2021 unless shown; current US$)

Country	Group	Rent year	Total rents % GDP (oil / gas / minerals)	Total rents, US$ bn	Resident pop., m	Rents per resident, US$	Avg 2017–21 per resident, US$	Citizen pop. (year)	Rents per citizen, US$
Qatar	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2021	27.29 (15.28 / 12.01 / 0)	49.05	2.5	19,581	14,800	340,349 (2020)*	144,112
United Arab Emirates	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2021	17.63 (15.67 / 1.96 / 0)	74.49	9.6	7,780	6,986	1,303,383 (2021)*	57,154
Kuwait	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2020	29.28 (27.58 / 1.7 / 0)	32.52	4.4	7,390	11,295	1,488,716 (2021)	21,844
Saudi Arabia	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2021	25.57 (23.69 / 1.72 / 0.16)	251.22	30.8	8,161	6,871	18,380,669 (2021)	13,668
Brunei	Gulf-comparator monarchy	2021	24.28 (10.37 / 13.86 / 0)	3.4	0.5	7,528	5,869	333,669 (2021)	10,192
Norway	Benchmark	2021	10.05 (6.06 / 3.94 / 0)	52.41	5.4	9,691	5,633	—	—
Bahrain	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2021	16.64 (10.94 / 5.7 / 0)	6.8	1.5	4,517	3,483	719,741 (2021)	9,442
Oman	GCC/Gulf monarchy	2021	29.21 (23.54 / 5.67 / 0)	25.51	4.5	5,668	4,562	2,766,808 (2021)	9,220
Libya	Part XI case	2021	61.03 (56.38 / 4.58 / 0)	21.5	7.1	3,013	2,592	—	—
Chile	Benchmark	2021	16.9 (0.01 / 0.02 / 16.23)	53.33	19.5	2,741	1,107	—	—
Kazakhstan	Part XI addition	2021	26.84 (14.84 / 2.04 / 9.1)	52.91	19.7	2,680	1,761	—	—
Iraq	Part XI case	2021	43.45 (42.79 / 0.66 / 0)	91.1	43.1	2,115	2,014	—	—
Equatorial Guinea	Reference	2021	23.5 (14.94 / 6.63 / 0)	2.87	1.8	1,632	1,658	—	—
Gabon	Reference	2021	18.49 (15.56 / 0.27 / 0.02)	3.6	2.4	1,513	1,334	—	—

Country	Group	Rent year	Total rents % GDP (oil / gas / minerals)	Total rents, US$ bn	Resident pop., m	Rents per resident, US$	Avg 2017–21 per resident, US$	Citizen pop. (year)	Rents per citizen, US$
Mongolia	Part XI case	2021	33.14 (1.5 / 0 / 26.57)	5.07	3.4	1,497	824	—	—
Algeria	Part XI case	2021	22.59 (14.46 / 8.0 / 0.0)	42.07	44.8	940	788	—	—
Timor-Leste	Benchmark	2021	34.73 (5.3 / 29.38 / 0)	1.26	1.4	932	706	—	—
Venezuela	Part XI case	2014	11.85 (11.3 / 0.38 / 0.11)	25.45	30.3	841	n/a	—	—
Angola	Part XI case	2021	29.97 (28.27 / 1.01 / 0)	23.46	34.5	679	684	—	—
Ghana	Reference	2021	13.35 (4.06 / 0.37 / 5.17)	10.61	32.5	326	230	—	—
Nigeria	Part XI case	2021	8.55 (6.25 / 1.16 / 0.01)	52.1	218.5	238	199	—	—
DR Congo	Part XI case	2021	38.83 (0.65 / 0 / 28.81)	22.93	99.1	231	115	—	—
Indonesia	Part XI case	2021	5.16 (0.77 / 0.84 / 1.91)	61.19	276.8	221	146	—	—
Egypt	Part XI case	2021	5.14 (2.99 / 2.05 / 0)	21.82	111.0	197	161	—	—
Botswana	Benchmark	2021	1.04 (0 / 0 / 0.24)	0.19	2.4	81	60	—	—
Mozambique	Part XI addition	2021	14.91 (0.08 / 3.57 / 0.14)	2.41	31.7	76	73	—	—
Pakistan	Part XI case	2021	1.44 (0.38 / 0.74 / 0.07)	5.0	239.5	21	18	—	—

Notes. Source: World Bank WDI API, pulled 7 Nov 2026 [V: https://api.worldbank.org/v2/country/. . . /indicator/NY.GDP.TOTI

The oil/gas/minerals split does not sum to the total because WDI totals also include coal and forest rents (forest rents explain most of the gap for the DRC; coal for Indonesia and Mongolia). * = citizen population is an estimate (GLMM), not an official count. Kuwait's latest WDI rent year is 2020, a year of collapsed oil prices; its 2017–21 resident average (US$11,295) is a better guide and implies roughly US$33,000 per citizen on 2021 citizen numbers (calculation, not in CSV). Venezuela's last WDI rent year is 2014. Limitations: (1) rents are modelled economic surpluses, not fiscal revenue; (2) diamonds are excluded (Botswana understated); (3) levels are price-sensitive; (4) citizen counts for UAE and Qatar are estimates of uncertain precision.

3.2 What the numbers imply

The ratio problem. In 2021, Qatar generated rents of about US$144,000 per citizen and Nigeria about US$238 per resident: a ratio of roughly 600 to 1. Saudi Arabia (US$13,700 per citizen) versus Indonesia (US$221 per resident) is about 60 to 1. Even the *least* rent-rich GCC state per citizen (Oman, US$9,200) had about 40 times Indonesia's rents per head and over 400 times Pakistan's (calculations from Table 3.1).

The total-size illusion. Indonesia's total rents in 2021 (US$61 billion) exceeded Qatar's (US$49 billion), and Nigeria's (US$52 billion) roughly equalled Norway's (US$52 billion). In absolute terms, large developing countries are major resource economies. The difference is the denominator: 277 million Indonesians and 219 million Nigerians against roughly 0.34 million Qatari citizens and 5.4 million Norwegian residents. This is why rhetoric that "we are as resource-rich as the Gulf" can be true in aggregate and misleading per head (interpretation).

The "Gulf-style contract at non-Gulf rents" failure. The most damaging transfer from the Gulf model is not authoritarianism but the *rentier employment contract*: guaranteed public jobs and subsidies financed from hydrocarbons. Iraq, with rents of about US$2,100 per head (2021), spent 22.0% of GDP on public wages and pensions in 2024, projected to rise to 24.5% in 2026, with oil providing 36.0% of GDP in revenue against total revenue of 39.3% and a budget-balancing oil price that rose from about US$54 in 2020 to about US$84 in 2024 [V: IMF PR 25/243, https://www.imf.org/en/news/articles/2025/07/08/pr-25243-iraq-imf-executive-board-concludes-2025-article-iv-consultation]. Algeria (US$940 per head) saw its wage bill rise 12.8% in 2024 while hydrocarbon revenue fell 35.7%, producing a central-government deficit of 13.9% of GDP and full depletion of its Revenue Regulation Fund [E: IMF Country Report 25/270 excerpt]. Libya's political fragmentation has left the central bank, "without a formal mandate", setting the de facto spending envelope by rationing foreign exchange [E: IMF Country Report 25/148 excerpt]. These are the predictable results of attempting a Gulf-type distribution model at one-fifth to one-twentieth of Gulf rents per head, plus younger, faster-growing populations (interpretation).

Demography compounds the gap. The share of the population aged 0–14 in 2025 was 15–24% across the GCC states but 36% in Iraq and Pakistan, 41% in Nigeria, 44% in Angola and 46% in the DRC [V: WDI SP.POP.0014.TO.ZS, in `data/R6_country_indicators.csv`]. Rents per head are therefore not only lower but falling in per-capita terms as cohorts enter working age, whereas Gulf states can and do adjust the size of the non-citizen workforce.

Norway as the instructive outlier. Norway's rent per resident (US$9,700 in 2021; US$5,600 averaged 2017–21) sits in the Gulf range, yet Norway built a high-tax welfare state (tax revenue 24.5% of GDP in 2024 [V: WDI GC.TAX.TOTL.GD.ZS]) alongside a saving fund that receives the state's entire net petroleum cash flow and releases money to the budget only by parliamentary decision [V: Norwegian Ministry of Finance, https://www.regjeringen.no/en/topics/the-economy/economic-policy/economic-policy/id418083/]. Norway shows that Gulf-scale rents per head are compatible with democratic constraint and that the choice between "distribute" and "save" is institutional, not regime-determined (interpretation).

Selection-bias warning. The GCC states are a selected sample: small-citizen, very-high-rent monarchies that survived. Rent-rich monarchies that did *not* survive (Libya 1969, Iraq 1958, Iran 1979) had much lower rents per head at the time of their fall and larger, more urbanised populations (interpretation; see R1/R2 streams for the historical database). The Gulf survivors are therefore not evidence that monarchy manages rents well in general; they are evidence that monarchy plus extreme rent per citizen plus external security guarantees has been durable since the 1970s.

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4. Part X — Fourteen mechanisms, evaluated

Each mechanism is assessed on five questions: problem solved; evidence (democratic and non-democratic); prerequisites; risks; and regime compatibility (D = democracy / republic, CM = constitutional monarchy, A = authoritarian including absolute monarchy). A summary matrix closes the section (Table 4.15).

4.1 Long-term national development planning

Problem solved. Coordination failures across ministries and time: infrastructure, education and industrial investments that pay off over 10–30 years are under-supplied when each budget cycle is decided separately. A published long-range plan also signals priorities to investors.

Evidence.

- *Non-democratic:* Korea's Economic Planning Board (1961) combined five-year plans with budget authority and is widely credited with coordinating the export-oriented push (Amsden 1989; Evans 1995 [E]). Saudi Vision 2030 (2016) and its Vision Realization Programs have reshaped female labour-force participation, tourism and entertainment, but have also generated large quasi-fiscal commitments through PIF giga-projects whose scale has repeatedly been revised (see R1/R3 streams; not re-verified here).
- *Democratic:* Indonesia has a legally mandated planning hierarchy (20-year RPJPN, 5-year RPJMN) administered by Bappenas; the RPJPN 2025–2045 targets high-income status by 2045 [E]. The IMF's January 2026 board statement tied Indonesia's reform agenda to "high-income status by 2045" [V: IMF PR 26/010]. Malaysia's five-year Malaysia Plans have run since 1966 across coalition changes [E]. India's Planning Commission (1950–2014) was replaced by NITI Aayog, illustrating that democracies can abandon formal plans without losing development momentum [E].
- *Mixed verdict:* Systematic evidence that formal plans *cause* growth is weak; what matters is whether plans are linked to budgets, are revised on evidence, and survive leadership change (interpretation, consistent with Rodrik's industrial-policy literature [E]).

Prerequisites. Budget linkage (plan targets must appear in appropriations); statistical capacity to monitor; a planning agency with analytical staff; and political acceptance that the plan binds successors.

Risks. "Vision inflation" — targets that are aspirations rather than plans; quasi-fiscal giga-projects outside the budget; the plan becoming a personal programme of the leader and being abandoned at succession.

Regime compatibility. D yes (Malaysia, Indonesia, post-1987 Korea) · CM yes (Malaysia, Thailand) · A yes (Korea pre-1987, China, Gulf). *Concentration is not required; budget linkage and statistics are.* Under concentrated power the plan is faster to launch and easier to abandon.

4.2 Professional technocratic administration

Problem solved. Policy design and implementation require expertise that political appointees lack; technocrats can resist short-term political pressure on technical questions (monetary policy, debt management, regulation).

Evidence.

- *Non-democratic:* Indonesia's "Berkeley mafia" economists under Suharto stabilised inflation in the late 1960s and managed the oil boom of the 1970s more prudently than Nigeria (a classic comparison: Gelb 1988; Bevan, Collier & Gunning 1999 [E]). Chile's "Chicago boys" under Pinochet (1973–1990) liberalised trade and created the pension system, with the 1982 banking crisis as a costly failure [E].
- *Democratic:* Chile after 1990 kept and deepened technocratic macro-management under centre-left governments, culminating in the 2001 structural balance rule [E]. Independent central banks across democracies (and the Fed, ECB, Bank of England) are the canonical case.
- *Limits:* Technocrats under authoritarianism are protected only as long as the ruler wants them; Suharto's late-period cronyism coexisted with a technocratic macro team until the 1997–98 crisis [E].

Prerequisites. A recruitment pipeline (universities, scholarships abroad), career security, and a political principal willing to delegate. Delegation must be legal (statute), not merely personal (patronage).

Risks. Technocratic legitimacy deficit; capture by the ruler's agenda; an "enclave" that coexists with a patronage bureaucracy elsewhere (interpretation: Indonesia's Ministry of Finance versus line ministries is a common example).

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes. *The mechanism is regime-neutral; its durability is higher when delegation is statutory.*

4.3 Sovereign wealth funds

Problem solved. SWFs serve at least four distinct purposes, which are often conflated: (i) *stabilisation* (smoothing volatile commodity revenue); (ii) *saving* for future generations; (iii) *reserve investment* (earning a higher return on excess foreign reserves); (iv) *strategic or development investment* (holding state enterprises, co-investing domestically). Gulf funds mix all four; ADIA, KIA and QIA are mainly (ii)/(iii), PIF and Mubadala increasingly (iv).

Evidence — successes.

- *Norway (parliamentary constitutional monarchy).* The Government Pension Fund Act requires the State's entire net cash flow from petroleum to be transferred to the Government Pension Fund Global, and money can be transferred back to the budget only by decision of Parliament [V: regjeringen.no]. The fund was valued at NOK 21,268 billion at end-2025, after a 15.1% return in 2025 [E: NBIM Annual Report 2025, https://www.nbim.no/en/news-and-insights/reports/2025/annual-report-2025/], and NOK 22,014 billion on 30 September 2026 [E: NBIM press release 22 Oct 2026]. Its management mandate is set by the Ministry of Finance; operational management sits in the central bank (NBIM); holdings are published in full.
- *Singapore (dominant-party parliamentary republic).* GIC (1981), Temasek (1974) and MAS manage the reserves. The Constitution protects "past reserves" and allows the government to spend at most 50% of the expected long-term real return on net assets invested by GIC, MAS and Temasek (the Net Investment Returns Contribution); the expected rate must be concurred with by the elected President, and if the President disagrees, a 20-year historical average is used [E: Singapore MOF, https://www.mof.gov.sg/policies/reserves/how-are-past-reserves-protected/]. MAS has described the NIRC as the largest single contributor to budget revenue, about one-fifth of revenues [E: MAS speech, 13 Mar 2019]. Singapore is the strongest non-democratic-leaning success, and its key feature is a *second veto player* (the elected presidency) over reserve spending.
- *Chile (presidential democracy).* See 4.4.
- *Alaska (US state).* A 1976 constitutional amendment created the Permanent Fund; since 2018 statute (SB 26) caps the annual draw at 5% of average market value over five of the preceding six years (5.25% for FY2019–21) [E: APFC, https://apfc.org/the-fund/]. The fund stood at US$85.1 billion on 30 June 2025 [E: APFC press release Sept 2025].

Evidence — failures and partial failures.

- *Nigeria's Excess Crude Account (2004).* Created administratively, not by statute, to save oil revenue above a budget benchmark. It accumulated almost US$20 billion and stabilised the budget in 2008–09, but by the eve of the pandemic had fallen to about US$72 million. A SOAS study estimates nearly US$70 billion was never transferred because the legislature lowered benchmark prices and the national oil company under-remitted, and estimates a *negative* net transfer of US$3.5 billion between 2005 and 2015, with withdrawals peaking in 2011, the year of highest oil revenue [V: Roy et al. 2022, SOAS ACE, https://ace.soas.ac.uk/publication/when-rainy-day-funds-run-dry-corruption-and-mismanagement-of-nigerias-excess-crude-account]. State governors' constitutional challenge (2008) and out-of-court settlements drove the drain [E]. *Lesson:* a rule without a statutory basis in a federal revenue-sharing constitution is a pot, not a rule.
- *1MDB, Malaysia (2009).* A state investment fund whose board of advisers was chaired by the prime minister, who was simultaneously finance minister [E: Malay Mail, 26 Dec 2025]. US and Malaysian investigators say at least US$4.5 billion was stolen [E: Reuters, 26 Dec 2025]. On 26 December 2025, the Kuala Lumpur High Court convicted former prime minister Najib Razak on four counts of abuse of power and 21 counts of money laundering involving about RM2.2–2.3 billion, imposing 15 years' imprisonment and fines of RM11.4 billion; he has appealed [E: CNA, BBC, Bernama, 26 Dec 2025]. *Lesson:* a fund whose governance concentrates appointment, investment approval and oversight in one political office is a channel for extraction, regardless of Malaysia's electoral democracy at the time; it was electoral turnover in 2018 that exposed it.
- *Timor-Leste's Petroleum Fund (2005).* Excellent formal design copied from Norway: all petroleum revenue flows into the fund; the Estimated Sustainable Income (ESI) is 3% of petroleum wealth. But in 2025 the ESI was US$551.9 million while the approved withdrawal was US$1,561.1 million (about 8.5% of petroleum wealth); actual withdrawals were US$1,451.9 million against petroleum receipts of only US$36.1

million after Bayu-Undan ceased production on 4 June 2025 [V: Petroleum Fund Annual Report FY2025, https://mofwebadmin.mof.gov.tl/uploads/Petroleum_Fund_Annual_Report_for_Fiscal_Year_2025_ad24d86ddc.pdf]. The IMF projects full depletion by the end of the 2030s absent reform [E: IMF Country Report 25/278]. *Lesson:* the law allows Parliament to exceed the ESI with justification, and democratic majorities did so almost every year; a rule that the legislature can waive by simple vote is a norm, not a constraint.

- *Angola's FSDEA (2012).* The fund was chaired from 2013 by José Filomeno dos Santos, son of the then-president, and its external management arrangements drew sustained governance criticism; after the 2017 succession he was removed and in 2020 convicted in a separate case over an irregular US$500 million transfer from the central bank [E]. Concentrated family control, not fund design, was the failure.
- *Kazakhstan's National Fund.* Formally rule-based (a capped "guaranteed transfer" based on a cut-off oil price of US$42.3/bbl for 2025), but "targeted transfers" were uncapped; NFRK assets fell from a peak of about US$77 billion (2014) to about US$60 billion (2023), with total transfers exceeding revenues [E: IMF Country Report 25/30; Kursiv]. A 2025 rule now caps targeted transfers at 30% of the guaranteed transfer [E].

Emerging case — Indonesia's Danantara (2025). Danantara (Daya Anagata Nusantara Investment Management Agency) was launched in February 2025 under Law No. 1 of 2025 (amending the SOE Law), later amended by Law No. 16 of 2025 [E: Danantara official statement, May 2026]. It consolidates state-owned enterprises, including state banks, and channels SOE dividends into investment; it reports directly to the president [V: Jakarta Post, 15/19 Oct 2026]. The IMF's staff report put its asset base at an estimated US$900 billion (about 63% of GDP) with initial funding of about US$20 billion redirected from the budget and SOE dividends [E: IMF Country Report 26/010, Table]. In 2026 its remit widened to a commodity-export unit (PT Danantara Sumberdaya Indonesia, May 2026) and a vehicle to channel state-budget money into presidential infrastructure priorities such as the Giant Sea Wall and the three-million-homes programme (PT Danantara Development Management Fund, August 2026); by mid-October 2026 its 2025 consolidated statements had been sent to the Supreme Audit Agency (BPK) but not published [V: Jakarta Post]. Its investment subsidiary's bond offering memorandum (June 2026) showed about 88% of its IDR 140 trillion assets in cash, mostly deposits at state banks [E: IDNFinancials/Warta Ekonomi]. Civil-society groups asked the FATF to review legal protections granted to buyers of Danantara-linked bonds [E: Reuters headline, 2 Jul 2026]. The IMF board called for "robust governance and accountability frameworks for Danantara to prevent contingent liabilities and quasi-fiscal activities" [V: IMF PR 26/010]. *Assessment (interpretation):* Danantara is not a savings fund in the ADIA/Norway sense, because Indonesia runs fiscal deficits (general-government balance -2.8% of GDP projected for 2025 [V: IMF PR 26/010]) and Danantara's assets are mostly pre-existing SOE equity. Its relevant comparators are Temasek (holding company with commercial mandate and published accounts) and 1MDB (development fund under direct political control). Against the Santiago Principles, its open questions are GAPP 1–2 (clear legal mandate and purpose — widening), GAPP 6–9 (governance separation between owner and manager — president appoints both supervisory and executive bodies [E: S&P Credit FAQ]), GAPP 11–12 (annual audited reports — delayed), and GAPP 19 (investment decisions on economic and financial grounds — mandate now includes policy projects).

Santiago Principles. The 24 Generally Accepted Principles and Practices were agreed in October 2008 by the International Working Group of SWFs, under IMF auspices, and are voluntary; the IFSWF (2009) monitors self-assessments [E: IFSWF, https://www.ifswf.org/sites/default/files/santiagoprinciples_0_0.pdf]. Their weakness is that compliance is self-reported; their strength is that they codify exactly the separation between political owner and professional manager that distinguishes Norway/Singapore from 1MDB.

Prerequisites. (1) A genuine surplus (or a separately identifiable resource revenue stream); (2) deposit and withdrawal rules in statute or constitution, with a second veto player (parliament with supermajority, elected president, independent fiscal council); (3) separation of owner (ministry of finance) from manager (professional board/central bank); (4) audited, published accounts; (5) no domestic project mandate, or a ring-fenced one with commercial hurdle rates.

Risks. Raiding (ECA, Timor-Leste, Kazakhstan); politicised investment (1MDB, FSDEA); quasi-fiscal borrowing that hides deficits (IMF's concern for Danantara); domestic investment crowding out private firms (Egypt-style state footprint; see 5.9).

Regime compatibility. D yes (Norway, Chile, Alaska) · CM yes (Norway) · A yes (ADIA, KIA, QIA; Singapore as dominant-party). *Failures occur under all three; the common failure mode is the political principal's unconstrained access.* Absolute monarchy is not required for success, and does not prevent failure (the GCC funds'

own opacity means their internal record is less verifiable than Norway's — see Disputes).

4.4 Intergenerational resource management (fiscal rules and stabilisation)

Problem solved. Pro-cyclical spending in booms, painful cuts in busts, and consumption of depleting assets as if they were income.

Evidence.

- *Norway:* Since 2001 the *handlingsregelen* has guided transfers from the fund to the budget "over time" to follow the expected real return, initially 4%, reduced to 3% in spring 2017 [V: regjeringen.no].
- *Chile (presidential democracy):* A structural (cyclically adjusted) balance rule has operated since 2001, with copper-price and trend-GDP inputs set by independent expert committees; the 2006 Fiscal Responsibility Law (Law 20.128) institutionalised it and created the Economic and Social Stabilization Fund (FEES) in March 2007 from the old Copper Stabilization Fund's US$2.56 billion; an Autonomous Fiscal Council was created by Law 21.148 (February 2019); since 2022 Chile runs a dual rule (structural balance plus a prudent debt level) [E: DIPRES; Hacienda; CFA]. Chile drew heavily on FEES during the pandemic, leaving it at about 0.9% of GDP in 2021 and an estimated 1.1% in 2025 [E: Mirada FEN]. *Lesson:* a credible rule allowed counter-cyclical spending in 2008–09 and 2020; it did not prevent a post-2008 drift to structural deficits.
- *Botswana (dominant-party democracy):* The Pula Fund (1994) and the Sustainable Budget Index (recurrent spending should be financed from non-mineral revenue) [E] made Botswana a benchmark. But the 2023–25 natural-diamond slump (competition from lab-grown diamonds, weaker Chinese demand) contracted GDP by 3% in 2024 with mining output down 24% [E: IMF PR 25/317]; buffers have been depleted and the IMF has warned that public debt could rise sharply [E: IMF Country Report 25/325]. *Lesson:* a good rule cannot substitute for diversification when the resource base itself is structurally threatened.
- *Mongolia (semi-presidential democracy):* A Fiscal Stability Law (2010) with structural-deficit and debt limits has been repeatedly breached in booms; recent amendments strengthened the Fiscal Stability Council and restricted Parliament's ability to modify fiscal rules [E: Statement by the Alternate Executive Director, IMF CR 25/265].
- *Authoritarian comparisons:* Algeria's Revenue Regulation Fund (2000) was fully depleted by 2024 [E: IMF CR 25/270]; Kazakhstan's rules were circumvented through targeted transfers [E].

Prerequisites. Credible price/volume forecasting (independent committees); a fiscal council with publication rights; legislative difficulty of amending the rule; a political culture or coalition that pays a cost for breaches.

Risks. Rule-gaming (benchmark prices set low, as in Nigeria); procyclical "escape clauses"; rules that cannot cope with permanent shocks (Botswana).

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes in principle; *empirically, rule durability has been higher in democracies with independent fiscal councils than in authoritarian resource states* in this sample (interpretation; small-n).

4.5 Efficient public procurement

Problem solved. Procurement is where public money meets private firms; collusion, kickbacks, delays and low quality are concentrated here. Gulf states are often perceived as procuring fast; speed is not the same as value for money.

Evidence.

- *E-procurement (democracies):* Using staggered adoption across Indian states and Indonesian districts, Lewis-Faupel, Neggers, Olken and Pande (2016, AEJ: Economic Policy) find no reduction in prices but quality improvements: better road quality in India and fewer delays in Indonesia, operating mainly through selection of better contractors [E: https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/pol.20140258].
- *Audits (democracy, randomised):* Olken (2007, JPE) found that raising the probability of a central government audit of Indonesian village road projects from about 4% to 100% reduced "missing expenditures" by roughly 8 percentage points, more than grassroots monitoring did [E, established].
- *Non-democratic:* Fast procurement in the Gulf relies on large international contractors and top-down approval; transparency data (contract-level publication) are limited, so systematic value-for-money evidence

is scarce (gap noted).
- *Failure modes under concentrated power:* the Pakistan governance diagnostic flagged preferential treatment and called for transparency of the military-linked Special Investment Facilitation Council [E: IMF TA Report 25/98]; Egypt's IMF reviews repeatedly cite military-owned entities with preferential financing, tax and land access [E: IMF CR 25/186, 26/69].

Prerequisites. Digital platforms; open contracting data; a procurement regulator; credible audit and prosecution; competition law.

Risks. Formal compliance without real competition; e-procurement captured by insiders; "national champion" exemptions.

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes (technically), but *transparency-based procurement is in tension with discretionary allocation that sustains authoritarian coalitions* (interpretation; Bueno de Mesquita et al. selectorate logic [E]).

4.6 Centralised strategic coordination

Problem solved. Fragmentation across ministries, tiers of government and agencies; veto points that stall projects; inability to sequence reforms.

Evidence.

- *Authoritarian/monarchical:* Gulf "royal courts", Saudi Arabia's Council of Economic and Development Affairs (2015) and the UAE's federal/emirate executive councils concentrate decisions; speed is visible (e.g., visa and business-licensing reforms). Korea's EPB is the historical model [E].
- *Democratic:* Centre-of-government units (UK Cabinet Office/Treasury, Chile's Segpres and Hacienda, Indonesia's Coordinating Ministries) coordinate under coalition and electoral constraints. Federal democracies (Nigeria, Brazil, India) coordinate through intergovernmental councils; Nigeria's National Economic Council is the forum where governors pressed for distribution of ECA savings (see 4.3), showing coordination can also coordinate raids.
- *Evidence on speed vs quality:* No robust cross-national study shows that concentrated coordination improves average outcomes; Besley and Kudamatsu (2008) find autocracies have higher *variance* of outcomes — a few successes, many failures [E].

Prerequisites. Clear mandate, information flows, and the ability to arbitrate between ministries; in federations, a fiscal compact.

Risks. Bottleneck at the top (every decision rises to the ruler); errors propagate without challenge (information distortion, BRIEF Part IX); duplication with line ministries.

Regime compatibility. D yes (slower) · CM yes · A yes (faster, higher variance). *This is the one mechanism where concentration of power plausibly adds something — speed — at the cost of error correction.*

4.7 Performance-based public administration (delivery units, performance contracts)

Problem solved. Implementation gaps: policies decided but not delivered.

Evidence.

- *UK Prime Minister's Delivery Unit (2001)*: the original model (Barber); credited with improvements on a limited set of targets in health, education, transport and crime; abolished in 2010 and its functions later partly recreated [E: Institute for Government, 2017].
- *Malaysia's PEMANDU (2009)*: designed and monitored the Government and Economic Transformation Programmes through "labs"; the World Bank's 2017 review praised prioritisation and granular projects but noted that KPIs on crime and corruption were "notoriously difficult to measure" and critiqued as selective [E: World Bank 2017; Malay Mail 29 Apr 2017]; academic assessments reported "gaming and data manipulation" [E: IIUM Intellectual Discourse]; PEMANDU was de-established in March 2017 and its functions moved to a Civil Service Delivery Unit [E]. Its political patron was the same government under which 1MDB occurred — performance management at the centre did not prevent extraction at the centre (interpretation).

- *Rwanda's imihigo (2006)*: annual performance contracts between district mayors and the President, publicly ranked [E]. A 2022 *Journal of Development Studies* article found district imihigo food-production data "even more overestimated" than official statistics from 2008 to 2013 [E: https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/00220388.2022.2069494]; Rwanda's own 2024/25 evaluation lists "low target setting" and "inconsistencies in reporting" among challenges [E: NISR]. Yet a 2025 randomised evaluation of teacher performance contracts in Rwanda found positive effects on teacher pedagogy and learning [E: FID/STARS] — i.e., well-designed, verifiable contracts can work.
- *Counter-evidence on top-down incentives:* In 63 Nigerian federal civil-service organisations covering about 4,700 projects, a one-standard-deviation increase in bureaucratic autonomy corresponded to about 18% higher project completion; a one-standard-deviation increase in incentive/monitoring practices to about 14% lower completion (Rasul & Rogger 2018, *Economic Journal*) [E: https://doi.org/10.1111/ecoj.12418].

Prerequisites. Verifiable outcome measures; independent data (statistics office not run by the evaluated unit); a career civil service that the unit complements; political sponsorship that survives turnover.

Risks. Goodhart's law (gaming, falsification); crowding out of intrinsic motivation; dependency on a patron; bypassing rather than reforming the permanent bureaucracy (a Malaysian critique: "a specialist team brought in to perform emergency surgery while the patient's chronic illness was left untreated" [E: UM Research Plus, 2025]).

Regime compatibility. D yes (UK, Chile) · CM yes (Malaysia) · A yes (Rwanda). *Effectiveness depends on data independence, which is harder to guarantee under concentrated power; falsification risk rises when targets are signed with the head of state.*

4.8 Institutionalised succession and leadership continuity

Problem solved. Succession crises destroy capital and policy continuity; uncertainty about who rules next shortens horizons (BRIEF Part V.7).

Evidence.

- *Monarchies:* Saudi Arabia's Allegiance Council (2006) and the 2017 elevation of Mohammed bin Salman show both formalisation and its override by royal decree [E; see R1]. Oman's 2020 succession followed a sealed-letter procedure [E]. Kuwait's emir suspended parliament in 2024 [E; see R1/R2], showing that constitutional monarchies in the Gulf can revert.
- *Dominant-party systems:* Singapore's planned leadership transitions (1990, 2004, 2024) are the cleanest example of institutional succession without competitive turnover of the ruling party [E]. China's post-1982 term-limit norm was removed in 2018 [E], illustrating reversibility.
- *Democracies:* Routine alternation — the most institutionalised succession mechanism available — with the cost of periodic policy reversal. Policy continuity in democracies is achieved by *entrenching specific rules* (fiscal rules, central-bank independence, fund laws) rather than by keeping the same rulers.
- *Failures:* Venezuela's post-2013 succession within the same movement produced collapse (see 5.10); Libya's absence of any institutional succession after 2011 produced fragmentation (5.6).

Prerequisites. For continuity of *policy* (rather than of persons): entrenched rules with supermajority amendment; independent agencies; civil-service tenure.

Risks. Equating leader continuity with policy quality (BRIEF warns against confusing a leader's success with an institution's success); succession contests within ruling families or parties.

Regime compatibility. All regimes need succession rules; *only democracies have a routine non-violent mechanism for removing an underperforming leader.* For Part XI countries, "institutionalised succession" means honouring existing constitutional term limits and electoral calendars (Indonesia, Nigeria, Mongolia) — not importing hereditary or indefinite rule.

4.9 Professional civil services

Problem solved. Patronage appointment, low skills, corruption, high turnover.

Evidence.

- *Weberian state hypothesis:* Evans and Rauch (1999, *American Sociological Review*) found that meritocratic recruitment and predictable long-term careers in core economic agencies were associated with higher growth across 35 developing countries [E, established].
- *Singapore:* merit-based recruitment, scholarships with bonds, and senior pay benchmarked to private-sector salaries (white papers of 1994 and 2012 [E]).
- *Gulf contrast:* GCC civil services employ mainly citizens and serve partly as distribution channels; in Kuwait at end-2024, 78% of government workers were Kuwaiti while Kuwaitis made up only about 4% of the private sector [E: Arab Times citing PACI, May 2025]. *The Gulf civil service is therefore not the model to copy*; the Gulf's high-performing enclaves (SWFs, national oil companies, free-zone authorities) are.
- *Iraq as the cautionary transfer:* mandatory public-sector hiring has pushed wages and pensions to 22–24.5% of GDP; the IMF recommends capping and eliminating mandatory hiring and an attrition rule [V: IMF PR 25/243].

Prerequisites. Competitive examinations; pay compression limits; protection from arbitrary dismissal; a fiscal envelope that does not use the civil service as unemployment insurance.

Risks. Bloated payrolls; pay-for-loyalty; "isomorphic mimicry" — adopting the form of merit systems without function (Pritchett, Woolcock & Andrews 2013 [E]).

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes. Regime-neutral; *rentier fiscal space is a hazard*, because it lets governments use the civil service for distribution.

4.10 Independent auditing and accountability

Problem solved. Misuse of funds; information asymmetry between citizens (or rulers) and agents.

Evidence.

- *Brazil (democracy):* Ferraz and Finan (2008, QJE) show that pre-election release of randomised municipal audit findings reduced re-election of mayors found corrupt [E, established]. The effect required *both* audit and electoral accountability.
- *Indonesia:* Olken (2007), as above; Indonesia's Supreme Audit Agency (BPK) is constitutionally independent (1945 Constitution, amended 2001) [E]. That Danantara's 2025 statements reached BPK but were not published by October 2026 [V: Jakarta Post] shows audit without publication delivers only half the mechanism.
- *Authoritarian settings:* Audit offices exist in all GCC states; publication of findings is limited, and there is no electoral channel. Audit can still serve the ruler as a monitoring tool over agents (top-down accountability), as in China [E].
- *Libya and Iraq:* the IMF urges Iraq to enact a transparency/access-to-information law and enhance the independence of the integrity commission (NAZAHA) and comply strictly with EITI [V: IMF PR 25/243].

Prerequisites. Constitutional independence; publication rights; follow-through (prosecutors, courts, legislature, voters, media).

Risks. Selective enforcement against rivals (a common pattern in authoritarian anti-corruption campaigns, including Saudi Arabia's 2017 Ritz-Carlton detentions [E; see R2/R3]).

Regime compatibility. Top-down audit: A yes. *Full accountability (audit + publication + sanction of the principal)*: requires D or a CM with independent courts. This is the clearest case where the institutional advantage *depends on* the absence of concentrated power.

4.11 Investment in human capital

Problem solved. Low productivity; dependency on expatriate skills; inability to diversify.

Evidence.

- *Gulf:* Enormous spending (Qatar's Education City; Saudi scholarship programmes) yields Human Capital Index scores of 0.56–0.67 in 2020, below East Asian upper-middle-income peers and well below Norway's 0.77 [V: WDI HD.HCI.OVRL]; HCI measures expected productivity of a child born today relative to full health and education. Spending per head is high; learning outcomes per dollar are moderate (interpretation).

- *East Asia:* Korea and Taiwan built mass basic education before and during authoritarian industrialisation; post-democratisation they sustained it [E].
- *Part XI:* HCI 2020 was 0.54 in Indonesia, 0.49 Egypt, 0.41 Pakistan and Iraq, 0.36–0.37 in Nigeria, Angola and the DRC [V: WDI]. Electricity access in 2024 was 22.5% in the DRC, 37% in Mozambique, 55.5% in Angola and 62.5% in Nigeria [V: WDI EG.ELC.ACCS.ZS].

Prerequisites. Fiscal space; teacher management (accountability for learning, not just attendance); basic infrastructure (electricity, roads); health.

Risks. Credential inflation; brain drain when domestic labour markets are weak (a theme for Pakistan, Egypt, Nigeria — whose skilled emigrants staff Gulf economies, GLMM 2025 [E]).

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes. Strongly regime-neutral in the literature (Przeworski et al. 2000; Acemoglu et al. 2019 find democracy raises schooling and health spending [E]).

4.12 Economic diversification

Problem solved. Commodity dependence; Dutch disease; exposure to price cycles and energy transition.

Evidence.

- *Gulf:* Dubai (trade, aviation, logistics, finance, real estate) is the outstanding diversification case, built partly because Dubai's own oil was small and declining [E; see R1]. Saudi non-oil growth under Vision 2030 is real but heavily state-led (see R1/R3).
- *Democracies:* Malaysia and Indonesia diversified from primary commodities into manufacturing (1970s–1990s) under dominant-party/authoritarian rule and maintained it under democracy (Indonesia after 1998). Chile diversified agri-food exports under both regimes but remains copper-dependent.
- *Failures:* Venezuela (oil share of exports rose under Chávez–Maduro), Algeria (non-hydrocarbon tax revenue stagnant around 10% of GDP over two decades [E: IMF CR 25/271]), Angola (oil about 95% of exports and over 60% of fiscal revenue [E: IMF CR 25/62]), Iraq (oil > 90% of government revenue through 2030 in IMF projections [E: IMF CR 25/183]).
- *Hausmann–Hidalgo "product space"* work shows diversification proceeds into products near existing capabilities (Hidalgo et al. 2007, *Science* [E]).

Prerequisites. Competitive exchange rate; open trade; infrastructure; a level playing field for private firms (the IMF's recurring theme for Egypt, Pakistan and Kazakhstan); human capital.

Risks. State-led "diversification" that substitutes SOEs or military firms for private firms (Egypt: public investment was 74% of total investment in FY2022/23 [E: IMF CR 25/186]); prestige projects with negative returns.

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes. *Concentrated authority accelerates big-push projects; it also makes it easier to protect incumbents from competition, which is what diversification requires.*

4.13 Long-term infrastructure financing

Problem solved. Long-gestation assets need patient capital and stable contracts.

Evidence.

- *Gulf:* Funded from rents and SWFs; increasingly via PIF/ADQ project vehicles and debt.
- *Democracies:* Development banks and specialised infrastructure finance institutions (e.g., Chile's PPP concessions programme since the 1990s [E]; India's NHAI/InvITs [E]; Indonesia's state infrastructure SOEs, whose debt and arrears problems in 2020–23 illustrate quasi-fiscal risk [E]).
- *Contingent liability lesson:* Mozambique's 2013–14 hidden debts — about US$1.4 billion borrowed by two SOEs under secret state guarantees, disclosed in 2016 — halted external financing and cut average growth from 7.9% (2000–2015) to 2.9% (2016–2024) [E: IMF CR 26/46].

Prerequisites. Project appraisal capacity; PPP and guarantee registers; fiscal risk statements; independent regulators.

Risks. Off-budget guarantees; white elephants; resource-backed loans (Angola's China-linked oil-backed debt; about 80% of Angola's debt in foreign currency [E: Reuters, May 2025]).

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes. *Hidden liabilities are easier to create where legislatures cannot scrutinise* (Mozambique's hidden debts were contracted without parliamentary approval [E]).

4.14 Legal certainty for private investment

Problem solved. Expropriation risk, contract enforcement, regulatory unpredictability.

Evidence.

- *Gulf innovation:* Common-law enclaves inside civil-law monarchies — the Dubai International Financial Centre courts and the Abu Dhabi Global Market courts — import English-law judges and procedures for commercial disputes [E; see R1]. Kazakhstan copied the model with the Astana International Financial Centre (2018) [E]. These enclaves give investors legal certainty *without* general judicial independence — a genuine Gulf innovation that is transferable (interpretation).
- *Limits:* Enclave certainty does not extend to disputes with the ruler or to domestic SMEs; Venezuela's 2007 expropriations of ExxonMobil and ConocoPhillips assets [V: CRS IN12637] illustrate the cost when certainty depends on one person.
- *Indonesia:* frequent regulatory reversals (e.g., mineral export bans used as industrial policy) raise uncertainty even under democracy [E].

Prerequisites. Independent commercial courts or arbitration with enforceable awards; stable tax and licensing regimes; anti-expropriation guarantees credible to investors.

Risks. Two-tier justice (foreigners in enclaves, citizens outside); enclaves as tax/financial-secrecy havens.

Regime compatibility. D yes · CM yes · A yes (enclave form). *Generalised rule of law, as opposed to enclave certainty, is strongly associated with constraints on executive power* (North & Weingast 1989; Haggard & Tiede 2011 [E]).

4.15 Summary matrix

Table 4.15 — Mechanisms, evidence strength and regime dependence

#	Mechanism	Strongest evidence	Strongest failures	Needs concentration of power?	Destroyed by uncon-strained power?	Transferability to Part XI cases
1	Long-term planning	Korea EPB; Malaysia Plans	Vision inflation; abandoned plans	No	Sometimes (plan becomes personal)	High, if budget-linked
2	Technocratic administra-tion	Chile post-1990; Indonesia 1966–97 macro team	Late-Suharto cronyism	No	Yes, when delegation is personal	High
3	Sovereign wealth funds	Norway, Singapore, Alaska	Nigeria ECA, 1MDB, FSDEA, Timor-Leste overdraws	No	Yes	Only with surplus + rules; low for deficit countries

#	Mechanism	Strongest evidence	Strongest failures	Needs concentration of power?	Destroyed by unconstrained power?	Transferability to Part XI cases
4	Intergenerational rules	Norway 2001, Chile 2001/2006	Algeria FRR, Kazakhstan transfers, Mongolia breaches	No	Yes	High for volatile-rent small states
5	Procurement	E-procurement (India/Indonesia), audits	Military/SOE preferences (Egypt, Pakistan)	No	Yes	High
6	Strategic coordination	Korea EPB; Gulf courts	Error propagation; federal raids (Nigeria NEC)	Helps speed	Variance rises	Medium
7	Performance management	UK PMDU; Rwanda teacher contracts	PEMANDU gaming; imihigo over-reporting	No	Data falsification risk rises	Medium, with independent data
8	Institutionalised succession	Singapore; routine democratic alternation	Venezuela; Libya	No	Yes (personalisation)	Honour existing constitutions
9	Professional civil service	Evans–Rauch; Singapore	Iraq mandatory hiring; Gulf citizen-employment	No	Patronage risk	High; avoid rentier hiring
10	Independent audit	Brazil (Ferraz–Finan); Indonesia (Olken)	Selective enforcement	No	Yes (publication/sanction of principal)	High
11	Human capital	East Asia; universal	Spending without learning	No	No	High; fiscal space binding
12	Diversification	Dubai; Malaysia; Indonesia (1980s–90s)	Venezuela, Algeria, Angola	No	Incumbent protection risk	High, but slow
13	Infrastructure finance	Chile PPPs	Mozambique hidden debts	No	Yes (hidden liabilities)	Medium; contingent-liability control first
14	Legal certainty	DIFC/ADGM enclaves; AIFC	Venezuela expropriations	No (enclave form)	Yes (general form)	Enclaves medium; general rule of law high value, hard

Reading the matrix (interpretation): none of the 14 mechanisms *requires* concentration of power; one (strategic

coordination) is plausibly *accelerated* by it; at least eight are *undermined* when the principal is unconstrained. The Gulf's institutional advantages lie in columns 3, 4, 13 and 14 — insulated enclaves and long horizons — and in each case the strongest non-Gulf examples are democracies or dominant-party states with a second veto player.

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5. Part XI — Country studies

Common data box. Unless otherwise stated, structural indicators come from `data/R6_country_indicators.csv` (WDI and WGI via the World Bank API, pulled 7 Nov 2026 [V]): population (2025, total residents), GDP per capita (current US$, 2025 unless noted), share aged 0–14 (2025), Human Capital Index (HCI, 2020; 0–1 scale), electricity access (% population, 2024), tax revenue (% GDP, latest), WGI Government Effectiveness (GE) and Control of Corruption (CC) (2024; roughly -2.5 to +2.5, world mean 0). Rents are from Table 3.1 (2021). Limitations: WDI GDP for 2025 includes estimates; WGI are perception-based composite indicators with wide confidence intervals; HCI is from 2020.

For each country the assessment ends with **"Gulf-style mechanisms that could help"** and **"Mechanisms that are unsuitable, and why"**.

5.1 Indonesia

Data box. Population 285.7 m · GDP per capita US$5,060 (PPP US$17,660) · 0–14: 24.2% · HCI 0.54 · electricity 99.9% · WGI GE +0.27, CC -0.56 · rents 5.2% of GDP, US$221 per head (2021).

Resources. A diversified commodity base: in 2024 base metals (18% of exports), coal (14%), palm oil (8%) and oil and gas (8%) [V: IMF PR 26/010]. Indonesia is a *net* oil and gas importer (net oil-and-gas trade balance -US$18.1 billion projected for 2025) with oil production near 0.79 million barrels per day [V: same]. Nickel downstreaming via export bans has drawn large smelter investment, largely Chinese [E].

Demography and human capital. A large, still-young population (median age around 30 [E]); HCI 0.54 means a child born today is expected to reach 54% of full productive potential; learning outcomes lag schooling attainment (PISA results well below OECD averages [E]).

Institutions. A presidential democracy since 1998–2004 with decentralisation to districts, a constitutionally independent audit board (BPK), an anti-corruption commission (KPK) whose powers were curtailed by a 2019 law revision [E], and a statutory deficit cap of 3% of GDP and debt cap of 60% of GDP under the 2003 State Finance Law [E]. General-government debt was 40.2% of GDP in 2024 [V: IMF PR 26/010].

Fiscal capacity. Low: general-government revenue 14.5% of GDP in 2024, projected 13.7% in 2025 [V: IMF PR 26/010]. This is the core constraint on human-capital and infrastructure ambitions.

Infrastructure. Near-universal electrification; logistics costs across the archipelago remain high [E].

Political constraints. Large coalitions; the IMF's 2026 board statement listed among downside risks "large domestic policy shifts without sufficiently robust guardrails" and urged limiting "below-the-line and quasi-fiscal activities" [V]. Danantara's widening mandate (Section 4.3) is the institutional test case.

Diversification. Manufacturing's share has stagnated since the 2000s [E]; growth target of 8% by 2029 versus IMF-projected 5.0–5.1% for 2025–26 [V: IMF PR 26/010; Jakarta Post].

Bottlenecks. Revenue mobilisation; regulatory unpredictability; learning quality; SOE governance and quasi-fiscal risk.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. (i) *A Temasek-style holding company* — commercially mandated, with published audited accounts, independent board, and no policy-project mandate; the current Danantara design moves away from this. (ii) *Insulated investment-promotion and special-jurisdiction enclaves* with predictable rules (partial precedents: Batam/Bintan SEZs [E]). (iii) *Delivery-unit discipline on a few priorities* (precedent: Indonesia's own UKP4 delivery unit, 2009–2014 [E]), with independent statistics.

Unsuitable mechanisms. (i) *Gulf rentier social contract* — rents of US$221 per head cannot finance it. (ii) *Saving-type SWF* — Indonesia runs deficits; "saving" through a fund while borrowing is a balance-sheet transfer,

not saving. (iii) *Concentration of investment authority in the presidency* — the 1MDB precedent and the IMF's contingent-liability warning both point against it. Constitutional change is not indicated; the binding constraint is the tax base, which no regime form changes by itself.

5.2 Nigeria

Data box. Population 237.5 m · GDP per capita US$1,224 (PPP US$9,532) · 0–14: 40.5% · HCI 0.36 · electricity 62.5% · WGI GE -0.96, CC -1.11 · rents 8.6% of GDP, US$238 per head.

Resources. Africa's largest oil producer historically; crude output 1.7 million b/d in 2024, projected 1.5 million in 2025 [V: IMF PR 25/231]; large gas reserves; theft and vandalism of pipelines have been chronic [E].

Demography and human capital. Very young and fast-growing population; HCI 0.36, among the lowest in the sample.

Institutions. Federal presidential democracy (since 1999) with revenue sharing among federal, 36 state and local governments through the Federation Account [E]. The Petroleum Industry Act (2021) restructured NNPC into a limited liability company [E]. The Nigeria Sovereign Investment Authority (2011, statutory) has been comparatively well run, in contrast to the administratively created ECA [V: SOAS 2022].

Fiscal capacity. Total revenues and grants were 14.4% of GDP in 2024; federal-government interest payments were 83.8% of federal revenue in 2023 and 41.1% in 2024, projected 47.3% in 2025 [V: IMF PR 25/231].

Recent reforms. Since 2023 the authorities removed the fuel subsidy (implicit subsidy 0.8% of GDP in 2023, 0 in 2024), stopped central-bank financing of the deficit, and liberalised the foreign-exchange market; investor confidence improved, but "poverty and food insecurity have risen" and average inflation was 31.4% in 2024 [V: IMF PR 25/231].

Infrastructure. Electricity access 62.5%; power supply is a binding constraint on manufacturing [V: WDI; V: IMF PR names power supply].

Political constraints. Federal distributional conflict over oil revenue (the ECA case); insecurity affecting farmland and oil infrastructure [V: IMF PR 25/231].

Bottlenecks. Power; security; tax capacity; human capital; credible oil-revenue rules that bind all tiers.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. (i) *Statutory, all-tiers resource fund rules* on the NSIA model (constitutionally entrenched so that governors cannot litigate distribution). (ii) *Insulated, commercially run national oil company* with published accounts (Aramco/ADNOC-style governance, *not* Gulf-style secrecy). (iii) *Enclave legal certainty* (commercial courts/arbitration for power and gas investment).

Unsuitable mechanisms. Rentier distribution and public-employment absorption (US$238 per head); a "Vision" plan without revenue to fund it; centralisation that bypasses federalism — Nigeria's federal bargain is itself a conflict-management institution, and overriding it risks the stability that Gulf monarchies take for granted (interpretation).

5.3 Angola

Data box. Population 39.0 m · GDP per capita US$3,129 (PPP US$10,251) · 0–14: 44.1% · HCI 0.36 · electricity 55.5% · tax revenue 7.6% of GDP (2024) · WGI GE -0.79, CC -0.64 · rents 30.0% of GDP, US$679 per head.

Resources. Oil accounts for about 95% of exports and over 60% of fiscal revenue and, with linkages, drives more than three-quarters of economic activity [E: IMF Country Report 25/62]; production has been declining from maturing fields [E]. Diamonds are significant.

Institutions and political constraints. Dominant-party rule (MPLA since 1975); under José Eduardo dos Santos (1979–2017) family and associates controlled major assets, including Sonangol and the FSDEA sovereign fund [E]; the post-2017 administration prosecuted some cases, including the FSDEA chairman [E].

Fiscal capacity and debt. Very high debt service: the authorities targeted government debt of about 69% of GDP at end-2024 and 63% by end-2025 [E: ED statement, IMF CR 25/62]; about 80% of debt is in foreign

currency, including oil-backed Chinese loans [E: Reuters, May 2025]; a total-return-swap facility triggered a US$200 million margin call after April 2025 market turbulence [E: IMF CR 25/269].

Bottlenecks. Oil dependence; debt service crowding out development spending; very low non-oil tax base; human capital; electricity.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. (i) *A stabilisation rule* tied to a conservative reference price, legislated with an independent council. (ii) *SOE/national oil company governance separation* (Sonangol as commercial operator, regulator separated — partially done with ANPG in 2019 [E]). (iii) *Debt-management professionalisation* (an insulated debt office).

Unsuitable mechanisms. Saving-type SWF while debt service absorbs a large share of revenue (the FSDEA experience shows a fund created under concentrated family power becomes a private channel); Gulf rentier contract at US$679 per head with a 44% under-15 population.

5.4 Democratic Republic of the Congo

Data box. Population 112.8 m · GDP per capita US$807 (PPP US$1,920) · 0–14: 45.9% · HCI 0.37 · electricity 22.5% · tax revenue 10.7% of GDP (2022) · WGI GE -1.72, CC -1.52 · rents 38.8% of GDP (minerals 28.8%), US$231 per head.

Resources. World-scale copper and cobalt; growth of 5.7% in 2025 driven by a 10.4% rise in copper output; cobalt exports were suspended for most of 2025 [E: IMF Country Report 26/246].

Fiscal capacity and conflict. Domestic revenue was about 11.5% of GDP in 2025; exceptional security spending was revised up to 3.4% of GDP for 2025 amid armed conflict in the east, with revenue losses from occupied territories; an Ebola outbreak added pressure [E: IMF CR 26/246; CR 26/002].

Institutions. Presidential system with weak state presence across a vast territory; Gécamines and opaque infrastructure-for-minerals contracts (Sicomines) have long been governance concerns [E].

Bottlenecks. Security and territorial control; electricity (22.5%); transport; revenue administration; contract transparency.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. (i) *EITI-grade contract transparency* and a professionalised mining cadastre (an insulated technocratic enclave). (ii) *Commodity-price stabilisation rule* once revenue is consolidated. (iii) *Enclave legal certainty* for mining investment.

Unsuitable mechanisms. Any SWF or saving rule before basic budget unity and security; centralised "big push" coordination where the state does not control territory. The Gulf presupposes a state that monopolises force and revenue; the DRC's binding constraint is that presupposition (interpretation).

5.5 Iraq

Data box. Population 47.0 m (IMF: 44.4 m, 2024) · GDP per capita US$5,410 (IMF: US$6,183, 2024) · 0–14: 36.0% · HCI 0.41 · WGI GE -1.13, CC -1.22 · rents 43.4% of GDP, US$2,115 per head.

Resources and fiscal structure. Crude production 3.9 million b/d (2024), exports 3.4 million b/d worth US$99.2 billion; oil revenue 36.0% of GDP within total revenue of 39.3%; wages and pensions 22.0% of GDP (2024), projected 24.5% by 2026; fiscal deficit projected to widen from 4.2% (2024) to 9.2% of GDP (2026); the budget-balancing oil price rose to about US$84 in 2024 from US$54 in 2020; government debt projected to rise from 47.2% to 62.3% of GDP [V: IMF PR 25/243]. Poverty was 23% in 2014, the latest figure cited [V].

Institutions and politics. Post-2003 parliamentary system with ethno-sectarian power-sharing (muhasasa) and a federal Kurdistan Region; "major data deficiencies" undermine surveillance [V: IMF PR 25/243].

Bottlenecks. The public-employment contract; electricity (high access but chronic outages and poor billing — the IMF urges improved collection before tariff increases [V]); state-owned banks; corruption.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. (i) *A Norwegian/Chilean-style fiscal rule* with a conservative reference price, which Iraq has never had. (ii) *Insulated professional enclaves* for oil, gas and electricity (the Gulf NOC model). (iii) *Gas capture* (Iraq flares associated gas while importing gas/electricity [E]).

Unsuitable mechanisms. Iraq is the clearest case of a *Gulf-style rentier employment model run at Gulf-incompatible rents*: about US$2,100 per head against US$13,700 per Saudi citizen. Expanding public hiring, as the Gulf does for citizens, is exactly what the IMF recommends reversing (attrition rule, end to mandatory hiring) [V]. A monarchy or strongman would not change this arithmetic; Iraq's 1958–2003 experience suggests concentrated power adds war and sanctions risk (see R2).

5.6 Libya

Data box. Population 7.5 m · GDP per capita US$6,449 · 0–14: 26.8% · electricity 77.4% · WGI GE -1.50, CC -1.54 · rents 61.0% of GDP, US$3,013 per head (the highest per head among Part XI cases).

Resources. Africa's largest proven oil reserves [E]; rents per head approach the lower GCC range — Libya is the one Part XI case where *Gulf-style fiscal arithmetic is not impossible* for its ~7.5 million residents.

Institutions and politics. Divided since 2014 between rival authorities in the west and east; "political instability and institutional fragmentation have prevented the adoption of a unified national budget", so the Central Bank of Libya, "without a formal mandate", sets the de facto spending envelope by limiting foreign-exchange use [E: IMF CR 25/148]. Growth fell from about 10% in 2023 to about 2% in 2024 on hydrocarbon disruption [E: IMF CR 25/148]. The Libyan Investment Authority's assets have been frozen under UN Security Council Resolution 1970 since 2011 [E].

Bottlenecks. Single legitimate budget authority; security; transparency of oil revenue (NOC -> CBL); wage-bill and subsidy growth.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help — after unification. A transparent oil revenue account, a rule-based fund, a professional NOC, and (with rents near US$3,000 per head) a *partly* distributive model such as an Alaska-style dividend to reduce fights over the state budget (hypothesis: dividends lower the stakes of controlling the treasury).

Unsuitable mechanisms. Concentrated personal authority as a route to unification — Libya's 1969–2011 experience under Gaddafi produced personalised, institution-less rule whose collapse left nothing to inherit (see R2). The precondition is a negotiated constitutional settlement, not a stronger ruler.

5.7 Algeria

Data box. Population 47.4 m · GDP per capita US$6,051 · 0–14: 29.9% · HCI 0.53 · WGI GE -0.21, CC -0.57 · rents 22.6% of GDP, US$940 per head.

Fiscal position. In 2024 hydrocarbon revenues fell 35.7% while the wage bill rose 12.8% and capital spending 31.8%; the central-government deficit widened to 13.9% of GDP and the Revenue Regulation Fund was fully depleted; reserves were US$67.8 billion (14 months of imports) at end-2024; staff estimate 5% of GDP of additional consolidation over 2025–28 would be needed to stabilise debt by 2028 [E: IMF CR 25/270]. Non-hydrocarbon tax revenue has hovered around 10% of GDP for two decades [E: IMF CR 25/271].

Institutions and politics. Military-backed presidential system; the 2019–2021 Hirak protest movement forced President Bouteflika's resignation (2019) but not a change in the underlying power structure [E; see R2].

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. A binding fiscal rule with a reference price; an independent fiscal council; SOE governance reform for Sonatrach; enclave legal certainty to attract non-hydrocarbon FDI.

Unsuitable mechanisms. Gulf-scale subsidies and public employment at US$940 per head and a 47 million population; a saving SWF while running double-digit deficits.

5.8 Pakistan

Data box. Population 255.2 m · GDP per capita US$1,596 (PPP US$6,573) · 0–14: 36.2% · HCI 0.41 · electricity 95.7% · WGI GE -0.54, CC -1.09 · rents 1.4% of GDP, US$21 per head (the lowest in the sample).

Resources. Pakistan is not a resource state in rent terms. Its relationship with the Gulf is as a *labour exporter and borrower*: remittances and Gulf deposits/rollovers are central to its external financing (see R4/R5 streams; not re-verified here).

Fiscal capacity. Tax-to-GDP "stubbornly low at around 10 percent of GDP over the past 5 years" [E: IMF Governance and Corruption Diagnostic, TA Report 25/98]; under the 2024 EFF, general-government tax revenue rose above 12% of GDP, with a 15% goal [E: IMF CR 25/332]. The diagnostic estimated that governance reforms could raise GDP by 5–6.5% over five years [E: Reuters, 20 Nov 2025].

Institutions and political constraints. A hybrid regime with a dominant military role in politics and the economy; the Special Investment Facilitation Council (2023) is chaired by the prime minister with senior military representation to fast-track Gulf and Chinese investment [E: Pakistan MOFA]; the IMF diagnostic called for an annual public report on SIFC's investments [E].

Bottlenecks. Revenue base (agriculture, retail, real estate under-taxed); energy-sector circular debt; elite exemptions; low human capital.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. Investment facilitation *if* transparent and rule-bound (one-stop shops, enclave arbitration); professional debt office; e-procurement.

Unsuitable mechanisms. *SIFC-type concentration of investment authority in an unaccountable military-civil council* is the Pakistani version of "Gulf-style centralisation", and the IMF's own diagnostic treats its opacity as a governance risk. With rents of US$21 per head, Pakistan has no rentier option at all: every Gulf mechanism premised on rents is irrelevant; those premised on capacity are relevant.

5.9 Egypt

Data box. Population 118.4 m · GDP per capita US$3,086 (PPP US$20,204) · 0–14: 31.6% · HCI 0.49 · WGI GE -0.17, CC -0.81 · rents 5.1% of GDP, US$197 per head.

Fiscal position. Interest payments absorbed about 73% of revenues (fifth/sixth EFF reviews, February 2026) and about 83% of tax revenue [E: IMF CR 26/69]; earlier, 9.8% of GDP and 78% of revenues [E: IMF CR 25/186]. General-government gross debt projected at 85.6% of GDP in FY2025/26 [E: Ahram citing IMF].

State footprint. In FY2022/23 public investment was 74% of total investment; state-owned banks hold about two-thirds of banking assets; state-owned entities "including military ones" operate directly in product markets with preferential financing and tax treatment [E: IMF CR 25/186]. Divestment under the State Ownership Policy has "fallen short of the commitments", and "military encroachment in various economic activities appears to persist" [E: IMF CR 26/69]. The 2024 Ras El-Hekma deal with Abu Dhabi (about US$35 billion) financed a record current-account gap [E: IMF CR 25/186].

Institutions and politics. Military-backed presidential rule since 2013 (see R2 for Nasser–Mubarak–Sisi).

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. Gulf *capital* (as investor, not model); insulated competition authority; a genuine holding-company separation of state assets with a commercial mandate and divestment (the IMF's prescription).

Unsuitable mechanisms. Gulf-style state-led giga-projects without rents (Egypt has tried this, with the New Administrative Capital and related projects financed by debt [E]); centralisation of economic authority in the security establishment. Egypt is perhaps the clearest evidence in the sample that *concentrating economic decision-making without rents produces debt rather than development* (interpretation).

5.10 Venezuela

Data box. Population 28.5 m · GDP per capita US$3,495 (2025) · 0–14: 24.9% · WGI GE -1.47, CC -1.58 · rents 11.8% of GDP in 2014 (last WDI year), US$841 per head.

Resources. Possibly the world's largest proved crude reserves, up to about 300 billion barrels [V: CRS IN12637]. Production was about 3 million b/d when Hugo Chávez took office in 1999, 2.7 million when he died in 2013, below 0.5 million in 2020, and just above 1.0 million by August 2025 [V: CRS].

Collapse. Real GDP fell by more than 75% between 2013 and 2021, "the single largest economic collapse for a non-conflict country in almost half a century", and about 7 million people (23% of the population) had left by August 2022 [E: IMF (2022), "The Venezuelan Exodus: An Unprecedented Economic and Humanitarian Crisis",

https://www.elibrary.imf.org/downloadpdf/view/journals/087/2022/019/article-A001-en.pdf]. ExxonMobil and ConocoPhillips assets were seized after 2007 [V: CRS].

2026 rupture. On 3 January 2026 a US military operation culminated in the arrest of President Nicolás Maduro; Vice President and Oil Minister Delcy Rodríguez assumed the role of acting president; the US announced sales of seized Venezuelan oil and work with "the Interim Venezuelan Authorities" on the energy sector [V: CRS IN12637, 9 Jan 2026]. Subsequent developments (hydrocarbon law reform, US sanctions waivers, earthquakes in June 2026) are reported in secondary sources but were not verified for this stream [E].

Assessment. Venezuela is the paradigm case of *concentrated power destroying a resource institution*: PDVSA was a relatively professional NOC before the 2002–03 politicised purge [E], and its decline accelerated under centralised, personalised control. Recovery depends on contract certainty, rebuilding PDVSA's technical cadre, debt restructuring (public debt estimated at about 180% of GDP by an IMF spokesperson in January 2026 [E: UK House of Commons Library]), and a legitimate government — none of which a different concentration of power supplies.

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. An insulated professional NOC; a transparent oil revenue fund with published flows; enclave arbitration for investors; an Alaska-style dividend to rebuild legitimacy of oil revenue (hypothesis). **Unsuitable:** any arrangement that again makes oil revenue the discretionary instrument of a single executive — domestic or foreign.

5.11 Mongolia

Data box. Population 3.6 m · GDP per capita US$7,108 (PPP US$20,798) · 0–14: 31.6% · HCI 0.61 · electricity 99.1% · tax revenue 16.9% of GDP (2024) · WGI GE -0.28, CC -0.47 · rents 33.1% of GDP (minerals 26.6%), US$1,497 per head.

Resources. Copper (Oyu Tolgoi) and coking coal exported overwhelmingly to China; minerals were about 87% of exports in 2024 [E: Mongolian MOF presentation, 2025].

Fiscal dynamics. A 2023–24 coal boom more than doubled government mining revenue and financed a procyclical spending surge; in 2025 coal export prices fell about 38%, mining revenue dropped, the government faced cash shortages and drew on the Fiscal Stability Fund; growth was nonetheless 6.8% in 2025 on agriculture and Oyu Tolgoi copper [E: IMF CR 26/219]. The Future Heritage Fund held about 5.8% of GDP at end-2025; a separate Savings Fund (1.2% of GDP) had been lent to banks for subsidised mortgages and is unavailable as a buffer [E: IMF CR 26/219]. Recent fiscal-framework amendments strengthened the Fiscal Stability Council, restricted Parliament's ability to modify fiscal rules and introduced a nominal debt ceiling [E: ED statement, IMF CR 25/265].

Institutions. A competitive semi-presidential democracy since 1990 — the only democracy in the sample with Gulf-like dependence on a single buyer and commodity volatility.

Bottlenecks. Procyclicality; diversion of savings funds to quasi-fiscal uses; landlocked logistics dependent on China and Russia; governance of mining SOEs (Erdenes) [E].

Gulf-style mechanisms that could help. Mongolia is the Part XI case where *rule-bound saving and stabilisation funds are most suitable*: small population, rents near US$1,500 per head, extreme volatility. The design lesson from its own experience is to forbid domestic quasi-fiscal lending from heritage funds and to entrench the rule beyond simple parliamentary majorities — i.e., Singapore's second-veto logic within a democracy.

Unsuitable mechanisms. A Gulf-style distributive state: rents per head are about one-ninth of Saudi Arabia's per citizen and far more volatile. Mongolia's earlier universal cash-handout experiments funded by anticipated mining revenue (2010–2012 [E]) illustrate the risk.

5.12 Kazakhstan (addition)

Data box. Population 20.8 m · GDP per capita US$14,692 (PPP US$44,293) · 0–14: 29.1% · HCI 0.63 · tax revenue 11.9% of GDP (2023) · WGI GE +0.07, CC -0.07 · rents 26.8% of GDP, US$2,680 per head.

Why included. It is the nearest non-Gulf analogue: centralised presidential rule, a large NOC (KazMunayGas) and sovereign holding company (Samruk-Kazyna), and a formally rule-based oil fund (NFRK), with rents per

head about one-fifth of Saudi Arabia's per citizen.

Fund performance. NFRK assets peaked at about US$77 billion (2014) and fell to about US$60 billion (2023), with total transfers exceeding total revenues over 2014–23 [E: IMF CR 25/30]. The guaranteed transfer is capped (2 trillion tenge per year for 2025–27, cut-off oil price US$42.3/bbl for 2025 [E: budget law]), but "targeted transfers" were uncapped until a 2025 rule limited them to 30% of the guaranteed transfer [E: Kursiv, Feb 2025]. The IMF's 2025 Article IV found the economy "showing clear signs of overheating", a non-oil deficit above 8% of GDP (structural non-oil deficit about 11%), and SOE balance-sheet expansion averaging about 20% of state-budget expenditure over five years — which, if counted as budgetary capital spending, would have raised the non-oil deficit by about 3.5 points [E: IMF CR 26/017].

Political constraints. The January 2022 unrest, triggered by a fuel-price increase, led to a state of emergency and CSTO deployment and to the sidelining of former president Nazarbayev's network [E; see R2].

Lesson for the monograph. Kazakhstan shows that *a Gulf-style fund under concentrated authority, without Gulf-scale rents per head, drifts toward use as a budget-support and quasi-fiscal pool.* The fund rules were real; the power to circumvent them through targeted transfers and SOE balance sheets was also real (interpretation).

Mechanisms that could help. Independent fiscal council; consolidation of SOE quasi-fiscal activity into the budget; AIFC-style enclave legal certainty (already present [E]). **Unsuitable:** expanding Samruk-Kazyna's or the fund's domestic investment mandate without commercial hurdle rates.

5.13 Mozambique (addition)

Data box. Population 35.6 m · GDP per capita US$627 (PPP US$1,698) · 0–14: 44.2% · HCI 0.36 · electricity 36.9% · tax revenue 21.8% of GDP (2024) · WGI GE -0.74, CC -1.04 · rents 14.9% of GDP, US$76 per head (2021, before major LNG).

Why included. It tests sequencing: can institutions be built *before* large rents arrive?

Hidden debts. In 2016 previously undisclosed borrowing of about US$1.4 billion by two SOEs (Proindicus and MAM) came to light, halting external financing; average growth fell from 7.9% (2000–2015) to 2.9% (2016–2024) and poverty rose [E: IMF CR 26/46, 26/045]. Out-of-court settlements in 2023–24 resolved disputed debts [E: IMF DSA]. In March 2025 S&P classified local-currency debt as "selective default", and arrears continued through 2025 [E: IMF CR 26/045].

LNG and the fund. Coral South FLNG has produced since 2022; TotalEnergies' onshore Mozambique LNG (about US$20 billion) restarted fully on 29 January 2026 after a 2021 insurgent attack on Palma, with production expected around 2030 and ExxonMobil's Rovuma project around 2031 [E: IMF; France 24; TotalEnergies]. TotalEnergies seeks to recover about US$4.5 billion in suspension-period costs from future revenues before taxes [E: ISS Africa, Mar 2026]. The SWF's management agreement was signed in November 2025, completing its legal framework; reported design allocates 40% of gas fiscal revenues to the fund and 60% to the budget [E: IMF CR 26/045; 360 Mozambique].

Assessment. Mozambique has, on paper, done what the literature recommends — fund law before rents. Its history (hidden debts contracted without parliamentary approval [E]) shows the risk lies in off-budget borrowing against future rents, which a fund law does not prevent. The IMF recommends a fiscal responsibility law [E: IMF PR 26/052].

Mechanisms that could help. Fiscal responsibility law; guarantees register with parliamentary approval; published LNG contracts and cost-recovery audits; Chile-style reference-price committee. **Unsuitable:** borrowing against future LNG to front-load spending — the Timor-Leste and Mongolia experiences, and Mozambique's own, all warn against it.

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6. Cross-country synthesis

6.1 A typology by rent per head and state cohesion

Table 6.1 — Part XI typology (interpretation)

Group	Countries	Rent per head (2021)	Binding constraints	Gulf mechanisms suitable	Gulf mechanisms unsuitable
A. Large population, low rent per head	Indonesia, Nigeria, Pakistan, Egypt, DRC	US$21–238	Tax capacity, human capital, power, security (DRC, Nigeria), state footprint (Egypt, Pakistan)	Technocratic enclaves, e-procurement, audit with publication, enclave legal certainty, Temasek-style holding company with published accounts	Rentier contract; saving-type SWF; centralised investment vehicles under the executive or military
B. Mid-rent, oil-dominated, fiscally overextended	Iraq, Algeria, Angola, Kazakhstan	US$680–2,700	Public wage bill, subsidy commitments, quasi-fiscal SOEs, debt service	Fiscal rules with reference prices; independent fiscal councils; professional NOCs	Expansion of public employment; uncapped fund transfers
C. Fragmented or collapsed authority	Libya, Venezuela	US$840–3,000	A single legitimate budget authority; security; contract credibility	(After settlement) transparent revenue accounts, professional NOC, possibly dividends	Any concentration of oil revenue in one executive
D. Small population, volatile rents	Mongolia, Timor-Leste (benchmark), Mozambique (future)	US$76–1,500	Procyclicality; fund raiding; off-budget borrowing	Rule-bound stabilisa-tion/saving funds with second veto; fiscal councils	Borrowing against future rents; domestic quasi-fiscal use of funds

6.2 What the cases say about the central principle

1. **The advantages travel; the power does not need to.** Every mechanism that worked in a Gulf state has a working counterpart in a democracy or constitutional monarchy (Norway, Chile, Alaska, Estonia, Botswana until the diamond slump, UK). The reverse is not true for failure: every failure mode in Part XI involves a principal able to override rules (Nigeria's governors and legislature, Malaysia's prime minister, Angola's presidential family, Kazakhstan's executive, Venezuela's presidency, Timor-Leste's parliamentary majorities). The variable that predicts failure is *unconstrained access to the resource flow*, which can arise under any regime type but is structurally maximised under concentrated power (interpretation).
2. **Concentration buys speed at the cost of error correction.** The one place where centralisation adds value — strategic coordination — is also where its costs (information distortion, higher variance; Besley & Kudamatsu 2008 [E]) appear. A rational design keeps fast coordination for implementation and slow, multi-veto decision-making for rules about money that belongs to future generations.

3. **The Gulf's most transferable innovations are enclaves, not monarchy.** Insulated SWF management, professional NOCs, and common-law commercial courts inside civil-law states (DIFC, ADGM; copied by Kazakhstan's AIFC) are design features that can be legislated in republics (interpretation).
4. **The Gulf's least transferable feature is its fiscal-social contract.** It depends on rents per citizen one to three orders of magnitude above Part XI levels, and on a non-citizen labour force that absorbs adjustment. Iraq and Algeria show what happens when the contract is attempted at a fraction of the rents.
5. **Constitutional change is not a lever in the evidence.** In none of the 13 cases does the binding constraint lie in constitutional form. It lies in revenue capacity, security, demographic pressure, enforcement of existing rules, and the political economy of who controls resource flows.

6.3 Implications for the monograph's final synthesis (BRIEF Part XII, questions 3, 8, 9)

- *Q3 (Is concentrated power necessary?)* — This stream's evidence answers no for each of the 14 mechanisms; similar coordination and long horizons can be achieved through entrenched rules, independent agencies and centre-of-government units.
- *Q8 (Which Gulf features can be adopted without absolute authority?)* — Rule-bound funds (where surpluses exist), professional NOCs, insulated investment and legal enclaves, delivery discipline with independent data, long-range plans linked to budgets.
- *Q9 (When does concentration create more problems than it solves?)* — When rents per head are low (no cushion for error), when populations are large and young (high cost of policy mistakes), when the state lacks territorial control (concentration cannot substitute for capacity), and when the mechanism's purpose is to restrain the ruler.

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7. Disputes and uncertainties

1. **Rents are not fiscal revenue.** Table 3.1 measures economic rent, not what governments collect. Gulf governments capture most rent through national oil companies; Nigeria, Angola and Mozambique share it with international operators under production-sharing contracts. The per-citizen gap in *fiscal* terms is probably wider than the rent gap for some pairs (Gulf vs Nigeria) and narrower for others. A fiscal-revenue-per-citizen series (IMF GFS hydrocarbon revenue ÷ citizens) would be a better measure; it was not built here.
2. **Citizen populations for Qatar and the UAE are estimates.** Neither publishes nationality-disaggregated totals; GLMM's estimates (UAE 1.30 million citizens in 2021; Qatar 0.34 million in 2020) may be off by tens of percent. GLMM noted in March 2026 that sources previously used for these estimates were no longer available [E: GLMM]. The direction of the conclusion (Gulf per-citizen rents vastly exceed Part XI levels) is robust to any plausible error.
3. **Price sensitivity.** 2021 was a mid-price year. In 2022 rents were much higher; in 2025–26 IMF documents describe lower prices (Brent near a four-year low in early 2026 [V: CRS IN12637]). Ratios between countries are more stable than levels.
4. **Gulf fund opacity limits the comparison.** ADIA, KIA and QIA publish far less than NBIM, GIC or APFC. The claim that Gulf funds "succeeded" is partly an inference from accumulated size and absence of visible scandal; their internal governance cannot be audited from public sources at Norway's standard. This creates an asymmetry: democratic funds' failures are visible (Timor-Leste, Alaska's dividend fights), autocratic funds' failures may not be (interpretation; selection bias).
5. **Small-n and endogeneity.** Statements such as "fiscal-rule durability has been higher in democracies with fiscal councils" rest on a handful of cases. Countries that adopt fiscal councils may already be more disciplined. Causal claims here are hypotheses.
6. **Delivery-unit evidence is mostly descriptive.** Few rigorous impact evaluations exist for whole-of-government delivery units; the more rigorous evidence (Rasul & Rogger; Rwanda teacher contracts) is narrower in scope and points in different directions depending on task observability.
7. **2026 events are fast-moving and partly unverified.** IMF documents from 2026 refer to a "war in the Middle East" whose spillovers affected Pakistan, Egypt and the DRC [E: IMF PR 26/227; CR 26/101],

and press headlines in October 2026 referred to Saudi economic contraction linked to war [E: Jakarta Post headline]. This stream did not verify the war's scope or its effect on GCC fiscal positions; any such effect would *reduce* the Gulf fiscal cushion and strengthen, not weaken, the rent-dependence argument. Venezuela's post-January 2026 trajectory (Maduro's arrest [V: CRS]) is too recent for assessment.

8. **Danantara is in flux.** Its legal basis was amended twice in 2025; its 2025 audited consolidated statements were not public as of mid-October 2026 [V: Jakarta Post]; asset figures in the US$600–900 billion range describe the consolidated SOE balance sheet, not liquid investable assets. Any assessment should be revisited once audited accounts are published.
9. **WDI rents for Botswana and other diamond producers are understated**; Botswana's role here is as an institutional benchmark, not as a rent comparator.
10. **The "Gulf model" is plural.** Dubai's diversification, Saudi Arabia's state-led transformation, Kuwait's parliamentary-rentier system and Oman's fiscal constraint differ greatly (see R1). This stream abstracts a stylised "Gulf mechanism set"; country-specific Gulf findings belong to R1/R3.

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